By Second Intention

Book One

BY SECOND INTENTION

A Novel

Warsaw · Berlin

This is a work of historical fiction. While certain institutions, streets, and public events of Berlin (1928–1933) and occupied Warsaw (1943) belong to the historical record, the principal characters and their private actions are inventions of the narrative.

Typeset in Libertinus Serif on a Royal Octavo (6 × 9 in.) trim.

Sanatio per primam intentionem fit cum vulneris labia, nullo extraneo interposito corpore, mutuo conglutinantur. Sanatio vero per secundam intentionem, cum propter contusionem, sordes aut mortuam carnem vulnus apertum servandum est, donec ex imo nova caro cum cicatrice granulet.

Healing by first intention occurs when the lips of a wound, with no foreign body between them, cleave cleanly together. Healing by second intention occurs when, by reason of bruising, filth, or dead flesh, the wound must be kept open until new flesh granulates upward from the bottom in scar.

— Surgical Compendium, Charité-Krankenhaus, 1928

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PART ONE

Per Secundam

February – March 1943

Chapter I

The Four-Minute Vessel

Warsaw, 9 February 1943

The boy on the cobbler's bench had bitten clean through his cap visor, cardboard stiffener and all, so gray pulp stuck to his lower teeth like wet bread. Whenever Sylwia drove the grooved director deeper along the wing of his ilium, his heels drummed once against the crate holding the lasts and stopped, because Marek had a knee planted across the backs of both thighs and Marek weighed seventy-eight kilos in his winter coat.

"Hold the lamp higher," Sylwia said. "Not closer. Higher. If you drop hot tallow into an open pelvis I won't bother fishing out the lead, I'll let him rot from the candle."

Waiter's hands were useless for light; engineers' were worse, because engineers corrected the angle by millimeters until they forgot they had wrists. Marek raised the carbide tin three inches. The flame hissed blue at its root and white at its tip, throwing the shadow of her Pean forceps huge across strings of dried sole-leather and three portraits of the Virgin tacked above the coal bin. All over ulica Pańska the thaw had failed at four o'clock; sleet rattled against the pavement grating overhead, and whenever a horse cart ground past toward Towarowa, grit sifted through the rotten mortar onto Sylwia's hair.

"Second fragment's turned," she said. Metal clicked against metal down in the dark red well—not bone, bone gave a wet wooden knock, unmistakable once you had scraped enough periosteum in winter—and her thumb adjusted on the ratcheted handle. "Ricochet off the coupling iron before it went through his trousers. Jacket split?"

"Copper's peeled back," Marek said, not looking down. He was watching the cellar steps through his eyelashes, counting tram bells two streets south on Aleje Jerozolimskie to mark the quarter-hours. Seven

fifteen. Curfew at eight, though since the sixth of February, when the three days of German mourning for Stalingrad ended and the *szczekaczki* went back to marches and transport quotas, the Schutzpolizei patrols around Dworzec Główny started clubbing stragglers at twenty to. "Take it whole if you can. The armourer wants to see whether Bahnschutz are still shooting Belgian stock."

"Tell your armourer to come dig in a railwayman's arse himself next Tuesday."

She twisted forty degrees, felt the jagged lip of the copper jacket snag fascia, freed it with the blunt tip of her left index finger—gloveless, because latex tore on brass splinters and three pairs of boiled Continental surgical gloves remained in Pavilion III's locked zinc box for laparotomies—and drew the slug out. It dropped into the chipped enamel saucer with a flat clink. Behind it welled dark venous blood mixed with grey wool threads punched straight out of the boy's railway uniform trousers. Those threads were what killed you five days later: *Clostridium perfringens*, horse dung dried into street dust, beaten into cloth all autumn and driven three inches into torn gluteus medius where oxygen never reached.

"Irrigate," she told the cobbler's wife, who stood by the pickle barrel clutching an Esmarch jug of boiled snow-water tinted faint violet with potassium permanganate. The woman's thumb shook on the rubber clip. Fluid hissed into the cavity, steaming in the four-degree cellar air, washing clots and three more black crumbs of wool over the oilcloth into a zinc tub.

Sylwia did not stitch him. Amateurs stitched bullet tracks in cellars because closed skin looked tidy by lamp-light and made the relatives pay faster; four days later the thigh crackled under your fingers like tissue paper full of lard bubbles, smelling of sweet mouse-nest, and then you took the leg off at the hip or signed nothing at all because the patient had no *Kennkarte* you dared enter in a register. She cut four strips of boiled linen with her Mayo scissors, soaked them in yellow rivanol solution, and packed them ribbon by ribbon down to the scraped bone with dressing forceps until only an inch of wet tail protruded.

The boy spat cardboard off his tongue. His face was the greenish tallow colour of lard sold at Hala Mirowska with chalk kneaded into the bottom of the tub. "Pani doktor," he whispered. "Tomorrow night—the points at Odolany—"

"Tomorrow night you'll piss into a bottle lying on your stomach and thank Christ if your temperature stays under thirty-nine," Sylwia said, pressing a thick pad of wood-cellulose wadding—German field-gray paper cotton, stolen out of Wehrmacht freight cars at Praga—over the drain tail and strapping it down brutally with two-inch adhesive plaster that ripped the dark hair on his flank when she pulled it taut. "Don't pull the wick out when it stings. If somebody tells you to put pork fat or ☒ oil on it, spit in his eye. Who turns him on Thursday?"

"My cousin," the cobbler's wife said. "She nursed at Świętego Ducha before the bombardment."

"Tell her clean boiled forceps, pull half an inch if it slides, re-pack loose if it bleeds bright, and if the skin around it goes bronze or crackles under her thumb, bring him to Lindleya gate in a vegetable cart with a typhus rag tied to the shaft so the gendarmes don't lift the blanket. Ask for Siostra Bronisława at Pavilion Three. Nobody else. Not the gate clerk, not the young doctor with the blond moustache."

She scrubbed her hands in the pickle-barrel dipper over the zinc tub—lye soap gritty with sand that stripped grease and half the epidermis together, then ninety-percent denatured spirit that bit raw purple fissures around every nailbed until her jaw locked. A surgeon's hands in the fourth winter of occupation looked like a washerwoman's scalded in beet-brine. In Berlin, twelve years ago, Geheimrat von Halden used to inspect his assistants' fingernails before eight o'clock rounds along a white towel, tapping any red cuticle with his gold pencil: *A butcher arrives raw, Fräulein Kotarska; a gentleman arrives intact.* Von Halden had three sisters in Charlottenburg and French glycerine soap in a porcelain dish.

Upstairs in the shop, behind shuttered glass still pasted with criss-crossed brown paper from September 'thirty-nine, Marek handed her into her coat. The lining under the left armpit had split again; cold iron from her instrument roll pressed through her wool dress against her ribs.

"Separate at Żelazna?" she asked.

"Walk with me as far as Koszykowa. Your night pass starts at eight; mine's good until nine on Ostbahn repair stamp." He unbuttoned his collar half an inch to scratch the red rash left by ersatz wool scarf dye. Marek had narrow gray eyes, flat cheekbones, and the dry sour smell of wet dog-hair that every winter coat in Warsaw gave off once the prewar

English nap wore down to reclaimed shoddy. “You have forty minutes before Pavilion Three.”

“Thirty-five. Mirecki drank half the spirit ration after noon amputations; if I’m late he’ll let Jankowski touch the hernia in Six, and Jankowski sews peritoneum like mailbags.”

They stepped out singly anyway, twenty paces apart until past Chmielna, out of habit deeper than courtesy. Sleet blew horizontally down the dark canyon of Sosa-blackened tenements. Streetlamps were blue slits painted down to thumbnails for blackout; only at the corner of Marszałkowska did light spill wide, dirty yellow across slush where two Feldgendarmerie troopers in crescent metal gorgets stood beside an iron brazier checking the *Kennkarte* of a man pushing a handcart of frozen rutabagas. Pasted across the round kiosk behind them, half-peeled by wet wind and over-slapped with fresh pink theater bills for the Komedia, hung Monday’s black-bordered proclamation from Berlin: the Sixth Army fallen faithful to its oath at Stalingrad, venues of amusement reopened since Sunday, defeatist rumour punishable under wartime special statute. Someone had hawked phlegm squarely onto the eagle’s wreath, where it had frozen into an amber bead.

At Koszykowa 33 they went up the back service stairs, four flights smelling of boiled cabbage cores, cat urine, and coal clinker used twice over. Inside Sylwia’s single room—partitioned in 1941 with beaverboard out of Advocate Goldfeder’s old library after the Goldfeders were marched north across the wooden footbridge over Chłodna—the green ceramic stove held barely enough banked peat ash to keep water in the enamel pitcher from skinning over with ice.

Sylwia didn’t light the carbide lamp. Carbide cost forty *młynarki* a kilo on Polna and left soot inside your nostrils all morning. Enough gray glare came off the snow on the courtyard roof across the well to show the brass bedstead, the stacked *Zentralblatt für Chirurgie* bound volumes propping up its broken caster, and the tin basin.

Marek locked the door from inside, dropped his wet sheepskin gloves onto the table beside her cold tea glass, and caught her by the hip before she had the second button of her coat undone.

“Your hands are freezing,” she said, though his were inside her wool waistband already, blunt-nailed and dry-chapped, shoving her skirt and grey knitted drawers down only as far as she needed to step one boot free.

"So's the stove. Turn round or lie back?"

"Stove's cold on the tiles. Bed."

Nothing about it pretended to be courtship; they had exhausted courtship in November forty-two in twenty minutes behind a blackout curtain in Żoliborz while waiting for a courier who never arrived because he was already dead on Pawiak cobblestones. Now there was the clock ticking inside her open coat pocket, the iron creak of Goldfeder's cut-down daybed, the scratch of Marek's belt buckle against her thigh before she pushed his wool trousers clear of his groin with her boot-toe. She spat into her palm because she was dry and tired and the room was six degrees above zero, reached down between them to guide him in before he bruised her dry against the pubic bone, and locked her ankles hard over his calves to take the weight off the loose caster.

He fucked with the compact, silent economy he brought to bridge demolition tables and dead-letter drops: jaw against her collarbone, breath whistling once through his crooked septum, wool coat still on so its sleet-wet lapel soaked cold through her blouse over her left breast. Halfway through, her eyes stayed open on the plaster rosette stranded half-sliced by the beaverboard wall—half a garland of stucco acanthus leaves going nowhere into raw lath. Beneath the smell of wet shoddy and coal dust sat faint carbolic and the iron stink of the railwayman's venous blood dried into the crease of her left thumb. She shifted her pelvis upward twice, hard, grinding the heel of her own hand against the bone until a sharp, mean knot broke loose low in her belly—more like sneezing out cold water than pleasure, fierce and instantly gone—and bit down on Marek's coat collar so the old widow across the beaverboard wouldn't hear through the plaster and start rattling her rosary beads against the headboard.

Marek came three thrusts later with a muffled grunt into her neck, shuddering once from shoulders to knees. For half a minute neither moved; their mingled breath hung white six inches above her chin.

Then the church clock at Zbawiciela struck the half-hour—seven flat, cracked iron notes carried downwind—and he eased back, wincing as cold air hit wet skin.

"There's lye water in the kettle behind the grate," Sylwia said, swinging her legs down to the rag rug and reaching straight for the Esmarch douche bulb and towel on the washstand without looking back.

Pregnancy in February forty-three meant Vesper's replacement list or a curette by mirror-light, and she trusted no man's timing, least of all an engineer's.

Marek buttoned himself in the dark, watching the pale line of her spine where her blouse had pulled free of her corsetless waist-slip. "You're thinner than New Year's."

"Everybody's thinner than New Year's except Bronka and the Volksdeutsche on Filtrowa. My sister had real goose dripping on Sunday. Stefan brought it home from the tram sheds wrapped in *Nowy Kurier Warszawski*." She shivered as icy vinegar-and-alum water bit her insides over the slop pail, dried herself briskly with rough linen, and tugged her drawers up. "Did the boy on Pańska see who shot him?"

"Bahnschutz patrol out of Ochota sidings. Except Bahnschutz don't carry Steyr-Solothurn submachine guns with silenced barrels, and there was a black Opel Admiral parked past the water tower before the shooting started." Marek picked up his gloves, slapped dust from them against his thigh. "Something's sour down toward Grójecka tonight. Half of *Abwehrstelle* had motor-pool movement after four, and Szucha wasn't notified—our girl on the switchboard says Kroll's desk asked the Wehrmacht duty officer twice why Towarowa barrier was closed and got hung up on."

Sylwia pinned a fallen coil of dark hair back above her ear with two steel *szpilki*, pressing them flat until their points scraped her scalp. "Let them shoot each other. Saves us sulfonamide."

"Nothing saves you anything when Germans shoot Germans in our district," Marek said dryly. "They still shoot fifty of us by Friday to balance the ledger. Keep your ears open if any railway casualties come through Lindleya before morning. Don't write anything down. I'll be at the seed shop Thursday noon."

He touched two fingers briefly to the nape of her neck—his sole concession to tenderness, dry and warm as paper—checked the stairwell crack, and was gone without making the third step creak.

Sylwia drank three mouthfuls of cold boiled barley water straight from the glass, slid her clean pocket case of scalpels and arterial clamps into her coat, checked that her *Nachtausweis* with Stabsarzt Vesper's violet eagle stamp sat flat inside her grey *Kennkarte*, and went out into the sleet toward Lindleya.

* * *

By midnight the sleet had stiffened into true eastern snow, dry as ground glass, hissing horizontally between the red-brick pavilions of *Szpital Dzieciątka Jezus*.

Pavilion Three smelled on winter nights as if someone had boiled an old sheep in hospital carbolic and burnt turnip peelings under the pot. Sixty-eight Polish surgical beds occupied the upper two floors—compound fractures from unlit factory belts, frostbitten toes going black like dried plums, perforated peptic ulcers chewed into clerks' stomachs by sawdust bread and terror, three septic abortions logged tactfully as *appendicitis acuta*—while the ground-floor east wing, Rooms Ten through Sixteen behind the double swing-doors painted with a black stencil (*Reserviert — Wehrmacht-Notdienst*), stood three-quarters empty on clean bleached sheets with two radiator pipes actually hot. Stabsarzt Vesper liked four spare emergency beds ready within three minutes of Dworzec Główny in case troop-train officers caught shrapnel from partisan mines east of Mińsk Mazowiecki or burst an appendix full of French brandy at the Soldatenheim. In exchange for keeping those six rooms immaculate, Pavilion Three got two tons of Silesian coal a month and enough ether that Mirecki didn't have to operate under pure rectal chloral like poor Świętego Łazarza.

At ten minutes past one, the city electricity dropped from yellow to copper wire-glow and died altogether.

"Psiakrew," Siostra Bronisława said placidly from the sterilizer alcove, not spilling a drop of the roasted-acorn coffee she was pouring through a surgical gauze square into two porcelain urine-specimen beakers—the clean unused ones from before the war, which held heat better than tin mugs. She struck a safety match on the sole of her wooden clog and touched it to the brass *karbidówka* hanging by chains above the scrub sink. Acetylene burped once, stank of rotten garlic, and bloomed into a hard, shadowless white glare that turned Bronka's broad pockmarked cheeks the colour of turnip and glinted off her gold left eyetooth. "Elektrownia Powiśle again, or the coal froze on the grate. Drink while it's hot, pani doktor, I put half a saccharin tablet in yours."

Sylwia leaned her hip against the cold marble instrument slab, warming both raw palms round the beaker. Across the corridor in the doctors'

cubby, Docent Mirecki lay asleep under his prewar camel-hair Raglan coat with his gold pince-nez dangling over his waistcoat buttons and an empty hundred-gram bottle of *Spiritus vini rectificatus* tucked guiltily behind *Chirurgia Kliniczna*. Let him sleep till four. His coronary arteries had been whistling like old kettle spouts since New Year's whenever he climbed stairs fast, and if Mirecki died, the *Amtsarzt* would put a Reichsdeutscher commissar or a Ukrainian collaborator over Pavilion Three within forty-eight hours.

"Bed Twenty-Nine's stump stopped oozing?" Sylwia asked.

"Dry as a bishop's tit since eleven," Bronka said. "I gave him twenty drops of valerian and told him it was pantopon. He went straight off snoring. Mind moves half the pain, like my father used to say when he stuck pigs on Górczewska—don't rattle the bucket till you're behind the ear." She cocked her head suddenly toward the frosted courtyard casement. "Listen."

Not an ambulance bell. Hospital horse-ambulances had brass hand-clappers, and German *Sanitätskraftwagen* used two-tone Bosch horns that echoed all the way from Chałubińskiego. This was an unmuffled four-cylinder air-cooled engine screaming in second gear up Lindleya, missing on one cylinder, chains thrashing cobblestones through packed snow—followed by a tremendous metallic bang as something hit the iron night-gate without waiting for old Walenty to pull the bolt.

Shouting broke out in the courtyard: raw German, high and cracked with panic, then two pistol shots fired straight into the snowy air to bring orderlies running.

Sylwia set the urine beaker down untasted. "Wake the Docent. Put two liters of saline on the Primus and unlock the ether tin."

Before she reached the vestibule doors they kicked inward from outside, smashing the brass latch-plate splintering out of the pine jamb. Freezing wind roared down the tiled hall in a white sheet of blown snow. Behind it came two Wehrmacht *Feldgendarmen* dragged off gate patrol, and ahead of them a bareheaded young *Gefreiter* in a torn Reversible winter parka whose left hand was wrapped in a grey woolen muffler dripping bright scarlet onto the black-and-white tiles like paint flicked from a brush. With his intact right fist and his teeth gripped into a canvas stretcher strap, the boy was hauling the front poles of a blood-blackened litter; a terrified gate porter stumbled backward with the rear handles.

"Chirurg!" the *Gefreiter* bellowed. East Prussian rural vowels, flat and broad, voice tearing raw in his throat; snow had melted and refrozen in blood down his blond eyebrows. Somebody tried to steer him toward the admissions desk ledger and the boy swung his bloody wool-wrapped left stump straight into the clerk's chest, knocking him into the coat rack, and drew a Walther P38 right-handed out of his belt. "Kein Papier! Operationssaal! Sofort—er verblutet mir unter den Händen—*Oberstleutnant*!"

"Put the pistol away before you shoot the chandelier onto your own officer," Sylwia snapped in Berlin German so flat and clipped that the two *Feldgendarmen* stiffened at the heels before realizing a woman in a patched white smock had spoken. "Table One, left through the glass doors. Lift—don't tip the head up if he's exsanguinating, tilt the feet! Bronka, four bricks under the foot-pins, Trendelenburg!"

They heaved the litter directly onto the white enameled operating table without transferring him, canvas poles and all, because the grey wool greatcoat underneath the unconscious man wasn't merely wet—it hung sagged like a hammock full of slaughterhouse offal, clotting dark red jelly sliding out through the canvas weave onto the floor drain. Across the casualty's upper left chest and shoulder socket, someone with crude but furious competence had jammed an entire compressed Wehrmacht field dressing and an officer's leather map-strap twisted with a bayonet scabbard as a makeshift Spanish windlass over the collarbone hollow, where no ordinary tourniquet could catch.

Every pulse beat—weak, racing at one-forty, fluttering like a trapped sparrow—still pushed a fresh bright-scarlet bubble of oxygenated foam and arterial blood up around the soaked wool collar. Subclavian or high axillary artery, plus a nicked apical pleura or bronchus whip-frothing it pink. Four minutes left in the vascular tree, maybe three if he had already dumped two liters onto the floorboards of a car between Ochota and here.

"Scissors," Sylwia said, grabbing the heavy curved Lister shears off Bronka's zinc tray without scrubbing—scrubbing took seven minutes, and in seven minutes this German would be cold meat on enameled iron. She poured raw ninety-percent spirit straight out of the stock jug across both ungloved hands, hissed through her teeth as the Pańska cuts blazed white-hot, and drove the blunt lower beak of the shears inside the stiffened collar of the *Feldbluse* at the throat latch.

Frozen blood, wool, silver-braided collar litzen, cotton undershirt, and linen *Soldbuch* corner parted with a thick, wet crunch. She ripped the left tunic front wide from sternum to shoulder seam, tossing the silver-piped shoulder board—braided *Oberstleutnant* cord, Heer staff crimson? no, plain white/transport dummy piping over field-gray—into the kick-bucket.

Docent Mirecki burst through the swing doors tying his apron crooked over his waistcoat, spectacles crooked, sweet cherry-spirit breath preceding him by a yard. "Meine Herren, bitte—only medical staff inside the sterile perimeter—"

"Stay at the head, panie docencie," Sylwia said in rapid Polish, tearing open the sodden undershirt and slicing the bayonet-twisted leather strap only half a turn while bracing four fingers of her left hand directly over the supraclavicular hollow to catch the geyser before it blew. "Check airway—jaw's locked—don't give ether yet, he hasn't the pressure for ether, give oxygen if the green cylinder's got twenty atmospheres—"

Blood and grey road slush caked the man's face from temple to chin where he had lain cheek-down against rubber floor-matting. Bronka dragged a wet saline sponge hard across his mouth, nose, and eyes to clear the nostrils for the nasal catheter.

The carbide lamp swung half an inch on its ceiling chain in the draft from the broken vestibule door. Hard white acetylene light dropped straight down onto the high bridge of the nose, the sharp philtrum, the flat, arrogant arch of the supraorbital bone, and—just beneath the right cheekbone, scrubbed suddenly clean of dried brown crust—a crescent-shaped white scar three centimeters long where four interrupted silk stitches had been put in slightly too tight in December nineteen-thirty, leaving tiny cross-hatched ladder marks Sylwia knew because she had watched Lotte Bergmann hold the mirror while a drunk Charité *Famulus* sewed it shut.

Above it, his eyelids fluttered half open. Not unconscious—exsanguination stupor. Beneath pale lashes crusted with salt rime, two irises the exact grey-green of winter Spree water under iron bridges stared blind straight through her chin without pupil focus.

Sylwia's heart did not skip; it dropped like an iron sash-weight into cold grease.

Ludwig Schoeler.

Beneath her left thumb, buried two inches deep behind the shattered middle third of his left clavicle and shredded pectoralis major, the torn mouth of his axillary artery bucked—*thup-thup-thup*—hot, slick, greased with fat globules and jagged brass splinters, squirting a thin bright jet across her white sleeve toward her throat the instant her thumb shifted half a millimeter in shock.

Nobody else in Warsaw knew that crescent scar. Mirecki saw a dying Wehrmacht *Oberstleutnant* with a smashed shoulder. Bronka saw three liters of mess on her clean tiles and a crazy Prussian corporal holding a Walther P38 against the door glass. Even the corporal staring wild-eyed over Bronka's broad back saw only two white Polish hands buried to the knuckles in his commander's chest.

Let your thumb slip.

The thought did not arrive in words; it arrived as an anatomical diagram from Corning's *Lehrbuch der topographischen Anatomie*, 1927 edition, page two hundred and fourteen, inked in red and blue. First part of the arteria axillaris, transitioning off the subclavian over the outer border of the first rib. Retracted proximal stump had already spasmed half-shut from cold and hypotension, which was the sole miracle keeping him breathing at one-fifteen in the morning; now that Pavilion Three's stove warmth and her own thirty-seven-degree fingers were touching the adventitia, the spasm was letting go. Lift her thumb two millimeters—keep her hand buried inside the bloody hole so the corporal saw frantic surgical heroism, call sharply for clamps, fumble half a second in dark pooled blood behind the splintered collarbone where even Geheimrat von Halden lost one in three—and in ninety seconds ventricular fibrillation would flatten those Spree-water eyes to boiled fish-glue.

Ten years since Savignyplatz. March 1933: snow mixed with black paper ash blowing down Luisenstraße, Jakob Mandelbaum's spectacles smashed on the marble stairs of the Pathology Institute, Ludwig standing inside her doorway in his new field-gray Reichswehr greatcoat with his hat in his gloved hand and that exact expressionless, intolerable stillness around his mouth while he laid a second-class sleeping-car voucher to Poznań on her trunk like money left on a whore's dresser. *Take the 23:14 from Friedrichstraße, Sylwia. Don't go back to the clinic for your notebooks.*

Now here he lay on Lindleya Street in a conquered city where children coughed up tubercle bacilli into newspaper handkerchiefs and men were

hanged along railway embankments in groups of fifty, wearing silver braided boards on German wool, his hot arterial blood pumping over her ungloved weddingless left hand onto Polish floor tiles.

Two millimeters. Count to sixty. Sign the death slip at 01:22: Exitus letalis in tabula—ruptura arteriae subclaviae sinistrae. Even Kroll couldn't hang a surgeon for failing to catch a retracted subclavian by carbide lamp.

On the table, Ludwig's split, bloodless lips parted around a string of pink pleural froth. Not a groan—he had hated groaning even at twenty-one when an abscess in his mastoid was lanced raw—just an ugly, ragged intake through clenched molars as his right hand, cold and gray-nailed, clawed instinctively at the enameled rim of Table One and locked onto the cold steel rail so hard a fingernail split audibly.

He won't die quiet, some vicious, ancient nerve behind her breastbone spat back. *And you won't miss a vessel on your own table for any Schoeler alive—not if Satan himself drove the car.*

"Bone cutter—Liston forceps, large!" Sylwia barked, voice dropping half an octave into pure ice, her left thumb clamping the proximal stump flat against the first rib so mercilessly that Ludwig's whole arched torso jerked upward off the canvas despite exsanguination shock. "Bronka, stop staring at the corporal's gun and retract the pectoralis flap hard upward! Panie docencie, two hundred milliliters warm physiological saline into the right cubital vein by cut-down right now—don't hunt for a needle vein, he's collapsed flat, take the #15 scalpel and cannulate! Not too fast till I have the proximal clamp on or you'll blow my clot!"

* * *

For twenty-two minutes nothing existed in the room except the six-inch circle of glare under the carbide reflector, smelling of hot garlic gas, wet bone meal, and iron.

Sylwia resected two centimeters of splintered middle clavicle cleanly with the Liston bone shears—*crunch, crunch*, periosteum stripped back swift and ruthless with a Farabeuf raspatory—because trying to sew a retracted axillary artery blind behind jagged collarbone shards in bad light was how timid surgeons killed men politely. Once the shattered bone wedge lifted out into the kidney dish, the whole infraclavicular fossa opened beneath her eyes like a wet red anatomical plate, though no

plate in Corning had two deformed steel grenade-casing fragments and a chewed lump of grey wool collar-felt driven straight across the brachial plexus cords.

"Suction's dead without current," Bronka grunted, wrist veins standing out like clothesline as she hauled the muscle hook upward with one hand and dabbed furiously with wrung-out hot saline gauze packs with the other. "Count sponges for me, pani doktor—that's seven in, seven out —"

"Bulldog clamps. Two. Wet them in sterile paraffin oil first."

Mirecki had the brass cannula tied into the right basilic vein at the elbow crease; warm saline ticked down from the glass funnel held high by the terrified gate porter while Mirecki watched Ludwig's carotid flutter under two trembling tobacco-yellow fingers. "No radial pulse at all, Sylwia. Pupils sluggish but symmetric. If you ligate the main trunk cold at this level in February, the collateral scapular circulation won't carry—the left arm goes gangrenous by Friday."

"I'm not ligating," Sylwia said between her teeth.

Ligating took ninety seconds: tie off both ends with heavy #1 silk, save the carcass, amputate the dead black arm at the shoulder joint four days later. In ninety-nine field dressing stations from Voronezh to Smolensk tonight, German surgeons were tying axillary trunks shut and throwing left arms into lime barrels by the dozen. Twelve years ago at the Charité, during the summer animal-vascular trials when she and Ludwig had spent six blistering July nights side by side in the basement dog-house sewing femoral arteries end-to-end according to Carrel's three-stay triangulation method—each counting the other's thrombi at autopsy the next morning with malicious glee—Ludwig had leaned across the slate sink smoking a cheap *Reval* and said: *Any butcher with twine can tie a pipe shut, Kotarska. Let me see your intima-to-intima everted seam hold eighty millimeters of mercury without leaking, and maybe I'll believe women have thumbs.*

"Carrel needle," she said to Bronka. "Straight fine milliner's if the curved eye's rusted—five-zero black arterial silk soaked in sterile liquid vaseline. Don't touch the thread belly with forceps."

By acetylene light that hissed and pulsed whenever snow gusted through the cracked vestibule, her raw, spirit-burned fingers stopped hurting altogether. Only the artery remained: pale yellow-pink slippery

tube five millimeters across, frayed at a ragged diagonal where a twisted flake of steel had sheared two-thirds through the wall and torn the subscapular branch clean off at its root.

She trimmed three millimeters of shredded adventitia and bruised media cleanly away from both ends with iris scissors—*one cut each, never nibble*—losing precious length until mobilizing the distal trunk meant dissecting perilously close to the median and ulnar nerve cords gleaming like wet white Violin strings in the pit of the armpit. If the lateral cord took scar-strangulation later, he would wake with burning causalgia down his thumb and index finger till Judgment Day. Let him burn; she spared the nerve sheath by half a millimeter anyway, because sloppy dissection disgusted her worse than Germans did.

Three equidistant stay-sutures at a hundred and twenty degrees. Bronka held two traction threads taut—steady now as granite, the old Wola midwife sensing delicate vessel work the way a blind horse knew rotten bridge planks—converting the round lumen into a flat glistening triangle so Sylwia could never accidentally catch the back wall with her needle point. Over-and-over continuous everted stitch, less than a millimeter apart, needle sliding grease-smooth through vaselined silk.

Halfway round the posterior wall, Ludwig surfaced out of shock without warning.

Mirecki's saline was refilling his right atrium just enough to perfuse his brainstem, and there was zero anesthetic in his blood—only twenty milligrams of cold morphine someone had jabbed into his thigh out in the snow, which hadn't even absorbed out of frozen subcutaneous fat until now. His spine bowed upward; a raw, guttural sound tore up behind his teeth, and his uninjured right arm whipped out of the porter's grip toward Sylwia's wrist.

Before the porter could yell, the East Prussian *Gefreiter* dropped his Walther back into its holster, lunged across the head of the table, and pinned his commander's right shoulder and jaw down against the rubber pad with his good forearm and the side of his own stubbled cheek—careful even in violence not to jar the left side by a hair's breadth.

"Ruhig, Herr Oberstleutnant," the boy rasped straight into Ludwig's ear, blood from his own mangled left muffler dripping down onto the zinc floor pan beneath the table head. "Liegenbleiben, Herr Oberstleutnant—

wir sind raus, der Koffer ist im Feuer, ich hab ihn verbrannt wie befohlen —ruhig jetzt—"

Der Koffer ist im Feuer. I burned the briefcase as ordered.

Sylwia did not lift her eyes from the triangle of silk by a fraction of a degree. Her needle took bite eleven, bite twelve, bite thirteen along the anterior wall, pulled snug, knotted thrice square against the third stay-thread. Only her ears registered every syllable in that East Prussian country rasp—*ambush, burned briefcase, before anybody else reached the wreck*—filing it cold behind her forehead where Marek's voice from five hours ago still sat: *Abwehrstelle had motor-pool movement after four, and Szucha wasn't notified.*

"Distal clamp off first," Sylwia murmured.

She pinched the lower bulldog clamp open. Dark retrograde blood filled the stitched segment smoothly, puffing the pale cylinder taut like a tiny white sausage skin. One pinpoint red bead sweated through between stitch four and stitch five; she pressed a warm saline patty gently over it with her ring finger without panic, waited forty seconds by her own carotid pulse, and released the upper bulldog clamp from beneath the first rib.

Thup. Thup. Thup.

The artery leaped alive under her bare fingertip—stronger now with four hundred milliliters of warm saline behind it, thrusting solid red hammer-strokes straight across the black silk ring down into the cold gray arm. She slid two fingers down to his left wrist, crusted with dried mud and powder-soot inside the torn cuff. Faint, thready, racing at one-twenty-eight, the radial pulse tapped back against her skin.

Mirecki let out a long wheeze through his moustache that smelled like a cherry orchard on fire. "Matko Boska. It holds. Give me five minutes of ten drops chloroform on the Schimmelbusch mask now so you can close the chest defect and skin before he wakes properly—"

"Close the apical pleura tear only," Sylwia said, picking up the heavy blunt Volkmann curette and curved tissue scissors instead of skin needles. "Three catgut mattress stitches over pectoralis minor to seal the lung dome after Bronka blows positive pressure—no, wait till he coughs on a drop of chloroform, clamp on full inspiration so we trap minimal air. The superficial wound, deltopectoral cleft, and axillary pocket stay wide open."

At the head of the table, the young *Gefreiter* stiffened suspiciously, looking at the gaping palm-sized crater in his officer's upper chest where clipped muscle bellies, resected collarbone ends, and the faint dark line of her stitched vessel pulsed behind a thin muscular curtain she was tacking loosely across it for cover. "Warum nähen Sie ihn nicht zu?" he demanded hoarsely. "Why aren't you sewing him shut?"

Sylwia looked up at him fully for the first time across the steaming tray. Boy wasn't twenty-three; turnip-blond hair plastered in sweat to his skull, pupils huge with shock from his own shattered fingers, dog-blind devotion keeping him upright on two boots full of snow-water.

"Because whoever shot your *Oberstleutnant* punched half a filthy winter overcoat, road horse-shit, and unsterile steel splinters four inches into torn pectoral muscle," Sylwia said in crisp German, cutting every trace of Slavic softness out of her consonants until she sounded like Luisenstraße Amphitheater Number Two. "Sew that shut tonight for cosmetic vanity and by Saturday gas gangrene eats across his mediastinum and kills him stinking. We heal contaminated war wounds *per secundam intentionem* —packed open from the floor up with iodoform gauze, drained, and scraped raw every forty-eight hours until clean granulation grows out from underneath. If you prefer pretty stitches and a pine box by Sunday, drive him to *Lazarett Ujazdowski* and let a Party dermatologist murder him cleanly."

Mirecki winced violently behind his pince-nez—talking about "Party dermatologists" in front of two armed *Feldgendarmen* by the vestibule door was a one-way tram ride toward Aleja Szucha—and hurried in with oiled silk Berlin deference: "Frau Doktor Kotarska trained five years under Geheimrat von Halden at the Berlin Charité, *Herr Gefreiter*. Her vascular technique just saved your commander's life and his left arm."

The boy's pale eyes flicked from Mirecki back to Sylwia's blood-caked hands, lingered half a beat on the steadiness with which she was laying yellow, pungent iodoform ribbon deep into the raw pocket around two fenestrated rubber Carrel tubes, and gave a short, jerky nod. Only then did his knees buckle two inches against the porcelain table pedestal before he caught himself on his right elbow.

"Sit down on that stool before I have two carcasses to mop around," Sylwia told him sharply. "Bronka, once Room Fourteen's bed is warmed

with hot bricks, bring this idiot back here so I can trim what's left of his metacarpals before he faints onto my instruments."

Mirecki touched three cautious drops of chloroform onto the wire gauze mask just long enough to let Sylwia drive three swift, brutal catgut figure-of-eights over the deep pleural tear at peak chest expansion, sealing off the sucking whistle in the lung apex while leaving the whole overlying flesh crater unpacked and weeping freely into five layers of yellow iodoform gauze and gray cellulose wadding. No plaster spica yet—if that arterial seam blew a secondary hemorrhage at four in the morning under plaster, nobody would reach the vessel before he died. Instead she bound his left arm tight across his lower ribs in a Velpeau turn of broad calico roller bandage so he couldn't abduct the shoulder and tear six millimeters of black silk apart in delirium.

When the two orderlies slid canvas poles through to lift him toward Room Fourteen, his head lolled sideways toward Sylwia's hip.

Chloroform was light; the cold air of the corridor was already clearing it. His eyelashes—dark at the roots, bleached pale at the tips just as she remembered hating across sunlit dissecting tables when her own eyes burned from formalin—twitched once. Through a slit of clouded green iris, his gaze snagged on her throat, climbed past her chin to her mouth, and stalled on her cheekbones under the harsh garlic-white glare of the corridor lamp.

No recognition could hold at seventy-over-forty pressure with two liters of blood missing; she knew shock physiology cold. Yet his cracked right hand shifted half an inch inside the blanket fold, and one dry German syllable scraped off the back of his tongue—not *Schwester*, not *Arzt*, not *Wasser*.

"*Du,*" he breathed, barely audible under the squeak of the rubber stretcher wheels, and went slack again into gray stupor before Room Fourteen's oak door swung shut behind him.

Sylwia stood alone beside Table One while warm red water swirled sluggishly around boot-clots toward the brass floor grate. Her left thumb joint ached all the way up the radial border of her forearm from twenty-two minutes of bone-crushing compression against his first rib. Slowly she looked down at her palm. Dried brown arterial crust from Ludwig Schoeler's heart filled every life-line and knuckle crease of her skin, overlaid squarely across the pale, twelve-year-old white scar at the base

of her thumb that she had taken in Berlin the last July night neither of them ever spoke about aloud.

Behind her at the zinc scrub trough, Bronka pumped freezing well-water into the basin with a screech of iron leather-washers.

"Hot bricks are under his feet, pani doktor," the matron said low in Polish, glancing once toward the vestibule where the two *Feldgendarmen* were already cranking the wall field-telephone to report an *Oberstleutnant* down to garrison headquarters. "The young corporal won't let our porter touch the bloody greatcoat—he dragged it into Room Fourteen himself and stuffed it under the iron bedstead. Who the devil did they shoot up at one in the morning in Ochota?"

Sylwia plunged both raw hands down into ice-cold sublimate of mercury until the salt-burn made gray sparks jump behind her eyelids, took up the stiff bristle brush, and began scrubbing Ludwig's blood out from under her nails.

"Bring the corporal in," she said. "And boil the small bone-nibblers twice."

Chapter II

Ether and Coal Dust

Warsaw, 10–11 February 1943

The corporal's fourth and fifth fingers hung by gray ribbons of flexor tendon and dirty skin, black with cordite tattooing where a bullet had smashed the steering wheel rim of the *Kübelwagen* into splinters of vulcanite and steel right inside his grip. His ring-finger metacarpal head was crushed into wet gravel.

"Sit back against the wall if your ears ring," Sylwia told him, drawing up two percent procaine—Polish *Polfa* prewar stock with sediment specks at the bottom of the brown bottle, hoarded for digits and teeth because general anesthesia cost forty grams of ether—into a glass Record syringe whose plunger leaked backward across her thumb unless she held it crooked. "I'm blocking the ulnar and median nerves at the wrist crease. It stings like boiling grease for ten seconds and then goes wooden."

"Kein Äther," the boy muttered. Without his reversible winter hood he looked even younger, ears sticking out red and chapped from aregulation Wehrmacht haircut shaved white above the neck-bone, nose broadened slightly at the bridge where a horse or a sergeant had kicked him years ago. With his good right hand he unbuckled his belt slightly, pulled out his gray metal identity disc only far enough for Bronka to copy the stamped characters onto the yellow Wehrmacht casualty slip—*Mekelburg, Bruno, Gefr. — St.Kp. Nachr.Ers.Abt. 1*, a bland Königsberg signals replacement depot tag that fooled nobody whose officer rode around Ochota burning briefcases at midnight—and tucked the tin oval straight back inside his damp wool shirt. "Ich muss wach bleiben. Bis unsere Leute da sind."

"Your people telephoned twenty minutes ago from Saski Square," Docent Mirecki said from the radiator, where he sat rubbing his blue-veined shins and pretending for dignity's sake that his hands weren't shaking

now that the adrenalin had ebbed out of his cherry spirit. "Two military policemen from *Kommandantur* are already smoking in my vestibule. Nobody is going to carry your *Oberstleutnant* off up the chimney while Frau Doktor tidies your stumps."

Mekelburg didn't answer Mirecki. Peasants from East Prussia—Masurian borderlanders half the time, with grandmothers who cursed cows in dialect Polish while voting German in plebiscites and sending grandsons to shoot Poles—knew instantly who ran a kitchen or a slaughter-shed. His pale, lashless eyes stayed fixed on Sylwia's face while she slid the needle point beneath his palmaris longus tendon.

He didn't flinch when the procaine went in, only clamped his back molars until the masseter muscle jumped under his stubbled jaw. While the block took hold, Sylwia scrubbed the shredded left palm mercilessly with warm sterile soap-water and steel forceps, picking five jagged crumbs of black steering-wheel ebonite out of the hypothenar muscle belly.

"What blew the glass in?" she asked conversationally in German, testing the web of his little finger with mouse-tooth forceps until she saw he felt pressure without pain. "Grenade or pistol?"

"Snowbank," Mekelburg said flatly. "Skidded into an iron post."

"Iron posts in Ochota spit nine-millimeter Parabellum jackets now?" She snipped the dead fifth ray cleanly disarticulated at the metacarpophalangeal joint with bone-cutting forceps—*snap*, cartilage gleaming pearly blue-white under the acetylene lamp before dark venous ooze filmed it over—and rongeured the shattered head of the fourth metacarpal smooth on a bevel so when skin flaps healed over the palm edge he wouldn't have a tender bone spur jabbing every shovel handle or rifle stock he gripped for the rest of his life. "Keep that story for your company clerk, *Gefreiter*. If an iron post also shot your commander through the left infraclavicular fossa at downward forty-degree trajectory from an upper window or railway embankment, tell him he was lucky the iron post shot high."

Mekelburg's breath hitched once—not at the bone-nibbler crunching his fourth knuckle away, because the procaine held solid, but at *downward forty-degree trajectory*. Slowly his eyes dropped to her swift hands fashioning a palmar skin flap—saving every scrap of tough, blood-rich volar pad from the ruined ring finger before discarding the dead bone, folding

thick hairless palm skin upward over the raw amputation stump so the scar line would lie dorsally out of his grip.

"Why are you turning the skin from underneath like that?" he asked hoarsely.

"Because you drive cars and lift crates with the front of your hand, not the back," Sylwia said, driving curved cutting needles through tough horny dermis with a rhythmic *chirp* of linen thread. "Put a scar in the crease of a working man's palm and it splits open every frost. You have a thumb, an index, and a middle finger untouched. Keep them clean for ten days and you'll still button your own trousers and hold reins. Leave the bandage soaked in axle grease and you'll lose the wrist to tendon-sheath pus by Lent."

For ten seconds the boy watched her knot off the sixth interrupted stitch, clip the tails cleanly to four millimeters, and dust yellow sulfanilamide powder sparingly along the seam before wrapping the ulnar half of his hand in gauze over a boiled wooden tongue-depressor splint. Something cautious and animal shifted behind his pale eyes—not gratitude, nothing so soft or treacherous, merely the slow calculation of a farm dog discovering the vet hadn't drowned the litter.

"Er hat Ihren Namen nicht gesagt," Mekelburg murmured suddenly, too low for Mirecki by the radiator to catch over the hiss of the Primus stove. *He didn't say your name.* "Im Wagen nicht. Nur dass Lindleya vierhundert Meter näher liegt als die Koszykowa-Wache, als mir das Lenkrad wegflog. Und dann auf dem Flur—" He stopped himself short, jaw snapping shut as if he had already given away three pfennigs too much.

Sylwia tied off the roller bandage around his wrist with a sharp double tuck that made him wince despite the nerve block. *He knew Lindleya was four hundred meters closer.* Meaning Ludwig Schoeler had been conscious enough in the back of a shot-up *Kübelwagen*, with two fingers of his own right hand stuffed under a bayonet strap into his spurting collarbone hole, to navigate Warsaw streets by memory in a blizzard—without having the faintest notion she worked inside Pavilion Three. Why should he? Last he knew of Sylwia Kotarska, she was boarding a night train to Poznań in March nineteen-thirty-three with two battered leather suitcases and four Reichsmarks sixty in her purse. Warsaw had a million and a quarter souls before the bombs and nine hospitals left standing. Sheer blind arithmetic of bleeding arteries and street corners had dumped him onto Table One.

She found she hated sheer blind arithmetic almost as much as design.

At half-past seven, when dirty pearl daylight was leaking through the frosted upper panes and city current had come back weakly enough to turn the ceiling bulbs the colour of stagnant tea, Stabsarzt Doktor Kurt Vesper arrived in great state.

Vesper always smelled from six paces away of pink Odol toothwater,Yardley lavender brilliantine looted from Paris in forty, and last night's cognac sweating sourly through fat white pores around his nostrils. Before the war he had owned a private gynecological sanatorium in Schwabing where Munich brewer's wives went for rest cures and discreet curettages; three years in the Generalgouvernement had thickened his neck over his velvet-edged Wehrmacht collar without teaching him which end of a Thomas femur splint went toward the hip. Behind him marched a tall, humorless Wehrmacht captain wearing *Abwehrstelle* staff tabs who introduced himself to nobody, and two military policemen with MP40 submachine guns slung across their chests.

"Unheard of," Vesper announced in the corridor outside Room Fourteen, slapping soft pigskin gloves against his riding breeches while Mirecki bowed three degrees deeper than strictly required by Generalgouvernement medical ordinance. "Utterly irregular, Herr Kollege Mirecki! An officer of *Oberstleutnant* rank brought into a Polish municipal pavilion without prior clearance from *Sanitätsabteilung Warschau*! My motor-ambulance from *Reserve-Lazarett Eins* is backing up to your ramp as we speak—stretcher crew waiting, heated cabin, German nursing sisters—"

"Nobody moves him today," Sylwia said.

She had not changed out of her operating smock; dried rust-brown spatters stippled the front from breastbone to hem because clean smocks came round on Mondays and today was Wednesday. She stood blocking the half-glass door of Room Fourteen with a tin temperature clipboard crooked under her elbow and dark purple hollows bruised deep beneath both eyes from thirty hours awake.

Vesper puffed his damp upper lip out beneath his clipped toothbrush moustache. He disliked Sylwia intensely—partly because her Berlin German made his Bavarian vowels sound like beer-hall cabaret, partly because last November she had corrected his diagnosis of an "acute appendicular phlegmon" in a Luftwaffe paymaster by pulling a ruptured

ectopic pregnancy out of the paymaster's Polish mistress on Table Two while Vesper stood blinking in galoshes.

"Frau Doktor Kotarska," Vesper said stiffly, raising his chin for the benefit of the silent *Abwehr* captain beside him, "your emergency intervention last night is noted and will be entered favorably in the quarterly municipal hospital report. However, post-operative care of senior Wehrmacht officers belongs exclusively under Reich medical supervision on Ujazdowskie—"

"Look at the chart before you sign his death warrant, *Herr Stabsarzt*," Sylwia interrupted, holding out the clipboard without yielding an inch of doorway. "Subclavian-axillary arterial transition severed two-thirds across by jagged steel casing. Primary end-to-end Carrel anastomosis in five-zero silk over a two-centimeter clavicular resection, completed five hours ago without heparin because there isn't a vial of Liquemin between here and Breslau. His systolic pressure is ninety-four over fifty-eight. Do you know how thick the wall of a human axillary artery is after intimal trimming, *Herr Stabsarzt*?"

Vesper's pink eyelids blinked rapidly. Gynecologists tied uterine arteries blind in broad ligament fat with #2 catgut thick as grocer's string; he hadn't touched a major peripheral arterial repair since his state exam under Lexer in nineteen-twenty-six. "Naturally—vascular wall fragility is well understood—"

"One millimeter point two," Sylwia said coldly. "Right now a fresh platelet fibrin cuff less than the thickness of wet cigarette paper is sealing twenty-four silk needle holes while every heartbeat hammers ninety millimeters of mercury against it, without a plaster shoulder spica because plaster hides secondary hemorrhage. Bounce him three kilometers east down Nowogrodzka and across Marszałkowska tram-rails in a springless field ambulance this morning, and stitch six tears through bruised media before you pass the church of St. Alexander. He will dump three liters of blood into the dressing in ninety seconds flat. By the time your orderlies open the rear doors at Ujazdowskie, you'll be lifting out a corpse."

She held out her cheap steel fountain pen, uncapped, nib pointed squarely at Vesper's chest buttons.

"Sign the transfer release right here across the top of my operative note, *Herr Stabsarzt*, accepting sole clinical responsibility over surgeon's

contraindication. I'll have two porters bring him down to your ambulance in four minutes."

Silence dropped over the tiled corridor, broken only by water knocking inside the half-warmed steam pipe along the wainscot and a distant coughing fit from the Polish ward upstairs.

Beside Vesper, the tall *Abwehr* captain spoke for the first time. He had thin gray hair combed flat across a narrow Prussian skull and eyes like two tarnished pfennigs. "How many days before an arterial suture of that class withstands transport, Frau Doktor?"

"Ten days minimum if it stays afebrile," Sylwia said directly to the captain, ignoring Vesper altogether. "Fourteen to twenty-one if anaerobic infection flares in the open muscle pocket—and it will flare, because whoever blew your car window in drove dirty overcoat wool down against his brachial plexus. Move him early and either the vessel blows out from bacterial mycotic softening of the suture line, or a mural thrombus shakes loose and plugs his left middle cerebral artery."

The captain looked past her shoulder through the wired glass panel of Room Fourteen, where Mekelburg sat upright on a wooden stool beside the white iron bed, splint resting across his knee, watching the door handle like a mastiff. Actually, keeping a wounded *Abwehr* officer tucked inside a quiet, sealed six-room annex on Lindleya with two sentries at the corridor doors—rather than on an open officers' surgical ward at *Lazarett Ujazdowski* where thirty Wehrmacht doctors, SD liaison clerks, and Red Cross visitors wandered past every bed—appeared to strike the narrow-skulled captain as unexpectedly convenient.

"My chief in Berlin will wish *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler alive and lucid rather than ceremonially housed, *Herr Stabsarzt*," the captain told Vesper softly. "We will post a twenty-four-hour two-man guard at the swing doors of this wing and one inside Room Fourteen. Clear Rooms Twelve, Thirteen, and Fifteen completely. Only Docent Mirecki, Frau Doktor Kotarska, and one vetted scrub nurse you personally vouch for are to enter Room Fourteen until *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler can sit upright in a staff car."

Vesper swallowed hard, rescuing his dignity by puffing out his chest and waving his pigskin glove magnanimously at Mirecki. "Just what I was about to propose on inspection of the pulse curve, Hauptmann! Quite out of the question to jolt fresh Carrel silk over winter potholes—elementary

vascular prudence! Docent Mirecki, you answer to me with your head for asepsis and security in this corridor. I shall inspect the wound personally every forty-eight hours."

"Every privilege, Herr Stabsarzt," Mirecki murmured, bowing until his pince-nez swung free on their black ribbon.

Sylwia capped her fountain pen with a sharp click. Behind her back, through four inches of painted hospital pine, she could almost feel the silent geometry of Room Fourteen tightening around Pavilion Three like wire twisted round a parcel: three German MP40s permanently stationed forty feet below the Polish wards where two forged typhus charts and a boy from the Radom railway sabotage ring were currently hiding under false appendectomy scars.

And on the iron bed inside, kept breathing by twenty-four tiny bites of black vaselined silk she had put in with her own steady hand, lay Ludwig.

* * *

Berlin, October 1928

In the autumn before the big freeze cracked the water mains along Unter den Linden, the dissecting hall of the *Anatomisches Institut* on Philippstraße smelled of phenol, wet loden coats, and cheap *Sturm* cigarettes smoked illegally behind the zinc cadaver vats by boys whose fathers wore duelling scars from Heidelberg and Bonn.

Sylwia was eighteen years and four months old, six weeks out of the Polish diplomatic flat on Kurfürstenstraße since her father had been recalled to Warsaw over the rye-tariff talks and left her eighty marks a month, an iron cot in Widow Pohl's boarding apartment off Savignyplatz, and cold instructions not to disgrace Poznań brains among Prussians. Out of a hundred and ninety second-semester medical students crowded around twenty-four grey slate tables under the skylights, eleven were women and precisely one had a Polish passport stamped across her *Studienbuch*. Whenever she asked for the bone-saw or the red wax pencil, the three *Corpsstudenten* assigned to Table Seven—two Pomeranian landowners' sons with sticking-plaster still taped across fresh *Mensur* cheek-cuts and a fat Saxon pharmacist's heir named Kleist—developed instantaneous deafness, conversing loudly across her crown about rowing sculls at

Grünau while leaving her the stripped abdominal mesentery fat nobody wanted to clean.

By the third week of October she stopped asking for instruments. She bought her own second-hand Collin dissecting kit from a pawnbroker behind Alexanderplatz—ebony handles darkened by some dead army surgeon's sweat, steel honed on a barber's Belgian hone until it shaved arm hair dry—arrived at six-fifteen every morning when the old one-armed *Diener* unlocked the zinc tanks, and claimed Cadaver Nineteen at the corner window table after a tubercular Rhineland student dropped out spitting blood.

Cadaver Nineteen had been a coal-barge woman fished out of the Landwehrkanal near Hallesches Tor in August: fifty-odd, broad-boned, calves knotted with purple varicosities fixed blue-gray by carbolic injection, calluses thick as horn along both palms from hauling wet hemp hawsers. Nobody wanted Table Nineteen because the cold draft down the tall north casement numbed your fingers stiff by nine o'clock and Geheimrat Professor von Halden's Wednesday surgical-anatomy spot-checks always started along the sunny center aisle before work took him back to Luisenstraße.

On the last Tuesday of October, Sylwia walked up the wet stone stairs at ten minutes past six in sleet-darkness, shaking rain off her too-long black umbrella, and stopped dead inside the swing doors.

The green-shaded gooseneck lamp above Table Nineteen was already lit.

Someone in a starched white laboratory smock two inches too short at the cuffs—wrists lean and big-boned, damp dark-blond hair raked carelessly straight back off a high forehead with wet fingers—stood bent low over her barge-woman's propped left shoulder, working a fine pair of Graefe iris forceps deep beneath the reflected pectoralis minor with unhurried, proprietary absorption.

Not one of the Corps boys. Corps boys stood spraddle-legged like cavalrymen and hacked fascia as if peeling turnips; besides, this one had an unmarked face—high, clean cheekbones, an arrogant narrow nose, a mouth cut too sharp at the corners for good humor—and a threadbare navy-blue naval officer's pea-coat from ten winters ago flung dry over the radiator pipe behind him, its brass anchor buttons replaced by plain horn.

Sylwia walked down the slate aisle until the wet rubber soles of her overshoes squeaked two feet from his elbow.

"That is Table Nineteen," she said.

He did not startle, and he did not take his forceps off the glistening pale cord of the musculocutaneous nerve until he had separated a delicate spiderweb of injected vasa nervorum intact down to its entry into the coracobrachialis. Only then did he straighten half-way, glancing sidelong down three inches of height at her drenched black felt cloche hat and fierce dark eyes.

Up close his irises were winter river-water—grey-green with a narrow black limbal ring—cool, sleepless, and wholly devoid of apology.

"Table Nineteen was unassigned on the beadle's chalkboard after Moeller hemorrhaged," he said. Not East Elbian Junker bark; crisp Berlin-West mixed with north-coast Kiel salt, fast and dry. "And whoever started reflecting the deltoid flap yesterday afternoon left five millimeters of clavipectoral fascia sloppy along the coracoid process, which would have torn the lateral thoracic artery off cleanly if I hadn't rescued it twenty minutes ago. You can take the right leg if you need femoral triangle practice."

Blood climbed hot and silent behind Sylwia's cheekbones—the dangerous kind that made her voice drop quiet rather than rise. "My name has been chalked in the corner slot of Nineteen's slate frame since Thursday. If you couldn't read four inches below your elbow, wash your eyes out at the tap. And I left that five-millimeter cuff of clavipectoral fascia unstripped deliberately because Nineteen has a high-splitting doubled thoracoacromial trunk piercing five millimeters medial to textbook line, which any second-day butcher hurrying to clear muscle bellies would have sliced off at the root—exactly where your left forceps blade just nicked the venous comitans."

For the space of two breaths his eyes flicked down into the axillary hollow—where, unmistakably, a tiny shred of blue-wax-injected vein wall lay severed beside his clean nerve—and then rose straight back to her face.

Most twenty-year-old men caught in an error by an eighteen-year-old girl with a faint Posen-Polish clip on her *r*'s either blustered red or laughed it off with heavy condescension. He did neither. His nostrils flared half a millimeter; the corner of his mouth tightened white, taking her entire measure—shabby black coat sleeves darned with silk thread

at the wrists, pawnshop ebony scalpel box already unlatched in her ungloved hand, furious precision—and filing her instantaneously not as a curiosity or a woman, but as an enemy on narrow ground.

"Schoeler," he said shortly, neither clicking heels nor bowing. "And Geheimrat von Halden's Wednesday demonstration prize this term goes to the cleanest unilateral brachial plexus preparation on the floor. One cadaver cannot turn in two left shoulders."

"Then go find yourself a dead Prussian in the tank, Herr Schoeler," Sylwia said, setting her ebony box down with a sharp snap on the slate lip beside his elbow and stripping off her wet coat without yielding two inches of table margin, "because the right plexus on Nineteen is mine, and by tomorrow morning at nine o'clock von Halden won't bother looking at your left."

They stood shoulder to shoulder across four feet of carbolized human carcass for eleven hours straight that Tuesday without speaking another ten words, sharing neither grease-pencil nor sponge bucket, elbows knocking cold whenever both leaned over the sternum at once to trace the scalene hiatus from opposite sides of the barge-woman's neck. At two in the afternoon Kleist strolled over eating a liverwurst roll to make some heavy joke about the *Polnische Wirtschaft* setting up shop with "Bastard-Schoeler from Charlottenburg," and shriveled backward three steps when both of them looked up from opposite sides of the corpse with identical murderous silence. By seven that evening Sylwia's fingers were numb blue to the second knuckle from phenol water and hunger; she refused to go down to Aschinger's for five-pfennig pea soup with unlimited rolls because Schoeler hadn't gone, and she knew—with visceral, lunatic certainty—that the second she left the hall he would work an hour past lock-up bribing one-armed Otto with cigarettes. So she stayed till nine, chewing half a dry crust of sour rye inside her smock pocket while her eyes blurred under the green glass shade, teasing every finest twig of the medial cutaneous nerve out of grey fat until the right axilla looked like ivory lace suspended over red muscle.

At nine-fifteen Wednesday morning, Geheimrat von Halden swept down the north aisle in his spotless floor-length white coat, trailed by three terrified *Oberärzte*, six *Assistenten*, and forty crowding students crane-necked for blood.

Von Halden paused at Table Nineteen, hooked gold-rimmed spectacles onto his hooked Pomeranian nose, and looked down at the left shoulder first.

"Clean," the great man murmured, touching the tip of a silver probe almost caressingly to Ludwig's preparation. "Subscapular nerves preserved down to the teres major entry. Who prepared the left?"

"Schoeler, Herr Geheimrat," Ludwig said smoothly. Not boastful; quiet, respectful, letting the work speak—and then, with a minute, deliberate half-turn of his shoulder that blocked two *Assistenten*'s view of the right side while sounding helpful as choir-silk: "A rare textbook variation on the left, Herr Geheimrat: complete absence of the lateral root contribution to the median nerve, compensated low in the mid-brachium. The right side appears symmetrical so far as the superficial dissection reached last night."

So far as the superficial dissection reached last night.

Sylwia felt cold needle-ice go straight down her spine into her heels. He hadn't sabotaged her side with a blade—that would have been clumsy, detectable, amateurish. Instead, arriving ten minutes before eight, he had draped her finished right shoulder neatly under a heavy phenol-soaked oilcloth sheet as custom required for *unfinished* specimens so drying air wouldn't shrivel half-cleaned fat, ensuring von Halden would inspect the uncovered left showcase, nod at "symmetrical," and sweep down the aisle without ever lifting the cloth!

Already von Halden was turning half a step toward Table Twenty.

Sylwia reached across the barge-woman's breastbone, pinched the corner of the dripping phenol oilcloth between two raw fingers, and whipped it clean off the right shoulder in a single crisp snap that spattered three drops of carbolic water across Ludwig Schoeler's starched cuff.

"Not symmetrical at all, *Herr Geheimrat*," Sylwia said clearly into the horrified hush of forty male throats. "Bilateral asymmetry. On the right side the missing lateral contribution does not wait for the mid-brachium —it pierces coracobrachialis high behind the pectoralis minor tendon and sends a recurrent communicating loop straight back beneath the axillary artery, where Herr Schoeler's left-side dissection stopped two millimeters too shallow to look behind the vessel sheath."

Dead, breathless quiet. Kleist actually opened his mouth round like a carp. Across the slate trough, Ludwig stood dead still, two dark spots

of carbolic wet on his white linen wrist, looking not at von Halden—at *her*, grey-green eyes narrowed to bright slits of pure, astonished venom and something sharper underneath that had no polite name in German or Polish.

Von Halden stepped back to Table Nineteen. For ninety eternal seconds the silver probe dipped behind Sylwia's right axillary artery—lifting the hair-fine white communicating loop she had found at half-past eight last night when her eyes were watering—and then crossed straight to Ludwig's left side, hooking Ludwig's intact axillary artery aside to reveal, buried untouched in deep perivascular fascia nobody ever opened unless hunting ghosts, the exact tiny mirror-loop Ludwig had missed because he had been busy admiring his clean nerve trunks.

Von Halden straightened slowly. He looked at the small dark nineteen-year-old girl in the darned black cardigan cuffs; he looked at the tall blond twenty-year-old boy with the horn-buttoned pea-coat behind him. A dry, dangerous crease dented one corner of the old surgeon's mouth.

"Herr Schoeler," von Halden said pleasantly, "knows how to display an anatomy plate so gentlemen clap. Fräulein Kotarska appears to know that corpses lie. Split the book voucher down the middle, Herr Oberarzt —and put them on opposite sides of the same dog table next semester so neither grows lazy."

When the retinue swept onward toward Table Twenty, nobody congratulated her. Across the sunken chest of the drowned barge-woman, Ludwig picked up his chamois cloth and wiped his scalpel blade dry from heel to point with slow, surgical care.

"Don't leave your oilcloth unwatched next time, *Fräulein Kotarska*," he murmured softly, for her ears alone. "Warsaw rules may forgive luck once. I don't."

"Buy deeper spectacles with your half-voucher, *Herr Schoeler*," she whispered back, smiling straight into his teeth while packing her pawnshop ebony case. "You dissect like a window-dresser."

* * *

Warsaw, 11 February 1943

At eleven o'clock on Thursday night the green-shaded reading bulb beside Bed Fourteen threw a tilted cone of weak yellow light across

scrubbed white floorboards and left the high corners of the ceiling drowned in shadow.

Outside the closed oak door, the two *Abwehr* military policemen traded matches in whispers; inside the room, Bruno Mekelburg slept sitting bolt upright on a straight chair jammed into the window corner behind the blackout blind, chin sunk onto his good chest-crossed arm, splinted left hand resting upright against his collarbone like a white wooden paddle. Every twenty minutes the boy woke for three seconds whenever Sylwia moved, checked that it was only her white smock between bed and tray, and dropped straight back under like a sentry trained in freezing trenches.

Ludwig had not slept since seven that evening.

Fever sat at thirty-eight point six—moderate surgical resorption fever so far, not yet the jagged saw-tooth spike of anaerobic sepsis—putting a dry, glassy sheen across his forehead and hollowing the sockets beneath his cheekbones until the skull architecture showed clean and gaunt as an X-ray plate. Forty hours after losing half his blood volume on a snowy floor, a sensible casualty lay quiet under ten milligrams of morphine and thanked God for warm linen. Four hours ago Ludwig had refused Bronka's evening morphine syringe by turning his head flat into the pillow and locking his jaws until Bronka threatened in Wola Polish to sit on his nose and pour castor oil down his ear instead; when Sylwia came on night duty at nine, she had found the morphine ampoule still unbroken on the enamel stand and his grey-green eyes wide open on the ceiling crack.

Now she stood on his left side—the ruined side, where he had to turn his head thirty degrees against stiff sternocleidomastoid pull to watch her—unpinning the outer cellulose pad to check the Carrel irrigation tubes and the distal radial pulse before midnight.

The sweetish, hospital-sharp reek of wet iodoform rose off the warm dressings mixed with old blood serum and the sharp, unwashed animal salt of male sweat. His chest was bare under the folded-back rough linen hospital sheet; somebody—Mekelburg, presumably—had shaved the dark-blond hair off his left pectoral and upper ribs dry when prepping the adhesive tape border, leaving two angry razor nicks near the nipple. Across his right ribs and flat, sunken abdomen, five winters of war had hardened the lean twenty-three-year-old body she remembered only

through starched clinic coats into corded, unforgiving sinew, with an older jagged white shell-splinter scar puckered low above his right iliac crest—France in forty, maybe, or nineteen-forty-one in the mud before Moscow.

She laid two cool fingers lightly over his left radial artery at the wrist. Eighty-eight beats per minute, full volume, warm skin down to the fingernails, capillary refill under two seconds when she pinched his thumbnail white. Intima-to-intima everted seam holding without a murmur of thrill.

"No aneurysm thrill yet," a dry, scraped voice said six inches above her bent ear, in Berlin German pitched barely louder than the steam-pipe hiss so Mekelburg in the corner didn't stir. "Five-zero vaselined silk, continuous over-and-over. I could tell by the wrist pulse yesterday afternoon you didn't waste time on interrupted mattress."

Sylwia did not take her fingers off his wrist until she had finished counting a full thirty seconds against her pinned lapel watch. Then she laid his arm precisely back inside the calico Velpeau sling fold and picked up the glass Dakin's syringe to flush five milliliters of fresh sodium hypochlorite down the upper rubber Carrel tube into the open wound bed.

Cold antiseptic hissed softly deep inside raw muscle; every tendon in his throat stood out like wire as the chlorine bite hit bare nerve endings beneath his resected collarbone, and sweat jumped in fine beads along his upper lip, though not a sound passed his teeth.

"Talk less," Sylwia said evenly, eyes on the yellow return fluid weeping cleanly into the kidney basin Bronka had left wedged on waterproof oilcloth under his shoulder. "You tore two centimeters of apical pleura Tuesday night. Pop a catgut knot coughing to show off your pulse diagnostics and I won't bother putting a chest drain in neatly—I'll stick a trocar between your ribs cold."

"You already left the whole deltopectoral triangle wide open like a butcher's stall." His voice sounded as if someone had dragged broken brick through his larynx—dry mouth from fluid restriction and mouth-breathing—yet the old razor-edged cadence sat intact underneath, unblunted by ten years or two liters of spilled blood. "I felt four inches of packed gauze when I shifted at dawn. What did you resect—middle third of the clavicle?"

"Two centimeters. Comminuted into four dirty splinters over the vessel." She capped the upper tube with its sterile glass spigot, flushed the lower tube, checked the return—turbid pink-amber, faintly sour, no gas bubbles, no mouse-nest stink yet—and tucked fresh dry cellulose wadding snugly over the iodoform pad. "Your shoulder girdle will drop six millimeters inward when it calluses. Tailor in Berlin can pad your left tunic board with horsehair so the generals don't weep."

A sound came out of his chest—half silent laugh, half immediate sharp catch of breath as the diaphragm tugged his torn pleura. When she straightened with the soiled kidney basin in her left hand, his eyes locked onto hers across two feet of green-lit air and held.

Ten years.

She had rehearsed seeing Ludwig Schoeler dead a dozen times between September thirty-nine, when German Heinkels dropped incendiaries onto Pavilion Two's roof while she was amputating a tram-conductor's crushed foot in falling plaster dust, and this week—imagining him frozen stiff in Russian snow outside Vyazma, or blown apart in some staff car by mines east of Brest, feeling each time a cold, tidy satisfaction like closing an old ledger column. Never once had she imagined him twenty inches away in white hospital calico with grey stubble shadowing the crescent scar under his right cheekbone, looking straight up through those clear, ruthless winter-water eyes into every line hunger and Warsaw had carved around her mouth since twenty-three.

"Still no gloves, *Kotarska*," he murmured, glancing down at the raw red mercury-burned cracks across her knuckles gripping the enamel rim of the basin. "Von Halden would dock your Sunday theater privileges."

"Von Halden doesn't scrub in ninety-percent methylated wood alcohol after digging German steel out of Polish backsides," she said softly, leaning six inches lower over the bedrail so her shadow fell square across his eyes while Mekelburg snored faintly by the blackout blind. Her voice stayed silk-flat, conversational enough that anyone peeking through the door glass would see a dutiful ward doctor adjusting a pillow corner. "And you aren't in Luisenstraße, *Herr Oberstleutnant*. You are four blocks north of Filtrowa in a city where boys hang from railway bridges with wire round their necks while your posters rot in the sleet."

His gaze didn't flicker away from hers by a hair's breadth. Pale fever-sheen gleamed along his cheekbones; his right hand lay outside the sheet,

long fingers curled loose against rough bleached linen, four paces from Mekelburg's holstered pistol and infinitely further from help if she had chosen Tuesday morning at one-fifteen to lift her thumb.

"I know what city I'm in," Ludwig said, very quiet. "And I know how long a transected axillary trunk bleeds before the heart pumps air. Three minutes, maybe four with cold spasm. Nobody in that theater knew an axillary stump from pectoral fascia except you." His eyes narrowed slightly on her mouth. "Why didn't your thumb slip, Sylwia?"

Hearing her given name spoken in that low Berlin register after ten years hit her solar plexus like swallowing crushed ice whole. Not a muscle in her face moved.

"Because it was my table," she said, cold as the zinc slab downstairs, "and nobody dies messily on my table to save himself a walk later. Don't flatter yourself into philosophy, Schoeler. Pigs get sewn up first so they're fat enough for autumn."

For one second—less than a pulse beat—the grim line of his bloodless mouth almost twitched at the corner, not into warmth, never warmth between them, into that old lethal recognition of thrust and parry no decent human being had ever given either of them since nineteen-thirty-three.

Then pain or exhaustion pulled the gray veil back behind his eyes; his jaw set hard against the pillow as the raw chlorine burn deep in his open chest settled into its long two-hour throb without morphine.

"Turn the lamp off on your way out," he breathed, staring back up at the cracked plaster ceiling. "Your hospital stinks of boiled cabbage and thieves."

"Sleep on your back," Sylwia answered at the door, snapping the green shade switch off with dry fingers and plunging him back into winter dark. "Roll left in your dreams and pull my stitches apart, and next time I'll let Docent Mirecki tie your arm off at the stump."

Chapter III

Debridement

Warsaw, 16 February 1943

The seed merchant's shop on ulica Bagno smelled of dried marjoram, mouse droppings, and dead brick dust blown across from the emptied streets of the Small Ghetto fifty yards west, where every window frame behind the bricked-up boundary wall had been pried out for firewood before Christmas so the tenements stared blind down onto Plac Grzybowski like skulls stacked in an ossuary.

Sylwia stood before the counter weighing small brown paper twists of winter radish and fodder-beet seed in her gloved palm as if calculating balcony pots for spring. Behind the counter old PanCzarnecki coughed wetly into a blue workman's handkerchief and counted zinc ten-grosz pieces into a cigar box so the brass bell above the door wouldn't catch them talking if a Blue Policeman ducked in out of the wind for warm stove air.

In the back storeroom behind stacked burlap sacks of vetch, Marek had spread three damp Leica contact prints no larger than postage stamps on an upturned herring tub.

"Look at the collar tab on the dead driver they fished out of the ditch at Szczęśliwice," Marek said, tilting his pocket magnifying lens over the middle square.

"Mekelburg isn't dead," Sylwia said, bending over the lens without touching the wet gelatin border. "I took two fingers off his left hand Wednesday morning. He eats three bowls of barley groats a day sitting on a stool behind Room Fourteen's door."

"Not Schoeler's driver. The *other* car's driver." Marek tapped the blurred grey rectangle with a matchstick. Snow banked along a railway drainage culvert; half a burned Steyr staff car canted on three wheels;

beside the running board lay a man in civilian sheepskin coat with his throat torn open by pistol fire at contact range and snow drifted into both eye sockets. “Found at five-thirty Tuesday morning by municipal track-walkers before the SD arrived from Aleja Szucha and cordoned half Ochota. One of our boys on the track gang pulled the left boot off before the gendarmes chased them back. Inside the felt insole were twelve hundred dollars in Swiss twenty-franc gold notes? No—paper Zürcher banknotes, serials non-consecutive, and the charred corner of a temporary *Durchlassschein* stamped *Abt. III F — Ast. Warschau*.”

Sylwia straightened slowly inside her thin wool coat. *Abteilung III F.* Even someone who loathed military acronyms knew what *Drei-Eff* meant in German intelligence: counter-espionage against enemy underground networks and foreign wireless rings. Not troop logistics, not bridge security, not Wehrmacht medical liaison.

“Ludwig Schoeler took a *summa cum laude* doctorate on collateral arterial pathways of the mediastinum in nineteen-thirty-two,” she said, hearing how flat her own voice sounded between the burlap sacks. “Geheimrat von Halden groomed him five years to inherit a university surgical clinic before forty.”

“Well, he isn’t cutting dogs now,” Marek said crisply, sliding the three tiny contact prints into a hollow brass curtain-rod section and screwing the end cap tight. “Since forty-one he’s been Canaris’s troubleshooter between Königsberg, Minsk, and Saski Square—rank *Oberstleutnant*, carried nominally on an East Prussian signals replacement roll so his name doesn’t cross regular garrison rosters. Our girls at the central post telegraph office pulled three coded Berlin wires addressed to his desk since Wednesday noon. One from Tirpitzufer itself.”

Tirpitzufer in Berlin—down by the Landwehrkanal, ten minutes’ walk south of the Tiergarten trees where she used to cut across snow in worn-out galoshes with physiology books burning her ribs. Everything in this cursed war turned out to sit four blocks from some street corner where you had once been twenty and hungry and stupid enough to think hatred was a private hobby.

“Then give me two milliliters of strophanthin-K undiluted,” Sylwia said calmly, “or four cubic centimeters of air into his Carrel venous line when Mekelburg steps into the corridor latrine at four in the morning.

Ventricular standstill in ninety seconds. Vesper signs post-traumatic pulmonary embolism before breakfast and goes back to his cognac."

Marek looked up from screwing the brass tube shut. In the grey shaft of light leaking through the frosted transom from Bagno, his cheekbones looked planed out of dry ash-wood; a shaving cut on his chin had scabbed black from cold.

"No," he said.

She stared at him. "You just told me he runs *Abteilung III F* counter-espionage against Warsaw nets."

"Which is why *Góra* wants him breathing inside your pavilion for another two weeks," Marek said, using the flat organizational word—*Upstairs*, High Command—that always shut doors in faces without leaving anybody present to argue with. "Think, Sylwia. Two cars met behind the Ochota coal-water tower at twenty minutes to one on Tuesday morning without notifying Aleja Szucha. Somebody opened up from the embankment above *both* vehicles with silenced submachine guns. Whoever was riding in that second car either died in the snow, got dragged into the black Opel Admiral our switchman saw before the shooting, or walked back into Warsaw carrying an Abwehr safe-conduct and twelve hundred Swiss francs' worth of Polish blood-money."

Cold crept up from the packed clay floor through Sylwia's thin leather soles. "You think someone from our own District staff was in that second car."

"I don't think anything; engineers measure loads," Marek said dryly. "If Szucha's SD ambushed an Abwehr meet on their own turf without telling Saski Square, then either Schoeler was turning one of our people, or one of our people was selling somebody else to Schoeler behind Kroll's back, and Kroll shot the table over to grab the ledger. Either way, if Schoeler dies tonight on Lindleya, Tirpitzufer sends a stranger we can't reach behind six walls at the Brühl Hotel, and whatever name burned in that briefcase stays ash."

He stepped closer between the burlap vetch sacks, resting one gloved hand briefly against her waist—possessive only in the functional way a carpenter tests whether a beam has shifted under snow load.

"You saved him Tuesday night," Marek said. "Good. Now use it. You're the only Pole in Warsaw allowed inside Room Fourteen with the door shut, and you speak their Berlin gutter-German better than half the

Volksdeutsche on Marszałkowska. Keep his wound open long enough that Vesper daren't move him to Ujazdowskie. Listen to every fever-word, every visitor's boots, every name he asks his corporal to burn or telephone. Did you know him in Berlin?"

The question dropped without emphasis—too casual by half. Marek never wasted breath on decorative curiosity. Somebody in *Kontrwywiad*'s biographical card-index had checked the dates on Sylwia's *Charité* diploma against Ludwig Schoeler's university matriculation year between Wednesday and Tuesday noon.

Lie to Marek now on a verifiable university calendar and by Friday she would have a nineteen-year-old boy in borrowed boots shadowing her down Koszykowa to see whom she met at tram stops.

"Everyone at the Charité between twenty-eight and thirty-three knew Schoeler," Sylwia said without blinking, keeping her chin level and her voice soaked in ten-year-old acid so authentic no listener alive could mistake it for fondness. "He was von Halden's prize Prussian bastard and we despised each other's guts across every exam board from anatomy to state finals. When the brownshirts cleared Luisenstraße in March thirty-three, he walked into a Reichswehr commission and I took the night train to Poznań."

Marek studied her dark eyes for three full seconds. Whatever harsh, ugly constriction sat around her mouth clearly satisfied him; nobody faked that particular reflex around a rival's name.

"Does he know who you are?"

"He recognized me Thursday night. And if he intended telling Vesper or the SD anything inconvenient about student politics from nineteen-thirty-two, I'd be on Szucha already instead of buying radish seed." She pulled back half an inch out of Marek's gloved hand, buttoning her top coat button against her throat. "Don't ask me to bat eyelashes at him, Marek. Try playing salon spy with Ludwig Schoeler and he'll smell it before you've crossed the doorsill."

"Don't bat anything," Marek said, almost smiling—a thin, joyless crease. "Hate him all you please. Men starting back from two liters of lost blood talk faster to someone they want to beat in an argument than they ever do to a pretty nurse. Just keep him under Lindleya's roof until we find out whose Swiss francs were in that boot."

* * *

At three o'clock that afternoon, Bronka laid out the boiled debridement tray in Pavilion Three's sterilizer room while water hissed white steam under the lid: two pairs of curved Mayo dissecting scissors honed that morning by old Walenty on the oilstone, toothed Kocher forceps, long anatomical thumb-forceps, a sharp Volkmann spoon, three kidney basins, iodoform ribbon, and one solitary brown five-milliliter ampoule of two-percent procaine.

Sylwia picked up the solitary ampoule between thumb and forefinger, holding it against the grey courtyard window. "Where's the rest of the box?"

"Herr Stabsarzt Vesper signed out eleven ampoules this morning for 'officers' dental blocks' at the Soldatenheim," Bronka said grimly, slamming the brass sterilizer lid down with her hip. Everyone in Pavilion Three knew Vesper traded hospital procaine to private dentists on Hoża for French cognac and real coffee beans. "Left us two ampoules for the whole week—one for the carpenter upstairs when we take his crushed toes off tomorrow, one for Room Fourteen. Unless you give the German a drop of ether on the mask—"

"Ether makes him vomit for four hours afterward, and one violent retching spasm with his clavicle resected tears my axillary suture line straight out of the first rib," Sylwia said, setting the single five-milliliter ampoule back onto the sterile towel with a dry clink. Five milliliters infiltrated skin margins if you diluted it half-and-half with physiological saline; deep down inside a palm-wide pectoral crater where bruised muscle bellies had turned grey-purple over seven days and had to be trimmed back raw to living, bleeding red fiber before anaerobic rot took root, five milliliters was pissing on a coal fire.

Inside Room Fourteen, someone had propped two hard horsehair bolsters behind Ludwig's good right shoulder so he sat tilted at forty-five degrees against the white iron headboard. Daylight was cruel to him in a way Thursday night's green-shaded sixty-watt bulb had not been: five days of resorption fever, meager hospital broth, and refusal of opiates had pared every gram of spare flesh off his jaw and temples, leaving skin the colour of wet putty stretched taut across high, unforgiving bone. Mekelburg had shaved him that morning—better than the butcher job on

his chest, leaving his throat and chin smooth around the pale crescent scar beneath his right cheekbone—and a fresh grey wool Wehrmacht blanket borrowed from his own field roll lay folded squarely across his waist instead of hospital cotton.

On his knees rested a yellow German message pad and a fountain pen held awkwardly in his right hand, writing left-to-right while pinning the paper corner down with his heavy silver pocket-watch so the pad wouldn't slide. The instant the door latch clicked, he flipped the top sheet face-down under the blotter without hurry.

"Lock the hall door while we're open, *Gefreiter*," Sylwia told Mekelburg as Bronka wheeled the enameled dressing cart up to the left rail. "I don't want corridor draft blowing ward dust into an open thorax, and if your military police poke their noses in halfway through they'll faint on my clean floor."

Mekelburg shot the brass bolt obediently and took up his post at the foot of the bed, wooden-splinted left hand tucked inside his tunic front like Napoleon's, watching Bronka lay waterproof rubber sheeting beneath his commander's left flank.

"Herr Stabsarzt Vesper honoured me for twenty minutes before noon," Ludwig remarked conversationally, eyes tracking Sylwia as she rinsed her raw hands in warm sublimate basin at the washstand. Without uniform collar tabs, bare from waist up except for the yellowed calico Velpeau bandage binding his left arm across his ribs, the sheer bony breadth of his shoulders made the narrow Polish municipal mattress look built for schoolboys. "Smelled like a Schwabing hairdresser's shop after closing time. Informed me at considerable length how fortunate I was that his Polish staff acted under his strict vascular protocols."

"Had you rather be at *Lazarett Ujazdowski* listening to gramophone records of Zara Leander while a dermatologist lets your axillary artery slough?" Sylwia dried her hands on a sterile linen towel, lifted the heavy bandage shears, and slit the outer Velpeau turns cleanly down the right ribs.

"God forbid. At Ujazdowski I'd be dead of boredom by Thursday, and half the SS liaison clerks from Aleja Szucha would be bringing me sour grapes to see whether my tongue works." He didn't wince until Bronka eased the stiffened inner gauze pads free from the dried serum crust around the skin edges; even then, only a tiny muscle below his left ear

jumped once as dark stale blood and sweet-rotten iodoform stink lifted into the cool room.

Sylwia bent low over the crater—six inches from his bare sweat-damp throat—and inspected every millimeter in silence.

Deep at the floor of the cleft, beneath the thin viable bridge of pectoralis minor she had tacked across the neurovascular bundle on Tuesday night, rhythmic arterial pulsation beat steady and clean. Good. No expanding pulsatile hematoma, no ominous dark thrill of mycotic blowout. Above and laterally, however, where shredded pectoralis major fibers and crushed subcutaneous fat had taken the full muzzle blast of shattered glass, steel splinters, and dirty overcoat cloth, seven days of compromised capillary blood supply had done their ugly winter work: two finger-thick shelves of muscle belly had turned dull greyish-plum, slimy with yellowish fibrinous slough and wholly avascular. Leave dead meat sitting inside an open wound past Day Seven and by Day Nine proteolytic bacteria liquefied it straight down through your protective muscle bridge onto the five-zero silk.

"What does it look like?" Ludwig asked directly above her temple. Because his neck was stiff from muscle splinting, his breath—dry, faint salt and black ersatz coffee, zero sweet acetone of starvation yet—brushed the dark hair pinned above her right ear every time he spoke.

"Like six-day horsemeat left behind a radiator," Sylwia answered briskly, nodding to Bronka for the Record syringe. "Deep bridge over your vessel held and is starting to granulate pink. Lateral pectoral shelf and superior clavicular pocket are necrotic slough two centimeters deep. They come out today down to bleeding muscle."

Ludwig's eyes flicked sideways onto the sterile towel—taking in at a single practiced surgeon's glance the Mayo scissors, the toothed forceps, the Volkmann curette, and the solitary five-milliliter brown ampoule of procaine diluted to ten in the glass cup.

Silence stretched two seconds. He did the milligram arithmetic faster than Mirecki could have done it on paper.

"Vesper drank the rest of the Novocain?" he asked dryly.

"Sold it, probably," Sylwia said, refusing him lies she wouldn't have insulted a third-year student with. "I have ten milliliters of one-percent for the skin rim where cutaneous nerves are dense, or Bronka can put

fifty grams of ether onto the wire mask and knock you under for twelve minutes."

"No ether," Ludwig said immediately. Not machismo—cold practical refusal, identical to his corporal's on Wednesday morning, except twice as alert: a man who knew twenty minutes of post-ether delirium loosened tongues in rooms with thin doors. "Save your ten milliliters for some chimney-sweep's toes upstairs. Cut fast and don't chatter like von Halden over fascia."

Sylwia paused with the syringe needle poised an inch above his bruised skin margin. Slowly she raised her eyes four inches into his.

Up this close she could see tiny flecks of slate-rust inside the grey-green ring of his irises, and three fine silver threads—grey hair at thirty-four, buried in the dark blond at his left temple—that hadn't existed in nineteen-thirty-three.

"Skeletal muscle bellies still carry deep nociceptive C-fibers along every arteriole, *Herr Doktor*," she said low in German, voice flat as scalpel steel. "Twenty minutes of sharp debridement raw isn't pulling a tooth."

"Then don't take twenty minutes," Ludwig said, jaw setting hard while a mocking, unbearable spark glinted deep in the winter-water green. "Unless Warsaw dulled your wrists, *Frau Doktor*. Give me the strap, Bruno."

Mekelburg didn't even blink; clearly this wasn't the first field table he had stood beside with his officer since nineteen-thirty-nine. The boy unbuckled his own heavy brown leather Wehrmacht equipment belt one-handed, folded four inches of thick saddle-hide double, wiped it once on his clean tunic sleeve, and laid it between Ludwig's back molars.

Sylwia set the unused procaine syringe down untouched beside the kidney dish. *Good,* she thought savagely—five milliliters saved for the seventeen-year-old carpenter upstairs whose gangrenous frostbitten toes didn't come with German pensions—and infiltrated nothing at all, picking up toothed Kocher forceps in her left hand and curved Mayo scissors in her right.

"Bronka, steady the right shoulder so he doesn't jerk left onto the scissor points," Sylwia said in Polish. "Warm Dakin's flush ready as soon as the dead shelf comes off."

She took hold of the plum-grey necrotic wedge of pectoralis major with the toothed jaws, lifted firmly until the demarcation line between dead grey pulp and living crimson muscle showed taut as string, and cut.

Dead flesh itself had no nerve endings; the first two snips gave only a wet, gristly *crunch* like slicing boiled gizzard. The third snip crossed half a millimeter into healthy, hyperemic viable muscle where inflammatory capillaries bled bright scarlet—and where raw, unanesthetized nerve twigs fired straight up the cervical cord like white-hot piano wire.

Ludwig's entire torso locked rigid as seasoned oak beneath Bronka's heavy red forearms. Leather creaked aloud—an ugly, wet saddle-groan—between his back teeth; instantly sweat broke not in drops but in a slick grey sheet down his temples, throat hollow, and flat sternum, smelling sharp and acrid under the hospital carbolic. His right hand gripped the vertical iron spindle of the headboard above his crown so violently that white paint flaked off onto his knuckles and the whole iron bedstead vibrated faintly against Sylwia's hip.

Sylwia did not slow down, and she did not flinch—hesitating halfway through living debridement only doubled the cuts and tripled the shock. Blade tip open, slide under dead grey fascia, *snip* rotate wrist thirty degrees away from the pulsating pectoral bridge below so one involuntary spasm couldn't drive steel through his repaired artery, *snip* sponge dark oozing blood clear with hot saline gauze; scrape dirty periosteal tags and black powder-grit clean off the sawn lateral end of the clavicle with three ruthless strokes of the sharp Volkmann spoon—*scritch, scritch, scritch*—bone grating right up through her own fingertips into her teeth.

Halfway through clearing the deep axillary pocket, her left hand had to go three inches inside the hot, wet cavity of his chest wall to shield the median nerve cord with two bare fingers while her right scissor-tips excised a grey sloughing pocket where wool threads had festered.

Inside there he was thirty-nine degrees warm—slick, pulsing, shockingly alive around her knuckles, every frantic hammer-stroke of his heart slamming through thin intercostal muscle directly against the back of her fingers while his ribs heaved short and shallow against the leather strap in his mouth. For three dizzying seconds the sheer carnality of surgery—having her bare hand buried inside the living chest of the boy who had stood across Slate Table Nineteen in clean starched cuffs, feeling his hot blood slick her palm while his breath hissed ragged six inches from her

mouth—hit her stomach with a jolt so physical and perverse it felt like vertigo on high scaffolding.

She excised the last necrotic tag cleanly, dropped three grey-purple lumps of dead muscle into the enamel kick-basin with a wet slap, packed two steaming hot saline sponges tight into the bleeding red cavity to tamponade capillary ooze for sixty seconds, and kept steady pressure down with the heel of her hand.

Ludwig spat the bitten leather belt onto his chest.

His chest heaved; dark blond hair clung dripping to his white forehead; pupils dilated black nearly to the outer rims of his irises from catecholamine surge, giving him the feral, dangerous stare of a wolf caught in steel jaws and chewing at the chain. On his lower lip a thin bright bead of blood welled where his upper canine had slipped off the wet leather.

"Eight minutes," he rasped, voice torn down to gravel, swallowing spit mixed with salt blood and staring straight up into her face six inches away while her hand stayed pressed firm over the hot sponges inside his shoulder. "Slowing down in your thirties, *Kotarska*. Von Halden's doghouse record was six."

"Dogs don't carry dirty Prussian wool four inches under their collarbones," Sylwia said evenly, though her own pulse was thudding hard inside her throat and her palm burned from the heat of his chest through wet gauze. "And dogs bite quieter."

Across the foot of the bed, Bronka blinked once behind Sylwia's shoulder—catching not the German words, since Bronka knew only fifty words of market German for lard, coal, and *weg*, but the shocking temperature drop when two people who ought to be surgeon and conqueror spoke to each other like knives scraping in one drawer.

Sylwia pulled the tamponade sponges out—clean, brisk capillary ooze now from healthy brick-red granulation buds across the entire wound floor, zero grey rot left, zero foul gas bubbles—irrigated generously with warm Dakin's solution while Ludwig locked his jaw bare without the belt and took the chlorine fire staring unblinking into her eyes, and laid fresh yellow iodoform gauze strips loose into every recess.

"Bronka, take the soiled tray out to boil and bring fresh adhesive strapping from the cupboard," Sylwia said in Polish. "Mekelburg—help

her carry the zinc pail down the hall to the sluice sink so the sentry unlocks once instead of twice."

Mekelburg hesitated half a beat, looking to the pillow. Ludwig gave one micro-nod of his damp chin. When the oak door clicked shut behind corporal and nurse—leaving one armed MP visible only as a blurred grey silhouette beyond frosted glass—the quiet inside Room Fourteen tightened instantly until the drip of melted frost between the double windowpanes sounded like small lead shot hitting tin.

Sylwia stood winding a fresh three-inch calico roller bandage across his bare ribs and right shoulder to anchor the dressing without adhesive tape tearing sweat-raw skin. Every pass round his back required him to lean forward four inches off the bolsters—unsupported, breathless, bare skin hot and damp with salt three millimeters from her white smock breast—while she reached both arms around his torso to pass the linen roll from right hand to left.

On the third pass, as she brought the roll forward beneath his good right armpit, he spoke six inches from her ear—not in German.

"*Dobra robota, pani doktor,*" Ludwig murmured in rough, guttural, unmistakably grammatical Polish—the hard *r* slightly over-rolled, the *ł* in his throat stiff with effort, yet every vowel placed where Warsaw streets placed it rather than phrasebooks.

Sylwia's fingers stopped dead on the calico roll against his ribs.

In Berlin between nineteen-twenty-eight and thirty-three Ludwig Schoeler had not known five words of Polish except *pszek* and *cholera*, and had mocked Slavic consonant clusters in Charlottenburg wine-cellars whenever he wanted to make her throw bread rolls at his head.

She did not pull back—pulling back ceded ground—keeping her eyes level with the wet hollow above his intact right collarbone before raising them slowly to his face. "Where did they teach *Abwehr* officers to speak Polish like cattle-dealers from Mława? Over Pawiak tables?"

His mouth curved faintly around the dried blood-fleck on his lower lip, catching the immediate give-away—no mere hospital doctor knew by Tuesday week that a signals-depot *Oberstleutnant* wasn't from signals unless somebody had looked under his rock—though he didn't pounce on the slip; he merely filed it behind those pale winter-water eyes with lethal amusement.

"Grodno and Białystok in forty-one, Lemberg in forty-two, here since November," he said, sliding back into quiet Berlin German as she pulled the fourth bandage turn deliberately tight enough across his lower ribs to make his breath catch sharp. "One learns the local vernacular when one gets tired of interpreters lying through their teeth for ten Reichsmarks a page. Though I confess your Poznań consonants used to ring in my ears whenever some schoolmaster in Wilno corrected my genitives."

"Keep my consonants out of your mouth," Sylwia said coldly, splitting the end of the calico roller up the center with her scissors and knotting the tails hard over his right shoulder seam. "How did an arterial surgeon from Luisenstraße end up riding round Ochota railway ditches at one in the morning burning leather briefcases?"

There. Dropped flat on the iron sheet between them without coyness—exactly as Marek would have hated and exactly the only way anyone ever rattled Ludwig Schoeler: straight into the solar plexus while his ribs still burned raw from her scissors.

Nothing in his face twitched, yet the pulse beating visibly in his carotid triangle slowed rather than raced—that cold reptile stillness she remembered from oral state exams whenever an examiner tried trapping him on rare cerebral aneurysms.

"Mekelburg talks when his hand hurts," Ludwig observed mildly.

"Mekelburg talked to keep you still while I had five-zero silk through your subclavian transition and zero anesthetic in your veins," Sylwia said, collecting her bloodstained Kocher forceps and Mayo scissors tip-down into a clean towel with small, metallic clicks. "Don't dock the boy's rations; without his belt on your neck Tuesday night you'd be under frozen lime at Powązki Military Cemetery right now, and Stabsarzt Vesper would be stealing your boots."

Ludwig leaned back slowly onto the horsehair bolsters, letting his head rest against the iron bars while grey exhaustion pooled dark beneath his lower lashes. Yet his eyes followed her raw hands wrapping steel in linen—lingering on the pale twelve-year-old scar at the base of her left thumb before lifting straight to her face.

"Why did you really leave Luisenstraße without taking your state surgical certificate from the dean's clerk on the tenth of March, Sylwia?" he asked very softly. "Your certificate sat stamped in Fräulein Weber's

pigeonhole until June. All you had to do was send the Polish Legation messenger down Unter den Linden for twenty minutes."

Her knuckles turned white through the linen instrument roll. Out in the corridor two heavy jackboots clumped back toward the frosted glass panel—Bronka and Mekelburg returning with the boiled pail.

"Ask Jakob Mandelbaum's widow why nobody went back down Luisenstraße that week," Sylwia whispered, voice shaking once—just once, furious with herself for even that hairline crack—with ten-year-old poison. "If you still remember which camp ditch they threw her spectacles into after you moved into his corner room."

Something violent and dark crossed Ludwig's chalk-white face—so fast, raw, and utterly unlike guilty evasion that for half a heartbeat she didn't recognize the expression at all before his teeth snapped shut and the door bolt rattled back from outside.

When Bronka pushed the door open carrying fresh white adhesive rolls, Sylwia was already standing three paces cleanly away by the porcelain washstand, writing *16.II.43 — Debridement necrotic pectoral fascia; arterial pulse radialis sin. strong, 84/min; wound remains packed open; unfit for transport minimum 12 days* across the yellow Wehrmacht chart in firm black ink.

She did not look back at the bed on her way out, though all the way up the stone stairs to the Polish wards on the second floor—where the carpenter with black frostbitten toes lay waiting for his saved five milliliters of procaine—her left hand inside her smock pocket still felt thirty-nine degrees hot, as if she had plunged it to the wrist into scalding tallow and couldn't wash the grease off.

* * *

Upstairs in Male Surgical B, forty-two iron cots stood jammed so close together that when Bed Twelve rolled onto his side to spit into his tin cup, his elbow bumped Bed Thirteen's traction pulley and set six pounds of sash-iron swinging. No German steam radiator had been bled properly up here since December; frost furred the lower putty of the tall casements in grey fern-fronds, and every breath hung visible above gray horse-blankets darned with butcher's string.

Antek, the seventeen-year-old joiner's apprentice hauled in three nights ago after hiding eleven hours inside an unheated timber wagon at Praga to dodge an *Arbeitsamt* labor sweep, lay at the far end behind a three-panel canvas screen whose oilcloth had cracked yellow like old parchment. His right first, second, and third toes had passed dry demarcation two days ago—shriveled hard and matte black as smoked sprats, tapping against forceps with a dry horn click—except along the cleft of the first metatarsal web, where damp foul pus had begun creeping pink up the dorsum of the foot since morning. Wait till Friday for dry autoamputation and streptococci would race up the lymphatics to his groin before Lent.

"Look what fell out of heaven," Sylwia said in Polish, holding the intact brown five-milliliter ampoule of *Polfa* procaine up to the gray window light before scoring its neck with a steel file and snapping the glass top off cleanly inside a gauze square. "Real Novocain, Antek. None of Bronka's valerian water today."

The boy's sunken brown eyes widened above two weeks of wispy blond chin-fluff. Hunger made seventeen look twelve round the collarbones and sixty round the mouth. "Will it take the whole foot, pani doktor?"

"Three toes and half the big-toe knuckle head if the bone bleeds red underneath," Sylwia said, drawing every clear drop up into her boiled syringe and diluting it to twelve milliliters with warm sterile saline so she could ring-block all three digital bases plus the dorsalis pedis twig above the ankle. "You won't dance mazurkas on Easter Sunday, and you'll limp when rain comes off the Vistula, but you'll stand at a joiner's lathe without a crutch. Look at the ceiling moulding and count the plaster roses aloud for me while the needle goes in."

He got to fourteen before his voice cracked on the deep plantar injection—plantar skin hurt worse than chest muscle because nature packed weight-bearing leather solid with Pacinian corpuscles—then blew out a shaky laugh five minutes later when Sylwia pinched the black big toe hard with toothed Kocher claws and he felt nothing at all except distant tugging up his shin.

Docent Mirecki came shuffling behind the canvas screen halfway through the bone-nibbling, tying a clean gauze mask beneath his pincenez with fingers stained faint violet from gentian ink. Downstairs in

his office someone had been telephoning; she could always tell when Germans had telephoned Mirecki, because a livid pink patch the size of a five-złoty coin stood out high on his left malar bone while the rest of his face went dough-pale.

"Clean marrow?" Mirecki murmured automatically in Latinized ward shorthand so the boy wouldn't panic at Polish butcher-words, peering over Sylwia's shoulder as she bevelled the first metatarsal shaft oblique with the rongeur.

"Punctate red bleeding two centimeters proximal to the joint line," Sylwia replied, snipping blackened extensor tendons high so they retracted cleanly out of the septic field and leaving the plantar flap loose over two tiny rubber glove-strip drains instead of tight sutures. "Lymphangitis streak stops below the malleolus. Give him four grams of Bronka's stolen Eleudron crushed in barley water over forty-eight hours and we save the tarsus." Only when young Antek had been wheeled back to his cot—staring down incredulously at a short white club of bandage where five black horn-claws had stunk all week, whispering clumsy thanks over Sylwia's red-cracked wrist—did she follow Mirecki into the narrow linen closet between Wards B and C and shut the pine door.

Stacks of grey boiled sheets smelled faintly of scorching iron and lye. Mirecki took off his pince-nez, polished both lenses furiously on the tail of his threadbare tweed waistcoat, and did not put them back on. Without spectacles his eyes looked naked, watery blue, and twenty years older.

"Aleja Szucha telephoned *Stabsarzt* Vesper's clerk ten minutes ago," Mirecki said quietly.

Sylwia's towel stopped moving between her wet palms. "Vesper isn't at Szucha. Vesper belongs to the Wehrmacht *Ortskommandantur*."

"Which is precisely why Vesper just rang me screaming until spit hit his mouthpiece," Mirecki said, leaning his narrow shoulders back against a shelf of unbleached pillowslips and closing his eyes briefly as a dull retrosternal ache tightened his jaw—not full angina, just the small cold iron fist he carried behind his fourth rib whenever Pawiak or Szucha entered a sentence. "An *SS-Hauptsturmführer* Kroll from *Abteilung Vier* inquired very politely why a Wehrmacht officer wounded inside the Warsaw municipal perimeter during an unnotified firearm incident on the ninth of February has not yet filed a signed deposition with Security Police ballistics."

Kroll. The exact name Marek had spoken two hours ago behind the vetch sacks on Bagno: *Kroll's desk asked the Wehrmacht duty officer twice why Towarowa barrier was closed and got hung up on.*

"And what did our courageous Munich gynecologist reply?" Sylwia asked.

"That *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler remains under toxic post-hemorrhagic wound fever on Lindleya and is strictly barred from non-medical questioning by joint order of *Sanitätsabteilung* and *Abwehrstelle Warschau* until Sunday," Mirecki said with a ghostly, bitter twitch of his moustache. "Whereupon Kroll thanked him most courteously and announced he will pay a brief pastoral visit to Pavilion Three on Sunday afternoon at four o'clock—merely to inspect municipal hospital admission ledgers from the night of the ninth and exchange three minutes' civility at the bedside."

Silence hummed inside the dark linen closet. Outside on Ward B somebody dropped an enamel bedpan with a ringing clang, followed by Bronka's carrying baritone cursing clumsy thumbs back to their mothers' bellies.

Sylwia calculated rapidly down the columns of the night register from February ninth. Between midnight and six a.m. only three admissions stood inked in old Walenty's copperplate hand: a sixty-year-old tramway widow with strangulated femoral hernia (dead Thursday morning, buried Saturday), *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler at 01:16, and *Gefreiter* Mekelburg at 01:55. The nineteen-year-old railwayman from Pańska hadn't come near Lindleya; his copper-jacketed Belgian slug sat right now inside Marek's pocket. On paper Pavilion Three was clean as snow.

Except Kroll wasn't coming to read old Walenty's handwriting. Kroll was coming because two German services had shot at each other in the dark behind an Ochota water-tower over a burned briefcase and twelve hundred Swiss francs, and caught squarely between their teeth was one Polish surgical pavilion full of counterfeit X-rays, hidden boys from Radom, and a Jewish bacteriologist downstairs feeding typhus lice on her own thighs under a dead Catholic schoolteacher's *Kennkarte*.

"Did you tell Schoeler?" Sylwia asked.

"How could I tell him? You had his chest open to the ribs ten minutes ago, and those two gorillas outside his door check my pockets for fountain pens!" Mirecki hooked his pince-nez back onto his nose with a tiny snap, looking straight at her through thick convex glass that magnified

his pupils huge and frightened. “Sylwia—listen to me as an old man who knew your father before he went to Berlin. Whatever happened or did not happen when you were students on Luisenstraße—do not get clever between two German millstones. Patch his collarbone, sign Vesper’s discharge slip the first morning that silk artery holds eighty paces, and get him out of my hospital before Kroll smells methylated spirit on our fingers.”

“Ten days minimum before that vessel takes car jolts without blowing,” Sylwia repeated evenly, hanging her damp hand-towel squarely on its brass peg. “Even for the Gestapo, collagen fibroblasts don’t granulate faster than forty-eight microns a day, panie docencie.”

Yet when she went down the back stone staircase at dusk toward the basement pathology Passage to sign off Antek’s pus swab with Halina, passing twenty feet behind the locked east-wing swing doors, she heard through two oak panels the steady, dry scratch of a German sentry striking a match—and behind that second door, silent and sleepless on two horsehair bolsters with raw unanesthetized muscle burning beneath three turns of Polish calico, she pictured Ludwig Schoeler turning his yellow message pad face-up again on his knees, calculating Sunday at four o’clock four moves ahead of every living soul in the building.

Chapter IV

Turnip Soup and Insulin

Warsaw, 21 February 1943

On Filtrowa Street the window glass was all whole, and when Wanda opened the front door a gust of warm cabbage-fat and beeswax floor polish rolled out onto the landing thick enough to make Sylwia's empty stomach contract like a fist.

"Take your galoshes off on the mat, Sylwunia, Stefan had the parquet scraped last month," Wanda said before she said hello, kissing the air half an inch beside Sylwia's cold cheek so she wouldn't catch hospital carbolic on her Sunday cardigan. Wanda was thirty-seven, four years older than Sylwia and born to Kazimierz Kotarski's first wife from Kalisz, who had left Wanda round china-blue eyes, soft sloping shoulders, and an unshakable conviction that history was primarily an rudeness aimed at respectable housekeeping. "Goodness, look at your wrists, haven't they even lard-soap left at Dzieciątka Jezus? Give me your coat—mind the sleeve lining, it's trailing."

"Leave the coat on the hook," Sylwia said, lifting her leather medical bag clear before Wanda could set it near the radiator pipe. "Insulin stays cold. Where's Staś?"

"In the dining room doing long division so he doesn't run about before his injection. Come see—Stefan got three real lemons through the Ostbahn canteen on Friday, actual Messina lemons wrapped in tissue paper with Italian print on it!"

Everything inside Number Sixty-Eight Filtrowa sat two inches off plumb with the rest of Warsaw, like a stage set carried intact out of nineteen-thirty-eight and bolted down inside a slaughterhouse. The brass pendulum clock still chimed quarters; the rubber plant in the bay window still had glossy leaves wiped every Saturday with skimmed milk; nobody

had sawed the legs off the walnut sideboard to feed the stove because Inżynier Stefan Bielski's tramway-workshop coal allotment arrived on the first of every month in plump hundred-kilo jute sacks delivered by municipal lorry. All it had cost Stefan in March forty-one was three signatures at the *Abteilung Bevölkerungswesen und Fürsorge* attesting that his late mother, born Hedwig Krawczyk in Tarnowitz, Upper Silesia, had raised him in "partially German domestic cultural consciousness"—whereupon the occupation authorities handed him a green *Kennkarte* of *Deutsche Volksliste* Group Three, revocable on ten years' probation, freeing his flat from requisition, doubling his butter coupons, and ensuring that every former Polytechnic classmate who passed him on Marszałkowska crossed silently into the slush on the far pavement rather than spit.

In the dining room Staś scrambled down off his plush-seated chair the second Sylwia appeared, thin knees knocking beneath grey flannel shorts outgrown by three inches—not because the Bielskis lacked cloth coupons, but because diabetic children since forty-one burned their own muscle fat whenever black-market insulin ran short for three days and grew upward like cellar potato-sprouts without thickening.

"Ciocia!" He flung both bony arms round her waist, pressing his warm, cropped dark head hard against her sternum before remembering himself and stepping back straight-backed as Sylwia had taught him. "Sixty-two milligrams minimal glycosuria all week—Mama boiled Benedict's solution Tuesday and Friday, stayed green-blue both times, zero brick-red precipitate!"

Sylwia's mouth softened—the solitary square yard of Warsaw where it ever did without irony—and she cupped two cold fingers beneath the boy's pointed chin, tilting his face toward the bay window to check his sclerae, tongue moisture, and breath. No fruity acetone smell of ketosis; mucous membranes decent pink; just violet smudges carved deep beneath long lashes too big for his face.

"Show me your injection map before you brag, panie profesorze," she said. "If you stuck the left outer middle quadrant three days running because your right hand's lazy, I'll make you recite the cranial nerves backward in Latin."

"Alternated like clockwork," Stefan Bielski announced genially, emerging from his study wiping tobacco crumbs off a trim brown moustache and extending two damp fingers Sylwia touched for half a second

and dropped. Stefan had put on four kilos since autumn—a soft pad under the chin, waist straining the third button of a good prewar Bielsko worsted vest—which in February forty-three looked almost obscene on a Polish frame, like rouge on a sexton. "Afternoon, Sylwia. Sit, sit, soup's cooling, and Wanda's been up since six skimming the stock."

"Injection first," Sylwia said, picking up her bag. "Fifteen minutes before carbohydrate load, Stefan, same as every month since forty. Come into the bathroom, Stasiu."

The tiled bathroom smelled of real Palmolive soap—another *Nur für Deutsche* shop miracle—and wet flannel. While her small nickel spirit-burner brought distilled water bubbling around the glass Record syringe and fine twenty-six-gauge needle, Staś sat perched on the closed wooden toilet lid with his right woollen stocking rolled down to the ankle, trying desperately not to stare at the fresh brown glass ten-milliliter vial Sylwia lifted out of cotton wool: *Insulin Leo — Nordisk Insulinlaboratorium, København — 40 International Units per ml.*

Nine-year-olds in Warsaw knew prices adults in Zurich didn't know. One ten-milliliter vial of forty-unit Danish insulin—four hundred units, barely twenty-five days' life at sixteen units daily even on strict turnip-and-buckwheat rationing—cost two thousand four hundred *młynarki* on the black corridor behind Świętokrzyska when a crooked Wehrmacht medical orderly happened to steal one off a hospital train from Berlin, and four thousand when none came through for three weeks.

"Did you get two bottles, Ciocia?" the boy whispered, watching her swab the rubber cap with spirit.

"Three," Sylwia lied smoothly without batting an eyelash—she had got one and a half, the half salvaged from a sixty-year-old Volksdeutscher butcher who died of uremia in Pavilion One on Thursday before his family claimed his washbag, and the whole vial bought by trading Bronka's best pair of stolen curved Krupp intestinal clamps to a railway pharmacist from Poznań. "Enough till Easter if your mother keeps her hands off the white flour. Pinch up—two inches above last Wednesday's dot."

Staś pinched a pitifully thin fold of pale thigh skin between thumb and index finger—almost zero subcutaneous fat pad left over vastus lateralis, so she had to slide the needle in at twenty-five degrees shallow not to hit muscle fascia where insulin absorbed too fast and dropped him into sweating afternoon hypoglycemia. He didn't even blink when the

steel pricked home, counting steadily under his breath: "*Jeden, dwa, trzy, cztery, pięć…*"

"Good soldier," Sylwia said, pressing dry sterile cotton briefly over the puncture before rolling his stocking up and ruffling his hair once. "Go eat your soup slowly. Don't gulp the barley."

When she came out drying her syringe parts in linen, Stefan was waiting alone in the hall doorway between bathroom and dining room, blocking the runner carpet with his broad worsted shoulders while Wanda clattered soup plates inside.

"How much do I owe you for the Danish bottle?" Stefan asked low, already pulling a thick calfskin wallet bloated with crisp hundred-złoty *młynarki* notes out of his breast pocket.

"Twelve hundred," Sylwia said, naming half what the Poznań pharmacist's markup cost in hard barter because taking Stefan's *Volksliste* paper money always left grease on her fingers, yet refusing it outright drove Wanda into three-hour weeping fits about pride.

Stefan peeled off fifteen hundreds anyway and pushed them into the outer pocket of her bag with heavy brother-in-law magnanimity. "Take fifteen—buy yourself fifty grams of lard before your skin cracks off your bones, Sylwia. Honestly, looking at you across the table makes Wanda cry all Sunday night. Why you insist on starving in that freezing municipal pest-house on Polish ration cards when one signature from Docent Mirecki certifying your six Berlin semesters puts you on *Ostbahn* contract medical scales—"

"Don't start, Stefan."

"—I'm speaking practically, as family!" His voice dropped into that aggrieved, oily whisper she had heard in twenty Warsaw drawing rooms where men tried scrubbing green ink off their souls with arithmetic. "Do you think I enjoy saying *Guten Morgen* to Herr Direktor Krehl from Essen every morning at the Wola sheds while boys chalk *Świnia* on my garden gate in the dark? Somebody has to keep seventy tramcars rolling or three hundred thousand Poles walk ten kilometers in slush to work! If I hadn't signed Group Three in forty-one, some Baltic German drunk from Riga would be sitting in my chair sending half my fitters to Reich factories, and Staś would have been dead in six weeks without coal or currency!"

Sylwia snapped the brass clasp of her medical bag shut. In the dim hall mirror behind Stefan's ear, her own face looked stripped down to

grey bone and dark eyes—thirty-three going on fifty, Helena's cold mouth inherited whole without Helena's morphine lullaby.

"Keep telling the mirror that when you shave, Stefan," she said quietly. "Just check your Wola workshop absence sheets twice before you sign them on Mondays. Word down on Towarowa is Direktor Krehl started forwarding three-day sick-leave names straight to the Skaryszewska labor-camp trucks last week—and when the boys who chalk gates get tired of chalk, they don't ask whose mother came from Tarnowitz."

All the healthy butter-pink drained out of Stefan's cheeks down into his collar. Before he could find breath to bluster, Wanda poked her head round the sliding oak doors calling brightly that the turnip broth was growing cold, and for forty-five minutes they sat beneath Kazimierz Kotarski's oil portrait eating yellow rutabaga soup boiled with a single goose neck while talking with grotesque, suffocating politeness about double-glazing putty and Staś's geography marks.

At ten minutes past three Sylwia kissed Staś's forehead, left half her slice of ersatz lemon-rind cake untouched beside her saucer because sweet saccharin made her throat gag, and walked back out into the sharp February wind toward Lindleya with twenty minutes to spare before SS-Hauptsturmführer Kroll came calling.

* * *

You could always tell when Aleja Szucha was inside a Polish hospital before you saw a single black collar tab, because every wooden clog on the ground floor stopped clattering.

Usually at four o'clock on Sunday afternoon Pavilion Three buzzed like a wet beehive: relatives smuggling jars of pickled beets under shawls up the back stairs, ward maids slopping grey lysol water out of galvanized buckets, convalescents with bandaged heads smoking split cigarettes in twos behind the radiator pipes. When Sylwia pushed through the courtyard side door at ten to four, the vestibule smelled solely of floor wax and cold iron. Behind the glass admissions partition old Walenty sat upright on his high stool with both hands flat on the green blotter while two young SD *Rottenführer* in field-grey SS tunics with silver *SD* sleeve diamonds stood beside the radiator smoking Turkish *Nil* cigarettes and flicking ash straight onto Bronka's scrubbed black-and-white tiles.

Inside Docent Mirecki's ground-floor consulting room, the porcelain stove had been stoked too hot.

SS-Hauptsturmführer Reinhart Kroll sat at Mirecki's own mahogany desk—not sprawling across it like cinema bullies, sitting very straight on the front half of the leather cushion with his knees together, his peaked cap resting upside-down on a clean handkerchief beside the inkwell so warehouse dust wouldn't touch the silver skull. He was perhaps thirty-one: slender, narrow-chested, smooth-shaven to baby pinkness, hair the pale sandy-ash of wet sawdust parted neatly with water on the left. Beneath immaculate French-cuffed linen shirt-sleeves protruding half an inch past his grey wool cuffs, he wore thin white cotton gloves even indoors; every two or three minutes, without looking down, the gloved index finger of his left hand stroked back and forth across the inner aspect of his right wrist, where something dry and inflamed rasped audibly beneath the cotton.

"Ah—Frau Doktor Kotarska," Mirecki said too fast from where he stood stranded beside his own bookcase, sweat shining high on his temples despite winter light. "Herr *Hauptsturmführer* Kroll was just reviewing our emergency theater register from Tuesday week."

"A model of legibility," Kroll said, rising two polite inches off the chair leather as Sylwia closed the door behind her. His German was educated Dresden Saxon rubbed nearly clean at Leipzig or Göttingen law school—soft consonants, gentle pitch, the voice of a notary explaining probate fees to an orphan. "One enters municipal establishments in the Generalgouvernement expecting administrative chaos, and instead encounters Prussian book-keeping. You studied in Berlin, Frau Doktor?"

"Friedrich-Wilhelms-Universität, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*," Sylwia said, standing still with her hands loose at her sides so he could see neither tension nor deference. "Nineteen twenty-eight to thirty-three. Surgical state examination under Geheimrat von Halden."

"Luisenstraße," Kroll murmured appreciatively, white cotton fingertip whispering *scritch-scritch* across his right wrist seam. "My uncle held the chair of administrative jurisprudence two streets over on Unter den Linden until his retirement in thirty-seven. Small world, even out here in the east. Sit down, please—no? Surgeons prefer standing; quite right." He glanced down at Walenty's heavy canvas-bound night register lying open across Mirecki's blotter. "I am merely tidying an untidy file for

the *Kommandeur der Sicherheitspolizei*. On the night of nine February, between midnight and one a.m., unidentified bandits discharged automatic weapons near the Szczęśliwice railway water-tower in Ochota, killing a Polish track-watchman? No, a civilian driver of uncertain papers, and burning a stolen passenger vehicle. Roughly forty minutes later—at 01:16 by your gate clerk's clock—*Oberstleutnant* Schoeler arrives here with gunshot and fragmentation injuries."

Sylwia kept her eyes calmly on the silver-braided edge of Kroll's upturned cap visor. Forty minutes. From Szczęśliwice water-tower to Lindleya Number Four, even skidding in second gear through snow on three good tires, took *nine* minutes—twelve at worst if Towarowa crossing gate was down. Where had Ludwig Schoeler and a bleeding corporal with two blown-off fingers spent twenty-eight missing minutes in a blizzard with a severed axillary artery?

Der Koffer ist im Feuer, ich hab ihn verbrannt wie befohlen. Burning wet leather and paper packets in February snow without petrol took twenty minutes if you waited till every cipher sheet turned black ash before driving to a hospital!

Except if Kroll proved twenty-eight missing minutes, Kroll had cause to strip *Abwehrstelle*'s jurisdiction away on grounds of destroyed criminal evidence—and drag Mekelburg (and anybody else near Room Fourteen) down to Aleja Szucha's basement corridor before supper.

"Gate clerk's clock runs off the wall pendulum in the unheated porter's lodge, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*," Sylwia said smoothly, as if reciting blood-count decimals at morning rounds. "Every frost freezes the oil in its escapement until it loses ten minutes, and old Walenty enters admissions *after* stretchers clear the vestibule—when the corporal stopped holding a Walther pistol at his ribs. By my lapel watch inside Operating Theater One, my Lister shears cut *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler's tunic at twelve minutes to one."

Beside the bookcase, Docent Mirecki didn't breathe; behind his thick pince-nez one eyelid gave a microscopic flutter at hearing Sylwia calmly move the German clock back twenty-eight minutes out of thin air without knowing what Schoeler himself had told—or was about to tell—Kroll down the hall!

Kroll tilted his sandy head five degrees, pale eyes mild and interested. "Twelve minutes to one. You checked your watch before cutting an exsanguinating man's collar open, Frau Doktor?"

"Every vascular surgeon checks clamping time to the minute before occluding a subclavian-axillary trunk, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*," Sylwia replied coolly. "Exceed warm ischemia limits or lose track of shock duration, and you don't know whether limb paralysis afterward comes from nerve severance or ischemic necrosis. Clamping began at 00:51; anastomosis flow restored at 01:14; Walenty copied the theater transfer down at 01:16 when the porter came out for hot bricks."

For four seconds the only sound in Mirecki's heated office was *scritch-scritch*, cotton across dry wrist-scabs.

"Admirable precision," Kroll said softly. "Then you won't mind accompanying me down the hall for three minutes while I pay my respects to *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler and receive any recollection he may wish to contribute toward catching the scoundrels who shot him."

"Three minutes maximum," Sylwia said, stepping aside to open the door herself before Mirecki's shaking knees had to lead. "His wound was debrided raw down to pectoral periosteum five days ago and he runs evening resorption spikes. Stabsarzt Vesper's chart instructions are posted on the door."

Outside Room Fourteen the two *Abwehr* military policemen did not snap heels quite so smartly for an SS *Hauptsturmführer* as ordinary infantrymen did; the senior sergeant—a grizzled forty-year-old Pomeranian from Saski Square—deliberately took twenty full seconds reading Kroll's silver warrant disc and logging Kroll's badge number in pencil on his wall clipboard before unlocking the oak door. Twenty seconds of loud brass key-rattling and heavy throat-clearing: ample warning for anyone awake behind four inches of pine.

Inside, Room Fourteen smelled sharply of Dakin's chlorine and fresh cold air from two inches of open top casement.

Ludwig lay propped on one bolster instead of two—looking calculatedly ten percent greyer and weaker than he had forty minutes ago when Bronka brought his afternoon barley water, eyelids half-mast over winter-water irises, left shoulder bulky under white calico bindings, uninjured right hand resting slack atop the grey Wehrmacht blanket. In the corner

by the radiator stood Mekelburg at rigid Prussian attention, wooden hand-splint gleaming white against his tunic buttons.

"*Herr Oberstleutnant*," Kroll said pleasantly, halting at the foot rail rather than approaching the right side of the bed. "Hauptsturmführer Kroll, *Kommandeur der Sicherheitspolizei und des SD Warschau*, Referat IV A. Permit me to express my commander's sincere wishes for your rapid convalescence."

Ludwig looked at Kroll down the high, gaunt bridge of his nose for two unhurried seconds before inclining his chin three millimeters. Even half-naked in coarse Polish hospital linen with twelve days' surgical pallor hollowing his cheeks, he managed to make a healthy man in pressed grey wool with two armed guards outside look like an insurance clerk calling without an appointment.

"Give *Standartenführer* Hahn my thanks, Kroll," Ludwig said, voice dry and slightly raspy, conserving breath with theatrical economy Sylwia recognized instantly from ten oral exams where he had milked examiners dry. "Though I understood *Abwehrstelle* liaison already forwarded our preliminary motor-incident report to Aleja Szucha on Thursday."

"A four-line summary from Hauptmann von Berg, yes," Kroll agreed gently, white cotton thumb stroking his right wrist cuff. "Inspecting Towarowa perimeter approaches prior to night courier dispatch; ambushed from darkness near Szczęśliwice embankment; vehicle disabled; immediate withdrawal to nearest surgical emergency post. Only two small technical puzzles remain for my ballistics people, *Herr Oberstleutnant*, before we close the street sweep."

"Ask them inside Frau Doktor's three minutes, then," Ludwig murmured, flicking a cool, utterly impersonal glance past Sylwia's white shoulder as if she were a radiator valve he barely knew by sight. "Her chlorine tubes make breathing tedious."

Watch out now, Sylwia's nerves sang, catching the exact cadence—now had to come the clock trap! How could she give him *twelve minutes to one* without opening her mouth out of turn?

Kroll stepped two paces round the foot rail. "First: municipal tramway night-watchmen near the Ochota water-tower logged gunfire bursts at twelve-twenty-eight a.m. Yet according to the hospital gate-book outside, your car struck the courtyard gate here at *one-sixteen*—nearly fifty minutes later, for a drive of three kilometers. My chief naturally wondered

whether your vehicle was forced down elsewhere along Grójecka in a second engagement, or whether you attempted pursuit on foot before collapsing."

Sylwia didn't look at Ludwig; she stepped crisply to the chart bracket hanging at the iron foot-rail right beside Kroll's elbow, unhooking the yellow Wehrmacht clinical sheet with a sharp tin rattle and holding the inked red temperature-and-clamp graph directly between Kroll and the bed as if corroborating an annoying bureaucratic point already settled.

"As I just explained in Docent Mirecki's office, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*," she said tartly in her briskest Luisenstraße ward voice, tapping the top left margin inked on February tenth, "the gatehouse pendulum runs slow and logs post-theater stretcher returns. Here is the operative anesthesia-and-hemostasis sheet signed by Docent Mirecki and myself on the morning of the tenth: *Clamping arteria axillaris sinistra 00:51; reperfusion 01:14.* If gunfire occurred at 00:28 in snow blackout with two shredded left fingers on the driver and a bayonet tourniquet to twist before driving through three closed barriers, twenty minutes barely got him through the gate alive."

Across the white cotton sheet, Ludwig's grey-green eyes met hers for one quarter of a second—stone-still, zero blink, absorbing *00:51* and the entire false timeline whole without moving an eyebrow.

"Twenty-three minutes," Ludwig corrected her irritably, speaking straight over the tin chart at Kroll with splendid, ill-tempered officer's pedantry. "Towarowa railway crossing barrier was frozen shut with nobody in the hut, so Mekelburg had to back fifty meters down a drifted coal alley on one rim and ram through the wooden cattle-fence behind Platynowa. My watch crystal smashed against the dashboard at twenty-nine past twelve when the burst took out our windshield. Look in the washstand drawer if your ballistics boys collect broken Junghans hands, Kroll."

Kroll did not open the washstand drawer. Instead he smiled—a small, thin, polite Saxon smile that didn't touch his sandy eyelashes—and moved seamlessly to trap number two.

"Most clarifying, *Herr Oberstleutnant.* Then the second detail is mere metallurgy. Near the water-tower ditch at dawn our patrol recovered nine-millimeter Parabellum casings of standard Austrian Steyr manufacture—*and* five deformed fragments of black vulcanite and brass matching

neither Wehrmacht *Kübelwagen* fittings nor Polish underground Sten guns, alongside a burned civilian Steyr 220 sedan fifty meters down the siding. Did you happen to observe a second vehicle at the embankment before the firing began?"

Every molecule of air in Room Fourteen seemed to freeze solid.

Sylwia remembered the five jagged black crumbs of ebonite she had picked out of Bruno Mekelburg's torn hypothenar muscle at two in the morning on February tenth and dropped straight into the zinc slop-pail with bloody gauze—burned in the furnace boiler by seven a.m.! Wait: *Kübelwagen* Type 82 steering wheels were painted pressed steel spoked with thin hard-rubber coating—or early bakelite—wait: had Kroll's men found fragments from the *other* car, or was Kroll bluffing to see if Schoeler admitted another car was parked right bumper-to-bumper with his?!

In the corner by the radiator, young Mekelburg stared straight ahead at the plaster wall above Kroll's shoulder, motionless as pine wood.

"Snow was blowing horizontally across our headlights at ten meters' visibility," Ludwig said dryly. "If a civilian Steyr was parked fifty meters down an unlit coal siding, whoever owned it didn't blow his horn to introduce himself before shooting out my glass. As for black vulcanite —ask Frau Doktor what she dug out of my driver's hand along with half my steering-wheel rim and radio handset casing. Our FuG field-set transmitter mounted under the dash took three rounds square before the grease caught fire."

Kroll's pale eyes slid sideways to Sylwia. "You recovered radio-handset bakelite from the corporal's palm, Frau Doktor?"

"Five angular fragments of black phenolic resin and one twisted brass contact-pin embedded in the fourth metacarpal web, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*," Sylwia lied without a ripple in her voice, inventing the brass contact-pin out of pure surgical detail so clean you could have mounted it in a glass jar on Philippstraße. "Discarded with amputated necrotic digits into the septic incinerator bucket per typhus-and-gangrene ordinance. Had *Sicherheitspolizei* requested foreign-body preservation on Tuesday morning, I would gladly have saved you the fingers in formalin."

For three silent beats Kroll looked from the crisp, dark-eyed Polish woman in her scrubbed white smock to the gaunt Wehrmacht intelligence officer propped against hospital bolsters. White cotton rasped once—*scritch*—across Kroll's right wrist.

"Formalin will scarcely be necessary, Frau Doktor," Kroll said softly. "You have both been admirably thorough. Pray do not let me tax your suture line another sixty seconds, *Herr Oberstleutnant*. When you return to Saski Square, perhaps you will dine with us on Szucha so we can compare notes on Towarowa night traffic."

"Delighted," Ludwig said flatly. "As soon as I can cut meat with two hands."

Kroll bowed two millimeters from the waist to Ludwig, inclined his sandy head politely to Sylwia, and stepped out into the corridor, where Mirecki stood waiting like a condemned vestryman to escort him back toward the courtyard gates.

Sylwia waited at the wired glass door-panel until Kroll's grey wool back and his two Turkish-cigarette *Rottenführer* disappeared past the vestibule swing doors. Then she turned slowly back into Room Fourteen.

"Step outside by the MP bench for two minutes and smoke, *Gefreiter*," Ludwig told Mekelburg quietly without taking his eyes off Sylwia.

Mekelburg slipped out and pulled the heavy oak door latched behind him.

Silence slammed down inside the white room—hotter and ten times uglier than when the Gestapo had been standing at the bed-foot.

Sylwia walked straight to the left rail, snatching up Ludwig's wrist not gently as on Thursday night, gripping two cold fingers hard over his radial artery while furious colour burned two sharp flags across her cheekbones. Pulse ninety-six—up twelve beats, steady as iron.

"Don't *ever* lean on my chart in front of Aleja Szucha without warning me what lie you've parked in your washstand drawer," she hissed in Berlin German barely above breath, low enough to die three feet short of the door crack. "Twenty-nine past twelve on a smashed watch crystal! What if I had told him one-fifteen upstairs in Mirecki's office?"

"You didn't," Ludwig said just as low, eyes glittering winter-green and wide awake now—every trace of theatrical invalid droop gone clean out of his jaw. "Because you knew forty-eight minutes between Szczęśliwice and Lindleya looked like an elephant in snow, and you never missed basic subtraction in your life. *Brass contact-pin from a FuG handset*, though—that was inspired, Sylwia. We didn't even carry a transmitter in the car."

Her fingers dropped his wrist as if the skin had blistered her. "Then what *did* burn for twenty-eight minutes in the snow while you bled two

liters through your collarbone onto floorboards—before your boy drove here?"

He looked straight up at her, close enough that she could smell dry iron salt on his skin under the chlorine dressing and see the tiny pulse kicking below the angle of his shaved jaw. No amusement left now; cold, lethal calculation stripped every civil mask off his bone structure.

"Something Kroll's people murdered two men at a water-tower trying to put their white cotton gloves on," Ludwig said softly. "And something that keeps your Docent Mirecki and half this hospital off Pawiak straw as long as Kroll goes home empty-handed. Who else asked you about Szczęśliwice before four o'clock today, *Kotarska*?"

Sylwia froze inside her white smock—not a flicker in her eyelids, not a millimeter of breath drawn early, yet she saw instantly in the razor-thin narrowing of his eyes that *he didn't even need her to answer*. Nobody innocent knew enough about Szczęśliwice railway ditches to invent FuG radio pins on a half-second cue unless she already knew Kroll had found a burned second car there!

For five seconds they stared straight into each other's eyes across twenty inches of hospital sheet—Polish underground asset and German *Abwehr* counter-espionage chief, neither speaking the fatal word aloud because speaking a word aloud inside four plastered walls turned suspicion into carcass-weight—locked in a mutual stranglehold where either one could hang the other before midnight and neither dared let go first.

"Drink your barley water," Sylwia said through stiff lips, stepping back from the iron rail and hooking the yellow chart back onto its tin peg with a metallic snap. "And if your fever crosses thirty-nine tonight because you played parlor games with a Dresden hangman, you'll sweat it out without aspirin."

"Lock the top casement catch before you go," Ludwig answered quietly against the pillow. "Wind's turning east again."

* * *

At half-past six Mirecki caught her in the ground-floor dispensary unlocking the poison cupboard for Tuesday's surgical morphine tally, shut the frosted glass door behind his heels, and poured forty milliliters of ninety-six-percent rectified spirit straight out of the pharmacy stock

carboy into two porcelain ointment-measuring cups without bothering to add cherry syrup.

"Drink," he ordered, shoving one cup across the zinc counter until clear alcohol sloshed over his blotter.

Sylwia tossed half of hers back raw—it burned down her esophagus like kerosene and lit an immediate small coal pit behind her ribs where Wanda's watery turnip broth had already vanished—and left the other half for Mirecki, who emptied his own cup first and eyed hers mournfully before looking away on principle.

"Where on earth did you get *zero-zero-fifty-one clamping time*?" Mirecki whispered, wiping his damp moustache with two trembling fingers. "On Wednesday morning you yourself wrote *circa 01:20* on the preliminary theatre scrap before Bronka burned the bloody paper!"

"And at ten minutes to four today Kroll sat in your chair trying to hang twenty-eight missing minutes round our gatehouse clock so he could arrest Schoeler's corporal for burning criminal evidence and haul Walenty down to Aleja Szucha to count his teeth," Sylwia said calmly, entering three morphine ampoules in purple indelible pencil across the narcotics ledger. "Once Walenty reaches Szucha, panie docencie, how many hours do you think an eighty-kilo gate porter aged sixty-four lasts on wet concrete before he mentions that young men with bandaged thighs sometimes leave Pavilion Three at five in the morning in vegetable carts?"

Mirecki sat down heavily on the tall dispensary stool, shoulders caving inside his threadbare English tweed until his collar stood half an inch away from his scrawny neck. Outside in the courtyard snow had started sifting down again off black roofs, whispering soft against the wired dispensary window.

"You noticed Kroll's wrists?" Mirecki asked dully.

"Neurodermatitis chronica," Sylwia said. "Weeping lichenified plaques under boiled cotton gloves. Scratches whenever somebody tells him a tidy story he doesn't quite believe."

"My cousin Bronisław—the advocate from Radom—was questioned by a Saxon Referent in white cotton gloves last October before they sent the autumn transport to Majdanek," Mirecki said, staring down into his empty porcelain measure. "Bronisław wrote one postcard from Lublin before Christmas saying the polite ones who offer chairs never shout;

they merely cross out three lines in pencil after you leave the room, and next Tuesday the truck stops at your door." He looked up sharply through his pince-nez. "Did Schoeler confirm your 00:51?"

"Down to the smashed watch crystal in his washstand drawer."

Instead of looking relieved, Mirecki looked sicker than ever. "Which means an *Abwehr* lieutenant-colonel lied in his teeth to the Security Police inside my ward, using your clinical chart as an alibi! Sylwia, for the love of Christ—get that wound closed or clean enough to sign out by Friday! Let Saski Square and Aleja Szucha strangle each other inside the Brühl Hotel where Polish doctors don't have to hold the basin!"

"Look at his temperature sheet tomorrow morning if you think we're signing him out Friday," Sylwia said, corking the spirit carboy tight and locking the narcotics cupboard with a double turn of the heavy iron ward-key. "Deep pectoral pockets full of street grit don't ask permission from Aleja Szucha before they suppurate. Good night, panie docencie. Don't drink out of the methanol jar by mistake—Bronka switched the shelves."

She walked back toward Koszykowa before the eight o'clock curfew bell with Stefan's fifteen hundred crisp *Volksliste* złoty folded inside her bag like greasy butcher's paper and the remaining half-vial of dead Volksdeutscher uremic insulin wrapped in flannel inside her inner pocket where snow-cold kept it stable without freezing it solid.

Along Nowogrodzka the wind off Ochota carried coal smoke mixed with burnt horse-hoof from the glue vat down by Towarowa. At the corner of Emilii Plater two boys no older than Staś squatted over an iron sewer grate trying to hook dropped coke cinders up through the bars with bent wire coat-hangers before a Blue Policeman in a dark navy greatcoat kicked their tin bucket clattering across the slush and sent them scattering like sparrows.

Back up four dark flights at Koszykowa 33, Sylwia wedged the precious half-vial of insulin between the outer and inner window-sashes behind two packed snowballs—nature's two-degree icebox until March—then boiled three potatoes in their skins over a handful of compressed peat dust and ate them salted straight off the point of a kitchen knife standing by the stove.

Across the room on her washstand lay her pawnshop ebony Collin dissecting box from Philippstraße, nineteen-twenty-eight, brass corner-

plates greened with fifteen winters of carbolic steam. Without intending to open it, she unlatched the little brass hook with her thumb.

Six slots in faded purple velvet: four worn scalpel handles honed thin down the belly like willow leaves, one silver probe, one pair of fine Graefe iris forceps whose serrated tips still closed true on a single human eyelash.

Who else asked you about Szczęśliwice before four o'clock today, Kotarska?

Ten years had turned Ludwig Schoeler from a brilliant, penniless twenty-three-year-old bastard fighting dockers under Schöneberg elevated rails into a thirty-four-year-old Wehrmacht intelligence hunter who spoke guttural Warsaw Polish, burned briefcases in snowy railway ditches while bleeding to death, and saw clean through her cover inside four sentences without moving his head off a hospital pillow. Had he wanted her dead or broken on Aleja Szucha's cellar tiles, one dry correction in front of Reinhart Kroll at four-fifteen today—*Frau Doktor must be misreading her watch, Hauptsturmführer; my car didn't reach Lindleya until past one*—would have put Kroll's white cotton gloves round her throat before dark while clearing Ludwig himself of colluding with Polish staff.

He hadn't done it. Not out of mercy—mercy didn't live inside fifty miles of Ludwig Schoeler's ribs—because he needed Lindleya's four quiet walls around him while his shoulder healed, and because if anybody in Warsaw was going to hold a knife over Sylwia Kotarska's neck or let her go, his insufferable Berlin arrogance would never hand the privilege to a Saxon lawyer in cotton gloves.

Sylwia snapped the ebony lid shut, blew out her tallow stub, and lay down fully dressed under two coats on Goldfeder's narrow daybed, listening to sleet hiss against blackout paper while four blocks north on Lindleya twenty-four stitches of her black silk pulsed eighty-eight times a minute in the dark.

Chapter V

Forty Point Four

Warsaw, 27–28 February 1943

Rigors in a six-foot man did not look like shivering; they looked like mild strychnine poisoning. Every skeletal muscle from trapezius to calf fired at twelve cycles a second to drive core heat upward, setting the brass caster-cups under Bed Fourteen chattering against the floorboards like loose teeth while Ludwig's jaw locked hard enough to crack enamel.

Sylwia shook the mercury column down twice before trusting the glass, because hospital thermometers bought through Kraków medical depots since forty-two sometimes separated an air bubble in the capillary stem. Forty degrees point two. Pulse one hundred and thirty-four, bounding and water-hammer hot beneath her fingertips before collapsing between beats.

When she pressed two bare fingers gently above the resected lateral stump of his clavicle—outside the open granulating crater, high beneath the anterior border of the deltoid where skin had looked flat and quiet yesterday afternoon—deep fluctuance yielded softly beneath brawny, angry plum-red edema, and even through forty-degree toxic stupor Ludwig's breath tore ragged through his nose.

A blind subdeltoid pus pocket had walled itself off behind the coracoid process, out of reach of her Carrel tubes.

"Keep him flat and don't pile coats on him when he shakes," Sylwia snapped at Mekelburg, who had flung two Wehrmacht greatcoats over the blanket in peasant terror at seeing his officer's teeth chatter blue. "Pile wool on forty degrees two and you cook his brain to boiled egg-white by midnight. Strip one blanket off, wring linen cloths out in snow-water at the tap, lay them across his forehead and groin creases. Bronka—sterile platinum loop and two clean glass slides!"

Three minutes later she took the cellar stairs two at a time with the flamed glass slides tucked warm inside a tin Petri box against her ribs.

Beneath Pavilion Three ran low-vaulted Prussian-brick service tunnels laid in nineteen hundred and one, sweating saltpeter crystals and smelling perpetually of wet coke, guinea-pig urine, and steamed agar made out of boiled horse-hoof broth. Behind a padlocked iron-sheathed door labeled in peeling black German and Polish paint *Fleckfieber-Labor — Eintritt strengstens verboten!* (*Typhus Laboratory — Entry Strictly Forbidden!*), nobody from the *Ortskommandantur* ever poked a booted toe. Germans feared Polish body-lice worse than partisan grenades; paint a red skull and *Fleckfieber* on a basement door and SS inspectors read the clipboard from six yards up the stairs through scented handkerchiefs.

Sylwia rapped three quick, one slow with her signet knuckle. Bolts slid back; Dr. Halina Różańska opened four inches of crack, saw Sylwia's white smock, and pulled her inside.

"Shut it quick, my stove pipe's drawing backward in the thaw wind and half my cages go sluggish under twenty degrees," Halina said, already turning back toward her Zeiss binocular microscope under a low tin reflector.

Halina wore a man's moth-eaten grey cardigan buttoned over her lab coat and thick brown woollen stockings rolled roughly below her knees because forty minutes ago she had finished the afternoon feeding: strapped around her bare pale upper right thigh, visible for two seconds as she hiked her skirt hem to scratch a livid red wheal with carbolic ointment, sat the grid of four hundred tiny purple pinpricks left by Rudolph Weigl's wooden louse-boxes. Ten tiny mesh-screened matchboxes containing eight hundred healthy, uninfected *Pediculus humanus* larvae drank forty minutes of Halina's blood every afternoon so the municipal sanitary institute kept breeding stock for vaccine gut-harvest—and so "Panna Irena Kwiatkowska, Catholic pharmacist's daughter from Łowicz, baptised St. Stanislaus Parish 1916," stayed entirely indispensable on German municipal typhus-control payrolls even when the hydrogen peroxide bottle ran low and a quarter-inch of stubborn, blue-black Różańska hair showed dark along the center parting of her brassy yellow dye job.

"Room Fourteen?" Halina asked without sentimentality, taking Sylwia's two pus-smeared slides with forceps and passing their backs

thrice through the blue tongue of her spirit Bunsen burner to heat-fix. "Tell me your Prussian bastard has gas gangrene and save my evening."

"Smell's sour-purulent, not mouse-sweet, and zero crepitus under my thumb," Sylwia said, leaning both palms hard on the scarred slate bench while Halina flooded Slide One with crystal violet, counted sixty seconds under her breath, rinsed into a pickle jar, and dropped Lugol's iodine over the purple film. "Spiked from thirty-seven eight at noon to forty point two inside four hours with violent rigors. Walled-off subdeltoid pocket behind the coracoid—three centimeters above my arterial suture. If it's *perfringens* or *oedematiens* eating downward behind pectoralis minor, my silk blows before morning."

Halina decolorized swiftly with acetone-alcohol, counterstained forty seconds in carbol-fuchsin, blotted dry between filter paper sheets, dropped cedarwood oil onto the glass, and racked the hundred-power oil-immersion lens down until brass nearly kissed smear.

For thirty seconds neither woman breathed; only the coal gas whispered blue in the burner tube and something small rustled dryly inside the warm wooden incubator cabinet where eight thousand lice digested Jewish blood under Polish stamps.

"Relax your sphincter, Kotarska," Halina muttered, squinting through the right ocular while rolling the fine micrometer screw half a hair with her thumb. "Not a single Gram-positive boxcar bacillus on five fields. No spores, no shredded ghost-leukocytes. What you've got is chains—long wicked violet pearl-necklaces everywhere, forty cocci to a chain—plus fat grape-clusters inside polymorphs. Beta-hemolytic *Streptococcus* and *Staphylococcus aureus* having a wedding feast in dead fat."

Air went out of Sylwia's lungs so fast her ribs hurt. Streptococcal phlegmon and staphylococcal pus could still kill a debilitated man by septicemia or erode a vessel wall if left dammed under tension—but streptococci bowed their necks to wide surgical incision and sulfathiazole, whereas gas gangrene inside the shoulder girdle meant disarticulating the entire forequarter through the scapula or watching a man swell black and burst awake.

"Thank God," Sylwia muttered before catching herself under Halina's sidelong dark stare.

Halina raised her head slowly from the brass eyepieces. One plucked eyebrow—still dark despite peroxide—arched sharp above cheeks hol-

lowed thin by eighteen months underground since climbing out over the Krochmalna court roof in forty-one. "Thank *whom*, Sylwia? Three weeks ago you wouldn't waste two grams of Cibazol on a Volksdeutscher stationmaster with pneumonia. Now an *Oberstleutnant* shivers upstairs and you sprint down my stairs three steps at a jump."

"If that *Oberstleutnant* dies of septic blowout under my chart while Aleja Szucha and Saski Square are fighting over who shot him," Sylwia said coldly, meeting Halina's stare straight on without blinking, "Kroll's grey boys clear Pavilion Three down to the cellar bricks looking for negligent sabotage—including why 'Irena Kwiatkowska' hides eight ampoules of insulin behind her agar tins and hasn't been to confession since Palm Sunday."

Halina's mouth twisted wryly—not cowed for an instant, because nothing since forty-one cowed Halina except silence from north of Świętojerska. "Fair arithmetic. You want Cibazol or Eleudron?"

"Intravenous Eleudron sodium—twenty-percent ampoules if Bronka didn't trade the last box to Praga. He's vomiting barley water through locked teeth; tablets won't stay down."

Halina unlocked the false bottom behind the horse-serum rack and laid four five-milliliter glass ampoules of German *Eleudron*—sulfathiazole, stamped *Wehrmachtseigentum, I.G. Farbenindustrie Bayer*—into Sylwia's palm. As their fingers brushed, Sylwia noticed a tiny tremor in Halina's right ring finger that hadn't been there Thursday.

"Did the municipal telephone plumber get through to Bonifraterska today?" Sylwia asked quietly.

Halina closed the wooden panel hard enough to rattle empty Petri dishes. Since the January roundups inside the remnant Ghetto—four brief fierce days when pistol shots had cracked back at SS clearing squads from Zamenhofa rooftops for the first time instead of passive marching—only two illicit line-taps through the sanitary sewer exchange still carried thirty-second voice scraps out of the brushmakers' shop where Halina's twenty-four-year-old brother Dawid sorted horsehair bristles twelve hours a day.

"Ninety seconds at noon," Halina said flatly, wiping cedar oil off her slide with xylol rag. "Tobbens and Schultz are trying to move the brush-shop machines to Lublin camps—Poniatowa, Trawniki—and nobody in Dawid's courtyard is packing suitcases. Boys are buying vitriol and six-

round Belgian pistols for five thousand złoty apiece through the wall." Her dark eyes lifted, dry as hot cinders. "Dawid asked if I could send twenty packets of sterile gauze and picric acid burn-jelly in with Tuesday's municipal lime cart. Not bread. Burn-jelly."

Burn-jelly meant petrol bottles brewed in tenement cellars against tanks and flamethrowers. Both of them knew what happened to twenty-four-year-old boys throwing home-made benzine bottles against German armor behind brick walls.

Sylwia didn't insult her with church comfort. "Tell Bronka to pack forty tins of picric ointment and six rolls of oiled silk under the chloride-of-lime sacks Monday night," she said simply. "Take them out of Vesper's German reserve cupboard—I'll log two fictional scald cases on Ward A to cover the stock sheet."

Halina nodded once, chin sharp, and turned back to her burner before anything human could ruin her voice. "Go stick your Prussian before he boils over. Drain that subdeltoid pocket wide—streptococci hate air almost as much as Germans hate drafts."

* * *

Berlin, December 1930

Snow mixed with soot off the Wannsee suburban locomotives fell thick down Potsdamer Straße the night Ludwig Schoeler stole Sylwia's venous-valve numbers and beat her by one ballot for the Rudolf Virchow Undergraduate Medal.

Not stole on paper—had he lifted a table from her typescript she could have laid both notebooks before Geheimrat von Halden and broken his spine across the faculty table. Worse: three weeks earlier, over wet slate sinks in the *Pathologisches Institut* while both of them were injecting red cinnabar gelatin into fifty cadaveric internal mammary and intercostal veins past midnight, she had argued fiercely for twenty minutes that collateral thoracic venous return reversed across valve-less paravertebral plexuses whenever superior vena cava pressure exceeded eighteen centimeters of water. Ludwig had leaned against the radiator smoking a crumpled *Reval*, calling her manometer tubing leaky Polish plumbing and laughing at her numbers. Then tonight, standing straight and insolent in a borrowed dark suit under the gilt portraits of Helmholtz

and Du Bois-Reymond in the great hall, when old Professor Kraus tried tripping Ludwig's arterial-collateral thesis on venous back-pressure congestion, Ludwig had calmly walked to the blackboard, chalked *eighteen centimeters water threshold via Batson-type paravertebral valve-less shunts* without a single note in his hand, added *"as recent manometric observations in our own institute suggest,"* and inclined his fair head half an inch toward the third bench where Sylwia sat frozen in her refurbished black velveteen collar!

Four professors applauded his magnanimity toward a junior female colleague's "preliminary bench work"; five voted him the hundred-mark gold-washed medal and thirty-two hundred Reichsmarks' research stipend; Sylwia got honorable mention on parchment and zero marks toward January coal.

By eleven o'clock she had walked five kilometers south across gleaming wet tram-tracks without feeling her toes inside thin leather boots, carrying the rolled parchment certificate like an iron pipe in her fist, looking to break his teeth with it if she had to knock on every door in Charlottenburg.

He never went home to Mommsenstraße after faculty nights. She knew that from Lotte Bergmann—twenty-five, crop-haired, tubercular-bright, who drew wicked charcoal caricatures of Reichstag deputies for *Ulk* by day, sniffed cocaine off nail-files in Nollendorfplatz ladies' rooms by night, and slept occasionally with half the clinical assistants at the Charité except Ludwig, whom Lotte called *der Eisschrank mit Zähnen*, the icebox with teeth, and followed around out of sheer baffled malice. *Go look behind the horse-butcher's yard on Bülowstraße,* Lotte had laughed at nine-thirty outside the cloakroom, pulling her faux-astrakhan collar high. *Below the elevated U-Bahn girders—old brewery cellar where communist meat-cutters from Central Cattle-Yard fight three-minute bare-knuckle or four-ounce-glove rounds for ten marks a purse. Whenever Margarethe Schoeler sends her bastard a cheque signed with her maiden hyphen, he goes down to Schöneberg to let dockers punch his ribs until he feels poor again.*

Under the roaring iron viaduct of Bülowstraße, where overhead trains showered blue electric sparks down into black slush every four minutes, the cellar reeked of sour *Schultheiss* beer, wet sawdust, sweat, and blood spat into tin buckets.

Sylwia pushed down the slick wooden steps inside her wet black coat, collar turned up, cloche pulled low over her eyebrows. Eighty men in cloth caps, leather aprons, and damp wool jackets jammed four deep around a sixteen-foot rope square slung between cast-iron cellar pillars—no Corps ribbons here, no Heidelberg *Mensur* goggles or padded silk neck-wraps where rich boys stood flat-footed trading decorative cheek-nicks for society brides. Inside the ropes a squat Moabit coal-heaver with shoulders like an ox-yoke and cauliflower ears had a taller, leaner twenty-one-year-old boy pinned against the corner post, driving short brutal hooks—*whack, whack*—into bare white ribs while blood ran bright from the tall boy's split nostril down across a grinning, terrifyingly alive mouth.

Ludwig wore faded grey athletic flannel trousers tied at the waist with surgical cotton tape and nothing above his belt; sweat glistened over flat muscle, every rib showing clean when he twisted inside the coal-heaver's clinch, pivoted off the wet pillar with vicious anatomical precision, and drove a straight right cross not at the heavy jaw—skulls broke bare knuckles—square into the solar plexus notch below the xiphoid cartilage where the phrenic plexus sat unprotected.

The coal-heaver folded forward as if poleaxed, wheezing sour beer onto the sawdust; three men in *Rotfront* badges booed furiously; Lotte Bergmann, perched atop two stacked beer crates by the stove in green silk stockings with a sketchbook across her knees, whistled piercing shrill between two fingers.

Ten minutes later, out in the pitch-black service passage behind the horse-butcher's ashbins where snow drifted down between brick fire-walls, Sylwia stepped out of the doorway shadow directly into Ludwig's path as he came up buttoning his collarless white shirt beneath his threadbare naval pea-coat, wet blond hair steaming in the freezing draft.

She threw the rolled parchment honorable-mention tube straight at his face.

He caught it one-handed six inches from his nose—reflexes still razor-lit from three rounds—glanced down at the Friedrich-Wilhelms wax seal in snow-glare from the streetlamp out on Bülowstraße, and looked up at her standing six feet away with snow melting in her dark lashes.

"Eighteen centimeters of water," Sylwia said, voice shaking with pure white-hot murder. "Three weeks you called my manometer leaky Polish

tin while you memorized every column out of my bench book backward —and then tossed me half a bow from the podium like table-scraps to a terrier so Kraus would call you chivalrous!"

Ludwig tucked her parchment cylinder neatly under his arm rather than dropping it into the slush, dabbing knuckles split purple across the third joint against his split lip and inspecting the dark red smear. Even winded, bruised red along his left ribs under his half-buttoned shirt, he looked more awake in a filthy Schöneberg alley than he ever looked on Mommsenstraße carpets.

"Had Kraus caught me stammering on paravertebral back-flow," Ludwig said coolly, breath smoking white between them, "he'd have handed all thirty-two hundred marks to Kleist's lymphatic-dye drivel, and next spring Kleist would have locked both of us out of the dog-house. You didn't publish your numbers before November fifteenth because you wasted ten days re-calibrating zero-drift like a nun counting beads. Next time print first or shut your notebook when I walk past."

"Thief!" She lunged forward without thinking, not slapping like a girl in a parlor—driving the heel of her gloved palm hard into his bruised left ribs exactly where the coal-heaver's hook had landed twice.

Air exploded out of his lungs in a sharp curse; his right hand shot out, grabbed both her coat lapels in one iron fist, and slammed her back flat against the wet brick fire-wall before she could kick his shin.

Before either of them drew another breath, heavy hobnailed boots splashed round the ashbins from the street mouth—four young men in brown storm-trooper shirts under short winter windbreakers, caps pulled low, hunting stragglers out of the red brewery cellar with lengths of rubber hose and unbuckled heavy brass belt-straps wrapped round their fists.

"Sieh mal einer an," the biggest one snarled, beer-drunk and itching after losing street ground off Nollendorfplatz earlier. "Zwei feine Herrschaften aus dem roten Keller—oder boxt der Herr Student für Moskau?"

"Run back down the cellar steps, Sylwia," Ludwig said very low without looking round, shoving her left behind his own hip and pulling her rolled parchment tube clear out of his armpit only to drop it safe onto an ashbin lid.

Sylwia didn't run half an inch; she reached straight into her coat pocket and closed her fist round the folded Collin dissecting scalpel she carried home every Friday to hone.

She never got the blade open. The first brownshirt swung two feet of heavy leather belt weighted with its rectangular brass buckle whistling through snow-dark aimed at Ludwig's temple; Ludwig ducked inside the arc—almost fast enough, two inches short—taking the sharp corner of the brass buckle edge-on across his right malar bone just beneath the eye while driving his left boot-heel crunching straight through the man's kneecap and slamming a second brawler skull-first into the iron ashbin rim.

Sylwia's heavy umbrella ferrule caught the third brownshirt square in the throat cartilage as Lotte Bergmann burst out the cellar door yelling *"Schupo! Polizei an der Ecke!"* at the top of her cabaret lungs and flinging two empty *Schultheiss* quart bottles smashing in green glass showers across the cobbles. Whistle blasts echoed down from the U-Bahn stairs; within fifteen seconds the four brownshirts dragged their howling knee-smashed comrade backward into the blowing snow and vanished toward Potsdamer Straße.

In the sudden quiet under the viaduct girders, blood poured bright black-red in the streetlamp glare down Ludwig's right cheek, dripping fast off his jaw-point onto snow. Buckles tore on bone like blunt chisels: three centimeters curved clean down to periosteum of the zygomatic arch. Let a casualty station intern stitch facial skin with thick casualty gut and it puckered his lower eyelid down in cicatricial ectropion for life.

"Sit on the crate," Sylwia snapped, fury abruptly swallowed whole by cold surgical reflex. "Lotte—have you got matches or a pocket torch?"

"Better—gin and a powder compact mirror!" Lotte crouched delightedly beside the upturned beer crate, holding a tiny silver-backed cabaret mirror angled to catch yellow electric light from the open cellar transom while overhead an U-Bahn train thundered past shaking soot onto their shoulders.

Out of Sylwia's pawnshop pocket roll came one fine curved Hagedorn skin needle threaded already from afternoon rabbit-ear work with thin black braided silk, soaked thirty seconds in the mouth of Lotte's flat bottle of forty-five-percent juniper schnapps before Sylwia splashed the rest of the schnapps straight across Ludwig's split cheekbone.

He hissed sharply between his teeth, sitting bare-headed on the wet crate with his shirt still half-open to the December freeze, knees spread wide so Sylwia had to stand wedged squarely between his thighs to steady his chin with her left palm while driving the unanesthetized needle point through cold, tough facial dermis six inches from his open eyes.

One. Two. Three. Four.

Every time steel pierced skin raw, his hands—resting loose on his own thighs two inches from the damp wool flanks of her coat—clenched once into white-knuckled stones and opened again without touching her. Up that close, wedged between his knees in the dark while gin-vapor, fresh hot blood, snow, and warm male skin steamed up into her face, Ludwig didn't look at Lotte's mirror; he stared straight up at Sylwia's mouth pinched grim in concentration, her dark lashes dusted white with melting snow, a smudge of his own cheekbone blood smeared across her chin where her wrist had brushed it.

"Pull stitch three half a millimeter tighter," Lotte offered helpfully, lighting a cigarette. "Give him something to remember Schöneberg by—he was hideously symmetrical anyway. Going to hold the spool for me while I sketch you two, or do I freeze out here alone?"

"Go inside and get warm, Lotte," Ludwig said without moving his eyes half a millimeter off Sylwia's face.

Lotte looked once from Ludwig's locked jaw to Sylwia's ungloved hands trembling faintly between his knees—not from cold—gave a low, wicked whistle through cigarette smoke, and banged the cellar door shut behind her, leaving them in dead blue snow-shadow behind the ashbins.

Sylwia bit the black silk thread off half an inch from the fourth knot with her own front teeth because her scissors were still buried inside her bag. Copper-salt blood and raw juniper gin coated her tongue.

Before she could step backward out from between his thighs, Ludwig's bruised right hand came up and caught the back of her coat at the small of her spine, pulling her four inches closer until her shins hit the crate edge and her knees wedged hard against his ribs.

"You bit dirty street silk with your teeth, *Fräulein Doktor*," he murmured, voice rough and low in his chest, breath hot against her cold mouth. Blood still oozed in one thin dark bead between stitch two and stitch three where she had pulled tightly enough to leave faint ladder-marks forever. "Bad asepsis."

"I hope it suppurates," Sylwia whispered, heart hammering so violently against her breastbone she felt half-sick with hatred and twenty-year-old hunger indistinguishable from wanting to kill him. Her cold, blood-sticky left fingers were still tangled in the damp collarless neck of his shirt over his collarbone; instead of letting go she twisted the linen tight against his throat. "Give me half the lab bench grant on Monday or I'll tell Kraus whose manometer tubes broke eighteen centimeters."

"Half the bench hours and zero pfennigs on your name," he breathed back, tilting his head up until his cold nose grazed hers and the unsplit corner of his mouth brushed—not kissed, scraped, salt-wet and furious—against her lower lip so she tasted his blood twice over. "You come work nights at my sink without whining to von Halden, *Polack*, or go starve in Posen."

For three seconds her mouth parted hot against his in the freezing dark—teeth clicking once against teeth, her thumb digging hard into the hollow above his sternum while his fingers bruised her waist through wet wool, both of them shaking on the edge of dragging each other down onto beer crates and dirty snow—until footsteps crunched loud at the street mouth and Sylwia shoved back out of his grip so savagely her elbow hit the brick wall, wiping the back of her hand hard across her mouth and snatching her parchment cylinder off the ashbin without looking back down Bülowstraße until the snow swallowed him.

* * *

Warsaw, 28 February 1943

At two-fifteen on Sunday morning the thermometer shook down from forty degrees point four.

Outside Room Fourteen the night corridor was dead black save for one blue blackout nightlight burning behind wire mesh; inside, Sylwia had turned off the overhead bulb and set a single shaded candle behind the porcelain washbasin so Stabsarzt Vesper's night patrol, if anyone drove past Lindleya gate, wouldn't see bright windows blazing in the quarantined wing.

At midnight she had incised the walled-off subdeltoid pocket herself right in the bed rather than risking an operating-room carry—one swift, deep five-centimeter stroke with a pointed #11 Bistoury along

the anterior deltoid border while Mekelburg pinned his half-conscious commander's right shoulder down. Sixty milliliters of thick creamy yellow streptococcal pus under fierce tension had gushed straight into the kidney basin before she slid a fenestrated rubber tube high behind the coracoid process, flushed until clear saline ran back out the lower axillary cleft, and injected two full grams of Halina's stolen *Eleudron* sodium slowly into his right cubital vein over ten minutes.

For two hours afterward the bacterial toxin dump from opening the abscess sent him higher instead of lower: forty point four, skin dry and burning like an iron stove-lid under her bare palms, breathing shallow at thirty-six a minute, muttering broken half-syllables in North German childhood dialect about salt water and a boat hook at Kiel before lapsing into terrifying rigid silences where Sylwia sat perched on the edge of the mattress itself with two fingers fixed permanently over his carotid artery.

Around two o'clock Bruno Mekelburg slid sideways off his wooden chair in the corner, worn clean out after nineteen days sleeping upright with a healing three-fingered stump, snoring mouth-open with his blond head resting against the cold radiator pipe.

Sylwia wrung out another coarse linen towel in the enamel basin of melted courtyard snow cut with hospital vinegar, folded back the damp sheet to Ludwig's waist, and wiped down his burning throat, right chest, ribs, and flat stomach in long steady strokes to pull heat off the great skin vessels by evaporation.

Under faint amber candle-shadow his torso gleamed wet; above the white gauze mountain strapping his left shoulder, the skin over his right clavicle and neck radiated dry furnace heat against her knuckles. Across his right lower ribs, just above that older jagged shell-scar from forty-one, gooseflesh prickled sharply beneath the cold vinegar cloth even while blood boiled underneath.

Without warning, his right hand whipped up out of stupor and locked round her wet left wrist.

Not sluggish invalid strength—pure brain-stem delirium force, fingers closing like five iron shackles directly over her radial styloid until bones ground together and she bit her lip hard not to cry out and wake Mekelburg six feet away.

His eyes were wide open in the dim candle-glow, dark pupils blown enormous across winter-green irises, staring straight up into her face bent

twelve inches above his chest—seeing her and not seeing Pavilion Three at all.

"Geh nicht zurück in die Klinik," he rasped in a hoarse, cracked whisper that raised every fine hair along the back of Sylwia's neck. *Don't go back to the clinic.* "Sie stehen schon unten am Tor in der Luisenstraße—lass die Hefte liegen, Sylwia, nimm den Zug—"

Sylwia stayed stone-still on the mattress edge, cold vinegar dripping off the forgotten linen cloth between her fingers onto his bare ribs while his burning thumb crushed her pulse point. March nineteen-thirty-three. Ten years buried under rubble, and inside forty-point-four septic fire he was standing in her Savignyplatz room again.

"Ludwig," she breathed almost inaudibly, trying with her free right hand to pry his iron thumb loose before he bruised her wrist purple enough for Bronka to see at morning rounds. "Let go. You're in Warsaw."

His brow furrowed fiercely, eyes flickering sideways toward the dark ceiling corner as if hunting shadows behind her shoulder, then snapping back to her face with sudden, chilling half-lucidity mixed into fever.

"Jakob wollte nicht einsteigen," he whispered raw through cracked lips, chest heaving short against the white Velpeau turns. *Jakob wouldn't get on.* "Ich stand vierzig Minuten am Anhalter Bahnhof mit den Prager Papieren—er ist zurückgelaufen wegen seiner Präparate, der alte Narr, wegen zwanzig Gläsern in Formalin—"

Sylwia's breath stopped dead inside her throat.

I stood forty minutes at Anhalter Bahnhof with the Prague papers—he ran back for his specimens, the old fool, for twenty jars in formalin.

Anhalter Bahnhof handled southbound expresses toward Dresden and Prague. On the eighth of March nineteen-thirty-three, when two SA trucks and criminal-police detectives had hauled Professor Jakob Mandelbaum off the steps of the Neuroanatomy Annex, every student left whispering on Philippstraße had sworn—Lotte Bergmann herself had sworn to Sylwia through tears at Friedrichstraße station!—that *Ludwig Schoeler* had unlocked Mandelbaum's private cabinet key for the Party commissar at noon in exchange for Mandelbaum's first-assistant stipend.

Why would a man burning alive at forty degrees point four with hemolytic streptococci in his blood invent standing forty minutes at Anhalter Bahnhof holding forged Prague papers for a dead Jew ten years ago?

Before her stunned brain could move a muscle, his grip shifted convulsively on her wrist, pulling her three inches lower as present-day terror crashed across the Berlin ghost behind his glassy eyes.

"*Chłodna zweiundzwanzig,*" he breathed straight against her cheek, switching without seam from nineteen-thirty-three into the rough, guttural Warsaw-German whisper of *Abwehrstelle* nights. "*Nicht vor dem Zehnten zum Optiker—wenn Kroll den Uhrzeiger hat, brennt das ganze Netz bis zur Spiska…*"

Chłodna twenty-two. Not to the optician before the tenth—if Kroll has the clock-hand, the whole net burns as far as Spiska.

Sylwia slapped her free right palm lightly—not gently, crisp and cold with snow-water—flat across his dry lips before a single louder consonant could reach Bruno Mekelburg's sleep-heavy ears by the radiator.

Beneath her wet palm his mouth burned like hot brick; she felt the faint, rough scar-ridge on his lower lip from biting Mekelburg's belt eleven days ago, and above her fingers his dilated eyes blinked once, twice, swimming violently upward out of delirium as cold snow-water hit his skin.

For five endless heartbeats she stayed pinned just like that: sitting sideways on his narrow iron bed in candle-darkness, her left wrist crushed inside his hot right fist against his bare wet sternum, her right palm pressed firm across his mouth, staring straight down from eight inches into grey-green eyes slowly, horribly clearing enough to realize somebody had been listening while his skull leaked.

Sweat broke suddenly—not cold shock sweat like Tuesday week, true defervescent crisis sweat as two grams of intravenous sulfathiazole and wide pus drainage finally cracked the hypothalamic thermostat—pouring out of his hairline, neck, and chest all at once in a hot salt flood underneath her wrist.

Slowly, finger by stiff finger, Ludwig loosened his grip around her bruised left radius.

Sylwia lifted her hand off his mouth. Neither of them wiped the wet away. His breathing slowed from thirty-six to twenty-four, ragged and exhausted; when he tried to speak, barely a thread of sound came out—dry, wary, searching her stony dark face in the amber gloom to read how much had spilled out of his mouth while the room spun.

"How high?" he whispered.

"Forty point four," Sylwia said, voice steady as cold slate though inside her skull two dynamite caps—*Anhalter Bahnhof* and *Chłodna twenty-two, der Uhrzeiger, Spiska*—were ringing until her ears hummed. Gently, with clinical detachment more brutal than any slap, she pulled his soaked blanket back up to his chin so his sudden sweat wouldn't chill into pneumonia, lifted her tin basin of pinkish-vinegar snow water off the night-table, and stood up. "Thirty-eight nine now by skin feel. Your pocket's draining clean and Halina's sulfathiazole caught the cocci before they reached my silk. Go to sleep, Schoeler."

His eyes tracked her shadow against the whitewashed wall all the way to the basin tap—narrowed, sleepless again despite exhaustion, haunted by the certainty that he had dropped a loaded pistol somewhere in the dark room and couldn't see whose pocket held it.

Out in the empty sluice corridor at four in the morning, with nobody awake in Pavilion Three except dying men upstairs and eight thousand lice in the cellar, Sylwia leaned her forehead for ten seconds flat against cold sweating tiles above the slop sink, looking down at four livid violet finger-marks already blooming purple around her left wrist where Ludwig had held on.

She did not write *Chłodna 22* down anywhere—Marek had taught her better than paper—and she did not tell herself what she was going to tell Marek at Bagno on Tuesday noon.

Chapter VI

The Louse Feeders

Warsaw, 8 March 1943

March arrived smelling of wet dog, rotten cabbages thawed out of courtyard snowdrifts, and dead mortar blowing off the rubble of the Small Ghetto whenever wind came round the corner of Żelazna.

In the ironmonger's cart-passage off Krochmalna, two apprentices in burlap aprons were hammering rust scale off salvaged boiler flues with ball-peen hammers—*clang, clang, clang*—loud enough to drown five conspirators shouting into a rain barrel. Sylwia stood behind a stack of cast-iron stove grates watching muddy thaw-water run black between the cobbles while Marek shook rainwater off his cap visor.

"Your Prussian isn't dying very fast," Marek said without preamble. "Nineteen days since the ninth of February. Yesterday afternoon Hauptmann von Berg from Saski Square spent forty minutes inside Room Fourteen with a locked dispatch pouch while two military policemen cleared your corridor."

"Wounds packed open across a two-centimeter clavicular gap take four weeks to granulate over a naked artery," Sylwia said, keeping her gloved hands buried deep inside her coat pockets where the faint yellow fade of Ludwig's four finger-bruises still ringed her left wrist bone. "You told me on Bagno to keep him under Lindleya's roof and listen."

"And what have you heard besides military policemen striking matches?"

Sylwia watched the smaller apprentice spit brown tobacco juice onto a rusty elbow-pipe. Eight days she had carried the fever-fragments around behind her teeth like bits of broken amalgam—turning them over during appendectomies, weighing them on tram platforms, testing where one cut led if you pulled the string. *Chłodna zweiundzwanzig—nicht vor dem*

Zehnten zum Optiker—wenn Kroll den Uhrzeiger hat, brennt das ganze Netz bis zur Spiska. Today was the eighth of March. Two days before the tenth.

Give Marek *everything*—optician, tenth of March, *der Uhrzeiger* ("the clock-hand," unmistakably *Zegar* if translated back into Polish!), and *Spiska*—and if Marek's own *Kontrwywiad* chain was clean, they caught a German drop red-handed on Wednesday. If, on the other hand, someone high enough up Warsaw District's ladder to have met an *Abwehr* car in Ochota with twelve hundred Swiss francs sat anywhere above Marek's reports, handing over the whole sentence signed Sylwia Kotarska's own death warrant because nobody on earth except the night surgeon in Room Fourteen had been inside four feet of Ludwig Schoeler's mouth when he hit forty point four.

Half a loaf tested the oven without burning the baker.

"Six nights ago he spiked past forty with a subdeltoid abscess," Sylwia said evenly. "In rigor delirium before the pus drained, he muttered one street number twice in German: *Chłodna twenty-two*. Something about an optician, not before the tenth of the month."

Marek's narrow grey eyes sharpened instantly—not surprise, recognition clicking onto an existing map grid behind his forehead. *Chłodna 22* stood halfway between Żelazna and Waliców, right along the narrowed Aryan carriageway corridor where trams clanged between the old northern and southern halves of the Ghetto wall, every ground-floor shopfront watched day and night by Blue Police posts and German *Zollgrenzschutz* customs guards.

"Optician," Marek repeated softly under the *clang-clang* of the boiler hammers. "Kaminski's spectacle-grinding shop was at twenty-two before forty-one; some Reich-German trustee from Łódź took over the lease making magnifying lenses for railway signalmen. Did he say a name? A cover-word?"

"Just boat hooks in Kiel and some dead professor from Berlin," Sylwia lied cleanly, looking straight at the wet collar button of Marek's coat without blinking. "Fever hash. Forty degrees four boils syntax before you get whole sentences."

Marek nodded once, calculating dates rapidly. "Tenth is Wednesday. Nobody from our shop goes near Chłodna twenty-two inside forty-eight hours—we'll put two girls with shopping baskets across the carriageway in the bakery queue from seven a.m. Wednesday and photograph every

bastard who walks under the spectacle sign." His mood lightened visibly with concrete quarry underfoot; stepping half a pace closer into the dark angle behind the stacked cast-iron grates, he slid one ungloved hand inside the open front of Sylwia's coat, cold fingers finding her waist above her skirt band and pressing her hip back toward the dry brick wall. "Come up to Koszykowa at seven tonight? My pass runs till nine on Tuesday shifts now."

Sylwia's spine went stiff before her brain gave permission.

Not revulsion—Marek smelled no different today than on the ninth of February, the same wet shoddy wool, iron rust, and dry male skin—simply a sudden, blank wall of physical refusal so absolute that if he had pushed his hand two inches higher under her blouse she would have struck his wrist off like a drunk orderly's.

"I'm on Praga supply run till curfew and taking Mirecki's night call afterward," she said, stepping sideways out of the angle and buttoning her coat over his withdrawing hand as briskly as shutting a ledger. "His angina flared twice on the stairs yesterday; he took nitroglycerin behind the X-ray screen and thinks nobody saw."

Marek paused with his hand half-raised between them, looking closely at her gaunt, closed face in the grey passage light. Engineers noticed tolerances shifting by half a millimeter even when they misread the load.

"That German keeping you up nights?" he asked dryly.

"Seventy surgical beds and three grams of stolen sulfonamide keep me up nights," Sylwia said, already turning toward the street arch where cold drizzle blew across Krochmalna mud. "Tell your girls in the bakery queue on Wednesday to watch for grey cotton gloves if Aleja Szucha knows the address already. Kroll hasn't stopped sniffing round Lindleya's gate-book."

* * *

At five-fifteen a red municipal Number Seven tram ground across Poniatowski Viaduct above a Vistula split into dirty grey ice-floes grinding northward toward Modlin like broken graveyard slabs.

Sylwia stood wedged on the rear Polish platform between a peasant woman reeking of wet calfskin who carried two live pigeons buttoned

silently inside her bosom and a one-legged railway pensioner leaning on an ash-wood crutch. Up ahead in the front half of the car behind the wooden chain—*Nur für Deutsche*—three Wehrmacht pay-clerks rode sitting down with six empty benches around their polished boots, reading the *Warschauer Zeitung*. Every time the tramwheels screamed round the curve descending into Praga, icy river wind whipped sleet under the canvas platform apron across Sylwia's ankles.

Inside her shabby black leather Gladstone bag—heavy enough to pull her right shoulder socket half an inch low—rode two sealed half-kilo tins of pure *Merck* anesthetic ether skimmed ten milliliters at a time off Vesper's German theater allotment over five weeks by Bronka, plus twelve hundred of Stefan's crisp *Volksliste* złoty folded inside a hollowed bar of grey clay ration soap.

Praga on the east bank always felt ten miles closer to Russia and fifty years rougher than left-bank Warsaw: low wooden fences rotting black beside brick railway tenements, horse-manure steaming outside vodka monopolies on Targowa, narrow-gauge sidings clanking behind tarred palings around **Dworzec Wschodni** where white-painted *Lazarettzüge* —hospital trains thirty cars long hauling frostbitten, shrapnel-chewed Wehrmacht remnants back from Kursk and Orel—stopped three hours to coal, water, and dump dead men before rolling west toward Breslau.

Hospital trains carried heaven in locked zinc cupboards: Bayer *Eleudron*, *Prontosil*, *Evipan* sodium, Dutch and Danish forty-unit insulin kept for diabetic colonels, genuine catgut sealed in glass tubes that didn't snap like rotten cotton inside a belly.

Behind the ruined spirit-rectification warehouse off Kijowska, thirty yards from the outer coaling fence where locomotive steam hung low and yellow-grey with sulfur in the March dusk, Pan Zygmunt was waiting inside a bombed coal-weigher's brick booth with his brass Ostbahn lantern turned face-to-the-wall.

Zygmunt had driven sleeping cars on the Warsaw–Vienna line before thirty-nine and still waxed the points of his grey moustache with axle-tallow. Without wasting civilities he lifted the canvas flap of Sylwia's bag, weighed both *Merck* ether tins on his palm—railwaymen and Wehrmacht dental orderlies paid gold for real Merck ether, either to trade to underground field stations east of Siedlce or to brew *hoffmannstropfen* spirit

punch that knocked soldiers blind drunk on ten drops—and counted her twelve hundred złoty under his thumbnail.

"Two boxes intravenous Eleudron, five ampoules each, unbroken Bayer seal," Zygmunt muttered, pulling flat cardboard cartons out from inside his quilted railwayman's vest where body heat kept glass from cracking. "And two ten-milliliter vials Danish Leo forty-unit, good till December forty-three—came off a Stabsarzt's refrigerator car out of Königsberg at noon."

"You promised three vials Tuesday on the telephone," Sylwia said sharply, checking the rubber diaphragm caps under the tiny crack of his hooded lantern to make sure no clever orderly had drawn half the insulin out with a fine needle and topped the volume up with tap water.

"Three when Berlin trains weren't getting blown off the rails outside Minsk twice a week, pani doktor. Take two or leave them—a pharmacist from Grochów offered eighteen hundred apiece an hour ago."

She pocketed both insulin vials deep inside her wool dress lining against her own ribs and slid the two Bayer *Eleudron* cartons into her bag on top of a clean layer of pickled-beet rags Bronka packed for cover. Fifty paces back along the broken cinder-path beside Kijowska's dead brick wall led out to the lighted tram stop at Targowa, twenty-five minutes before eight o'clock curfew.

She had covered thirty of those fifty paces through drifting yellow coal-steam when a man in a belted leatherette trenchcoat and checked cloth cap stepped out from behind a rusted switch-box directly across the cinder path, whistling *Rozszumiały się wierzby płaczące* cheerfully off-key between crooked teeth.

Sylwia didn't break stride, shifting her Gladstone handle to her left hand so her right stayed free inside her pocket around her heavy brass flat-key—and knew instantly from the practiced half-circle shuffle of his galoshes that he wasn't a drunk after purses.

Szmalcownik. Or railway-siding Gestapo tout—same vermin in Praga, thirty-year-old Warsaw gutter-rats who hung round Dworzec Wschodni arches smelling black-market butter, escaped Jews with sewn-in gold coins, or Wehrmacht medical contraband at forty yards like ferrets smelling rabbit holes.

"Evening, pani doktor," the tout said amiably in Warsaw street-corner Polish, blocking the two-yard gap between brick wall and barbed-wire

railway ditch so close she smelled pickled herring and bad dentist's clove oil off his breath. Small wet pig-eyes flicked straight down to the rectangular bulge inside her worn Gladstone bag. "Careful on those cinders in the dark—drop glass ampoules stamped *Wehrmachtseigentum* out here by the Bahnschutz fence and those Ukrainian guards shoot before they count boxes. Let's have a little look inside the bag, sweetheart, or we stroll sixty yards down to the guard-hut together and split the reward legal."

Rage—cold, murderous, crystal-clear—dropped Sylwia's heartbeat instead of speeding it. Hand over the bag and Staś ran dry of insulin by April third while Pavilion Three lost ten ampoules of sulfathiazole; scream on Kijowska sidings and two Bahnschutz riflemen came running inside forty seconds to find *Wehrmachtseigentum* Bayer cartons in a Polish surgeon's bag—straight to Pawiak women's ward "Serbia" by ten p.m.

"Twelve hundred's all the cash on me," Sylwia said flatly, pretending terrified compliance as she dipped her right hand slowly into her coat pocket—not for notes, hooking her middle finger squarely through the heavy brass bow of Koszykowa's four-inch corridor key with its jagged ward-bit protruding forward between her knuckles like a chisel. "Let me take the insulin out—it's for a child—"

"Bag and coat-pocket both, lady, and pull that little gold watch off your blouse pin while you're—"

He reached his left hand out to grab her collar.

Before Sylwia's brass key cleared wool, something grey-white and silent materialized out of the locomotive steam four paces behind the tout's right shoulder.

Zero shout, zero warning movie-hero bark—just two fast muffled crunches in wet coal cinders and a twenty-inch length of iron lorry tire-lever wrapped twice in burlap sacking whipped horizontally out of the fog into the side of the tout's right clavicle with a sodden *whock* like splitting wet marrow-bone with an axe-back.

Collarbone snapped audibly on impact. Before the tout could get half a scream past herring-stinking teeth, a booted knee drove up into his groin, folding him nose-down onto his face, and the same right fist—swinging alone because the attacker's left forearm stayed tucked rigid inside a grey reversible Wehrmacht parka front—brought the burlap-wrapped iron heel down once, short and economical, across the bridge of the man's nose and upper incisors against the frozen cinders.

Blood snorted black into coal mud; the tout twitched twice at the heels and went slack, snoring wetly through crushed nasal cartilage without waking a single Bahnschutz dog sixty yards down the fence.

Sylwia stood motionless against the damp brick wall with the brass key clenched between her knuckles, staring down at **Gefreiter Bruno Mekelburg**.

He wore no helmet and no silver belt-buckle shine—parka turned grey-side-out, field cap stuffed inside his pocket, breath steaming short through parted country-boy lips as he knelt one-kneed beside the unconscious tout, flipped the leatherette coat lapels open one-handed to verify no Gestapo metal warrant-disc hung inside on a chain—nothing, only a greasy blue *Kennkarte*, three pawn tickets, and a flick-knife—and wiped two drops of blood off the burlap-wrapped tire-iron onto the tout's checked cap before sliding the iron cleanly down inside his boot-top.

"Walk to the tram stop, *Frau Doktor*," Mekelburg whispered in flat East Prussian German, rising without looking down again at the groaning heap in the cinders. "Number Seven pulls round the loop in two minutes. Don't run—running makes the bridge sentry look twice."

Sylwia did not move a muscle for two seconds, eyes blazing straight into his turnip-pale face in the sulfur mist. "You followed me across the river from Lindleya."

"Talk on the bridge, not beside sixty railway guards," Mekelburg said grimly, tilting his chin toward Targowa's dim blue streetlamp. "Move your feet, *bitte*, or I carried this iron across Warsaw for nothing."

Common sense beat fury by half a length. She walked—brisk, steady, chin high, Gladstone bag knocking lightly against her calf—out onto Targowa pavement just as the red Number Seven clanged round the terminal loop. Mekelburg swung aboard the *front* German platform twenty feet ahead of her, flashing his Königsberg signals *Soldbuch* to the Polish conductor without once glancing rearward toward the wooden dividing chain where Sylwia stood gripping a cold brass upright behind two washerwomen's laundry baskets.

Halfway back across Poniatowski Viaduct, when wind roared loud off the ice-choked Vistula below and the front German compartment happened to empty out at Solec ramp, Mekelburg stepped back against the dividing chain to light a crumpled *Juno* cigarette one-handed—striking the match deftly with thumbnail against box wedged beneath his splinted

left armpit—back half-turned to Sylwia two feet behind him so anyone watching saw only a sullen Wehrmacht corporal blocking Polish wind with his shoulders.

"He sent you after me," Sylwia said low in German straight at the shaved nape of his neck above the grey parka collar. "From a hospital bed with an open chest."

"Der *Oberstleutnant* didn't send me anywhere," Mekelburg muttered around the unlit cigarette without turning his head, eyes fixed forward through sleet-streaked tram glass. "He slept from three till four after Hauptmann von Berg left. I saw your old fat nurse packing two ether tins out of the German cupboard into beet rags before five, and I know what railwaymen trade at Dworzec Wschodni because I traded two cans of pork fat there myself last Tuesday for clean socks."

Sylwia's grip tightened on her bag handle. "And what business is it of yours what my matron packs in beet rags?"

"None—so long as half of what came out of that railwayman's vest goes into Bed Fourteen's veins when his fever climbs again instead of all going upstairs to Polish carpenters," Mekelburg said with blunt, unembarrassed peasant cunning that nearly took her breath away. Gently under his parka front he shifted his three-fingered left hand in its wooden splint. "Besides—catch you with Bayer army boxes at Kijowska fence, and tomorrow morning that white-gloved SS bastard from Aleja Szucha locks Pavilion Three up tight, throws my *Oberstleutnant* into an SS ambulance before his artery's tough, and puts me in a penal battalion clearing mines with a stick at Rzhev. Breaking one Warsaw rat's nose saved everybody trouble."

Wind howled across the viaduct ironwork; below them black water chewed white foam along stone piers blown up in thirty-nine and patched with raw pine timbers.

"I bought two boxes of Eleudron," Sylwia said coldly at the back of his big red ear. "Ten ampoules. Five stay locked in Room Fourteen's washstand for your commander if streptococci flare again; five go upstairs where I please. Breathe one word to Vesper or your *Oberstleutnant* about Kijowska—or trail my coat again—and next time I change your finger dressings I'll leave just enough silk knot deep in the third web-space to keep your palm suppurating till Christmas."

Mekelburg's narrow shoulders actually gave a single silent heave that might, in East Prussia, have passed for laughter. "Agreed, *Frau Doktor*. Though if you want forty-unit Danish insulin cheaper than railway thieves sell it, tell me next Monday before you cross the river—our *Sanitätspark* clerk on Królewska owes me forty Reichsmarks from skat, and he steals cleaner than train guards."

Before Sylwia could frame an answer sharp enough to flay him, the tram ground screeching into Aleje Jerozolimskie at Marszałkowska corner and Mekelburg dropped cleanly off the front step into blowing sleet, vanishing down Brackia three minutes ahead of her so Lindleya's gatehouse would never log surgeon and corporal walking through the arch inside the same quarter-hour.

* * *

At ten minutes to ten Room Fourteen was quiet except for rain ticking against blackout tin and the slow dry turn of thin Bible-paper pages.

Ludwig sat propped upright on two bolsters with a faded grey linen Leipzig pocket edition of Thucydides—*Der Peloponnesische Krieg*, Greek facing German—resting open against his bandaged left forearm like a music stand while his uninjured right hand pared tiny shavings off a rock-hard wedge of smoked sheep's cheese Mekelburg had conjured from God knew which peasant market, laying each transparent curl onto dry ration crispbread with surgical neatness.

Twenty-seven days since Table One. Eight days since forty point four. Without toxic fever puffing his face, he looked leaner than ever—collarbone hollow on the intact right side deep enough to hold walnut shells, dark blond hair grown long enough over his collar to curl slightly damp from evening washing—yet the grey putty death-cast had vanished completely. Healthy colour sat faint beneath wind-roughened skin; when Sylwia unlocked the washstand cupboard with her iron ward-key and laid one unbroken five-ampoule carton of Bayer *Eleudron* silently on the zinc shelf beside his irrigation bottles, his winter-green eyes lifted over the top of Thucydides without missing a stroke of his pocket-knife blade.

"Generous of the municipal pharmacy," Ludwig remarked mildly.

"Your corporal snores louder than he walks, *Herr Oberstleutnant*," Sylwia said without turning round from prepping the evening Dakin's

syringe. “Tell him next time he takes evening strolls across the river in reversible parkas to scrape yellow Kijowska coal-ash off his boot welts before standing at attention on my white floor.”

Behind her in the corner chair, Bruno Mekelburg went brick-red clear up into his shaved blond bristles, staring fixedly at the ceiling moulding as if reciting artillery tables.

On the bed, Ludwig slowly closed his folding pocket-knife with a soft *snick* and looked first at Mekelburg’s muddy boot-heels, then back at the hem of Sylwia’s wool skirt peeping two inches below her white ward smock—where three identical dried grey-yellow spatters of Praga locomotive cinder-slush marked the black cloth.

Clearly Mekelburg *had* kept his word and hadn’t breathed a syllable since returning at eight; watching Ludwig put the entire Praga equation together in three silent seconds—stolen ether out, Bayer sulfathiazole and black-market contraband back, a broken-knuckled corporal playing uninvited bodyguard—was like watching steel tumblers click inside a Chubb safe.

“Bruno,” Ludwig said pleasantly, “go ask Siostra Bronisława whether the kitchen stove still has hot water for shaving tomorrow morning. Take ten minutes.”

Mekelburg escaped into the hall as if shot from a mortar.

Sylwia unpinned the outer dressing pad without waiting for commentary. “Lean forward two inches so the towel catches the flush.”

He leaned forward off the bolsters—effortless abdominal core strength now compared to two weeks ago, no tremor at all—letting her peel away the yellow iodoform strips. Underneath, the wound looked magnificent in the ugly, uncompromising way only *per secundam* surgery ever looked magnificent: zero grey slough, zero pus, the subdeltoid counter-incision already flat and dry, and across the entire palm-sized deltopectoral floor a carpet of firm, bright beefy-red granulation buds bleeding tiny pinpricks where gauze lifted off, already contracting inward three millimeters round the edges to bury her deep muscle bridge over the axillary artery forever under tough fibrous scar.

“Ten more days and skin grafts wouldn’t even save time,” Ludwig observed, craning his chin down sideways to inspect his own raw chest wall with clinical detachment while Dakin’s solution hissed faintly down

the shallowing trough. "Clean granulation. My compliments, *Frau Doktor*. Even von Halden's septic ward rarely looked cleaner by week four."

"Save your compliments for Stabsarzt Vesper's discharge ledger," Sylwia said briskly, packing half the previous depth of gauze into the shrinking cavity. "Inside twelve days that scar shelf is tough enough to bounce from here to Königsberg in an ammunition lorry without tearing a stitch, and Pavilion Three gets its six beds—and its quiet corridors—back."

He didn't lean back onto the bolsters when she finished the first calico turn; he stayed forward four inches, bare right shoulder and warm throat level with her chin while she passed the linen roll behind his spine, gray-green eyes resting steady and unhurried on her profile from ten inches away.

"You really want your corridor quiet right now, Sylwia?" he asked softly.

Her hands didn't pause on the bandage roll, pulling the cross-turn snug across his sternum. "My corridor was quiet before nine February."

"Your corridor was lucky before nine February," he corrected her quietly. "Right now two military policemen with *Abwehrstelle* warrant brassards sit outside your east doors night and day, which means neither Schutzpolizei street patrols nor Reinhart Kroll's junior clerks from Aleja Szucha can walk unannounced into Pavilion Three without signing a Wehrmacht counter-intelligence logbook twenty paces from your stairs. Take my sentries away next week—after Kroll has already smelled something clever round your gatehouse clock—and how long before white cotton gloves come back alone at three in the morning to count every patient and laboratory girl under your floorboards?"

Sylwia's fingers stilled for half a second on the split calico knot above his right clavicle.

He didn't know Halina's real name—couldn't possibly know about Dawid or Weigl lice on Jewish thighs unless walls had X-ray eyes—yet a professional counter-espionage hunter lying awake twenty-seven nights in a Polish municipal hospital heard clogs on cellar stairs at midnight, smelled extra broth pots carried past locked doors, measured the exact nervous sweat on Docent Mirecki's forehead whenever German boots echoed in the hall, and knew an underground burrow by the draft under the wainscoting!

"Are you threatening my hospital, *Schoeler*, or charging rent?" she whispered, bitter and low above his bare collarbone.

"Neither," Ludwig said, eyes dark slate-green at close range, not a trace of mockery in them now. "Just reminding a clever surgeon not to pull a tamponade plug out before she knows what bleeds behind it. And don't curse Mekelburg for walking behind you at Kijowska. Half the touts working Dworzec Wschodni coal fences report twice a week to Referat IV N on Szucha for vodka money. Had you put your brass house-key into that pig's eye tonight and left him alive enough to describe a tall dark woman doctor with Berlin German, Kroll would have lined up every female physician in Warsaw by noon tomorrow."

Blood stung hot behind Sylwia's ears—furious at being seen right down to the brass key inside her right pocket! "Tell him to stay inside this room where he belongs."

"Tell an East Prussian farm boy twice not to do something after you saved three of his fingers and you might as well talk Greek to a mule." Ludwig shifted back onto the bolsters as she clipped the knot tails short, reaching his right hand underneath the corner of his grey Wehrmacht blanket where his leather map-wallet sat wedged against the iron frame. Without ceremony he tossed three flat square silver-foil packets onto the white sheet beside her instrument tray: *Dextropur — Reiner Traubenzucker — Luftwaffen-Notration.* Pure crystalline medicinal glucose blocks issued to bomber crews against high-altitude exhaustion. "Whoever you're buying black-market forty-unit insulin for on railway ramps—when ration turnips miscalculate starch against forty-unit depot peaks at three in the morning and there's no sugar lump in the flat, half a square under the tongue beats boiling potato peelings."

Sylwia stared down at the three silver-foil squares glinting on the coarse hospital sheet.

Last month, during the January freeze when Polish sugar coupons went unhonored for three weeks, Wanda had woken screaming at four a.m. to find nine-year-old Staś drenched in icy sweat and twitching in hypoglycemic convulsions at twenty-eight milligrams blood glucose, forcing Sylwia to sprint eight blocks through curfew snow with twenty milliliters of hospital fifty-percent intravenous dextrose to pull him out of coma before brain damage set in.

She looked up from the silver foil straight into Ludwig's eyes.

Giving them back out of patriotic theater meant gambling a nine-year-old boy's cortex for her own pride; saying *thank you* to an *Oberstleutnant* of the occupying Wehrmacht choked in her throat like ground glass.

Ludwig didn't wait for her to say a word—already picking up his tattered Leipzig Thucydides one-handed and propping it back open against his bandaged sling as if the foil squares had fallen out of the ceiling plaster by themselves.

"Good night, *Kotarska*," he said to the Greek page without looking up. "Tell your Docent his cherry alcohol smells all the way down the radiator pipe when he hides in the dispensary."

Sylwia swept the three silver *Dextropur* packets silently into her smock pocket alongside her scissors, picked up the soiled kidney basin, blew out the extra washstand candle, and walked out into the corridor with her jaw locked so hard her back teeth ached.

Chapter VII

One-Handed Razor

Warsaw, 19–26 March 1943

On the morning of St. Joseph's Day Sylwia pushed Room Fourteen's door open six minutes before seven without knocking, expecting to catch Mekelburg brewing illegal spirit-tea on the radiator, and stopped two paces inside the threshold.

The bed was empty and stripped neatly back to air the mattress ticking.

Over by the tall frosted window, standing barefoot on the cold scrubbed pine boards in grey Wehrmacht officer's riding-breeches with his grey elastic braces hanging unlooped down either thigh, Ludwig was shaving his own throat right-handed in a six-inch square of tarnished mirror hung from the window latch.

Mekelburg wasn't even in the room—gone down to the kitchen pump with the slop pail. Without calico turns binding his left arm across his ribs—because the bastard had taken scissors to her Velpeau sling himself sometime after dawn, leaving the cut linen heap folded tidily atop the washstand—his left forearm hung free at forty degrees flexion, fingers pale and slightly puffy from five weeks' immobilization, flexing slowly open and closed, open and closed in stubborn isometric counts while his right hand drew five inches of hollow-ground Solingen steel upward from Adam's apple to jaw-point with long, whistling scrapes through cold lye-soap lather.

Seen upright for the first time since lying stretched out bloody on canvas poles, he took far too much air out of the narrow white room. Six feet one even barefoot, waist lean inside high-cut wool breeches left unfastened at the top button so a flat line of dark blond hair disappeared down below his navel, back muscles shifting taut and asymmetrical across

his shoulder blades every time he raised his right elbow: clean smooth rhomboid and latissimus on the right, angry puckered purple-red star pulling inward beneath a palm-sized square of adhesive gauze on the left.

In the six-inch mirror glass his winter-green eyes met hers without breaking the upward glide of the razor across his carotid pulse.

"Close the door, *Kotarska*," he said calmly around a corner of soap lather. "Draft freezes the soap before the blade gets there."

Sylwia kicked the oak door shut behind her heel and walked straight across the floorboards in cold fury, grabbing the cut calico heap off the washstand. "Who gave you permission to cut off a Velpeau immobilization sling before week six?"

"Immobilize a resected clavicle and traumatized brachial plexus past day thirty-eight," Ludwig said, rinsing lather and dark gold stubble off the Solingen blade in a tin mug of lukewarm water before wiping his chin dry on a rough hand-towel, "and fibrous adhesions glue the subdeltoid bursa solid to the coracoid process for life. Von Halden mobilized dog shoulders on day twenty-one; Lexer mobilized cavalrymen on day twenty-eight. Sit on your hands six weeks for Stabsarzt Vesper's textbook and you leave Lindleya with a frozen wing that won't reach a tunic pocket."

He turned round to face her fully, folding the straight razor shut into its black horn scales one-handed against his thigh.

Even furious, her surgeon's eye involuntarily registered the truth of it: standing upright, his left shoulder girdle sagged seven millimeters lower and slightly forward where the missing two centimeters of middle collarbone let pectoralis pull the acromion inward, yet his wrist drop wasn't there, his interossei hadn't wasted into claw-hollows between the knuckles, and blood flow down the arm was warm pink rather than cyanotic violet.

"Sit on the stool," she snapped, pointing at Mekelburg's wooden chair. "Before you faint onto cold pine and split your skull open for an encore."

"My hemoglobin was sixty-eight percent Sahli on Tuesday's ear-prick," he said mildly, sitting down anyway because standing twenty minutes *had* put a fine bead of sweat at his temple hairline, though he would cheerfully have chewed glass before admitting dizziness to her. "And your Jewish girl downstairs counts red cells cleaner than Vesper's orderlies."

Sylwia's fingers did not pause or twitch by half a millimeter as she peeled back the square of adhesive gauze over his left infraclavicular hollow. Zero change in breath, zero glance toward the floor, zero defensive denial—because denying a phrase tossed like a lead sinker into dark water only told the fisherman how deep the bottom sat.

"Panna Kwiatkowska's father kept the parish apothecary opposite the collegiate church in Łowicz for thirty years," Sylwia said in flat, bored German, dabbing warm boric solution around the contracting granulation rim with cotton forceps. "If she looks dark to northern eyes, blame Masovian Tatars—or buy thicker spectacles, *Herr Oberstleutnant.* Lift your left elbow forward ten degrees. Stop the instant you feel traction behind the collarbone."

Ludwig watched her face from eight inches below while obeying—lifting the pale left humerus five degrees, eight, twelve, until a sharp cord of scar-fascia pulled taut directly across the deep pectoral bridge over her vascular repair and his jaw tightened once.

Up close in clear March daylight, the wound had shrunk from a palm-wide crater down to an oval shallow trough no wider than two thumbs laid side by side: clean firm crimson granulations flush with surrounding skin, pearly blue-white epithelial islands already creeping inward three millimeters from every margin like thin ice forming round a pond. No rubber Carrel tubes remained; nothing drained now except scant clear amber serum.

Whether Docent Mirecki prayed for it or Marek Wolski cursed it, biology did not take bribes: inside fourteen days—by the end of the first week of April at the absolute outside—even the most shameless surgical liar in Europe wouldn't be able to tell Stabsarzt Vesper this man risked arterial blowout in a staff car.

"Don't worry about Panna Kwiatkowska's baptismal font on my account," Ludwig murmured directly beneath Sylwia's chin as she laid a thin Vaseline-gauze square over the pink epithelial rim so dry cotton wouldn't rip newborn skin cells off tomorrow. "Any bacteriologist who keeps eight thousand typhus lice alive under my floorboards keeps SS inspection clerks out of this wing better than barbed wire. Just tell her—if you happen to pass her on the stairs—that cheap Silesian peroxide turns hair brass-orange at the tips when steamed over agar pots, whereas chamomile decoction keeps ash-brown plausible."

Sylwia pressed two strips of zinc-oxide adhesive plaster down hard across his bare clavicle skin—harder than strictly necessary—before looking straight down into his cool, unblinking eyes.

"Why aren't you cutting chests on Luisenstraße, Ludwig?"

The question came out starker than she had meant to ask it—stripped suddenly of titles, war-rank, and fencing masks, dropped straight into the pale morning light between washbasin and unmade bed while her raw fingers still rested half an inch from the purple star her own knife had carved into his chest.

For three seconds he looked up at her without answering. A shaft of watery March sun broke briefly between courtyard clouds, striking through frosted glass across the sharp crescent scar beneath his right cheekbone and turning his grey-green eyes transparent as bottle glass.

"Because by May nineteen-thirty-three," Ludwig said quietly, "Geheimrat von Halden was opening faculty meetings with his right arm stuck out at forty-five degrees so thirty-year-old Dozenten in SA riding boots wouldn't audit his wife's grandmother from Frankfurt, and Kleist—remember fat Kleist from Table Seven who couldn't find the thoracic duct in a horse?—was appointed provisional leader of the National Socialist Lecturers' League for Anatomical Sciences."

Sylwia stared down at him. "So to escape brownshirts in lecture halls you put on a soldier's coat for the same regime?"

A cold, humorless edge cut across his mouth. "In nineteen-thirty-three the hundred-thousand-man Reichswehr still shot brownshirts who tried climbing barracks fences—until thirty-four taught generals how cheaply honor buys paint. And when Margarethe von Dewitz-Schoeler's lawyers informed me that spring that my late father's naval pension died with my university enrollment unless I signed her chemical-trust proxy papers, an army medical-reserve transfer into Bendlerstraße paid rent without kissing Kleist's boots." His gaze rose steady and pitiless to hers. "Once you're inside the machine, *Kotarska*, nobody asks at the door whether you climbed in to steer or merely to stay out of the mud. One day you wake up in Minsk or Warsaw wiping blood off oilcloth, and every exit door behind you bricked up five years ago."

No plea for sympathy softened a syllable of it—not *I hated it*, not *I was trapped*, not *forgive my uniform*, none of the rotten green-*Kennkarte* whining Stefan Bielski served with goose-neck turnip soup on Filtrowa.

Just cold iron fact laid bare on scrubbed pine: *this is what I am now, and here we stand.*

Out in the corridor heavy boots clumped past the sentry bench—Mekelburg coming back from the kitchen carrying two steaming tin buckets.

Sylwia stepped back half a pace from the wooden chair before the latch clicked, tossing him a clean hospital linen shirt off the foot rail so he wouldn't sit half-naked when Bronka brought morning gruel.

"Put your arm back in a light triangular neck-sling past noon," she said briskly, voice all starch and cold water again. "Fifteen minutes passive pendulum swings morning and evening—zero weight-bearing, zero chin-ups on doorframes, or you'll pull clavicle callus crooked and press bone callus straight down onto your brachial plexus."

Ludwig caught the linen shirt right-handed in mid-air, burying one corner against his chest as he slid his stiff left arm cautiously down the sleeve without asking help.

"And you?" he asked casually as his head emerged through the collar slit, hair rumpled gold-ash across his forehead. "Nobody waiting in Poznań with a brass nameplate and four fat children after ten years?"

"Warsaw had plenty of shrapnel without importing husbands from Poznań," Sylwia said at the door, hand on the brass knob. "Button your cuff before Bronka comes in—she dislikes bony Prussians before breakfast."

* * *

Four days later, at noon on Tuesday the twenty-third of March, rain fell cold and vertical through the roofless brick shell behind the bombed Warsaw Philharmonic on ulica Jasna, dripping off twisted iron balcony girders into weeds browned by last autumn's frost.

Marek did not take off his wet hat, and he did not step close between the broken marble columns where prewar concertgoers used to smoke during Chopin intermissions. Even from six paces Sylwia saw the pinched grey line round his nostrils that meant an operation had gone sideways.

"What happened on Chłodna on the tenth?" she asked before he spoke.

"Nothing happened from Saski Square," Marek said flatly. "My two girls stood in the sour-rye queue opposite Number Twenty-Two from six-forty-five in the morning with a Leica hidden inside a hollowed cabbage loaf. At seven-ten—twenty minutes after shutter-opening—a dark-grey Adler Trumpf sedan with civilian Warsaw plates that match Aleja Szucha's motor-pool parked thirty meters west by Waliców corner. Two men in loden coats sat inside smoking until six p.m. Neither Kaminski's Łódź optician nor a single courier from *Abwehrstelle* came within two blocks all day."

Cold rain trickled off Sylwia's umbrella rim onto her shoe-cap.

Think fast, clean, without panic. On February twenty-eighth at two-fifteen a.m., burning at forty degrees point four, Ludwig had gasped: *Chłodna twenty-two—not to the optician before the tenth—if Kroll has the clock-hand, the whole net burns as far as Spiska.* On March eighth at four p.m., behind stacked stove grates off Krochmalna, Sylwia had given *Chłodna twenty-two* and *the tenth of March* to Marek Wolski—nobody else on God's earth—and thirty-nine hours later Reinhart Kroll's Gestapo surveillance car sat parked at Waliców waiting for someone to walk into the optician's shop!

Two possibilities existed in physical space, and both turned her blood to ice water.

Possibility One: Kroll *already* owned the optician's address from whatever courier died at the Ochota water-tower on February ninth—which meant Ludwig's delirium fear (*wenn Kroll den Uhrzeiger hat*) had already come true weeks ago, and Abwehr had abandoned the drop independently.

Possibility Two: someone sitting inside Warsaw District *Kontrwywiad*—either above Marek, beside Marek, or *Marek himself*—had read Marek's Tuesday evening report on *Chłodna 22* and passed it across town to Aleja Szucha before Wednesday dawn!

And thank Christ—thank ten years of Berlin paranoia carved into her bones—she had kept *der Uhrzeiger* and *Spiska* locked behind her own teeth on Krochmalna!

Now Marek was staring straight across wet brick rubble at her with the exact mirror-image suspicion hardening his narrow grey eyes.

"You told me Schoeler muttered that address in forty-degree delirium," Marek said quietly.

"Forty point four, before pus drainage," Sylwia said without moving an eyelash. "With his corporal snoring six feet away."

"Are you certain he was delirious, Sylwia?" Marek stepped two paces closer over broken plaster, voice dropping dry and lethal. "An *Abwehr* counter-espionage chief lies in your pavilion three weeks, recognizes an old Berlin rival walking round Polish wards, pretends forty-degree babble, and drops a burned address straight into your lap to see whether Polish underground watchers turn up opposite Number Twenty-Two inside forty-eight hours—while tipping Szucha himself, or watching Szucha's existing stakeout catch our girls with a camera in a bread loaf!"

"My girls weren't caught?" she asked sharply.

"No, because Anka spotted the Adler's tire tracks from Pawiak vans inside five minutes and bought two kilos of turnips instead of clicking a shutter." Marek's jaw worked once under wet skin. "Upstairs wants to know every single word Schoeler has spoken to you since nine February—Berlin, Warsaw, Latin, or Greek. And the day Vesper removes the military police guard from your corridor or signs his transfer paper back to Saski Square, *Kontrwywiad*'s liquidation squad takes his car at the corner of Koszykowa and Chałubińskiego."

Wind gusted rain sideways through a blown-out arched window overhead, spattering dark drops across Sylwia's wool sleeve. Sixty meters south of Lindleya gate—shoot up a Wehrmacht *Oberstleutnant*'s staff car thirty seconds after Pavilion Three discharged him, and before the brass shell casings stopped rolling in the gutter, Reinhart Kroll would line Docent Mirecki, Bronka, Walenty, Halina, and thirty random hostages from Ward B up against Pavilion Three's courtyard brick and machine-gun every last one of them!

"Shoot him inside five blocks of Lindleya," Sylwia said, voice so cold and level Marek stopped breathing mid-sentence, "and you murder seventy Polish patients, three underground surgeons, and Warsaw's clandestine typhus vaccine cellar in ten minutes flat. Tell *Upstairs* if they want dead Germans, shoot them on Królewska or Aleje Ujazdowskie—not across my hospital gate."

"Since when do surgeons draw street maps for execution squads?" Marek asked softly.

"Since engineers started parking bread-loaf cameras outside burned addresses and blaming thermometers when Aleja Szucha beats them to

the kerb," she snapped back, turning on her heel before he could reach for her elbow. "Don't come to Koszykowa this week, Marek. Vesper's inspecting surgical stock inventories Thursday and Friday, and my stairs aren't clean."

* * *

On Friday afternoon the twenty-sixth of March, spring wind blew sudden warm dust up Marszałkowska for three hours, drying pavement puddles white with winter road-salt before gunshots tore the five o'clock sky open north toward the Old Town edge.

At Lindleya, three kilometers southwest of the Arsenal arch at Długa and Bielańska, nobody heard the first Sten bursts or grenade concussions directly—city tram rumbling drowned anything lighter than artillery past Saski Garden. What Pavilion Three heard at five-forty-eight was every *Polizei* klaxon, SS riot-truck horn, and street corner *szczekaczka* megaphone across downtown Warsaw erupting inside the same ninety seconds like kicked hornets.

Sylwia was in Theater Two closing the peritoneum on a fifty-year-old seamstress's perforated duodenal ulcer when Bronka pushed her masked head round the scrub-room doorframe, eyes hard as black buttons above white gauze.

"Big shootout up by Nalewki or Bielańska ten minutes ago," Bronka muttered low in Polish while Mirecki tied skin sutures beside Sylwia. "Bread boy who just slipped in the kitchen alley says boys with grenades blew open the big grey prison truck coming from Aleja Szucha to Pawiak—killed four or five Gestapo guards in the street and carried twenty prisoners off in lorries! Half the city north of Senatorska's crawling with armoured cars already, and checkpoints are dropping barriers across Marszałkowska!"

Mirecki's needle-holder clicked sharply against the toothed tissue forceps in his hand; one grey drop of sweat rolled straight off his eyebrow onto his gauze mask. Everybody in Warsaw knew what happened within twelve hours when four Gestapo men died on open asphalt: Pawiak cellars emptied into execution trucks, hospitals raided bed by bed from Wola to Praga for fresh bullet wounds, any unregistered bandage under fifty years old dragged out onto stretchers with bayonets.

"Finish the skin clips, panie docencie," Sylwia said without raising her voice, stripping blood-streaked rubber gloves off inside-out into the talc basin—one of the two precious pairs saved for open bellies—and listening to boots running already outside the east-wing guard post downstairs as *Abwehr* telephone bells shrilled behind the sentry desk. "If German patrols seal Chałubińskiego before seven, any boy hit near Bielańska who drove south before the cordons closed has nowhere left to go except Lindleya or private flats."

She was barely down the back service stairs to check the courtyard coal-alley gate when dusk thickened into indigo sleet-clouds and two dull iron taps—*two, pause, three*—sounded against the zinc-lined mortuary cart-door facing Nowogrodzka back lane, forty yards away from the main Lindleya gatehouse where Wehrmacht MPs smoked.

Not Walenty's knock. *Kedyw* medical emergency code, unused since November's railway sabotage arrests.

Sylwia didn't call Mirecki—Mirecki's grey lips would drop dead of coronary spasm on the spot—motioning only to Bronka heaving laundry sacks by the boiler chute. Together they slid the rusted mortuary bolt back three inches into darkness smelling of wet coke and panic.

Backed tight against the brick arch with headlights blacked out sat a municipal street-sweeping horse wagon heaped high with stinking gutter-sweepings and wet straw. Down under the straw, held quiet by a white-faced girl courier no older than nineteen whose camel coat was soaked black from waist to hem with somebody else's arterial and venous blood, lay two boys in mud-caked civilian windbreakers.

"Wola safe-flat's cut off by gendarmes on Towarowa," the girl gasped, teeth chattering so hard she bit her own tongue bloody. "Świętego Ducha's surrounded already—we came down Emilii Plater five minutes ahead of the motorcycles. One's femoral—tourniquet on since five-forty—the little one took a machine-pistol round low right ribs coming over a wall on Długa—"

"Don't bring them up the main ramp—there are two Wehrmacht MPs forty paces left behind the glass swing doors!" Sylwia hissed, climbing straight onto the wagon hub to shove two fingers inside the collar of the smaller boy under the wet straw.

Barely eighteen—freckled nose, soft chestnut hair matted with street filth, breathing shallow bubbling red foam at forty breaths a minute,

right lower hemithorax dull to percussion and abdomen board-hard underneath: right costophrenic angle through-and-through, nicking lung edge and tearing liver dome! Leave him in a horse wagon thirty minutes more and he died in straw; carry him upstairs to Polish Ward B and the first midnight Gestapo bed-check murdered the entire hospital.

"Plaster cellar under Theater Two," Sylwia decided in three heartbeats, grabbing the boy's wet armpits herself while Bronka—built like an ox from Wola butcher's hooks—hoisted both his mud-caked boots together under one massive forearm. "Coal-chute steps! Girl—leave the second boy under straw ninety seconds till we clear the steps, then drive your horse straight out Koszykowa gate as if you dropped slops and burn that coat before eight!"

Down six narrow brick steps behind the anatomical ash-bins they dragged first the chest-shot freckled boy ("Leszek" painted on a torn cardboard tag inside his pocket? no, zero papers at all, pockets turned cleanly empty per Kedyw combat standing orders, just a lead St. Christopher medal on dirty string round his throat) and ninety seconds later the older boy ("Sowa," twenty-two, teeth locked over a knotted handkerchief, lucky clean through-and-through lateral thigh track missing the femoral artery by a finger's breadth).

The plaster-of-Paris storage cellar beneath Theater Two had no windows at all—twelve feet by nine, stacked ceiling-high with paper drums of gypsum powder, Thomas splints, and rusty Balkan traction frames, forty horizontal feet down the brick foundation corridor from Halina's locked typhus lab and directly *underneath* the floorboards of the ground-floor German annex! Overhead, muffled through twelve inches of oak joist and slag-fill, Sylwia could actually hear heavy German jackboots pacing briskly back and forth outside Room Fourteen as alarm dispatches crackled in from Saski Square.

For two hours by one hooded electric trouble-lamp hung low inside a zinc bucket so not a splinter of yellow light leaked under the iron door, Sylwia and Bronka worked on their knees across two trestle-planks laid over gypsum drums.

Sowa took ten minutes: release tourniquet, verify intact femoral pulse, irrigate track with rivanol, pack open, splint knee straight, gag him gently with dry gauze and twenty milligrams of morphine so he couldn't groan through ceiling joists.

Leszek took ninety minutes of quiet hell under trickled local procaine along the ninth rib bed and light open-drop chloroform dripped by Bronka ten drops at a time onto folded gauze while Sylwia resected four centimeters of ninth costal cartilage, evacuated six hundred milliliters of dark liquid liver-blood out of the subphrenic space with soup ladles boiled in the sterilizer upstairs, packed a thick Viuchnevsky bolster of hemostatic catgut and oxidized gauze tight into the bleeding four-centimeter stellate rent on the dome of his right hepatic lobe—liver parenchyme tore like wet cheese if you pulled silk unbolstered—closed the diaphragm defect so blood wouldn't drown his right lung, and brought a rubber Pezzer drain out between his ribs into a water-seal pickle jar on the floor.

By nine-thirty the boy was breathing twenty-six times a minute instead of forty, pulse weak at one-eighteen but holding, pale freckled cheek resting cold against rough canvas while half a liter of Type O universal blood—drawn ten minutes earlier straight out of Bronka's own left median cubital vein into sodium-citrate bottle without cross-match fuss because Bronka bled like a prize heifer twice a month for dying kids and ate horse-liver afterward to make it back—dripped dark crimson down rubber tubing into his ankle saphenous cut-down.

Sylwia knelt back on her heels on the gypsum-dusted bricks, wiping sweat off her forehead with a blood-stiffened forearm. Every muscle across her lower spine burned; she hadn't eaten since breakfast gruel at seven.

Upstairs, two floors seemed suddenly to vibrate at once as heavy motor engines—not one ambulance, three or four heavy six-wheeled lorries—growled to a halt along both Lindleya and Nowogrodzka curbstones outside.

Above their heads in the ground-floor vestibule, iron-shod boots slammed across tiles—ten, twelve pairs—followed not by Stabsarzt Vesper's bluster, by a polite, quiet Saxon voice Sylwia knew in her marrow even muffled through mortar.

Bronka froze with her thumb still pressed over the citrate cotton wad in her own elbow crease, gold eyetooth glinting dull in the bucket-shaded light.

"Matko Przenajświętsza," the matron breathed without sound. "White gloves. And dogs."

Chapter VIII

Through the Tile Wall

Warsaw, 26–27 March 1943

Dogs changed the physics of a building.

You could forge an X-ray plate so neatly that three German military surgeons swore a bullet track in a boy's femur was childhood osteomyelitis; you could paste red *Typhus exanthematicus* warning strips across ward doors and watch SS clerks back hastily down the steps holding cologne-soaked handkerchiefs to their noses. An Alsatian trained at Oranienburg or Trawniki could not read Latin, did not fear lice, and smelled three hundred milliliters of spilled fresh human blood diluted under carbolic soap from forty yards downwind.

In the gypsum cellar beneath Theater Two, Sylwia blew out the shaded bucket-lamp? No—electric bulb, she unscrewed it half a turn in its brass socket with dry fingers until darkness dropped total, smelling hot tungsten cool in dusty air while overhead ten pairs of nailed boots divided left and right across the ground-floor vestibule.

"Upstairs first," Bronka breathed against Sylwia's ear, so close her warm breath smelled of raw citrate blood and roasted barley. "Always top floor down so nobody climbs onto roofs. Ten minutes—maybe twelve before they bring the dogs down the boiler chute."

Sylwia's mind moved through the brick floor-plan of Pavilion Three like steel probes through a familiar joint.

Two boys lying on planks in the dark at her knees. Sowa—twenty-two, conscious, femoral flesh track packed tight with rivanol, zero chest injury—could breathe sulfur dioxide and cresol vapor for half an hour without suffocating if Halina burned two sulfur disinfection candles in the typhus-delousing anteroom thirty feet down the foundation tunnel; burning sulfur seared nasal mucosa in dogs flat blind inside two sniffs so

handlers yanked their leashes back rather than ruin expensive tracking noses.

Put eighteen-year-old Leszek—resected ninth rib, fresh diaphragmatic suture, bruised right lower lung lobe draining pink air-bubbles into a pickle-jar water seal—inside a sulfur-filled delousing box for five minutes, and bronchospasm tore his diaphragm stitches open and drowned him in his own blood before midnight.

Where in Pavilion Three couldn't Kroll's dogs poke their muzzles without tearing through Wehrmacht counter-intelligence tape?

Only one corridor on three floors: the six-room ground-floor east annex behind the stenciled *Reserviert — Wehrmacht-Notdienst* swing doors, where two armed military policemen from Saski Square answered to *Abwehrstelle Warschau* rather than Aleja Szucha.

And directly behind the head wall of Room Fourteen—accessible *not* from the guarded front corridor, accessible from the tiny narrow iron spiral dumbwaiter-and-linen stair rising out of the cellar wash-house because in nineteen-oh-two the Russian municipal architect had built shared plumbing stacks between pairs of private rooms—sat the locked, disused hydrotherapy sluice-closet of Room Thirteen, its hall door bolted from *inside* and blocked on the corridor side by stacked spare horsehair mattresses since forty-one!

Between that six-foot tiled closet and Ludwig Schoeler's iron headboard stood four inches of hollow glazed brick and one rusted brass Louvered air-grille six inches square, eight feet above the floor.

If Leszek made one loud groan while awake—Ludwig heard him.

Leave Leszek down here in the gypsum dust—Kroll's dogs tore his throat out in twelve minutes and hung Sylwia, Bronka, Mirecki, and Halina from balcony railings before dawn.

"Take Sowa down the tunnel to Halina right now," Sylwia whispered into the dark, already clamping Leszek's rubber chest-tube double with heavy Pean forceps so air couldn't suck backward into his pleura when she disconnected the pickle-jar seal. "Tell Halina light two sulfur pots in the outer louse-vestibule—stink the whole cellar ramp yellow so no handler brings an Alsatian past the boiler arch! Then meet me at the bottom of the dumbwaiter spiral in ninety seconds."

"Pani doktor—behind Fourteen's wall—"

"Move!"

Ninety seconds later two women—one forty-six and built like a slaughterhouse dray, one thirty-three and fueled by cold terror sharper than amphetamine—carried sixty-two kilos of limp, chloroform-drowsy eighteen-year-old boy vertical up fourteen narrow cast-iron spiral steps inside a pitch-black plumbing shaft no wider than a coffin stood on end.

Halfway up the spiral, through the cast-iron wall plate six inches from her scraped knuckles, Sylwia heard Kroll's polite Dresden voice out in the main ground-floor lobby instructing Docent Mirecki to unlock Operating Theaters One and Two and produce every surgical dressing book since noon! Down on the ground floor already—he had split his squad, half sweeping top wards downward while Kroll himself went straight for the operating theaters and basements!

At the top landing of the spiral shaft, Bronka slipped a greased skeleton key into the rear iron service latch of Room Thirteen's old sluice-closet. Hinges greased last month by Bronka for hiding black-market lard tubs swung inward without a squeak.

Pitch dark inside; smelled of dry drain-traps, old porcelain, and cold mortar. Barely five feet between the cracked sitz-bath tub and the glazed white brick partition wall—through whose upper brass air-grille filtered a faint rectangle of pale yellow electric light and the slow, regular scratch of a steel pen nib writing in the next room!

Ludwig was awake three feet away on the other side of four inches of brick.

Moving in dead silence, boots wrapped in burlap rags left over from lard sacks, Sylwia and Bronka eased young Leszek down onto two folded winter blankets inside the dry porcelain sitz-bath itself, propping his torso at thirty degrees so liver ooze pooled low rather than pressing his sewn diaphragm, and slipped the lower end of his unclamped intercostal rubber tube back under two inches of sterile boric water inside a flat glass urinal bottle wedged between his knees so not a bubble clicked loud.

Sylwia pressed two fingers against the boy's carotid in the pitch dark. Pulse one-twenty-four; shallow chloroform sleep wearing thin already. Dare she give him ten milligrams of morphine to keep him quiet? Give morphine on top of chloroform and half a liter of lost blood with one bruised lung, and respiratory depression killed him silently in the dark; give nothing, and when pleural raw nerve endings woke in ten minutes he coughed!

She drew five milligrams only—half an adult ampoule, judged pure by thumb-notch on the plunger barrel in blackness—slid the needle subcutaneously into his deltoid, laid four folded layers of dry surgical gauze loosely across his mouth and nose to muffle breath-whistle without starving him of air, and backed out down the spiral iron steps two seconds before heavy boots kicked open the cellar fire-door at the far end of the boiler passage.

By the time Sylwia stepped calmly through the ground-floor dispensary swinging doors buttoning a clean white coat over her wool dress, bare-eyed, blinking innocently at the corridor glare with Mirecki's narcotics ledger tucked open under her elbow—the basement below had erupted into furious canine barking cut abruptly short by violent coughing as sulfur dioxide rolled thick and yellow out of Halina's delousing vestibule up the boiler chute!

"Impossible down there without gas masks, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*!" an SD *Oberscharführer* reported up the cellar stairhead, eyes streaming red tears, holding a snarling, sneezing grey Alsatian back on short leather choke-chain. "The typhus woman's fumigating louse-coats with burning sulfur—dog won't put his nose within ten meters of the ramp, and there's nothing in the coal-bins or plaster room except gypsum barrels!"

Wait: *nothing in the plaster room except gypsum barrels*—Bronka had kicked clean gypsum dust across three dark drops of floor blood on her way out with Sowa thirty seconds ahead of the boots!

In the center of the tiled vestibule stood Reinhart Kroll, immaculate greatcoat unbuttoned over grey SS wool, peaked cap still square on sandy hair, white cotton left index finger stroking *scritch-scritch* across his right wrist cuff while Docent Mirecki trembled beside him holding three ward registers.

Kroll's pale, lashless eyes lifted slowly from the weeping dog handler to Sylwia emerging from the dispensary.

"Good evening again, Frau Doktor Kotarska," Kroll said pleasantly. "You work late on Fridays."

"Perforated duodenal ulcer in Theater Two at five-thirty, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*," Sylwia answered evenly, opening the Theater Two register under his nose where the fifty-year-old seamstress's name, address on Wspólna, and excised callous ulcer specimen—still floating dutifully in a formalin jar on the theatre shelf if he cared to smell stomach acid—stood

entered in Mirecki's purple pencil. "She is upstairs in Female Post-Operative Bed Four under gastric suction if your surgeon wishes to examine abdominal stitches."

Kroll barely glanced at the purple ink. His nose wrinkled slightly at the acrid tang of sulfur drifting up from the basement stairs; then his gaze turned ninety degrees eastward down the ground-floor hall toward the closed swing-doors stenciled *Reserviert — Wehrmacht-Notdienst*, where the grizzled Pomeranian *Abwehr* military-police sergeant stood planted square across the middle of the passage with his thumb hooked over his MP40 sling.

"Every Polish bed upstairs accounted for against pre-curfew municipal *Kennkarte* stubs," Kroll murmured thoughtfully, as if conversing with himself in a law library. "Cellars full of typhus lice and sulfur smoke. Which leaves six ground-floor rooms behind those doors—five of them nominally unoccupied since ten February."

Mirecki swallowed audibly. "Under exclusive Wehrmacht counter-intelligence seal, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*, as *Hauptmann* von Berg's order on the door frame specifies—"

"Naturally I would not dream of disturbing *Abwehrstelle* papers," Kroll said with silk courtesy, already walking down the hall toward the swing-doors so Sylwia and Mirecki had no choice on earth except to walk behind him while two SD men and one dog handler—leaving the sulfur-blinded Alsatian tied to the vestibule radiator—followed at his heels. "However, four bandits escaped near Bielańska this evening bleeding heavily from machine-pistol fire after murdering German officers. Empty hospital rooms have windows facing Nowogrodzka courtyard, *Herr Feldwebel*, and municipal orderlies hold master keys. Unlock Rooms Ten through Sixteen for visual inspection."

The Pomeranian MP sergeant didn't budge an inch, jaw set like salted beef. "Rooms Ten, Eleven, Twelve, Fifteen, and Sixteen you may view from thresholds under my escort, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*. Room Thirteen is nailed shut for plumbing rot behind stacked mattresses, and Room Fourteen houses *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler under medical orders."

"I know whom Room Fourteen houses," Kroll said softly. "Let us look at the empty ones first."

Ten: bare iron bedframe, rolled mattress, cold radiator, window painted black and latched from inside with unbroken cobwebs in the corner.

Eleven: identical.

Twelve: stacked broken traction splints and six crates of empty mineral-water bottles.

Outside Room Thirteen, four dusty horsehair mattresses leaned stacked ceiling-high against the Bolted pine doorframe. One of Kroll's young SD *Rottenführer* shoved two mattresses aside with his boot and rattled the brass handle—solidly bolted from the *sluice-closet side* or painted shut since forty-one, dust flaking down off the transom in grey snow onto his sleeve.

"Behind Thirteen sits an old bath-closet backing onto Fourteen's plumbing stack," Kroll observed quietly—*he had read the municipal architectural blueprint at City Hall before driving here!* Sylwia's stomach turned cold without showing a ripple in her face as she stood two paces behind his grey shoulder. "Where does that plumbing stack open?"

"Service spiral down to the laundry cellar, locked since the pipes burst in the forty winter," Mirecki lied bravely, voice squeaking only slightly on *forty*, "and vented only into Room Fourteen's upper air shaft."

Kroll turned three paces right and knocked twice—*tap, tap*, white cotton knuckles polite against painted pine—on the door of Room Fourteen before pushing it inward without waiting for Mekelburg's bolt.

Mekelburg hadn't bolted it; the boy stood six feet inside the room with his good right hand hanging dangerously close to his holstered pistol flap until Ludwig, sitting half-propped in his hospital linen shirt with Thucydides lying closed on the blanket, raised two quiet fingers to still him.

"Forgive the late intrusion, *Herr Oberstleutnant*," Kroll said, stepping well inside the room until he stood four paces from the iron bed—and less than *seven feet* from the glazed white partition wall behind Ludwig's headboard, where eight feet up near the ceiling molding the rusted six-inch brass air-grille showed black square holes opening straight down into the pitch-dark porcelain tub where an eighteen-year-old boy with a sewn liver and bruised lung lay breathing through four layers of dry gauze!

Sylwia stepped inside the doorway to Kroll's left, forcing herself to look bored and mildly affronted rather than staring upward at that lethal six-inch square of rusted brass.

In the dead hush as Kroll paused to take in the sparse room—washstand, closed cupboard, chair, narrow bed—a faint, unmistakable sound came out of the upper plumbing wall.

Not loud. Just a wet, bubbling intake—*hrrk*—as five milligrams of light morphine failed to suppress pleural irritation from the intercostal rubber tube rubbing parietal pleura, and behind four inches of hollow brick a half-conscious boy drew breath to cough!

Kroll's sandy head tilted three degrees toward the headboard wall. His left cotton fingertip stopped scratching his wrist.

"Rats in your ventilation shaft, *Herr Oberstleutnant*?" Kroll murmured, taking one slow, deliberate step past the foot rail toward the head of the bed—three yards from the grille, ears cocked sharp as a terrier's in dead quiet—just as a second, deeper, unmistakable human rattle gathered behind the rusted brass louvers!

In the tarnished six-inch shaving mirror still hanging from the window latch across the room, Ludwig's winter-green eyes met Sylwia's for one tenth of a second.

She hadn't moved a lash, hadn't looked up at the grille—yet he had heard that wet pleural *hrrk* two seconds before Kroll walked in (any thoracic surgeon knew human bronchial blood-rattle from rats in half a note!), had heard muffled movement behind his headboard twenty minutes earlier when sulfur smoke hit the basement, and saw in one flash of dark glass across Room Fourteen that if Kroll stepped two paces closer when that boy coughed aloud, Sylwia Kotarska swung from a meat-hook by Sunday noon.

Ludwig didn't argue law with Kroll, and he didn't pretend to cough politely into a handkerchief.

With cold, shocking physical violence that made Sylwia's breath catch for real in her throat, Ludwig braced his bare left elbow hard against the iron vertical bar behind his pillow and *wrenched* his healing left shoulder girdle backward and upward at full leverage—tearing five weeks of fresh, vascularized red granulation tissue and newborn marginal epithelium straight apart across his resected collarbone gap in a single silent rip—

while biting down savagely onto the inside of his own left cheek until bright arterial mouth-blood flooded across his tongue!

Simultaneously he doubled forward off the bolsters in a violent, strangled paroxysm of racking coughs loud enough to drown five men choking in a closet—hacking bright red blood mixed with saliva straight across the white hospital sheet and spattering three scarlet drops squarely onto the polished black toe-caps of Reinhart Kroll's jackboots while bright dark-red venous and capillary blood soaked rapidly outward in a spreading crimson palm-print across the left breast of his white linen shirt!

"Mekelburg—basin!" Ludwig choked out raw between genuine pain-spasms—nobody tore five centimeters of living chest granulation apart raw without going chalk-white to the lips and sweating ice inside two seconds!—slamming his blood-flecked right fist onto the mattress edge as Kroll stepped hurriedly *backward* two paces to save his immaculate grey trouser cuffs from infectious hospital blood.

Sylwia moved faster than thought, shoving straight past Kroll's white-gloved elbow to drop both hands onto Ludwig's heaving shoulders while shouting in furious, ringing Berlin German loud enough to cover anything short of cannon-fire behind the tiles:

"Out! Clear the room this second! *Bronka*—sterile tamponade packs and hemostatic clamps on the double! Didn't you read Stabsarzt Vesper's vascular hemorrhage warning on the door, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*?! Ten men tramping dust and sulfur fumes up the stairs set him coughing into a secondary granulation bleed over an open subclavian repair—get your troopers out of my doorway before he aspirates or blows the main trunk!"

Behind the tile grille, whatever cough had broken loose died completely unheard beneath Ludwig's rasping, blood-spitting paroxysm, Mekelburg's overturned wooden chair crashing across pine boards as the boy lunged for the enamel kidney dish, and Docent Mirecki bustling frantically forward at the door yelling in Polish down the hall for ice-bags and coagulen ampoules!

Kroll stood just outside the threshold now, looking down with fastidious Saxon distaste at the three bright red droplets drying dark across his left boot-toe while inside the room Sylwia ripped Ludwig's blood-soaked linen shirt open down the front, exposing five inches of freshly torn, furiously bleeding red chest flesh welling dark scarlet down his ribs onto the rubber sheet.

Nothing fake about *that* blood—real human granulation tissue bled like cut liver when ripped off underlying fascia, soaking two big gauze pads red through Sylwia's bare fingers in ten seconds flat!

"Unfortunate timing," Kroll said mildly from the hall, pulling a clean folded handkerchief from his skirt pocket—never using his white cotton gloves on leather—and stooping neatly to wipe his boot-cap clean before tossing the spotted square into Bronka's corridor slop-pail. "Pray convey my regrets to Stabsarzt Vesper for the disturbance to his patient, Docent Mirecki. Clearly nobody crawled through Room Fourteen's window tonight. Good recovery, *Herr Oberstleutnant*."

Ludwig didn't answer him—head bowed over the enamel basin held by Mekelburg, spitting one last mouthful of pink-streaked spit from his bitten inner cheek into the tin, breathing ragged and genuine through clenched teeth while sweat shone wet down his white temples.

Ninety seconds later, through the frosted courtyard glass, three six-wheeled SD lorries ground into first gear along Lindleya and roared away south toward Koszykowa and Aleja Szucha.

* * *

Not until quarter past one in the morning—after Leszek had been eased back down the dark spiral plumbing shaft into Theater Two's scrubbed recovery cubby under a dead seventy-year-old peasant's pneumonia chart, and Sowa had been driven safely out to Grochów under municipal night-soil barrels—did Sylwia come back through the quiet east-wing doors alone.

Both *Abwehr* MPs sat drowsing outside on their bench; inside Room Fourteen, Mekelburg had washed the blood off the floorboards and been sent next door into unlocked Room Twelve to sleep horizontal on stacked blankets for four hours after Sylwia swore on her mother's grave nobody from Szucha came back twice in the same night.

One shaded sixty-watt bulb burned low beside the washstand.

Ludwig lay back flat on one low bolster, naked to the waist under the grey wool blanket pulled up to his hipbones, eyes closed, right forearm flung across his forehead shielding his face from the bulb glare. Beneath her temporary tight pressure pad strapped at midnight, fresh dark red serum had seeped through one corner onto his skin.

Sylwia locked the hall door softly from inside, washed her hands for three full minutes in warm sublimate until the shaking that had waited patiently behind her knees since eleven-thirty finally consented to stop, and brought the boiled dressing tray to the left rail.

When she peeled the clotted midnight pad gently away with warm saline soak so it wouldn't tear a second time, Ludwig lowered his right arm off his eyes and looked at her.

In the quiet yellow light she saw the full damage he had done himself in half a second: three weeks of slow, painstaking pink epithelial creep round the margins ripped jaggedly back to raw dermis; a deep fissure split straight across the center of the granulating bed down to pectoralis minor fascia—thank heaven two millimeters shallow of her deep arterial bridge, which still beat strong and intact underneath, though another ten pounds of backward wrench might genuinely have avulsed a side-branch and killed him on the mattress. Inside his mouth, when he parted dry lips to draw breath, the left buccal mucosa was swollen dark purple where he had bitten clean into his own cheek artery to get instant bright mouth-blood onto Kroll's boots, because torn chest wounds didn't make you cough red foam on cue!

"Open your mouth," Sylwia said quietly, voice stripped bare of every sharp edge she normally carried into this room.

He opened his jaws half an inch without sarcasm. She shone her tiny pocket diagnostic torch inside: two-centimeter ragged bite laceration opposite the upper first molar, clotted firm now, no stitch needed if he rinsed with salt water.

She clicked the torch off, took warm boric sponges, and began cleaning dried crimson crust off his left ribs, sternum, and throat hollow with slow, feather-light strokes utterly unlike her brisk daytime ward wipe.

Neither of them spoke while she dusted sterile sulfanilamide snow across the torn granulation fissure, laid double Vaseline-tulle so nothing stuck raw, and strapped a fresh thick pad gently in place—adding five days, maybe seven, to his stay under Lindleya's roof with a single wrench of his own arm.

Only when she dipped a fresh linen corner in clean warm water to wipe a dried streak of mouth-blood off the corner of his jaw—her bare knuckles grazing the crisp gold-ash stubble along his chin—did his right

hand rise quietly off the blanket and close round her forearm just below the rolled cuff of her white smock.

Warm fingers, dry now, zero fever, holding firm without crushing bone like last month's forty-point-four vise.

"How old is he?" Ludwig asked in a murmur barely louder than the radiator tick.

Sylwia didn't insult him—or cheapen what he had just ripped his own flesh open to cover—with one syllable of pretense.

"Eighteen," she whispered back in German just as low. "Right lower lung graze and torn liver dome. He'll live if pneumonia doesn't take him by Tuesday."

Ludwig's thumb moved once—barely two millimeters—against the bare inner skin of her forearm above her scarred wrist, testing the fast, hard hammer of her radial pulse through thin skin. Up close his grey-green eyes looked exhausted down to bone-ash, dark rings bruised under pale lashes, yet clear as winter stars.

"Move him out of this building before Sunday noon," he murmured. "Kroll wiped my blood off his boot with his bare pocket-handkerchief—not into the stove, into your nurse's corridor bucket, and I watched his rear man pick that handkerchief out of the pail on his way through the swing-doors."

Cold went straight through Sylwia's chest. *Blood-typing or microscopic check!* Mixed buccal squamous cells and saliva in coughed "lung" blood—any decent pathology lab at the State Institute of Hygiene or German Forensics on Oczki Street looking under a hundred-power lens saw flat mouth pavement-epithelium and zero alveolar macrophages inside five minutes, proving an *Abwehr* lieutenant-colonel had bitten his own cheek to clear a Gestapo search out of Room Fourteen!

"Wait—if Kroll puts that handkerchief under a microscope tomorrow—" Sylwia started, dropping three inches lower over the bed.

"Bronka dumped half a pint of lysol and sheep-broth slops into that bucket ten seconds before his man fished it out—I watched her through the glass panel," Ludwig said, the faintest ghost of grim respect touching the bruised corner of his mouth. "Your fat Wola matron has faster eyes than half Canaris's majors. Lysol lyses epithelial cells to mush inside twenty minutes. Kroll gets nothing provable—only certainty in his Saxon belly, which he had already."

For four seconds Sylwia stood motionless beside the bed with his warm fingers wrapped round her bare forearm and the smell of fresh blood, boric acid, and clean male skin filling every breath she drew. All her neat categories from Berlin and Warsaw—enemy, butcher, debt, ledger—lay smashed in pieces on the floor beside Mekelburg's chair. Ten days ago Marek had told her *Kontrwywiad* meant to machine-gun this man's car the morning he left Lindleya; two hours ago this man had torn his own chest raw and spat his own blood across SS leather so an eighteen-year-old boy from *Kedyw* wouldn't strangle on a Gestapo rope and Sylwia Kotarska wouldn't go down to Aleja Szucha's cellar.

"Why did you do that?" she whispered, hating how raw the words scraped out of her throat.

Ludwig looked straight up into her dark eyes—no smile at all now, grave, pitiless, ancient Berlin steel gleaming clear through ten years of ash.

"Don't go soft in the head, *Kotarska*," he said softly. "Nothing in Warsaw is free. You added a week to my granulation tonight; by the middle of April I still walk out of your hospital. And two days before I sign Vesper's discharge book, you are going to carry one small parcel ten blocks across town for me where Kroll's grey Adler cars don't watch Polish women doctors—and then our ledger from Table One and tonight sits square at zero."

Slowly she pulled her forearm backward; this time he let her skin slide cleanly out through his fingers without holding on, though the warm ring where his palm had rested burned up to her elbow all the way down the dark corridor.

At the door she paused with her hand on the light switch, looking back once across shadowed white linen at the lean outline of his unbandaged right shoulder and the pale crescent scar she had stitched in Schöneberg snow thirteen winters ago.

"Good night, Ludwig," she said—the first time she had spoken his given name awake since March nineteen-thirty-three—and clicked the room dark.

PART TWO

Granulation

April – June 1943

Chapter IX

The Dead Letter on Chłodna

Warsaw, 13–15 April 1943

At a quarter past three on Tuesday the thirteenth of April, the tin *szczekaczka* bolted twenty feet up the cast-iron tram standard at the corner of Marszałkowska and Nowogrodzka cut off a brass band mid-march with three loud static cracks and began speaking Polish in the oiled baritone of the Kraków propaganda studio.

Usually when the megaphone barked in Polish, every pedestrian within fifty yards lowered his chin into his collar and walked faster so German photographers across by the café awnings couldn't snap "attentive crowds" for Berlin newsreels. Today people stopped dead in the gritty April wind—first a grey-haired postman holding a bicycle by its rusted handlebars, then two women carrying willow baskets of sprouting potatoes, then Sylwia herself coming out of the pharmacy supply depot on Wspólna with a brown paper parcel of boric powder under her arm.

Smolensk, the tin horn rattled overhead, echoing flat off pockmarked stucco walls where winter soot ran grey streaks down from windowsills. *Pine woods at Kozie Góry—Katyń Forest. Layers of bodies stacked twelve deep in sandy pits, hands wired behind backs with braided cord, Polish eagles still stamped on uniform buttons, letters from Warsaw and Lwów and Poznań dated no later than April nineteen-forty inside rotted breast pockets, every skull pierced from behind at the occipital bone by seven-sixty-five-millimeter pistol rounds…*

Nobody in the street spoke a word. Wind whipped dry horse-dung dust round people's ankles; two red trams ground past clanging bells that sounded suddenly obscene; across the kerb a woman in a faded navy mourning coat from thirty-nine sank slowly down onto an iron cellar-

hatch with both hands clapped over her mouth, staring straight ahead at dirty puddle water.

Every Pole over twelve in Warsaw knew how to read German lies upside-down: subtract ninety percent when Berlin talked about U-boat tonnages or glorious elastic shortenings of the Eastern Front. Yet nobody standing under that tin horn subtracted a single corpse from Smolensk. For three years three thousand families in Warsaw alone had stared at empty postboxes wondering why letters from Kozielsk, Starobielsk, and Ostashkov stopped cleanly in the same week of April nineteen-forty—why even after Sikorski signed treaties with Moscow in forty-one, four thousand medical officers, reserve engineers, judges, schoolmasters, and colonels never walked into Buzuluk assembly tents.

Sylwia's own father's cousin, Reserve Captain Henryk Kotarski, lecturer in agricultural chemistry at Poznań University, had sent one birch-bark-pencil postcard from Kozielsk dated the nineteenth of March nineteen-forty asking whether the pear trees behind Sołacz survived the big frost. Nothing since.

Ten yards down Marszałkowska a young Volksdeutscher clerk in a Tyrolean hat with a white feather stepped out of a tobacconist's doorway grinning around a fresh cigar: "Hear that? Now the Polacks see what their English friends in Moscow save for dessert!"

An old bricklayer standing beside Sylwia turned his head slowly, spat dark tobacco juice square across the toe of his own boot—two inches short of the Tyrolean shoes, where spitting didn't earn a pistol butt—and walked away without uttering a syllable.

When Sylwia pushed through Pavilion Three's rear courtyard door twenty minutes later, Bronka met her at the foot of the stairs with two fingers pressed to her lips, jerking her chin toward the narrow frosted-glass door of the surgical instrument room behind Theater One.

Inside, no overhead light burned. Grey afternoon light came off wet brick across glass cabinets where rows of Krupp bone-saws, intestinal clamps, and trephines gleamed in neat steel ranks. Docent Tadeusz Mirecki sat hunched sideways on an enameled revolving operating stool, his camel-hair waistcoat unbuttoned, a damp extra-edition broadsheet of the German-printed *gadzinówka*—the "reptile sheet," *Nowy Kurier Warszawski*, still smelling of cheap kerosene ink—spread flat across his knees.

Sylwia shut the door behind her without clicking the latch.

"First thirty identified names from Pocket Lot One," Mirecki said in a dry, conversational whisper without looking up from the grey newsprint. His pince-nez lay folded on the marble shelf; he was tracing one line three inches from the bottom with a fingernail stained purple by surgical gentian violet. "Antoni Mirecki, Major-Lekarz Reserve, born Płock eighteen-ninety-three. Gold pocket-watch stopped at six-twelve, wooden cigarette holder carved with initials *A.M.*, vaccination scar left deltoid."

Sylwia stood completely still beside the glass cabinet. She remembered Antoni Mirecki from thirty-eight—tall, louder than Tadeusz, booming laugh over duck soup after Medical Society lectures on Niecała, smelling of Russian leather cologne and fine cigars, teasing Tadeusz mercifully about bachelor hypochondria while slipping fifty-złoty notes to needy fifth-year interns before Christmas.

"He couldn't even shoot a hare at Konstancin," Tadeusz Mirecki remarked mildly to his own knees. Not a tear wet his bagged lower lids; grief past fifty in Warsaw looked drier than lime dust. "Whenever our uncle put a twelve-bore shotgun into Antoni's hands in October, Antoni aimed three feet over the birches so the beaters wouldn't laugh at his nerves, and then sat up till midnight splicing broken wings on woodcock with matchsticks. Somebody tied an ophthalmologist's wrists behind his back with twine in pine mud and put lead through his cerebellum so he wouldn't prescribe spectacles to bourgeois children."

Slowly Mirecki folded the *gadzinówka* into neat quarters, then eighths, until the damp ink stained both his palms grey, and dropped it into the zinc waste-pail reserved for amputated tissue rags.

"Tomorrow morning," Mirecki said, hooking his pince-nez back onto his nose with steady, terrible calm, "Stabsarzt Vesper will bounce in here smelling of mouthwash to invite my signature on a Polish Medical Chamber delegation protest telegram for Dr. Goebbels's wireless. Refuse outright, and Aleja Szucha adds Pavilion Three's chief to Friday's Pawiak list as a Bolshevik sympathizer. Sign one syllable on German paper while German ovens burn three miles north of here and German ropes hang boys along Towarowa, and Antoni rises out of Smolensk sand to spit in my soup."

"Sign nothing," Sylwia said quietly, laying one raw hand for two seconds flat on his thin tweed shoulder—the first time in four years she had

ever touched Tadeusz Mirecki outside passing retractors. “Have a forty-eight-hour coronary spasm in bed starting tomorrow at seven a.m. I’ll inject half a milligram of atropine to push your pulse past a hundred and ten and rub amyl nitrite on your pillow before Vesper climbs the stairs. Even Vesper can’t carry a dying cardiopath to Kraków press conferences.”

Mirecki looked up at her through thick lenses; something fierce and grateful flickered inside watery blue before disappearing behind old irony. “What would thieves and cowards do without your needle-box, Sylwia? Go check Fourteen before curfew—Hauptmann von Berg brought his uniform trunk back from Saski Square an hour ago. They’re signing him out Friday morning.”

* * *

Friday morning. Forty hours left.

When Sylwia knocked once and entered Room Fourteen at nine-thirty Wednesday evening, the white iron room already looked half-abandoned, like a railway waiting-room after trunks are strapped.

Gone were the irrigation bottles, the rubber Carrel tubes, the yellow iodoform jars, even the tattered Leipzig Thucydides. Folded across the foot of the bed lay a freshly pressed field-grey Wehrmacht *Feldbluse*—not the slashed, blood-stiffened rag she had cut off him with Lister shears sixty-four nights ago, a new tailored Gabardine tunic with silver-braided *Oberstleutnant* shoulder boards and dull grey collar *Litzen* sewn clean. Mekelburg was down in the courtyard greasing a staff car brought round from Saski Square for Friday’s nine o’clock departure.

Ludwig stood fully dressed in trousers, polished black ankle-boots, and white linen collarless shirt with the left sleeve rolled past the bicep, testing passive forward elevation of his left arm against the tiled door-frame—ninety degrees, a hundred, a hundred and five before the missing collarbone segment made the scapula wing slightly and stopped him thirty degrees short of vertical.

Eight weeks under Lindleya’s roof had remade him under her hands: lean still, three kilos lighter than February ninth, yet solid muscle packed back across his right shoulder and ribs, skin clear, eyes winter-water sharp beneath lamplight. Only above the unbuttoned neck of his shirt, extending sideways from sternum hollow under his left brace-strap,

showed the permanent work of her knife: a five-centimeter sunken crimson-purple trough of dense, shiny scar tissue fused firm to underlying pectoral fascia, puckered at its upper corner where he had ripped it open for her on the night of March twenty-sixth and healed now beneath one final dry crust no larger than a ten-grosz piece.

"Hundred and ten degrees abduction," Sylwia said professionally, shutting the door behind her without locking it so the MP outside wouldn't wonder. "Push past horizontal before May and you'll avulse coracoclavicular scar fibers. Keep stretching five degrees a week on warm doorframe wood after hot water."

"You sound almost reluctant to lose your showcase specimen, *Frau Doktor*," Ludwig said, rolling his left shirt-cuff down and fastening the horn button deftly right-handed against his thigh.

"I'll sleep six hours straight Friday night when those two gorillas stop clicking heels outside my corridor," Sylwia replied coolly, laying a last small envelope of zinc ointment on the washstand. "And I've brought no flowers, so give me your parcel and let's clear our books."

All lightness left his face at once.

He walked two silent paces to the window casement, checked through a hairline crack beside the blackout frame that nobody stood directly beneath on courtyard gravel, then lifted his newly delivered gabardine uniform tunic off the foot-rail, slid two fingers inside a stitched inner map-lining behind the Iron Cross First Class loops, and drew out an object no bigger than a cigarette case.

Two flat rectangles of thin grey plumbers' lead foil—the exact sheet-lead dentists and hospital radiologists wrapped round occlusal X-ray plates to block scatter—crimped tight along three edges and sealed across the fourth flap with three drops of un-stamped black cobbler's pitch.

He held it on his open palm without handing it over yet.

"Before you put this in your pocket," Ludwig said quietly in Berlin German pitched solely for the two feet between them, "tell me one thing cleanly, Sylwia. No theater. On the night of twenty-seven February, when I spiked past forty degrees and you drained my shoulder—what street number did I say aloud?"

Sylwia's pulse gave one heavy stroke against her ribs; her face remained carved out of grey stone.

Lie now—say *you babbled about Kiel boat-hooks and nothing else*—and watch those winter-green eyes shut iron doors against her forever because he *already knew.*

"Chłodna twenty-two," Sylwia said straight into his teeth. "Optician's shop, not before the tenth of March."

Not a flicker of anger crossed Ludwig's face—instead, a terrifying, grim relief, as if confirming a malignant biopsy on somebody *else* rather than on her!

"When did you pass that address to your Polish handler?" he asked softly.

"Afternoon of the eighth of March," she answered—giving nothing on Marek's name, place, or description, yielding only timestamp arithmetic because timestamps harmed no innocent street and told her everything she needed to survive tomorrow. "Just the street number and the date. Not the other two words."

Ludwig's eyes held hers hard in the dim yellow bulb-light. "*The other two words.*"

"Clock-hand and Spiska," she breathed barely audibly, so faint a lip-reader three yards off would have missed the German labials. "Those stayed behind my teeth."

For two full seconds Ludwig stared down at her—taking in the staggering fact that a Polish underground surgeon holding his throat in her hand had deliberately held back two-thirds of a gold-mine intelligence windfall from her own superiors out of pure cold instinct—and blew out a single noiseless breath through his nostrils.

"Thank your Poznań grandmother's suspicious bones you held those back," he said very low. "Because Chłodna twenty-two was a virgin emergency dead-drop cut-out set up personally between me and one dead railway courier on eight February—never once used on wireless, never entered in Saski Square registries, unknown to every soul on Aleja Szucha. Nobody on earth knew 'tenth of March, Chłodna twenty-two' except me—until forty degrees four spilled it onto your apron, you handed it to your handler at four p.m. on Monday the eighth, and by six-forty-five Wednesday morning Reinhart Kroll had two Gestapo surveillance men parked opposite Number Twenty-Two in a grey Adler sedan."

Cold sweat prickled instantaneously between Sylwia's shoulder blades beneath clean wool.

On Jasna behind the bombed Philharmonic three weeks ago, Marek had looked straight into her eyes with aggrieved accusation—*Are you certain Schoeler was delirious, Sylwia? Maybe he dropped a burned address to trap our girls!*—when Chłodna twenty-two hadn't been burned on the German end at all! Somebody sitting inside the exact room where Marek Wolski filed his Tuesday night *Kontrwywiad* slip—either Marek's section chief, Marek's cipher clerk, or Marek himself—was *der Uhrzeiger*, *"Zegar"*, feeding fresh Polish counter-intelligence straight into Reinhart Kroll's white cotton gloves inside thirty-six hours!

And had she spoken *Spiska* aloud behind those Krochmalna stove-grates on March eighth, whoever lived or worked on Spiska Street would already be hanging in Aleja Szucha's basement while Kroll dragged Sylwia Kotarska out of Pavilion Three by her hair as the sole possible source!

"Who is *der Uhrzeiger*?" Sylwia whispered.

"If I knew his Polish face, I wouldn't have taken three rounds through my windshield in Ochota trying to buy his German pay-sheet off a terrified clerk," Ludwig said grimly. He pressed the flat lead-wrapped packet into her raw palm and closed his fingers briefly over hers so cold metal warmed between both their skins. "Tomorrow at noon—Thursday the fifteenth—walk into St. Charles Borromeo Church on Chłodna during the twelve o'clock Angelus bell. Third side-altar on the north aisle, St. Anthony of Padua. Underneath the hinged oak kneeler bench on the far left end is a gap behind the loose brass foot-strip. Slide this flat behind the brass, kneel thirty seconds for your dead relatives, and walk out the Waliców side porch without looking back toward the choir stairs."

Sylwia weighed the lead rectangle—forty grams, stiff enough inside not to bend like bare film—looking straight up at him without pocketing it yet.

"What am I putting behind St. Anthony's kneeler, Ludwig?" she asked coldly. "If it hangs one Polish boy or buys Aleja Szucha five minutes' peace, drop it in the Vistula yourself Friday morning."

"Give me credit for knowing whom I'm asking to carry mail, *Kotarska*," he said dryly. "There isn't a Polish name inside that lead—unless three safe-house addresses rented under false Łódź merchant names by Kroll's *Referat IV N* provocateurs and two blown London radio crystals count as Polish. Don't open the wax—and for God's sake don't put it near Docent

Mirecki's fluoroscope tube just in case you think lead foil means X-ray film, though lead blocks half-second scatter anyway. Deliver it sealed by twelve-fifteen tomorrow, and Table One, Room Thirteen's bath-closet, and ten winters of bad temper sit even."

"Ten winters never sit even," Sylwia said automatically—then caught the sharper shadow buried underneath: *What happened at Anhalter Bahnhof with Prague papers in March thirty-three?* hovered hot at the tip of her tongue for one perilous second before she bit it back down. Asking him about Jakob Mandelbaum tonight while holding an intelligence packet in her fist mixed two poisons in one cup; Berlin could wait until she knew nobody was hanging tomorrow.

She slid the cold lead rectangle into her inner smock seam pocket. "Twelve o'clock tomorrow. And when Stabsarzt Vesper signs your sheet Friday at nine, drive straight to Saski Square by Nowogrodzka and Marszałkowska—*not* south down Chałubińskiego past Koszykowa."

Ludwig's pale lashes narrowed one millimeter, catching the exact street-corner warning instantly without needing a diagram drawn in chalk.

Kontrwywiad's liquidation squad takes his car at the corner of Koszykowa and Chałubińskiego.

She hadn't planned on giving him that corner; five minutes ago, before *Chłodna twenty-two* proved a traitor sat inside her own reporting chain, she had torn herself apart wondering how to steer his route three blocks north on medical pretexts just to keep seventy patients in Pavilion Three out of retaliatory fire. Now the five words dropped clean off her tongue without excuse, watching a slow, dangerous stillness settle over his mouth as he realized she had just stepped across an invisible line to warn him off an ambush box.

"Nowogrodzka to Marszałkowska," Ludwig repeated softly, neither thanking her nor asking whose Sten guns waited at Koszykowa corner. "I always preferred wider boulevards in spring anyway. Watch your back tomorrow noon on Chłodna, Sylwia."

* * *

Of course she opened it at midnight.

Only saints and fools carried sealed lead envelopes through occupied Warsaw on a German spy's word of honor, and Sylwia Kotarska had never qualified for either guild.

Down in Halina's deserted cellar laboratory at twelve-forty a.m.—Halina having gone home before curfew to her rented attic on Tamka—Sylwia locked the *Fleckfieber* iron door from inside, lit only the dim ruby-red photographic safelight Halina used for printing electrophoretic strips just in case light-sensitive emulsion lay inside, heated her finest narrow #15 scalpel blade ten seconds over a spirit wick, and slid the hot steel silk-smooth underneath the three black drops of cobbler's pitch without melting or smearing their outer thumb-textured domes.

Inside the folded sheet-lead wrapper—lead chosen solely to defeat casual pocket-magnet or thin-finger pinch checks, and perhaps fool anyone sniffing for bulky paper—lay zero photographic film at all: two ultra-thin sheets of unwatermarked Swedish pelure tissue typed without ribbon (pure carbon impression only, untraceable to a specific platen roller if burned fast) in dense German-and-numeric blocks.

Even under dim ruby light, Sylwia's eyes raced down five unmistakable lines before her breath caught cold:

1. *WARNUNG LONDON-KREIS W-4:* Radio quartz 7140 kHz captured intact at Milanówek 29.III; operators currently transmitting under SD control (*Funkspiel "Kuckuck"*). Cease traffic immediately. 2. Three Warsaw apartment addresses—*Wspólna 47 m. 9, Żurawia 18 m. 4, Mokotowska 51 m. 11*—listed as false "underground transit mailboxes" operated directly by *SS-Hstuf. Kroll / Ref. IV N* using turned agents. 3. At the bottom, one single terse Polish sentence without signature: *Uważajcie na "Zegara" w wydziale II — płacono frankami szwajcarskimi przez Gdańsk do 9.II.* (*Beware "Zegar" in Section II — paid in Swiss francs via Danzig up to 9 Feb.*)

Sylwia stood frozen under the red bulb for twenty seconds while eight thousand lice rustled faintly in their warm dark cabinet behind her back.

Ludwig Schoeler wasn't turning Polish agents on Chłodna; Ludwig Schoeler was feeding blown *Funkspiel* radio warnings, Gestapo provocateur addresses, and confirmation of a high-level traitor inside *Armia Krajowa*'s own Section II counter-intelligence straight to a rival Polish-London channel—either to break Reinhart Kroll's neck, or on orders from

whatever quiet conspiracy sat rotting inside Admiral Canaris's Berlin Tirpitzufer corridors after Stalingrad, or both at once!

And if *Kontrwywiad* Section II contained *"Zegar"*—the very section Marek Wolski worked for!—then Marek's urgent order on Jasna (*shoot Schoeler's car at Koszykowa and Chałubińskiego the morning he leaves Lindleya*) wasn't patriotic retaliation at all: either *"Zegar"* upstairs had ordered Schoeler silenced before Schoeler could re-establish contact and expose him, OR Marek himself was carrying water for the traitor!

With hands steadier than steel, Sylwia folded the Swedish pelure tissue back along its exact microscopic creases, tucked it inside the lead foil, heated the flat of her scalpel blade warm again, and fused the underside of the three black cobbler's-pitch drops tight to the lead without leaving a scratch visible under Halina's ten-power hand-loupe.

At three minutes to twelve on Thursday morning, while dusty April sunshine slanted down across the brick canyon of Chłodna and a packed red tram clanged past the whitewashed brick Ghetto boundary wall thirty yards north, Sylwia walked bare-headed in a dark kerchief up the stone steps of St. Charles Borromeo, dipped two raw fingers in dry holy-water marble, and knelt alone at the far left end of St. Anthony's side altar just as the noon Angelus bell began booming overhead in bronze triplets.

Six old women in black shawls muttered *Zdrowaś Maryjo* up near the communion rail; nobody stood near the choir stairs except a blind beggar rattling tin. Bending low as if tying a loose bootlace beneath her skirt hem, Sylwia slid the lead packet flat behind the loose brass kick-strip under the oak kneeler—where her fingertips brushed empty dry wood dust, wedged it snug out of floor-broom reach, stayed on her knees counting sixty slow heartbeats while staring up at plaster St. Anthony's pink painted toes, and walked calmly out the Waliców side porch into spring sun.

Forty minutes later she met Marek Wolski by the leafless hornbeam hedge behind the stone sundial in Saski Garden—the Polish-permitted outer path along Marszałkowska before the iron fence closed off the German lawns.

Marek wore a light spring gabardine raincoat today and carried a rolled *Warschauer Zeitung* under his elbow. "Von Berg signed vehicle requisition for tomorrow morning at nine," he said low, walking slow beside her along raked gravel where nursemaids pushed Volksdeutsche

perambulators twenty yards ahead. "Schoeler's leaving Lindleya at nine o'clock?"

"Eight-thirty, out the Nowogrodzka ambulance gate," Sylwia lied smoothly—thirty minutes early and the opposite gate from Chałubińskiego, though Ludwig already knew better than to touch Chałubińskiego anyway. Then, looking straight ahead at budding hornbeam twigs with calm, clinical curiosity, she dropped one tiny drop of barium dye into the stream to watch where it flowed: "By the way—Mekelburg sent a post-card by kitchen boy yesterday to a leather-goods mender at *Elektoralna fourteen, courtyard right*, asking to have an officer's briefcase clasp repaired before Saturday noon."

Elektoralna fourteen did not have a leather-goods mender in the right courtyard; *Elektoralna fourteen* had an empty bombed glazier's shed Sylwia walked past twice a week, directly visible from the upstairs window of Bronka's cousin's flat across the street!

Marek's step didn't falter on the gravel, yet his fingers tightened almost imperceptibly around the rolled newspaper. "Elektoralna fourteen, courtyard right. Saturday noon?"

"Before noon, the kitchen boy said."

"Good catch," Marek said briskly, touching the brim of his grey trilby as they neared the Królewska corner gate where German officers strolled two by two out of *Abwehrstelle* headquarters toward luncheon tables at Café Europejski. "Stay inside your wards tomorrow morning between eight and ten, Sylwia. Don't stand near courtyard gates."

"I have three hernias booked from seven-thirty," she said evenly, watching him turn south down Marszałkowska without once looking back.

Then she turned west toward Lindleya—cold right down into her marrow, knowing that by Saturday noon beside a bombed glazier's shed on Elektoralna she would know for certain whether the man who had shared her narrow bed on Koszykowa fed names to Aleja Szucha.

Chapter X

Anastomosis

Warsaw, 17 April 1943

At twenty minutes to twelve on Saturday morning, Bronka's cousin Pelagia set a chipped saucer of pickled mushrooms down on the sewing-machine table without speaking and went back into her kitchen so she wouldn't know whom the hospital lady was watching through the darned Nottingham lace curtain.

Two floors below, ulica Elektoralna glared white and gritty in sudden warm April sun. Horse carts loaded with spring lime creaked toward Hala Mirowska; directly opposite Pelagia's window yawned the bombed archway of Number Fourteen, its courtyard right-hand glazier's shed roofless since September thirty-nine, nothing inside its blackened brick walls except dead nettles, broken bottle glass, and a stray ginger cat licking its paw on an upturned wheelbarrow.

Nobody on earth had sent a postcard to a leather-goods mender at *Elektoralna fourteen, courtyard right*—because Sylwia had invented the leather-goods mender, the kitchen boy, and the courtyard out of whole air forty-six hours ago beside the stone sundial in Saski Garden while looking straight into Marek Wolski's grey eyes.

At eleven-forty-two, a dark-grey four-door Adler Trumpf sedan turned unhurriedly off Orla, slowed without braking squeal thirty yards east of Number Fourteen's arch, and let a thin man in a greenish loden coat and soft felt hat step out onto the kerb to buy a newspaper he didn't read while leaning his shoulder comfortably against the tobacconist's shutter opposite the gate.

Sylwia did not touch the lace curtain. She stood two feet back inside Pelagia's dim room, counting the licence digits painted black on white

above the Adler's rear bumper as it glided away toward Bankowy Square: *Ost-44189*. Security Police pool plate.

Down in her stomach nothing felt hot or theatrical; everything went twenty degrees below zero, clean and surgical as liquid ethyl chloride sprayed onto skin before lancing a boil.

Forty-six hours. Thursday two p.m. into Marek Wolski's ear; Saturday eleven-forty-two a.m. out Reinhart Kroll's boot-leather.

Did that prove Marek himself took Swiss francs or Danzig transfers? Not necessarily—Marek reported verbally and on cipher slips every Thursday night to Section II's Warsaw District desk officer, whom Sylwia had never met and knew only as *"Inżynier Stach."* Either Marek was *"Zegar"*, or *"Stach"* was *"Zegar"*, or the girl who keyed Section II's Thursday slips into carbon flimsies slept with an SD clerk. For practical survival inside occupied Warsaw, the distinction mattered no more than which tooth on a circular saw took your fingers off: anything spoken to Marek Wolski walked up Aleja Szucha inside two nights.

And yesterday morning at eight-thirty, Stabsarzt Vesper had marched into Pavilion Three puffing cognac and lavender water to announce that *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler's Friday discharge was postponed seventy-two hours until Monday the nineteenth at nine a.m., because following the "regrettable hemorrhage disturbance of twenty-six March," *Sanitätsabteilung Warschau* required a formal orthopedic range-of-motion clearance signed before returning a senior staff officer to duty!

Meaning whoever waited with Sten guns at Koszykowa and Chałubińskiego yesterday morning had waited in empty wind—and by Monday morning Ludwig would leave by Nowogrodzka while Marek never received another true syllable out of Sylwia's mouth as long as she breathed.

When she walked back into Pavilion Three at half-past two, she found Ludwig waiting not in Room Fourteen, in the narrow tiled plaster-and-splint room off Theater One—door shut, Mekelburg posted outside in the corridor—sitting shirtless on the high leather-padded orthopedic table with his left arm dangling free.

"Who unlocked the splint room for you?" Sylwia asked, hanging her outdoor coat on the peg behind the door and rolling her black wool dress sleeves past her elbows before tying on a clean white apron.

"Docent Mirecki, before he retired upstairs with his mysterious tachycardia," Ludwig said dryly, watching her scrub at the corner porcelain

basin. Mirecki's atropine-and-amyl-nitrite "coronary crisis" on Wednesday had spared him Vesper's Katyń press delegation splendidly, though Ludwig's left eyebrow told her inside half a glance exactly how much faith he placed in Mirecki's electrocardiogram. "Stabsarzt Vesper writes *partial ankylosis left shoulder girdle, unfit for field service* on Monday's sheet unless abduction clears a hundred and fifty degrees. Write *unfit for field service* on an *Abwehr* personnel card in April forty-three, and Berlin transfers me within ten days to a desk in Dresden sorting postal censorship while Hauptmann von Berg hands Saski Square's Warsaw files over to 'liaison coordination' with Aleja Szucha."

Sylwia turned off the brass tap and shook water off her fingers. "You hit a hundred and ten degrees Wednesday night. Push past a hundred and ten before week nine and you tear dense subdeltoid and coracoacromial adhesions raw."

"Precisely why orthopedic surgeons perform *brisement forcé* before fibrous scar calcifies," Ludwig said calmly.

She walked across the tiles until she stood right beside his left knee. Even sitting down on the high padded table, his eyes were level with hers; pale April light slanting through the high frosted transom caught the sunken crimson-purple scar trough beneath his resected collarbone gap and the hard, lean curve of pectoralis and deltoid knotted tight around it.

"Under deep ether or intravenous Evipan," Sylwia said flatly, "so pectoral muscle spasm doesn't snap the surgical neck of the humerus in half like dry pine when the lever goes up. We have zero Evipan left until May, and fifty grams of ether puts you vomiting on a stretcher till dusk."

"You broke frozen cavalry shoulders with von Halden in the outpatient clinic using ten milliliters of intra-bursal procaine and two steady hands," Ludwig said. "I didn't ask for Evipan, and I don't need ether."

"You aren't twenty-two years old showing off for nurses, Ludwig, and your middle clavicle is missing two centimeters of strut!"

"Which means you stabilize the scapula manually against the ribs with your left palm so leverage falls purely across the subdeltoid bursa instead of the vascular bridge," he answered without raising his voice a decibel, unbuckling his leather officer's trouser belt right-handed, folding four inches double—the exact grim routine from sixteen February, except today there were no nurses, no orderlies, and zero septic haze—and holding the folded hide in his palm. "Ten minutes, *Kotarska.* Break the

adhesions clean now behind closed doors, and Monday morning I lift my left arm over my head in front of Vesper's spectacles and stay in Warsaw where Kroll can't eat your hospital alive."

And where Elektoralna fourteen proved ten times over what Kroll already owns, clicked silent behind Sylwia's forehead.

She didn't mention Elektoralna—telling him even half a Polish counter-intelligence failure felt like stripping naked in winter wind—simply turned to the locked glass drug cupboard, drew ten milliliters of one-percent procaine into a long spinal needle, swabbed his lateral deltoid skin cold with spirit, and slid the steel three centimeters straight beneath the acromion into the obliterated subacromial space.

Procaine numbed synovial lining; against thick finger-wide bands of tough six-week collagen gluing torn muscle bellies to periosteum, ten milliliters of one-percent was spit on hot iron.

"Lie flat?" she asked five minutes later, testing skin numbness over the deltoid tuberosity.

"Supine lets the shoulder blade slide across leather," Ludwig said, bracing his bare soles against the iron foot-stirrup bar along the table side instead. "Do it seated—brace your hip inside my left knee so the trunk can't twist away when the band gives."

Pure textbook Lexer mechanics; any orthopedic manual printed in Munich or Vienna showed the identical plate in black-and-white halftone, two sexless mannequins in loincloths demonstrating scapular fixation. Neither Munich nor Vienna printed what happened when the surgeon stepping inside a six-foot man's spread knees to wedge her hip hard against his inner thigh and pelvis was five feet six in thin wool, smelled of rain and carbolic soap, and hadn't stood this close to his bare skin without gauze between them since thunderstorm lightning lit zinc sinks on Luisenstraße twelve summers ago.

Sylwia stepped squarely between his knees.

Rough grey Wehrmacht breeches scraped both outer sides of her thighs through her black dress and white apron; to lock his left scapula immobile against chest-wall rotation while her right hand took the humerus lever at the elbow, she had to plant her bare left palm flat and heavy across the hot, scarred hollow behind his left armpit and brace her own breastbone four inches from his bare chest.

Ludwig set the folded leather belt between his back molars. Up this close his grey-green eyes didn't close or look at the ceiling; they stayed wide open, locked straight onto hers from six inches away while heat radiated off his skin like sun off dark slate.

"Exhale on three," Sylwia said quietly. "Don't fight my right hand with your latissimus or you fracture bone. One. Two. Three."

On *three* he blew breath out; before pectoral reflex could clamp down, Sylwia sank her body weight hard against his pelvis to pin him upright, locked his shoulder blade down with her left heel-of-hand, and drove his flexed left elbow smoothly, relentlessly *upward* past a hundred and ten degrees—one-twenty, one-thirty, one-forty—straight into the wall of solid fibrous scar.

Beneath her left palm, deep inside living muscle three inches from her ear, tough collagen bands tore apart with three wet, sickeningly audible snaps—*pop, crk, pop*—like ripping heavy wet canvas seam by seam!

A muffled animal sound tore behind the leather belt in Ludwig's teeth; every muscle in his neck, abdomen, and thighs turned instantly to white-hot iron round her hips. Before he could help himself, his uninjured right hand—searching blindly for counter-purchase rather than grabbing her operational arm—clamped hard onto the curve of Sylwia's left hipbone and waist, fingers digging straight through thin apron linen and wool into flesh while his damp forehead dropped forward three inches until it rested rock-hard against the bare side of her neck and collarbone!

"One band left—posterior capsule—don't lock!" Sylwia gasped against his sweat-wet temple hair, her own heart slamming wild against her ribs as she rotated the elevated humerus thirty degrees externally—*rip!*—feeling the final dense cord part clean beneath her palm as his left elbow cleared full one hundred and seventy degrees vertical beside his ear!

She eased the arm down slowly—never drop a manipulated joint fast—cradling his trembling, sweat-slick left forearm against her own breast with both hands while holding him upright between his knees until the grey vagal wave of pain-shock passed without dropping him off the table edge.

Ten seconds passed. Twenty.

Neither of them moved an inch.

Ludwig had spat the leather belt onto the padded table beside his thigh; his forehead still rested heavy and burning hot in the hollow

between Sylwia's neck and right shoulder, his breath rasping ragged and wet directly across her bare collar-skin down inside the open V of her dress collar while his right hand stayed locked hard over her hipbone—thumb pressing slow, involuntary white-knuckled force into the soft hollow above her iliac crest. Beneath her hands holding his left forearm against her ribs, she felt both his racing pulse and the violent, unmistakable kick of her own heartbeat hammering straight back through thin cotton into his wrist.

Smell of hot salt sweat, crushed hair, clean lye soap, and blood-iron filled her throat until her knees went treacherous inside his braced thighs.

One turn of her head—two centimeters left—put her mouth directly against the damp corner of his jaw below his ear. And from the sudden dead-still tension across his back and the slight shift of his gripping fingers upward along her ribs—not pushing her away, *pulling* half an inch closer before freezing rigid—she knew in every nerve of her body that if she turned those two centimeters inside this locked white room, neither war nor uniform nor ten years of corpses would stop what happened across this leather table in the next sixty seconds.

* * *

Berlin, July 1931

At midnight during the great July heatwave, when asphalt melted sticky along Unter den Linden and thunderheads stacked purple-black over the Spree without dropping rain, the experimental surgery cellar beneath Geheimrat von Halden's clinic smelled of dog hair, ozone, and hot sublimate.

Sylwia hadn't eaten since noon on Wannsee, where von Halden's annual summer clinic picnic had trapped twelve sweating junior staff and student assistants aboard two rented yachts tacking sluggishly past Pfaueninsel while Frau Geheimrat served lukewarm potato salad and Ludwig Schoeler—brown-armed in rolled white tennis sleeves, hair bleached two shades lighter by sun, steering Boat Two with infuriating north-coast competence—had spent four hours deliberately luffing across Sylwia's bow wind every time she took the tiller from clumsy Oberarzt Weber.

At eleven p.m., back in Berlin with lightning flickering silent sheet-white behind the Pathology chimneys, Sylwia had slipped down into the animal quarters to check Dog Seven—her tawny mongrel bitch whose right femoral artery she had resected and bridged forty-eight hours earlier with a preserved jugular-vein segment for her doctoral trial—and found the dog's right hind paw ice-cold, cyanotic, and pulseless.

Not surgical error along her suture line: sitting beside the cage water-pan lay half a chunk of fatty pork rind laced white with barium meal powder somebody from Kleist's morning stomach-X-ray bench had tossed carelessly (or *not* carelessly!) into a vascular-fasting cage, sending the dehydrated animal retching violently for three hours until hypotension clotted the fresh venous graft solid!

Let Dog Seven's leg go necrotic before seven a.m. rounds, and von Halden struck Sylwia's entire six-month venous-graft series out of the autumn *Archiv für klinische Chirurgie* volume in favor of Ludwig's collateral-ligation paper.

By eleven-forty she had the twenty-kilo bitch strapped supine under light open-drop ether on Zinc Table Two, hair shaved clean, skin painted brown with iodine, femoral incision re-opened under one buzzing green-shaded bulb—working furiously *alone* without an assistant to hold stay-sutures or drip warm Ringer's solution while sweat dripped off her chin onto her gauze mask and a fresh mural thrombus six millimeters long bulged dark blue inside the delicate vein graft!

Try milking a clot out of a four-millimeter dog vein single-handed while holding two bulldog clamps and keeping ether dripping up by the muzzle—impossible with two hands; inside ninety seconds the thin jugular wall tore if nobody held the third stay-thread!

Behind her the heavy iron fire-door from the pathology tunnel clicked open and shut.

Sylwia froze with iris scissors half-open over the exposed femoral sheath, heart leaping into her throat—night watchman meant a ten-mark fine and expulsion from animal rooms; Oberarzt Weber meant disgrace.

Ludwig walked into the cone of green light without a white coat.

He wore dark evening trousers and the damp white linen shirt from Wannsee, collar open two buttons at his sunburned throat, jacket slung over one shoulder—coming back late from some Charlottenburg supper by shortcut through the clinic yard to fetch books before the storm broke.

Five paces from Table Two he stopped dead, taking in at one sweep the dripping ether cone, the cyanotic paw, the half-eaten barium pork rind lying on Sylwia's stool as evidence, and the bulging blue thrombus between two bulldog clamps while Sylwia stood trapped with only two hands.

Walk out that door—he didn't even have to report her, merely walk upstairs to bed!—and by nine o'clock tomorrow morning the autumn *Archiv* slot belonged exclusively to Ludwig Schoeler uncontested.

"Your ether cone's drying out—she'll kick inside forty seconds," Ludwig said irritably, dropping his jacket onto a dry radiator, rolling both shirt-sleeves above his elbows in three jerks, and plunging his bare hands straight into the sublimate basin without asking whether she wanted him within a mile of her dog.

"Get away from my table," Sylwia hissed through her wet gauze mask, pride blazing hotter than ninety-degree July air. "I don't need charity from Boat Two!"

"Call it curiosity whether your jugular patchwork holds eighty millimeters when somebody isn't feeding your dogs barium grease," Ludwig snapped back, shaking sublimate off his wet fingers, dripping ten fresh drops of ether onto the wire muzzle cone so the bitch settled deep into surgical plane, and stepping squarely opposite her across the two-foot-wide zinc trough to take two fine Carrel stay-threads gently in his steady fingers. "Open the anterior suture line three stitches only—don't take the whole graft down or you'll narrow the lumen re-sewing. Flush proximal clamp half a second to blow the tail clot out before you close."

For twenty-eight blistering minutes while thunder finally cracked straight overhead—shaking dust off basement steam-pipes and making the single bulb blink yellow—they worked four hands inside three square inches of living flesh like two halves of one brain that hated its other hemisphere. Neither called an instrument twice; before Sylwia's scissors finished snipping three silk loops, Ludwig's paraffin-wetted forceps had lifted the intimal lip without bruising endothelium; when she cracked the proximal clamp half a turn and dark worm-clot shot cleanly out into gauze followed by bright scarlet arterial spurting, his traction threads pulled the triangle taut before she drew breath, letting her lay four microscopic five-zero stitches home in ninety seconds flat.

Clamps off. Smooth crimson flow raced down the pale blue vein bridge; inside sixty seconds the grey-cold hind paw pads flushed warm shell-pink, digital pulse tapping lively against Ludwig's fingertip!

Only afterward—at twelve-forty a.m., when Dog Seven lay sleeping warmly in clean straw under a blanket and Sylwia stood at the slate sink scrubbing dried blood off a thin-walled liter Erlenmeyer flask of carbolic rinse—did exhausted fingers slip in soapy lather just as a tremendous bolt of lightning hit the Charité lightning-rod outside and plunged the basement lights black for two seconds.

Glass exploded against slate edge directly inside her left grip.

When the bulb flickered back on yellow, a curved jagged shard of thick flask-neck stood driven deep across the thenar eminence at the base of Sylwia's left thumb, pumping dark red venous and palmar-arch branch blood down her wrist into the soapy grey sink water!

"Verdammt noch mal, Kotarska—let go the glass!" Ludwig cursed, shoving her hip sideways away from the broken shards, grabbing a clean rubber Esmarch tourniquet band off the shelf to twist tight above her wrist in two turns so the bleeding dropped instantly to slow ooze, and pulling her palm straight under the cold boiled-water tap.

No fracture, flexor pollicis longus tendon gleaming white and intact at the bottom of a clean four-centimeter gash—miss that tendon by two millimeters and her surgical life ended at twenty-one!—just skin and superficial muscle fascia sliced wide open, stinging fire from soapy five-percent carbolic.

"Hold your own wrist steady on the slate," Ludwig ordered without asking permission, snatching up her leftover boiled Hagedorn skin needle and black silk off Table Two's sterile corner—zero procaine drawn because drawing procaine meant unwrapping a fresh syringe while tourniquet ischemia burned her forearm. "Four stitches. Revenge for Schöneberg—let's see if you sit quieter than I did."

He didn't sit her on a crate; he backed her hips straight against the cool front lip of the slate sink, pinning her leaning slightly backward while standing six inches in front of her in sweat-damp shirt-sleeves that clung transparent across his chest and shoulders in the ninety-degree cellar steam, cradling the back of her cut left hand gentle as porcelain inside his broad left palm while his right drove four swift, razor-clean interrupted silk bites through her raw thumb base.

One. Two. Three. Four.

It burned like hot wire, and Sylwia didn't make a sound—staring fixed at the tiny crescent ladder-scar *she* had put beneath his right cheekbone seven months earlier, shining pale against his sun-browned skin six inches from her eyes while outside torrential July rain hammered down onto the courtyard skylights like gravel flung by shovels.

Ludwig snipped the fourth silk tail with scissors, untwisted the rubber tourniquet band off her forearm, and didn't drop her hand.

Capillary flush rushed hot back into her fingers; wrapped in sterile gauze, her left palm lay trapped flat against the damp linen over his ribs where his heart was knocking fast and heavy—hundred and ten, hundred and twenty—nothing to do with sewing four stitches.

"Kleist threw that pork rind in," Ludwig said quietly, voice rough in the thunder-hush, looking straight down into her dark, dilated eyes. "I saw grease on his white cuffs when he came up the dog stairs at six. Want me to break his collarbone tomorrow, or ruin his stomach X-rays yourself?"

"Ruin them myself," Sylwia whispered—or started to whisper, because before the last consonant cleared her teeth her eyes dropped involuntarily to his mouth, remembering juniper schnapps and copper blood in Schöneberg snow, and his right hand came up cold-wet from the tap to catch the back of her neck beneath her pinned dark hair, tilting her chin up hard as his mouth came down on hers.

Nothing cautious or polite lived inside ten yards of either of them.

Her mouth opened furious under his—salt sweat, soap, sharp male breath—biting his lower lip hard enough to make him groan deep in his throat as he lifted her bodily right up by the thighs onto the cold slate rim of the scrubbing bench so her wet shoes swung clear of the floor and her knees parted instinctively round his lean waist! Bandaged left palm tangled in his soaked hair, intact right hand ripping two horn buttons clean off his damp shirt front to get bare palms onto burning skin over ribs she had watched under boxing-cellar ropes, while his rough surgeon's hands slid hot under her thin summer cotton skirt up bare thighs above her stocking tops—fingers digging bruising-hard into bare hip flesh, pulling her groin flush and grinding hard against the rigid ridge straining inside his dark wool trousers until Sylwia's head fell back against the cool tiled wall with a ragged, shameless gasp that echoed loud across the dog-pens!

His mouth dragged scorching down her throat to the hollow of her collarbone, right hand already fumbling between their crushed bodies at her cotton knickers elastic while she hooked both heels frantic behind his thighs to pull him straight inside her on cold wet slate right beside bloody sink-water—

—when three sharp iron raps rattled the outer tunnel padlock thirty feet away, followed by old night-watchman Krause's lantern beam sweeping yellow through the upper wired transom glass: *"Ist da noch Licht im Hundestall? Herr Oberarzt?"*

Both of them froze stone-dead in the shadow behind the sink pillar —panting without sound into each other's skin, her skirt bunched round her waist, his forehead pressed slick against her bare breastbone above her slipped camisole—until Krause muttered about defective switches, clicked the corridor master-breaker outside off, and clumped away down the wet stone passage.

In pitch blackness smelling of rain-ozone, ether, and raw sex stopped two seconds short of the cliff, humiliation and terror at what she had just let Ludwig Schoeler feel her begging for hit twenty-one-year-old Sylwia like ice-water thrown across hot glass.

She shoved both palms hard against his bare chest, sliding down off the slate lip onto unsteady legs and yanking her rumpled cotton skirt down in the dark.

"Touch me again when lights are on, *Schoeler*," she breathed shaking through clenched teeth, "and I'll put a #10 blade between your ribs."

Out of the blackness six inches away came his ragged laugh—ugly, breathless, just as shaken and twice as proud to bleed before showing it.

"Buy thicker buttons for your blouse before autumn, *Kotarska*," he whispered back in the dark, "or lock your cages earlier."

Neither of them ever mentioned that Tuesday night aloud through twenty more months in Berlin—fighting ten times more viciously across every ward round, lecture hall, and laboratory table until the Reichstag burned—and every single morning when Sylwia scrubbed her hands she saw four tiny black-silk dots healed white across the base of her left thumb.

* * *

Warsaw, 17 April 1943

Sylwia wrenched backward out from between Ludwig's knees in the tiled splint room as if the leather table had caught fire.

Her apron front was damp where his forehead sweat had pressed against her collar; her left hipbone throbbed dull and hot under wool where five fingers had dug straight to bone during the capsule tear. Across the room by the porcelain basin she grabbed a folded roller bandage without looking round until her breathing flattened out by sheer murderous will.

Behind her on the high leather table, Ludwig didn't jump down or make a single clever Berlin remark. Slowly he sat upright, wiping sweat off his jaw and throat with the clean linen shirt beside him, then raised his bare left arm—stiffly, grimacing once at raw bruised muscle, yet smoothly, without mechanical block—straight up past horizontal, past one-forty, all the way vertical beside his left ear until fingers brushed the frosted light chain overhead!

"Hundred and seventy degrees," he said, voice still low and rough-scraped down in his chest as he lowered the arm slowly and slid into his grey wool shirt. "Vesper can't write *unfit* on Monday now if he brings three micrometers."

"Ice pack twenty minutes tonight, active wall-climbing exercises thrice daily starting tomorrow," Sylwia recited toward the glass instrument cabinet, counting shiny curved scissors she didn't need to count while curling her scarred left thumb unconsciously inside her fist. "Granulation crust separates inside ten days; apply plain sterile boric ointment if dry. After Monday nine a.m. your surgical chart closes here."

Silence stretched three beats behind her back while horn buttons slipped through buttonholes one-handed.

Then paper rustled faintly, and heavy leather boots crossed three paces of white tile to lay a stiff, pale-green folded card stamped with the dark blue eagle-and-swastika of *Wehrmachtkommandantur Warschau* squarely onto the marble shelf beside her elbow.

Sylwia looked down without touching it.

SONDERAUSWEIS — Ärztlicher Außendienst. Valid throughout the Warsaw municipal and German residential districts (*einschließlich Sperrbezirk Palais Brühl / Królewska*), authorizing **Dr. med. Sylwia Kotarska** (*Szpital Dzieciątka Jezus*) unhindered passage with surgical instrument

bag Tuesdays and Fridays between 16:00 and 21:00 hours for mandatory specialist vascular-and-orthopedic follow-up attendance upon **Oberstleutnant Dr. L. Schoeler**, *Królewska 16, Wohnung 4.* Counter-signed *Dr. K. Vesper, Stabsarzt* and *i.A. von Berg, Hptm.*

She turned round slowly, fury rising hot enough to burn away the dizzying phantom heat still clinging to her skin.

"Your wound needs zero twice-weekly specialist house calls once epithelium closes," she said coldly. "Have an orderly at Saski Square dab zinc paste on it, or walk into *Lazarett Ujazdowski*."

Ludwig stood eighteen inches away buttoning the grey gabardine collar of his fresh *Feldbluse*—looking abruptly, chillingly no longer like her half-naked surgical quarry on Bed Fourteen, looking every inch a senior Wehrmacht staff officer with silver cord gleaming on grey wool shoulders and cold river-green eyes cutting down into hers.

"Walk into Ujazdowski twice a week," Ludwig said quietly, "and Vesper sees how little dressing I need while you lose the single stamped pass in Warsaw that lets a Polish surgeon cross German police cordons past curfew with an unsearched leather bag—and lets us talk twice a week where neither Docent Mirecki's thin walls nor whoever leaked Chłodna twenty-two out of your underground mailbox can press an ear to the plaster."

Sylwia's breath caught silent behind her ribs. *He already assumed she had tested her Polish line—and saw from her eyes right now what she had found on Elektoralna!*

"Królewska sixteen is inside the German residential block," she said tightly. "Walk me through a *Nur für Deutsche* front hall in Polish shoes twice a week and every janitor on the block reports a Polish whore visiting an officer."

"Service stair from the garden passage comes straight up into the pantry—and half the German medical officers on Królewska bring Polish masseuses and dentists in by stamped *Außendienst* card without raising an eyebrow," Ludwig said without softening a fraction. His gaze dropped for half a heartbeat to the pulse beating fast in the bare hollow of her throat—two inches from where his sweating forehead had rested five minutes ago—and lifted straight back to her eyes. "Tuesdays and Fridays at five, starting the twenty-seventh of April, *Frau Doktor*. Miss an

appointment without sending word, and I assume either Reinhart Kroll or your own leak on Chłodna picked you up—and I act accordingly."

Before she could throw the green card back at his silver buttons, he picked up his peaked cap off the stool, inclined his head two millimeters with immaculate, infuriating Prussian correctness, unlocked the splint-room door, and walked out to Mekelburg waiting in the corridor.

Alone on the white tiles, Sylwia stared down at *Królewska 16, Wohnung 4* stamped in violet Reich ink beside her own name—then picked up the green card with two fingers and slid it deep inside her pocket beside the bruised bone of her hip.

Chapter XI

Ash on the Laundry

Warsaw, 19–24 April 1943

What woke Sylwia at six minutes past six on the Monday of Holy Week was not the noise itself—four explosions three kilometers north sounded no louder against Koszykowa's windowpanes than coal wagons coupling hard down by Towarowa—it was the rhythm afterward.

Railway shunters banged twice and stopped to curse; German anti-aircraft batteries practiced in crisp four-gun salvos that rattled teacups and echoed away across the Vistula. This was low, flat seventy-five-millimeter field howitzer fire—*thump… crump*—firing point-blank over open sights between brick walls where echoes had nowhere to roll, stitched together instantly by two distinct kinds of automatic chatter: the tearing, thousand-round-a-minute rip of Wehrmacht MG-34s answered three seconds later by slower, sharper pistol cracks and the dull subterranean concussion of homemade grenade tins exploding inside courtyards.

Sylwia swung bare feet onto cold floorboards without putting on slippers, pushed the blackout blind aside two inches, and unlatched Goldfeder's inner casement.

April morning air rushed in sharp and blue, smelling of wet lilac buds from courtyard trees, coal smoke, and—faint at first, drifting high down out of the north over Elektoralna and Grzybowska—cordite mixed with burning kerosene.

Across the narrow courtyard well, two tenement windows snapped open; a bald tailor in striped flannel nightshirt leaned out craning northward, crossed himself rapidly, and pulled his head back inside before his wife grabbed his elbow. Down on Koszykowa cobbles milk-carts rattled uninterrupted; a red Number Nine tram clanged past heading east on schedule.

Passover tonight, Sylwia realized with a jolt behind her breastbone, counting calendar days backward from Easter Sunday. *And Tuesday's picric-acid lime cart never goes in again.*

When she reached Pavilion Three at seven-fifteen, half the convalescent fractures on the third floor had limped out onto the iron fire-balcony facing north in grey hospital dressing-gowns, shading their eyes against bright spring sun. From third-floor height, above the slate mansards of Nowogrodzka and Bagno, you saw it plain: a thick, greasy column of brown-black smoke rising straight up out of the Muranów skyline north of Chłodna into windless blue heaven, spreading at a thousand feet into a flat dark anvil cloud while faint dull thuds vibrated up through brick soles every forty seconds.

Down on the ground floor, the stenciled *Reserviert — Wehrmacht-Notdienst* sign was already being unscrewed from the east-wing swing doors by a hospital carpenter while Stabsarzt Vesper strutted up and down the tiled corridor in freshly polished riding boots, slapping his gloves against his thigh and beaming as if he personally had sewn Ludwig Schoeler's subclavian artery together with his teeth.

At eight-forty-five Room Fourteen's door opened for the last time.

Mekelburg came out first carrying his commander's battered leather portmanteau in his intact right hand, three-fingered left palm scarred tough pink without splint now and tucked neatly behind his belt buckle; as he passed Sylwia standing beside Docent Mirecki at the admissions counter, the boy snapped his heels together two degrees sharper than regulations required for civilian doctors, pale country eyes meeting hers for one silent flick before he carried the bag down the steps toward a mud-splashed grey Wanderer staff car idling in the courtyard.

Behind him walked Ludwig.

In tailored field-grey wool greatcoat buttoned up to the silver-piped collar, peaked cap set slightly low over his brow so the black patent visor shadowed his winter-green eyes, he looked ten miles removed from any man who had ever lain shivering under vinegar cloths or spat leather straps onto hospital linen. Only Sylwia—knowing where two centimeters of bone were missing underneath that left shoulder-board—saw how meticulously the Berlin tailor's horsehair pad masked the six-millimeter drop of his left acromion, and how consciously he carried his gloved left hand loose along his coat seam rather than stiff in a sling.

"Splendid functional restoration, *Herr Oberstleutnant*!" Vesper trumpeted, flourishing three carbon copies of the yellow Wehrmacht discharge certificate across Walenty's oak counter. "One hundred and sixty-five degrees painless abduction recorded Saturday—scarcely a five-percent pensionable impairment! Sign the bottom duplicate here for *Ortskommandantur* records, if you please, and Docent Mirecki witnesses municipal release."

Ludwig uncapped his own black Pelikan fountain pen right-handed and bent slightly over the counter to sign *Schoeler, Obstlt.* in small, slantless vertical script sharp as copperplate needles.

Outside through the open courtyard doors, three dull cannon thuds sounded back-to-back from the north, shaking a pinch of dry putty dust off the vestibule transom. Vesper cleared his throat loudly, pretending artillery inside a conquered capital three hundred miles behind the front was merely Tuesday weather: "Sanitary clearing action in the northern quarantine sector—high time those bandit nests were smoked out before warm weather breeds typhus!"

Mirecki stared fixedly at the floor tiles behind his pince-nez. Bronka, standing four feet back with folded arms like salt pork, narrowed her eyes at the back of Vesper's pink neck as if measuring where a cleaver went between third and fourth cervical vertebrae.

Ludwig capped his pen without glancing at Vesper, handed the sheet across to Sylwia—whose countersignature as attending vascular surgeon occupied line three—and stepped half a pace round the corner of the oak desk while she signed so Vesper's fat shoulder stood blocked by Mirecki signing copy two.

Through the open vestibule doorway drifted a tiny grey curl of charred feather-tick ash, spinning lazily down on sunlit draft to settle right onto the green blotter six inches from Sylwia's knuckles.

"Keep your cellar bolted tight this week, *Kotarska*," Ludwig murmured in crisp Berlin German pitched below the scratch of Mirecki's nib, looking down at her bent dark head rather than her face so Vesper saw nothing except an officer waiting for his copy. "SS-Brigadeführer Stroop took command over Hahn's head at six this morning with Lemberg pioneer battalions and flamethrowers. Anyone caught near northern manhole covers gets shot on the asphalt without *Szucha* paperwork."

Sylwia finished the final tail of *Dr. med. S. Kotarska*, blotted the wet black ink calmly with wooden rocker-blotter, and lifted her eyes straight into his under the black cap visor.

"Tuesdays and Fridays," he added a fraction louder—loud enough now for Vesper's benefit, cool and official as ice—"five o'clock sharp per *Herr Stabsarzt*'s outpatient order, Frau Doktor. Don't make my clerk telephone your hospital."

"Tuesdays and Fridays, *Herr Oberstleutnant*," Sylwia said without expression.

He touched two leather-gloved fingers to his visor—one salute covering Mirecki, Vesper, and six Polish orderlies without distinguishing her by half an inch—walked down the stone steps into blinding April sunlight, folded his long frame into the rear seat of the grey Wanderer without favoring his left shoulder, and was gone through Lindleya gate before the gatehouse clock finished striking nine.

Behind him Room Fourteen stood wide open to ward maids sloshing lysol water across empty pine boards. All morning, whenever Sylwia walked past the ground-floor east corridor on her way between Theater One and the stairs, the missing click of military-police boots outside those swing doors felt not like liberation, like having a tooth pulled out by the roots and leaving a raw, bleeding socket her tongue couldn't stop touching—while thirty blocks north the cannon fire grew heavier every hour.

* * *

By Good Friday the sun over Warsaw turned the colour of a dirty copper five-grosz piece seen through smoked glass.

Not clouds—blue sky still burned cloudless above Praga and Mokotów—a vast, slanting river of greasy brown-violet smoke pouring continuously south-southeast off burning Muranów, Nalewki, Zamenhofa, and Świętojerska as SS demolition engineers Stopped storming stairwells where Jewish pistol teams shot them off landings and began systematically torching tenement block after tenement block from cellar to roof with incendiary charges and crude-oil sprayers.

Up on Pavilion Three's flat tarred gravel roof at two in the afternoon, sixty boiled hospital sheets hung flapping on galvanized wire lines strung

between brick chimney-stacks. Every sheet Bronka had hung wet-white at eight a.m. was speckled gray-black by noon with greasy soot flakes the size of fingernails—charred ledger paper carrying Hebrew and Polish print still legible until you touched it and it crumbled to black tallow on your skin, burnt horsehair mattress stuffing, scorched pigeon feathers, and a sweetish, roasting fat-and-lime stench no hospital surgeon who had ever smelled cautery on human muscle could mistake for pinewood.

"Three tubs of lye wasted," Bronka muttered savagely, yanking clothes-pegs off wire with cold red knuckles and stuffing ruined grey-streaked sheets into wicker laundry hampers while wind whipped her white head-cloth sideways. She paused with an armful of linen crushed against her apron, staring north over a mile of sunlit slate roofs toward the rolling black wall where orange flame-tongues licked visible even at midday whenever a tenement roof collapsed inward.

Down below along Marszałkowska and Aleje Jerozolimskie, church bells were silent since Maundy Thursday *Gloria*—wooden clappers rattling dry for Good Friday liturgy—yet carried clear down a freak north gust past Saski Garden came the tinny, cheerful oompah-oompah of the steam calliope on the Easter fairground carousel erected thirty yards outside the Ghetto wall on Krasiński Square, turning round and round with painted wooden horses while crowds in spring coats licked watery fruit-ice cones and watched dive-bombers or artillery shells burst two hundred feet away behind brick!

"Swine," Bronka spat straight onto the tarred roof gravel—not specifying German swine or Polish carousel-riders, cursing the whole bipedal species under heaven in one mouthful—and crossed herself hard with her left thumb still holding three wooden pegs. "Even beasts in Wola stockyards bellow when the shed next door burns. Up by Krasiński they buy sunflower seeds and lift children on their shoulders to watch roofs fall in."

"Take that hamper down to soak cold before the grease sets," Sylwia said, pulling a charred scrap of printed Yiddish prayer-book margin gently off a pillowcase before folding it into her pocket—not out of piety, she hadn't knelt sincerely in church since her mother died pickled in morphine at nineteen-twenty-nine, only because throwing letters burned off living rooms into a hospital slop-tub felt obscene. "I'm going down to check Halina before three."

Down in the *Fleckfieber* basement tunnel, zero daylight reached; yet even down there, drawn through the courtyard intake flue feeding the agar stove, hung that unmistakable sweet-greasy char.

When Sylwia rapped three-and-one on the iron-sheathed door, nobody slid the bolt for twenty seconds. She rapped harder; finally the upper iron bolt scraped back slow, and Halina stood there without her grey cardigan, sleeves rolled past white forearms covered in fresh purple louse-bite grids—she had strapped twelve Weigl cages instead of ten onto her thighs *and* forearms today as if trying to drain half a pint out of herself on purpose—holding a broken glass Pasteur pipette in her right fist with bright red blood dripping steadily off her cut thumb pad onto the stone floor.

Sylwia stepped inside, kicked the iron door bolted behind her, took Halina's bleeding right wrist without a word, and steered her to the slate laboratory sink.

The telephone junction box behind the horse-serum rack—where two hair-fine copper wires spliced clandestinely into the municipal sanitary sewer cable had carried ninety-second whispers from Bonifraterska twice a week since winter—hung open with both copper leads cut clean off and wrapped back round porcelain insulators.

"Melted short at four yesterday afternoon when they blew the brushmakers' block on Świętojerska," Halina said in a voice so flat and conversational it raised gooseflesh down Sylwia's arms. She didn't look down while Sylwia picked a three-millimeter needle-sliver of soda-glass out of her thumb pulp with iris forceps and poured raw iodine straight into the cut. Zero flinch, zero hiss. "Municipal linesman came down the manhole at dawn to clear fault alarms before German post-engineers traced the bridge back here. Said the cast-iron sewer cover at Świętojerska corner was red-hot enough to fry spit, and water running down the storm main toward the Vistula was forty degrees warm and full of dead people boiled in cellars."

Sylwia pressed sterile gauze tight over Halina's thumb and wrapped adhesive tape twice round it, keeping hold of the younger woman's icy hand between both her own raw palms when she finished.

"Brushmakers' block had deep brick vaults connecting into the main four-foot storm collector toward Bonifraterska and Długa," Sylwia said steadily, refusing past tense until someone showed her Dawid Różański's

body on zinc. "If twenty boys in Dawid's courtyard bought Belgian pistols and petrol jelly in February, they didn't sit upstairs waiting for roofs to fall—they went down into the bunkers and sewers when the walls caught."

Halina's dark eyes—huge, sunken black coals below that ridiculous strip of brassy yellow peroxide hair—lifted straight to Sylwia's face. Not a drop of moisture swam in them; everything wet in Halina seemed burned dry down to white salt.

"Give me that bottle behind the agar tins," Halina said.

Sylwia reached behind the horse-meat agar canisters, pulled out the quarter-full liter bottle of ninety-five-percent laboratory absolute ethanol Halina used for Gram decolorizing, poured two fingers into two clean fifty-milliliter Pyrex beakers, diluted both splash-for-splash with distilled water so it wouldn't strip pharyngeal mucosa raw, and handed one over.

They drank standing against the slate microscope bench while eight thousand typhus lice rustled dryly inside dark thirty-degree wooden drawers two yards left.

Halina set her empty Pyrex beaker down with a sharp click that nearly cracked the rim. "Two sewer workers from the municipal water board—Poles who took gold twenty-dollar pieces in January to map the storm-main grates under Krasiński Gardens and Długa—came to my landlady's cousin on Tamka at midnight last night. They want ten thousand złoty more by Monday before they lift a single manhole iron outside the wall, because Stroop's pioneers started dropping smoke grenades and gas candles down the inspection shafts yesterday."

"Have you got ten thousand?" Sylwia asked immediately.

"I have four thousand two hundred sewed inside my mattress hem and my mother's gold wedding ring worth two thousand on Marszałkowska," Halina said starkly. "Which leaves three thousand eight hundred short before Monday night—and if anyone *does* crawl out under Długa or Bonifraterska next week, half of them will have third-degree benzine and phosphorus burns, smoke-blinded corneas, and sewer-rat Weil's disease with nowhere to lie except coffins."

Sylwia didn't hesitate half a second. Upstairs in Koszykowa's hollowed soap-bar sat nine hundred złoty left from winter; Stefan Bielski owed eighteen hundred for Easter insulin come tomorrow afternoon; and locked inside Docent Mirecki's private emergency safe sat twelve gram vials of Swiss *Ciba* morphine tartrate worth four hundred złoty apiece

to any society physician on Mokotowska whose rich nervous patients couldn't sleep for the smoke!

"Keep your mother's ring in your mattress," Sylwia said coldly. "You'll have four thousand cash in your coat pocket Monday noon before the water-board shift changes. And starting tonight Bronka and I pack six sterile burn-and-eye kits inside zinc autopsy specimen drums in the mortuary annex—tannic acid jelly, silver nitrate one-percent drops, atropine eye ointment, anti-tetanus horse serum, twenty-gram sulfanilamide packets. Anyone your sewer men pull up alive after dark comes in the Nowogrodzka hearse wagon under coffins to our contagious morgue vestibule."

For the first time Halina's chin quivered one millimeter—fierce, ugly threat of human cracking she killed instantly by biting down hard on her own lip until blood showed red against pale teeth.

"If Kroll or Vesper catches one burned Jew from Muranów inside your contagious morgue, Kotarska," Halina whispered harshly, "they don't give you Pawiak—they shoot you right against the coal bin beside me."

"Then don't drop your pipette on the floor before Monday," Sylwia said tartly, rinsing both Pyrex beakers clean under the cold tap so not a trace of alcohol smell lingered on laboratory glass. "And dye your roots tonight with strong chamomile tea mixed into half-peroxide—somebody upstairs with good eyes remarked last month that Silesian bleach goes orange over agar steam."

Halina blinked once in sheer, stunned disbelief—realizing *which* German upstairs had noticed her hair roots for five weeks and walked out Monday morning without opening his mouth to Aleja Szucha—and let out a single short, barked laugh darker than pitch. "What a charming century we picked to learn medicine in, Sylwia."

* * *

On Holy Saturday afternoon the twenty-fourth of April, Wanda Bielska's dining-room table on Filtrowa gleamed snowy white under starched damask ironed twice with borax water, centered round a crystal bowl of hard-boiled eggs dyed russet-mahogany in boiled onion skins, scraped white horseradish root, green boxwood sprigs, a sugar lamb with a tiny

red paper resurrection banner, and two coils of real pale pork *biała kiełbasa* glistening with marjoram fat.

"Shut the balcony window, Stefan, for heaven's sake!" Wanda cried from the sideboard, dabbing furiously with a damp dishcloth at three greasy black soot-smudges that had drifted straight onto her lace runner while Stefan aired his cigar smoke. "Every ten minutes another filthy flake blows down from town—I've washed the kitchen sill thrice since breakfast! Why can't they put water hoses on it if buildings are burning?"

"Because nobody wastes municipal fire brigades inside a closed bandit perimeter, my dear," Stefan Bielski said reasonably, latching the brass casement handle tight against the copper-haze April sky and turning back toward the table rubbing soft pink hands. Today Stefan wore a new charcoal-grey suit cut from *Bezugsschein* textile coupons issued to senior *Ostbahn* and municipal tramway engineers. "Sit down, Sylwia, take three slices of white sausage before Staś eats the whole ring—real country garlic sausage from Łowicz, my foreman's brother-in-law brought two kilos in yesterday! Honestly, whatever one thinks privately as a Christian—and nobody pities misled women and children more than I do—launching armed anarchy with machine-guns inside the middle of a crowded city during Holy Week is sheer criminal madness. All it accomplishes is ruining everybody's Easter air and provoking tighter police curfews on hardworking Poles."

Sylwia stood behind Staś's chair with both hands resting lightly on the boy's narrow flannel shoulders.

Two hours ago she had finished packing six zinc autopsy drums in Pavilion Three's dead-house with tannic burn-jelly and silver-nitrate eye drops for people crawling blind through four feet of human excrement beneath Bonifraterska; on her walk down Chałubińskiego ten minutes ago a warm gray flake of charred feather-mattress had landed right in her hair, smelling of roasted lard and lime. Looking down at two coils of pale garlic pork sausage nested in green Easter boxwood while Stefan Bielski mourned his window-lace made something cold and bright snap clean behind her eyes.

"Eighteen hundred złoty turned into three thousand eight hundred this morning, Stefan," Sylwia said pleasantly, not sitting down and not touching her plate.

Stefan paused with his carving fork poised half an inch above the sausage skin. "Excuse me?"

"Staś's May insulin," Sylwia lied with crystalline, glacial calm, looking straight across the sugar resurrection lamb into her brother-in-law's plump face. "Danish refrigerator wagons got held up behind troop-trains from Lemberg—probably carrying flamethrower oil for that 'sanitary nuisance' spoiling Wanda's lace curtains. Railway pharmacists raised forty-unit Novo vials to nineteen hundred apiece cash before Monday noon. Two vials makes thirty-eight hundred. Plus eight hundred left from March if you want June covered before summer heat spoils unrefrigerated stock. Four thousand six hundred total."

Wanda gasped audibly, clutching her dishcloth to her bosom. "Four thousand six—Sylwia, have railway people no fear of God on Holy Saturday?! Extorting four thousand złoty out of a sick child's veins!"

Stefan flushed dull brick-red from collar to ears—not stupid enough for five seconds to believe insulin had jumped two hundred percent since Palm Sunday, yet trapped dead flat in front of his wife and diabetic nine-year-old son! Question Sylwia's black-market price aloud, ask for receipts, refuse to pay—and watch nine-year-old Staś stare up with huge dark eyes wondering why Papa bought Łowicz garlic sausages and new charcoal wool suits while begrudging insulin money; pay up, and watch four thousand *Volksliste* złoty walk straight out his front door into whatever dark Polish gutter Sylwia chose to pour it down!

"Outrageous profiteering," Stefan choked out through tight teeth, yanking his fat calfskin wallet out of his breast pocket so jerkily two ration coupons fluttered onto the carpet. "Bandits at every railway siding—no wonder order takes an iron hand in this country!"

One, two, three, four—forty crisp hundred-złoty Bank Emisyjny notes slapped onto the corner of the damask cloth two inches from the horseradish dish, plus six fifties and three twenties until four thousand six hundred sat stacked neat.

Sylwia picked up the stack bare-handed, counted it deliberately leaf by leaf right in front of Stefan's bulging eyes—letting eight hundred reserve go toward actual May insulin from Mekelburg's cheap *Sanitätspark* clerk and clearing *three thousand eight hundred exact* for Halina's sewer workers Monday morning!—and slipped the roll into her worn black handbag with a crisp brass snap.

"Enjoy your sausage, Stefan," Sylwia said mildly. "Chew the gristle well—we lost a Volksdeutscher miller on Ward A last Tuesday when pork fat impacted above a pyloric spasm, and nobody likes having a rubber stomach-tube shoved down his nose on Easter Sunday."

"Sylwia, you aren't leaving without touching an egg!" Wanda wailed, tears springing instantly into round china-blue eyes. "On Holy Saturday! Mother in heaven—you come in smelling of ether like an executioner, empty Stefan's pockets, insult our table, and walk out without sharing *jajko*!"

Sylwia took one quarter-wedge of brown onion-dyed boiled egg off the saucer edge, touched half to Staś's solemn outstretched piece—*"Health and quiet nights, Stasiu"*—ate her sliver standing up in two chews so hospital protein wasn't wasted, kissed the top of Wanda's powdered cheek once out of sheer pity for soft creatures born without armor, and turned to the hall.

Staś slipped down off his chair without asking permission and ran into the dark vestibule to unbolt the heavy front door for her before Stefan could follow.

Out on the cold stone stair-landing, with the front door pulled almost shut behind his skinny shoulder-blades, the nine-year-old boy looked up at her with huge, sleepless eyes that missed nothing—neither green *Kennkarte* shame nor hospital lies.

"Ciocia," he whispered so low Wanda inside couldn't hear. "At recess behind the courtyard pump yesterday, Janek the janitor's boy said the black snow falling on the roofs isn't coal soot—it's people burning alive behind the wall on Nalewki. Papa told Mama Janek's father listens to London lies."

Every tidy maternal lie ever invented for nine-year-olds rose to Sylwia's tongue and died before passing her teeth. Lie to this child today while he smelled the grease himself through cracked stair-putty, and by fifteen he either grew into Stefan Bielski or hated her for treating him like cattle.

She dropped to one knee on the stone landing so her dark eyes sat level with his thin face, buttoning the top horn button of his grey cardigan under his chin with gentle, mercury-scarred fingers.

"Janek's father isn't lying, Stasiu," Sylwia said very quietly. "Men and women behind that wall chose to die fighting with pistols in their hands

rather than get onto cattle trains, and the Germans are burning the houses down over them because they're afraid to walk up the stairs. Don't repeat that at school, and don't argue with your father at supper—your job this year is to measure your Benedict's tubes straight, eat every spoonful of buckwheat, and grow tall enough to outlive them. Understand?"

Staś looked straight back at her for three solemn seconds, chin firming into Kazimierz Kotarski's narrow Poznań jaw, and nodded once without crying.

When Sylwia stepped out onto Filtrowa pavement five minutes later—three thousand eight hundred złoty of collaborator's blood-money warm inside her purse toward lifting manhole irons under Długa, and Ludwig Schoeler's green *Sonderausweis* waiting in her pocket for Tuesday at five o'clock—a single grey ash-flake drifted down out of the copper sky onto the back of her bare wrist, weightless as breath, and vanished when she closed her fist.

Chapter XII

Nur für Deutsche

Warsaw, 27 April – 4 May 1943

Two painted wooden sawhorses and fifty yards of barbed-wire concertina separated Marszałkowska mud from the swept granite flags of ulica Królewska, and crossing between them at ten minutes to five felt like walking out of a typhus ward straight onto the stage of a Viennese operetta performed by butchers.

Outside the barrier, women in cardboard-soled shoes queued three deep in blowing Muranów ash for four hundred grams of gluey clay bread; forty paces inside the barrier, beneath green-and-white striped canvas awnings opposite the colonnade of Saski Palace, two bareheaded Wehrmacht Signals auxiliaries in sheer rayon stockings sat laughing over tall glasses of real raspberry *Eisbecher* topped with whipped cream while a waiter in a white jacket swept fallen chestnut blossoms off the kerb with a twig broom.

Sylwia walked up to the sentry box wearing her best prewar charcoal-grey tailored suit—pressed at midnight under a damp towel with a flatiron heated on two handfuls of precious peat, skirt let in two inches at the waist since thirty-nine—carrying her scuffed black Gladstone bag in her left hand and her grey *Kennkarte* tucked inside Ludwig's green Wehrmacht *Sonderausweis* in her right.

The Bavarian *Schutzpolizei* corporal leaning against the striped barrier pole didn't bother lowering his cigarette until her shoe-tips stopped two feet from his boots. One lazy flick of small blue eyes took in the Polish cut of her collar, the absence of any Reich swastika pin or *Ostbahn* badge on her lapel, and the dark hair coiled severe under a plain black felt hat.

"Runter vom Bürgersteig," he grunted automatically around his cigarette butt, jerking his thumb toward the wet cobbles of the carriageway

reserved for delivery handcarts and Poles with work-gang passes. "Pavement's German."

Sylwia didn't step down an inch, and she didn't raise her voice—simply flipped open the stiff green *Wehrmachtkommandantur* card six inches under his nose so the violet eagle of *Abwehrstelle Warschau* and Stabsarzt Vesper's counter-stamp filled his vision.

"Ärztlicher Außendienst auf Befehl des Oberkommandos," she said in clipped Charlottenburg German cold enough to frost brass. "Królewska sechzehn, Wohnung vier. Call the duty officer inside Saski Palace gate if you have trouble spelling *Oberstleutnant*, *Herr Wachtmeister*."

Nothing cowed minor German policemen faster than pure Westend Berlin syntax delivered as if their boots were dusty. Out came the cigarette from between his teeth; heels came half-together before his brain caught the Polish surname *Kotarska* on line two, leaving him marooned halfway between a salute and a scowl as he waved her sullenly past the sawhorse along the clean granite sidewalk.

Number Sixteen Królewska had been built around nineteen-twelve for wealthy advocates and bank directors who wanted chestnuts outside their tall French windows and five minutes' walk to the Stock Exchange: cream limestone facade undamaged by thirty-nine's shells save for pock-marks round the cornice, wrought-iron vestibule gates polished black, brass plate beside the front bell reading *Quartieramt der Wehrmacht — Hausverwaltung*.

Remembering Ludwig's dry instruction in the splint room, Sylwia bypassed the marble front portico altogether, turning down the narrow vaulted carriage-passage into a quiet graveled rear courtyard where lilac bushes were just breaking purple bud despite the faint brown haze still staining the upper sky toward the north.

Service Stair B smelled not of cabbage-water and cat urine like Koszykowa—it smelled of turpentine floor-wax, real coal smoke, and roasting meat drifting out of somebody's second-floor kitchen vent.

On the second-floor back landing, beside a tall narrower pantry door painted cream over older mahogany, Sylwia raised her gloved hand to press the porcelain bell-button—and stopped with her knuckle half an inch from the china disk.

Right beside her eye on the painted wooden doorpost, tilted at the unmistakable thirty-degree inward slant no carpenter ever used for bell-

wires or nameplate screws, ran a faint four-inch oblong scar beneath one coat of German cream paint where an older brass or silver case had been wrenched off with a chisel blade, leaving two plugged nail-holes top and bottom.

Even painted over twice by *Quartieramt* painters in forty-one, wood remembered. Before the war, half the senior appellate barristers along Królewska had been assimilated Polish-Jewish jurists whose grandfathers wore silk top hats in eighteen-eighty and still nailed a tiny silver *mezuzah* to the back service doorpost for old mothers from Kazimierz.

Before she touched the bell, the pantry door clicked open from inside.

Bruno Mekelburg stood there in clean shirtsleeves and grey uniform braces, polishing a black riding boot with a horsehair brush held deftly in his good right hand while the boot-tree sat wedged between his knees. His scarred three-fingered left stump looked pink, tough, and entirely uninflamed.

"Afternoon, *Frau Doktor*," Mekelburg said low, stepping wide to let her into a tiled butler's pantry lined with glass-fronted oak china cupboards. No military policemen here; quiet apartment thick-walled enough to muffle cannon three miles off down to distant summer thunder. Before hanging her charcoal jacket on the pantry peg, the boy reached behind two stacked soup tureens, pulled out a small square parcel wrapped in brown Wehrmacht ration-butcher paper tied with hemp string, and slid it straight down into her open Gladstone bag alongside her stethoscope without rattling a bottle. "Three vials. Forty-unit Novo, good till March forty-four. Twenty Reichsmarks—forty złoty official, wait, zero złoty to you: my skat clerk took one small bottle of hospital spirit Bronka gave me last month and called us square."

Three ten-milliliter vials of forty-unit Danish insulin—seventy-five days of nine-year-old Staś Bielski's life, worth nearly six thousand złoty at Holy Saturday railway extortion prices—tucked into her bag for half a pint of stolen rectified alcohol!

Sylwia looked sharply into Mekelburg's turnip-blond country face, checking whether Ludwig stood behind that skat story.

"Did your *Oberstleutnant* pay twenty Reichsmarks for those?" she asked straight out.

"Didn't tell him," Mekelburg muttered stolidly, going back to buffing toe-leather until it shone like black glass. "What officers don't sign for,

officers don't answer for. He's down the hall in the corner study—second door left."

Down a wide parquet corridor stripped of carpets—pale oblongs on oak herringbones showing where Persian runners had lain for twenty years before some *Quartieramt* wife rolled them up for Munich—every piece of remaining heavy furniture bore a tiny white pasted paper square under its rim stamped in purple ink: *Wehrmacht-Unterkunftverwaltung Warschau — Inv. Nr. 4412.*

Inside the corner study, tall double casements stood latched against spring ash, looking sideways into the green tops of Saski Garden's horse-chestnuts. Books still lined two walls ceiling-high behind leaded glass —not German military manuals, rows of gilt-stamped *Orzecznictwo Sądu Najwyższego* (Decisions of the Polish Supreme Court), French civil codes, leather-bound Mickiewicz and Heine—because nobody bothered carting Polish law books to Berlin when requisitioning a warm flat for staff colonels.

And curling up off a small silver tray set on the Biedermeier side-table came a smell so shockingly rich, roasted, bitter-sweet, and extinct that Sylwia's parotid glands contracted with actual sharp pain beneath both ears before her brain named it.

Real coffee.

Not burnt barley, not bitter chicory-and-sugar-beet *plujka*, not roasted acorns: genuine dark oil-roasted Santos or Guatemala beans ground ten minutes ago in a brass hand-mill, steaming black inside two eggshell-thin Rosenthal cups with two white cubes of real beet sugar sitting on each saucer.

Ludwig stood beside the tall porcelain corner stove in white linen shirtsleeves and uniform trousers without tunic, reading a typed blue flimsy held in his left hand—actually holding paper steady between left thumb and index finger now without tremor—while his right leaned casually on the warm tiles. Eight days outside hospital walls had browned his gaunt cheekbones slightly in spring wind; without ward calico round him, standing tall among stolen Polish law books with real coffee steaming at his elbow, he belonged suddenly and intolerably to the winning side of the barbed wire outside.

"Five minutes early," Ludwig observed, tossing the blue flimsy into an iron wire basket containing cold grey paper-ash—he burned notes right

at his elbow as he read them—and nodding toward the silver tray. "Drink it while it's hot. Came off a Lisbon courier bag via Madrid last week; even Vesper hasn't smelled beans like that since forty."

Sylwia set her Gladstone bag down on a straight wooden chair—not the leather armchair—walked two steps to the glass-fronted bookcase beside the tray, and tilted her head slightly to read the small engraved bookplate visible inside an open volume of *Prawo Cywilne* lying face-up on the blotter corner:

Ex Libris Dr. jur. Maurycy Silberstein, Sędzia Sądu Apelacyjnego w Warszawie.

Maurycy Silberstein. Sylwia remembered her father speaking that name across dinner linen in twenty-six with dry grudging respect: sharpest commercial-treaty jurist in Warsaw, seventy years old by forty-two if typhus or Treblinka cattle-cars hadn't finished him eight months ago, leaving behind three thousand law volumes, two plugged nail-holes on his pantry doorpost, and thin Rosenthal porcelain for Wehrmacht officers to pour Lisbon courier coffee into while Muranów burned three kilometers north.

Without saying a single word, Sylwia picked up the thin porcelain cup poured for her—hot black fragrance rising dizzying straight into four years of caffeine-starved brain vessels—carried it six paces back across the parquet to the open pantry sink-alcove visible from the study threshold, tipped the cup upside down into the brass drain-hole while Mekelburg blinked over his boot-brush, rinsed the brown stain down with two splashes of cold tap water, and walked back into the study to set the empty white cup neatly onto its saucer.

Ludwig hadn't moved an inch beside the porcelain stove.

His winter-green eyes tracked the empty cup down onto china, then lifted straight to her face—zero flush, zero bluster, zero cheap German defensive excuse (*"If I hadn't moved in here some SS captain would have"*—Stefan Bielski's line!). Instead his mouth tightened by one hard millimeter at the corner, taking the slap clean across the jaw in dead silence.

"Take your shirt off and sit under the window light," Sylwia said coldly in German, unstrapping her leather bag. "Twenty minutes—that's what your green pass buys."

He unbuttoned his white linen shirt from throat to belt without haste, pulled the left arm free last, and sat sideways on the straight wooden

chair facing the tall French window rather than Silberstein's deep leather armchair.

Green-gold reflection off Saski Garden's young chestnut leaves washed sideways across bare bone and muscle. Ten days since she had broken his shoulder adhesions raw in the splint room. Every trace of open raw granulation trough had finally epithelialized shut save one dry pinhead scab at the medial end: in its place stretched a dense, contracted, glossy purple-crimson keloid star five centimeters wide, fused deep to pectoralis fascia over the two-centimeter gap in his collarbone, pulsing faintly at its lower border with every beat of her five-zero silk artery repair buried half an inch beneath.

Sylwia did not put on gloves, and she did not warm her fingers at the stove first.

Standing at his left shoulder, smelling turpentine floor-wax, faint roast coffee she had refused to drink, and clean warm skin without hospital iodoform for the first time since February, she pressed two cool thumbs firmly into the thick purple scar-cord to test deep gliding mobility over the subclavius bed.

Beneath her cold thumbs his pectoral muscle twitched once—involuntary skin-reflex—and went rock-still.

"No deep tenderness over the vessel?" she asked, sliding firm cross-fiber friction strokes across the keloid border with a dab of plain lanolin out of her jar so tight new collagen wouldn't strangle the lateral pectoral nerve twigs.

"Only when cold wind hits it off the river," Ludwig said quietly, staring straight ahead at glass rather than up at her chin while her thumbs worked slow deep circles half an inch below his bare collarbone. "Tingling down thumb and index finger mornings for ten minutes until I hang from a door-lintel—lateral cord traction in scar tissue. Clears once blood warms it."

"Door-lintel hanging's idiotic before week twelve—stretch against a wall corner with elbow bent ninety degrees, or you'll tear what I sewed." She lifted his left wrist to test radial pulse under maximal overhead abduction—raising his bare arm high until pectoralis stretched drum-tight beneath her fingers, checking whether scar compression pinched the repaired axillary trunk when overhead (*Adson-type positional occlusion*).

Radial pulse stayed full, strong, seventy-two beats per minute without diminishing a hair.

Scientifically, medically, honestly, she could sign him completely cured today and never walk up Judge Silberstein's stairs again.

As she lowered his arm slowly back toward his knee, Ludwig spoke into the quiet room without turning his head.

"On Saturday the seventeenth of April at eleven-forty, Reinhart Kroll's *Referat IV N* surveillance log booked an urgent street-check on *Elektoralna fourteen, courtyard right*."

Sylwia's fingers stayed resting lightly round his bare left wrist for two frozen heartbeats before letting go cleanly.

"Nothing was found in the bombed glazier's shed," Ludwig continued in that same quiet, level tone while reaching for his white shirt. "Whereupon Kroll annoyedly docked two hundred Swiss francs off Friday's Danzig courier disbursement to source *Uhrzeiger*—code-entered on Szucha's Polish desk as *Zegar*—for passing unverified hospital gossip."

Even knowing it already from Pelagia's lace curtain, hearing the cold archival confirmation out of Aleja Szucha's own books landed like iron dropping down a shaft.

"How did you get inside Kroll's disbursement log?" she asked softly.

"One of Kroll's Baltic-German typists on Szucha has a brother serving in a penal sapper company outside Velikiye Luki whose transfer papers cross *Abwehr* East desks once a quarter," Ludwig said dryly, slipping his arms back into white linen without buttoning the front yet, turning on the wooden chair so he looked straight up at her standing two feet away between him and the window. "Who did you feed *Elektoralna fourteen* to on Thursday the fifteenth, Sylwia?"

Every instinct drilled into underground cells screamed *never name a Polish operative to a German uniform under torture, let alone standing upright in daylight!* And Ludwig didn't wait for a name—raising two fingers half an inch to stop her before her lips even parted.

"Don't tell me his name," he said sharply. "I don't want his name in my head. Just listen carefully to the mechanics before you get yourself killed out of loyalty to rotten wood. Whoever you handed *Chłodna twenty-two* and *Elektoralna fourteen* to sits inside twenty-four hours of Kroll's wire—either directly taking Swiss francs himself, or handing every scrap straight to a superior who does. Cut him off abruptly tomorrow without

excuse, and if *he* is *Zegar*, he realizes instantly why you went dry and hands your *Koszykowa* address to Kroll inside twelve hours to scrub the witness before your own underground court-martial catches him."

Sylwia's eyes narrowed cold on his face. *Your Koszykowa address.* "When did you look up my home street?"

"Ten February at noon, when Hauptmann von Berg ran security checks on every pair of Polish hands allowed inside Room Fourteen," Ludwig answered without a flicker of apology. "Koszykowa thirty-three, fourth floor rear, partitioned library. Which means if my clerk found it inside six hours on municipal medical rosters, Kroll's dogs find it in ten minutes once somebody points. Keep meeting your handler once a fortnight when summoned, feed him harmless Stabsarzt Vesper gossip—cognac crates, hospital coal thefts, routine troop-train frostbite numbers—and zero names, zero hours, zero streets."

Silence hummed inside Judge Silberstein's study. Outside in Saski Garden a blackbird whistled liquid gold notes in a chestnut tree while half a league north another heavy demolition charge—*crump*—shook window putty faint under Sylwia's fingertips.

"Why?" Sylwia asked flatly, looking down at him sitting bare-chested under unbuttoned linen with her purple scar-star gleaming between collarbones. "Our ledger sat even at St. Charles Borromeo on Chłodna twelve days ago. You got your pelure warning out to London's circle; I got an eighteen-year-old boy out of a bath-closet and three warnings out of your mouth. Why drag me across barbed wire twice a week on a forged medical excuse to coach me how not to get shot by Aleja Szucha?"

Ludwig looked up at her for five long seconds without speaking.

In afternoon chestnut-shadow his face had none of the boyish swagger from Wannsee and none of the fever-vulnerability from Lindleya—just thirty-four years of hard bone, sleepless intelligence, and an honesty uglier than any compliment because it stripped away the last rag of noble pretense between them.

"Because Tirpitzufer is losing its footing in Berlin week by week since Oster's people stumbled," Ludwig said very quietly—meaning nothing specific to her yet on *Oster*, everything on tone—"and inside six months either Kroll's black-coats swallow Saski Square whole, or Warsaw blows sky-high under everybody's boots. Until one of those happens, you are the single human being within four hundred miles who doesn't lie to

me like a subordinate or lick boots like Stefan Bielski's tramway clerks —and if Reinhart Kroll hangs you off a balcony on Koszykowa because some fool in a trenchcoat sold you for two hundred Swiss francs, I'll do something stupid enough on Aleja Szucha to get shot before autumn."

Sylwia's breath caught—not soft, sharp as swallowing a needle whole —at hearing *Stefan Bielski's* name and *if Kroll hangs you I'll do something stupid* spoken in the exact dry, furious voice in which at twenty-one he had said *Want me to break Kleist's collarbone tomorrow?*

"Leave my sister's husband out of your files," she whispered fiercely, snatching her lanolin jar off the side-table and dropping it clattering into her leather bag.

"Tell your sister's husband to stop drinking beer at the *Deutsches Haus* annex with Direktor Krehl's bookkeeper, then, and his name won't cross counter-sabotage tramway summaries," Ludwig replied coolly, buttoning his white shirt right-handed from bottom to collar without standing up to block her exit. "Friday at five, *Frau Doktor*. Next time I won't insult your politics with coffee—we have boiled tap water in the pantry."

* * *

By the fourth of May—her third visit across the Królewska sawhorses —the giant black smoke-column over Muranów had thinned to a low, ragged grey pall smelling more of pulverized brick, carbolic lime, and blown-out sewer gas than fresh burning timber, though sporadic pistol cracks still echoed stubbornly after dark out of deep cellar bunkers six feet below glowing rubble.

Something far worse than hostility began settling into those twenty-five minutes every Tuesday and Friday between five and five-twenty-five inside *Wohnung 4*: familiarity.

Not peace—peace never survived ten sentences between them—a taut, silent bodily truce inside four high-ceilinged rooms where nobody else entered once Mekelburg vanished down to polish staff-car fenders in the courtyard.

On Tuesday the fourth of May a sudden violet cloudburst swept off the Vistula at four-fifty, drenching Sylwia from knees to shoulders in warm sheet-rain during the last hundred yards down Królewska after lightning struck a tram-wire on Marszałkowska. When Mekelburg let her up the

pantry stair, water ran in dark streams off her felt hat-brim onto waxed tiles.

Before entering the study, while peeling off her sodden charcoal jacket in the unlit pantry passage, Sylwia's eyes snagged on something low along the unpainted inside edge of the kitchen pantry doorframe—missed last week because the door had stood open against the cupboards.

Five horizontal pencil marks notched into varnished pine between three feet and four feet eight inches off the floor, dated in tiny neat script beside a child's name:

Róża — VI.1935 Róża — VI.1936 Róża — VI.1937 Róża — VI.1938 Róża — VI.1939

No *VI.1940*. Judge Silberstein's granddaughter, nine or ten years old when the pencil stopped—Staś's exact age right now on Filtrowa.

Sylwia stood motionless in her wet white cotton blouse—thin prewar batiste clinging damp to her shoulder blades and black brassiere straps—with one fingertip resting feather-light on *VI.1939* without touching graphite hard enough to smudge it.

Behind her on dry parquet, shod in the soft indoor leather slippers he wore when pacing over maps, Ludwig stopped in the pantry doorway carrying a dry folded hand-towel he had fetched without being asked when he heard rain hammering the courtyard zinc.

He saw where her finger rested on the doorframe.

Neither of them spoke. Not *terrible times*, not *they weren't here when I took the billet*—quartermaster inventories told dates plain enough: two Wehrmacht transport colonels had occupied *Wohnung 4* between forty-one and this January before Ludwig ever unpacked a razor here, and neither dead transport colonels nor grammar changed where little Róża Silberstein's shoes ended up in forty-two.

Noticeably, however, nobody in two years had painted over the inside edge of the pantry frame, and when Mekelburg scrubbed woodwork every Saturday with soda-water, the boy scrubbed *around* those five pencil lines down to an eighth of an inch.

Ludwig held out the dry linen towel without stepping across the pantry sill.

Sylwia took her finger off *1939*, accepted the rough towel without brushing his hand, dried her rain-wet throat, face, and coiled dark hair—

pins loosening until one damp black strand fell curling past her collarbone —and walked past him into the study.

Because rain drowned daylight dark green through the chestnut trees outside, Ludwig hadn't turned on the chandelier—only the green-shaded brass banker's lamp on Silberstein's desk, throwing the exact submerged emerald-and-amber aquarium glow across books and leather sofa that had burned above Slate Table Nineteen and Room Fourteen's night-table.

"Lie flat on the sofa today so I can stretch the posterior axillary fold past horizontal without your spine arching," Sylwia said, voice slightly husky from rain-chill, kneeling on one knee beside the long dark-green leather sofa rather than pulling over chairs.

Ludwig lay back flat in unbuttoned shirt-fronts pushed wide off his left chest, head resting directly on cool green leather without bolster, letting her take his left wrist and elbow from behind his crown.

Ten minutes of slow passive stretching—pushing scarred pectoralis major and latissimus fibers millimeter by millimeter into full overhead extension while her bare right hand pressed steady counter-weight down across his warm lower ribs to keep his thoracic cage flat against the leather.

Rain drummed thick and hypnotic against tall glass six feet away. Beneath her right palm his ribs rose and fell slow, deep, eight seconds to a cycle; thin damp batiste of her rain-wet blouse cooled rapidly against her own breasts until nipples tightened hard and treacherous against worn cotton—and when she leaned forward over his shoulder to test internal rotation behind his scapula, her fallen dark damp curl brushed bare across his chin and throat.

Ludwig's eyes stayed wide open two inches beneath her collarbone, grey-green gone nearly black in green banker's-lamp shadow.

He didn't grab her wrist today, and he didn't make a single Berlin crack. Only his right hand—lying loose along the outer edge of the leather cushion two inches from her bent knee on the parquet—closed slowly into a tight, silent fist against smooth calfskin until the leather creaked faintly under his knuckles, waiting out the last sixty seconds of her twenty-minute clock without touching her by a hair.

When Sylwia stood up abruptly at five-twenty-two, blood drumming hot and furious in her ears at nothing that had even happened, her damp blouse had picked up dry warmth off the air six inches above his chest.

"Once a week is ample from mid-May," she said too fast toward her open bag, snapping steel latches shut without looking round. "Your range is ninety-five percent normal and the nerve-tingling's dropping."

From the sofa behind her, buttoning linen slow in green shadow, came his quiet voice:

"Keep Tuesdays *and* Fridays on the card, *Kotarska.* May's going to get uglier before June, and Stabsarzt Vesper never reads range percentages past page one."

She grabbed her half-dry charcoal jacket off the pantry hook and went fast down the waxed service stairs into warm spring rain without touching the doorframe on her way out, breathing deep gulps of wet lilac air in the courtyard before putting her mask back on for Marszałkowska.

Chapter XIII

Under Bonifraterska

Warsaw, 10–12 May 1943

Two nights after German sappers pumped gas into the command bunker under Miła Eighteen, the municipal sewer inspector knocked on Halina's attic window on Tamka at nine-fifteen and took her four thousand złoty without counting the fifties.

By eleven-forty Sylwia was lying flat on her stomach alongside Halina inside the tarred plank false-bottom of a two-horse municipal sanitary dray creaking north up Marszałkowska under full curfew *Nachtfahrt* lantern permits. Six inches above the backs of their necks lay twelve heavy empty pine hospital coffins being hauled nominally from *Dzieciątka Jezus* to the Powązki municipal carpenter's yard for zinc-lining repairs; through cracks between the planks smelled chloride of lime, horse sweat, and sweetish warm May night air tainted thick as grease with smoke blowing off the dying fires of Nalewki.

Nobody spoke inside the nineteen-inch crawl space. Every time iron-rimmed wheels bounced across tram-switches at Królewska—two hundred yards west of Judge Silberstein's dark windows where Ludwig Schoeler was doubtless sleeping or burning blue flimsies—Sylwia's shoulder bumped Halina's rigid arm, and Halina's teeth clicked once together in the pitch dark without a breath escaping.

Past Senatorska the driver turned east off Theatre Square into a narrow cobbled service cul-de-sac behind a bombed-out printing works off **ulica Długa**, four hundred meters south of the Bonifraterska wall where orange searchlight beams and Magnesium parachute flares still hung white and theatrical every three minutes above blackened brick chimneys.

Wood scraped iron; coffins slid six inches rearward as the drayman unlatched the tailboard.

"Eight minutes," whispered a hoarse voice stinking of raw spirit and sewer methane—Kazik, the fifty-year-old water-board ganger, already prying up the round cast-iron inspection cover tucked inside the ruined printer's archway with a greased crowbar so iron didn't ring on stone. "Ukrainian patrol walks past the outer corner every quarter-hour. Two of my boys went down with ropes twenty minutes ago to guide them south from the storm-junction under Krasiński. Only four made it past the iron weir—Stroop's engineers rigged hand-grenades on tripwires across the main four-foot brick collector at noon."

Up came the hundred-pound iron lid onto folded burlap sacks; out of the black twenty-four-inch hole in the cobbles belched a hot, suffocating wave of fermented human excrement, illuminating-gas condensate, dead rat, and bitter almond-chlorine residue from German tear-gas candles dropped up-line that afternoon.

Sylwia didn't gag—four winters of ruptured gangrenous appendices cured gagging—tying a vinegar-soaked gauze pad tight over her nose and mouth, strapping her flat canvas burn-pouch crosswise over her chest, and swinging rubber-booted legs straight down the slimy iron wall-rungs ahead of Halina because Halina weighed forty-eight kilos and couldn't haul drowned deadweight vertical up iron rungs alone.

Ten feet down, her boots hit two feet of rushing black sludge moving swift toward the Vistula outfall.

Down inside the four-foot ovoid brick vault, sound behaved insanely: street patrols twenty feet above vanished altogether, replaced by hollow roaring water-echoes, dripping lime stalactites grazing her kerchiefed hair when she bent double, and—forty yards north up the pitch-black tunnel—faint rhythmic splashing coupled with torn, whistling human breaths that sounded like broken bellows pumped under water.

One tiny shielded bicycle-dynamo red lens blinked twice out of darkness. Two water-board men in thigh-waders materialized bent nearly horizontal under the low brick crown, dragging between them three figures who could no longer walk upright because forty-eight hours crouching knee-deep in pitch-black freezing sewage without food or drinking water locked quadriceps and hamstring tendons into stone cramps. Behind them stumbled a fourth—taller, bony, bareheaded, sup-

porting a tiny girl no bigger than twelve-year-old bone structure hooked over his burned left shoulder while feeling along slimy brick with an empty oxidized Belgian Browning pistol welded shut into his right fist by dried blood and rust!

Halina shoved past Sylwia's hip in two feet of rushing filth, biting clean through her vinegar gauze mask so not one echo carried up the iron shaft as her hands hit the tall boy's wet, soot-blackened face.

"*Dawid—*"

Barely a breath—soundless tear of air—as the twenty-four-year-old boy flinched violently backward against brick at human touch before recognizing his sister's voice through sewer roar.

Up close under Sylwia's hooded red surgical pencil-torch, Dawid Różański looked eighty years old: eyebrows and front hair singed clean off down to blistered scalp, right eye swollen half-shut around soot-bleeding conjunctiva, left cornea milky opaque white where burning white-phosphorus or lime splatter had seared epithelium two days ago on Świętojerska, shirt burned completely off his left scapular blade leaving raw charred dermis weeping yellow plasma mixed with black sewer water.

"Take Rachela first," Dawid croaked—voice burned down to raw vocal-cord whisper from inhaling superheated bunker smoke, shoving the tiny girl off his raw shoulder straight into Sylwia's arms before letting Halina touch him. "Swallowed smoke when they blew the ventilation pipe at Franciszkańska—she's drowning sitting up—"

Sylwia caught the girl—sixteen, maybe seventeen, weighing less than Staś's bicycle, wet wool dress hanging heavy with forty pounds of sewage—and heard without a stethoscope the coarse bubbling pink foam boiling straight up out of trachea and nostrils with every agonized gasping heave: acute phosgene-or-smoke pulmonary edema flooding both lungs solid!

"Up the rungs—fast!" Sylwia hissed, hoisting the girl upward under wet armpits while Kazik leaned down through the manhole collar above to grab wrists and drag her clear into the dark courtyard archway, followed inside ninety seconds by two silent boys from Hashomer Hatzair with shrapnel-chewed calves and last of all Dawid himself—having his cramped legs pushed rung by rung from beneath by Sylwia's shoulder while Halina pulled desperately from above until all four lay hidden flat inside the false plank coffin-bed!

Down went the cast-iron manhole cover onto greased burlap without a clink; twelve empty pine coffins slid booming back over the trapdoor; whip cracked once over the horses' rumps as Ukrainian *Trawniki* auxiliary boots clicked loud round Długa corner eighty yards east!

Inside the pitch-black nineteen-inch crawl space rolling south down Marszałkowska toward Lindleya, packed six human bodies abreast stinking of excrement and burnt flesh so close ribs ground against ribs, sixteen-year-old Rachela died against Sylwia's collarbone before the dray passed Saski Garden.

Nothing heroic or clean happened in nineteen inches of dark plank: Sylwia tried clearing pink froth out of the girl's throat with two bare fingers hooked behind the tongue base, injected half a milligram of atropine and two milliliters of camphor-in-oil straight through wet dress cloth into pectoral muscle by blind touch, even tried turning her prone so fluid drained downward—and at Królewska corner (fifty yards from chestnut trees and white café awnings!) the small wet ribcage gave two convulsive shudders against Sylwia's breast, blew warm bloody foam across Sylwia's neck, and stopped moving forever.

Beside Sylwia in the dark, Dawid felt the stillness through his sister's arm without asking. Nobody wept; cry aloud inside a sanitary cart passing Marszałkowska night gendarmes and six more people died before Towarowa. Only Halina's freezing fingers locked around Sylwia's wrist for ten crushing seconds in pitch blackness, and let go when the wheels turned hollow through *Dzieciątka Jezus*'s back mortuary lane.

* * *

From two a.m. until quarter past five in the brick contagious-dead-house annex behind Pavilion One—windowless, freezing cold, protected by four genuine typhus corpses lying tagged in open pine boxes along the outer vestibule slab so even night porters crossed themselves and stayed twenty yards clear—Sylwia, Bronka, and Halina worked without pause under two hooded paraffin surgery lamps.

Sixteen-year-old Rachela needed no forged papers now: Bronka washed sewer filth gently off the thin child-face with warm water, wrapped her in a clean hospital shroud under yesterday's unclaimed female typhus charity-ward slip (*NN — femina circa 18, ex via Krochmalna*),

and nailed the pine lid down herself with muffled hammer-strokes padded through folded felt so tomorrow's municipal burial lorry carried her uninspected to Bródno pit with a priest's Latin instead of Gestapo photographs.

The two Hashomer boys had clean shrapnel leg wounds without major bone smash; dressed, fed hot sweet barley broth with forty drops of rectified spirit, injected with three thousand units each of horse tetanus antitoxin, and buttoned into dirty municipal coal-heaver overalls Bronka kept ready, they went out at four-forty in a baker's flour wagon toward a railway safe-house at Włochy before first light.

Dawid could not travel twenty yards without dying of burn shock or septicemia.

Thirty percent body-surface second- and patchy third-degree flame-and-phosphorus burns stretched from left trapezius across scapula down to tenth rib, crusted black with sewer silt and brick dust. Give general ether to a smoke-damaged lung and pneumonia killed him inside thirty-six hours; clean thirty percent raw burns soaked in human sewage *without* anesthesia killed by neurogenic shock.

Sylwia gave twenty milligrams intravenous morphine slow into his right forearm vein, waited eight minutes until his single seeing right pupil contracted down to a black pinhead and his breathing slowed to fourteen deep draws, then spent ninety merciless minutes with sterile forceps, warm physiological saline, and neutral soap lifting every single black shred of blistered epidermis and sewer-contaminated slough off living dermis before painting the entire raw crimson back black-violet with five-percent silver nitrate and warm sterile tannic-acid jelly to seal weeping plasma loss under dry coagulum.

Halina held his forehead steady on folded towels across her own knees the whole ninety minutes without dropping one tear onto sterile linen, murmuring low Polish nursery nonsense from Warsaw Nalewki courtyard rhymes into his blistered ear whenever forceps hit unburned nerve edge.

Last came the left eye.

Under magnifying loupe with lid-retractors gently separating swollen palpebral fissures after four drops of precious cocaine-hydrochloride surface solution salvaged out of Mirecki's prewar ophthalmic box, Sylwia irrigated three tiny embedded white-phosphorus ash specks out of the

inferior conjunctival fornix before they burned deeper through sclera. Central cornea over the pupil was cooked dense porcelain-white—permanent leukoma; he would never read print through that left eye again unless somebody thirty years hence grafted donor cornea—yet the globe hadn't perforated, zero hypopyon pus sat in the anterior chamber, and a crescent of clear peripheral iris survived temporally enough to catch light and shadow if infection stayed out! Atropine sulfate one-percent ointment in, sterile petrolatum eye-pad taped smooth.

At five-fifteen they slid Dawid—sleeping deep under morphine on dry rubberized ticking—into the brick recessed cooling-alcove behind the towering stoneware formaldehyde carboys, screened off by stacked coffin-lids painted red with *FLECKFIEBER — NICHT BERÜHREN!* Until seventy-two-hour burn plasma shift stabilized and Bronka's brother-in-law brought a turf-cutter's wagon from Konstancin woods on Friday night, Halina's brother lived six feet behind dead typhus paupers fifty yards across slushy gravel from Pavilion Three.

Out in the grey courtyard dawn smelled suddenly clean of wet lilac and bakery smoke—Muranów's wind had shifted east toward Praga.

Sylwia stood behind the boiler-house coal pile stripping her sewer-soaked wool skirt, stockings, and blouse straight off into a galvanized tub of boiling cresol water Bronka had waiting, scrubbing her bare skin from neck to ankles with coarse yellow lye-soap in ten-degree morning draft until her ribs and breasts turned bright lobster-pink and the phantom stickiness of sixteen-year-old Rachela's bloody lung-foam finally washed off her collarbone.

Pulling on clean rough ward linen under a fresh white smock, drinking black barley *plujka* scalding out of an enamel mug while sparrows chirped insanely cheerful along the eaves, she felt something hard and irreducible settle behind her breastbone: no exhaustion left room for fear anymore.

Staying awake through Tuesday's eight-o'clock surgical list took black coffee and cold tap-water splashed behind both ears every forty minutes, because ten o'clock brought the municipal burial lorry backing its iron-rimmed tailgate right up against the contagious dead-house threshold fifty yards across the yard.

Standing by Ward Two's tall landing window with post-operative charts clamped tight against her ribs while pretending to dictate dressing

changes to Dr. Jankowski, Sylwia watched two municipal grave-carters in carbolic-soaked canvas aprons sling hooks into the five nailed pine boxes lined along the outer vestibule slab—four genuine charity-ward typhus dead plus sixteen-year-old Rachela sleeping weightless under *NN — femina circa 18, ex via Krochmalna.* Six feet behind that inner brick partition, separated only by stacked red-stenciled *FLECKFIEBER* coffin lids and stoneware carboys of forty-percent formalin, Dawid Różański lay flat on rubberized ticking with silver-nitrate coagulum stiffening across thirty percent of his back. If burn delirium broke through fading midnight morphine while those two municipal carters heaved pine boxes across stone—if one cracked, smoke-burned Hebrew or Yiddish syllable rasped out from behind the formaldehyde carboys—both carters ran straight to Walenty's gatehouse shouting ghosts or Jews, where two *Schutzpolizei* troopers stood smoking cigarettes beside a flat bicycle tire!

Nothing moved behind the carboys. Rachela's light pine box slid *thump* onto the lorry bed third from left; canvas straps buckled tight; horses leaned into leather collars and hauled Nalewki's daughter out through iron gates toward consecrated pauper sand without a German boot lifting off the kerb.

Sylwia had barely exhaled half a breath when downstairs through Pavilion Three's rear garden door stepped **Docent Tadeusz Mirecki** himself—hatless in May sunshine, linen laboratory duster flapping round narrow trousers, carrying an empty two-liter ground-glass jar straight across the gravel path toward the contagious dead-house to draw concentrated formalin off the reserve carboys for a resected gastric-carcinoma specimen!

Sylwia took the stone ward stairs three treads at a jump without seeming to run—skirting the lilac hedge fast enough to step across the dead-house threshold four seconds behind Mirecki just as the old surgeon set his glass jar down on the zinc draining board and paused, nostrils flaring sharp behind gold-rimmed pince-nez.

Forty-percent formaldehyde stung nose and conjunctiva fiercely inside the windowless brick vault; yet underneath formaldehyde—unmistakable to a man who had spent forty years walking surgical burn-wards from Vienna to Warsaw—hung the faint, sweetish-astringent hospital tang of **fresh warm tannic-acid jelly, silver-nitrate protein crust, and living human sweat**.

Mirecki did not touch the brass spigot on the stoneware carboy.

Very slowly his watery blue eyes shifted left past the carboy necks toward the dark recessed cooling-alcove blocked off by three propped pine coffin-lids painted *FLECKFIEBER — NICHT BERÜHREN!* Down along the damp brick mortar-joint two inches above floor level trailed one dried black drop of five-percent silver nitrate splashed off Sylwia's forceps at four a.m.

"Since when," Mirecki asked in a voice barely louder than mouse-claw on slate, without turning his grey head from the coffin-lids, "do dead typhus paupers in cold brick alcoves smell of fresh hospital tannic-acid paste and twenty-milligram morphine ampoules, Pani Doktor?"

Sylwia closed the heavy oak dead-house door quietly behind her own spine—dropping the iron latch noiselessly into its slot so zero sunlight or yard shadow crossed the threshold—and stood three paces behind her chief with both raw hands hanging open at her sides.

Tell him a lie, and forty years of clinical authority felt insulted into panic; tell him a name, and if Aleja Szucha ever twisted Mirecki's thin sixty-two-year-old wrists downstairs, he carried fatal freight in his skull.

"Nobody is in that alcove, *Panie Docencie*, after eleven o'clock tonight when turf-carts load behind Koszykowa," Sylwia said quietly in Polish. "Until eleven o'clock tonight, if anybody opens those three coffin-lids, neither you nor I nor sixty beds upstairs see Saturday."

Mirecki stood motionless for six full seconds staring at the red *FLECKFIEBER* stencil six feet ahead of his shoes. Through the thin linen shoulders of his coat Sylwia saw the slight senile tremor that always took his left scapula after two hours standing at the operating table—an honorable prewar Warsaw professor who hated loud noises, kept his German tax receipts filed in three neat drawers, crossed the street when gendarmes shouted, and paid five hundred złoty every month out of his shrunken stipend into All Saints' poor-box without signing his name.

Behind the stacked pine lids, six feet away in pitch shadow, somebody drew one slow, ragged, whistling breath through smoke-scorched vocal cords—and held it dead still.

Mirecki's chin flinched half an inch; he did not step forward, and he did not step back.

Instead he bent stiffly over the stoneware formaldehyde carboy, turned the ground-glass spigot open until two liters of pungent clear

preservative hissed up to the neck of his specimen jar, stoppered it tight, and straightened up facing Sylwia in dim grey door-crack gloom.

"Our night dispensary ledger," Mirecki remarked dryly, looking six inches past her left ear at the whitewashed brick wall, "shows thirty grams of tannic-acid burn jelly and four ampoules of two-centigram morphine unaccounted for since Saturday's foundry scalding on Wola. Kindly enter them on Bed Twelve's foundry chart before municipal auditors check narcotics on Friday, Pani Doktor—sloppy pharmacy arithmetic gives Stabsarzt Vesper indigestion."

He reached into his side coat-pocket, drew out his own spare brass mortuary padlock key—the duplicate second key nobody save the surgical chief carried!—and laid it silently on the cold zinc draining board beside Sylwia's hip so no third porter could open the dead-house before midnight.

"And give five hundred milliliters of warm subcutaneous Ringer's solution before moving extensive second-degree burns by cart," Mirecki added softly with one hand on the oak latch. "Secondary plasma collapse hits hardest round hour twenty-four, even in robust young subjects."

Then the old man slipped out into May lilac sun without looking back once, carrying his glass carcinoma jar upright across the gravel as fussy and unremarkable as any sixty-two-year-old museum curator in Europe.

At ten-forty-five that Tuesday night, after eight hundred milliliters of warm subcutaneous saline under both clavicles steadied Dawid's radial pulse down to a firm ninety-two and fresh sterile vaseline gauze cushioned his black tannic-acid carapace against jolting boards, Sylwia and Bronka carried him slung low inside a clean canvas laundry-sheet out the boiler-lane postern straight into the hollowed peat-turf bed of Bronka's brother-in-law's country cart. Halina didn't even come out past the cellar shadow lest some night window spot her pale face—she simply pressed one tiny folded square of greased paper holding her dead mother's gold wedding band into Sylwia's palm to slide inside Dawid's knotted shirt-hem before dry brown bog-peat stacked loosely over breathing slats hid him clean under country stars rolling south toward Konstancin pines.

* * *

Fifteen hours later, at two o'clock on Wednesday afternoon the twelfth of May, circular rip-saws screamed through wet pine logs inside Brzeziński's timber yard on ulica Towarowa—*zeeeeeeee-krrrrk!*—throwing yellow resin-smelling sawdust ankle-deep across the yard and drowning human voices at four paces so thoroughly that Marek didn't even lower his chin when he stepped beside Sylwia behind stacked scaffolding planks.

Sylwia hadn't seen Marek alone since Saski Garden four weeks earlier—having answered two intermediary notes with polite hospital excuses about Vesper's typhus spot-checks while feeding one harmless typed note on Wehrmacht frostbite train numbers up the drop so nobody smelled sudden silence.

Looking at him today in hard May sunlight between pine stacks, seeing the familiar grey eyes, crooked nose-bridge, and dog-wool jacket of the man who had lain between her thighs on Koszykowa in February while knowing *Elektoralna fourteen* had gone from his ear straight into Reinhart Kroll's Gestapo log inside forty-six hours, Sylwia marveled coldly at how seamlessly her own face produced calm collegial attention.

"Vesper didn't cancel your Friday five-o'clock pass to Królewska?" Marek asked over the scream of the thirty-inch steel blade twenty yards left.

"Signed through the end of May," Sylwia said, brushing pine sawdust off her sleeve. "Twice weekly—Tuesdays and Fridays. Why?"

"Because Friday the fourteenth is the last afternoon *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler spends in Warsaw before flying to Berlin-Tempelhof Monday morning with six months of *Abwehr* Eastern counter-espionage summaries in his briefcase," Marek said cleanly.

Sylwia's pulse didn't jump—simply noted the lie or half-truth immediately: yesterday afternoon at five o'clock on Królewska, Ludwig had mentioned casually while she stretched his shoulder that *Hauptmann von Berg* was flying routine quarterly returns to Tirpitzufer next Monday while Ludwig himself remained in Warsaw! Why did Marek's Section II desk think—or *claim*—Ludwig was carrying files to Berlin Monday?

Marek reached inside his waistcoat ticket-pocket and pressed a tiny cylindrical cardboard pill-tube no longer than Sylwia's thumb directly into her gloved hand.

Inside, cushioned in grey cotton wool, sat one flame-sealed amber glass two-milliliter ampoule without factory label, bearing a single scratch of a diamond glass-cutter on its neck.

"Two-percent procaine hydrochloride solution containing forty milligrams anhydrous aconitine nitrate and strychnine base," Marek said, voice flat as bridge-girder arithmetic beneath the howling rip-saw. "Clear as tap water, pH adjusted so it doesn't sting sharper than ordinary Novocain on needle entry. You still infiltrate two milliliters locally around his lateral pectoral scar cord on Fridays for nerve-traction pain?"

She hadn't injected procaine into Ludwig's scar since the seventeenth of April—she used plain lanolin and bare thumbs—yet three weeks ago on her dummy report slip she *had* written *"weekly procaine scar-infiltration continuing"* to make her continued green *Sonderausweis* sound unimpeachably clinical to Section II!

"Two milliliters subcutaneously above the coracoid," Sylwia lied without blinking.

"Inject this instead at five-fifteen Friday," Marek ordered. "Subcutaneous absorption gives you six to nine clean minutes before paresthesia and ventricular fibrillation hit—plenty of time to snap your bag shut, walk down the back pantry stairs past his corporal, and clear the Królewska barrier before he drops off his chair. Autopsy at *Lazarett Ujazdowski* finds needle-puncture matching four weeks' logged procaine blocks, acute pulmonary congestion, zero gross poison lesions—classic delayed procaine idiosyncratic syncope, two cases in every surgical textbook. Special Court liquidation warrant was signed at ten this morning by *Góra*."

Saw-teeth hit a pine knot with an ear-splitting shriek that made sawdust jump on plank ends.

Sylwia held the tiny cardboard cylinder steady in her palm, looking straight into Marek's grey eyes from eighteen inches away.

Every piece of the February-to-May puzzle locked together with sickening mechanical beauty:

1. On February ninth in Ochota, Ludwig met someone bringing proof of *"Zegar"* inside AK Section II—and Kroll's squad ambushed both cars to protect Kroll's star source. 2. On April fifteenth, Ludwig slipped warning of *"Zegar" in Section II* through St. Charles Borromeo Church on Chłodna to London's independent audit channel! 3. Now London's audit inquiry had started rattling cages high up inside Warsaw Dis-

trict headquarters—terrifying *"Zegar"* inside Section II that if Ludwig Schoeler stayed alive in Warsaw another fortnight comparing notes with Berlin or Western cut-outs, *"Zegar"* got unmasked and shot in a cellar! 4. So *"Zegar"* forged or pushed through an emergency Section II liquidation order handing Sylwia Kotarska four centigrams of aconitine to murder the single man in Warsaw who knew *"Zegar"* existed—knowing full well that if German toxicologists in Berlin *did* run alkaloid tests on an *Abwehr* lieutenant-colonel dropping dead ten minutes after a Polish doctor's needle, Reinhart Kroll immediately arrested and hanged Sylwia Kotarska too, burying *both* ends of the *Chłodna 22 / Elektoralna 14* trail in one afternoon!

"Did you see the signed Special Court warrant yourself, Marek?" Sylwia asked quietly as the saw-blade spun down whining between logs.

For one micro-second—barely the blink of a shutter—something defensive tightened round Marek's mouth. *No,* that flicker said plain as print: *Inżynier Stach handed him the ampoule verbally over table-cloths!* Marek wasn't *Zegar* Marek was *Zegar*'s loyal, blind, lethally obedient hammer, handing his own former lover a suicide needle without asking twice because engineers obeyed blueprints!

"Written court warrants aren't carried through street checks in May," Marek said stiffly. "Verbal confirmation from Section Chief direct. After Friday five-fifteen you don't go back to Koszykowa or Lindleya—walk straight to the Ursuline convent garden gate on Wiślana with your bag; clean *Kennkarte* and railway travel papers to Lublin district surgical inspectorate are waiting under Sister Teresa's blotter."

Bet Sister Teresa's garden gate has a dark-grey Adler Trumpf Ost-44189 parked across the street at five-forty-five, Sylwia thought with icy, murderous calm.

"Understood," she said evenly, sliding the cardboard tube containing forty milligrams of aconitine deep into her jacket pocket. "Friday at five-fifteen."

Marek looked almost relieved—reaching out briefly as in winter to touch two dry fingers toward the side of her cheek.

Sylwia didn't flinch away this time; she stood rock-still and let dry paper-warm skin brush her cheekbone for half a second, feeling nothing at all except clinical pity for a dead man walking who didn't even know

whose shovel he was carrying, before turning cleanly out through the timber-yard gate into Towarowa dust.

Chapter XIV

The Judge's Desk

Warsaw, 14 May 1943

At four-fifteen on Friday afternoon Sylwia rode a rattling Number Four tram down Krakowskie Przedmieście toward Powiśle without getting off, standing wedged behind two nuns on the rear platform while peering down the steep cobbled drop of ulica Wiślana as the car ground past the corner.

Forty yards down Wiślana, opposite the high mossy brick garden wall of the Ursuline convent where Sister Teresa supposedly kept a clean Lublin *Kennkarte* waiting under her blotter for five-forty-five, a young man in a belted grey leather motorcyclist's coat leaned casually over the saddle of a parked BMW sidecar combination, pretending to clean a spark-plug with emery cloth ninety minutes early while his companion smoked inside the baker's doorway across the street.

Ost-44 painted white across the mudguard curved plate.

Sylwia didn't even blink as the tram lurched southward round the bend; she stayed aboard two stops to Nowy Świat, stepped down calmly at Świętokrzyska, and walked west toward Królewska with forty milligrams of anhydrous aconitine clinking softly inside its cardboard tube deep inside her right jacket pocket where her bare fingers rolled the smooth cylinder round and round as she walked.

Had she obeyed Marek's order blindly today: At five-fifteen she slid forty milligrams of monkshood alkaloid under Ludwig Schoeler's scarred skin. At five-twenty-four Ludwig died convulsing in silent ventricular fibrillation on Maurycy Silberstein's parquet while Mekelburg shouted down the stairs. At five-forty-five Sylwia walked dutifully down Wiślana expecting convent sanctuary—straight into that BMW sidecar crew from Aleja Szucha, tipped off in advance by *"Zegar"* inside Section II so

Reinhart Kroll could arrest the "rogue Polish assassin" red-handed with a Diamond-scored syringe still wet in her bag, hang her inside Pawiak before dawn Saturday, and close *both* ends of the leak forever without a single witness left breathing!

And if she simply failed to inject Ludwig today and told Marek tomorrow *"I couldn't do it"*? Within forty-eight hours *"Zegar"* either sent a three-man liquidation squad to shoot Sylwia on Koszykowa stairs for disobeying a Special Court execution order, or tipped Kroll anyway to clear the board.

To walk out of Friday evening alive, she needed two things inside the next forty minutes: an ironclad physical alibi recorded on German sentry paper proving *nobody* could have given an injection at Królewska 16 at five-fifteen today—and whatever scrap of paper inside Ludwig Schoeler's flat pointed toward *"Zegar"*'s real Polish throat.

At four minutes to five Bruno Mekelburg opened the cream-painted pantry door on Service Stair B.

Today the boy wore his field-grey tunic buttoned neat, belt buckled, boots gleaming—clearly waiting to drive somewhere at six. "Afternoon, *Frau Doktor*. He's in the study, though Berlin trunk-line's been ringing back every ten minutes trying to clear static through Breslau."

Inside the study chestnut leaves pressed thick green shadow against open casements; warm May air smelled of dust, lilac, and beeswax. Ludwig stood behind Judge Silberstein's broad mahogany desk in uniform trousers and grey wool service shirt with collar open, sorting three sheaves of pale-pink and grey onion-skin flimsies into two piles: one going into the iron wire burn-basket by the porcelain stove, the other sliding into a thin buff folder inside the wide shallow center drawer of the desk.

When Sylwia crossed the threshold, he looked up—catching something razor-taut in the set of her shoulders before she said good afternoon—closed the shallow center drawer until its brass lock tongue clicked lightly, and turned the small flat Chubb key half a turn, leaving the keyring lying momentarily beside his inkstand only because out in the front vestibule the heavy brass field-line extension bell suddenly jangled three long, urgent rings!

Mekelburg poked his head in from the hall: "*Amt Tirpitzufer* through Königsberg repeater, *Herr Oberstleutnant*—scrambler line's clean for three minutes only."

Scrambler equipment sat bolted inside the locked front cloakroom closet where German transport colonels had wired direct trunk pairs from Saski Palace. Ludwig glanced once from her scuffed Gladstone bag on the wooden chair to the Chubb key-ring beside his blotter—picked up the *key-ring* naturally out of lifelong intelligence habit and dropped it into his trouser pocket!—and paused passing her shoulder.

"Wait four minutes," he said crisp and low. "Don't leave."

Double frosted-glass hall doors clicked shut behind him; thirty feet down the corridor a second oak door muffled his voice completely. Out in the pantry Mekelburg was whistling tunelessly between his teeth over running tap water rinsing spinach grit out of a colander for supper.

Four minutes. Maybe two and a half if Königsberg cut off early.

Sylwia did not waste three seconds staring at doors. Moving silent on thin leather soles across bare oak parquet, she stepped behind Judge Silberstein's desk while pulling from her open Gladstone bag not a clumsy hairpin—locks laughed at hairpins—her stiff stainless-steel Kocher grooved surgical director and a narrow pair of curved Hartmann ear-forceps.

Cabinetmakers in nineteen-twelve fitted Biedermeier mahogany drawers with flat two-lever brass mortise locks, not bank-vault Chubb cylinders—Ludwig had turned a small flat warded brass key on his ring, not a pin-tumbler!

Sliding the flat two-millimeter steel tongue of the grooved director up under the upper brass strike-plate first to test spring tension, she felt the bolt nose—not dead-bolted twice, single-throw spring-latched!—hooked the stiff curved jaws of the Hartmann ear-forceps inside the keyhole below the ward post, pressed upward against the single brass tumbler leaf until grease yielded with a tiny oiled *tick*, and eased the center drawer open four inches without making wood creak.

Right on top lay the thin buff folder stamped across its diagonal corner in red purple-pad block letters: **SONDERMAPPE: UHRZEIGER / KROLL-ABFLUSS (NUR EIGENHÄNDIG)**.

Sylwia flipped the cover back with dry fingertips, eyes photographing German type faster than breath:

Top sheet: carbon transcript of Danzig *Commerzbank* safe-deposit transfers converted into twenty-franc Swiss bank-notes—*14.XI.42, 18.XII.42, 22.I.43, 08.II.43*—drawn by *SS-Sturmbannführer* Hahn's special slush fund and signed out on Warsaw receipt slips by *Hstuf. R. Kroll* for informant **IV N / 119 ("Uhrzeiger" / poln. "Zegar")**.

Second sheet: Ludwig's own slantless vertical fountain-pen ink notes reconstructed after the February ninth Ochota ambush from what his dead railway cut-out had glimpsed before Kroll's squad opened fire:

1. *Quelle "Uhrzeiger" sitzt unmittelbar im Stab Kedyw / Abt. II Bez. Warschau (Zugriff auf Tagesmeldungen binnen 12–24 Std.).*
2. *Anwerbung Okt. 42 über Pawiak-Erpressung: Neffe (Medizin- od. Polytechnikum-Student, ca. 20 J., verhaftet Sept. 42 bei Funkpeilung Żoliborz) heimlich nach Dachau überstellt statt erschossen; Lebenszeichen monatlich gegen Lieferungen.*
3. *Warnung: am 8.II. meldete "Uhrzeiger" verdächtige chirurgische Kellerstelle ul. Pańska (Bahnarbeiter-Schusswunde)—Zugriff durch SD wegen Ochota-Gefecht am 9.II. unterblieben!*

Blood roared cold inside Sylwia's ears.

1) Recruited October 42 via Pawiak blackmail over a twenty-year-old nephew (medical or Polytechnic student arrested Sept 42 in Żoliborz radio-direction raid) transferred secretly to Dachau instead of shot, monthly proof-of-life postcards traded for underground deliveries! 2) On EIGHT FEBRUARY —twenty-four hours BEFORE Sylwia ever dug that copper-jacketed bullet out of the nineteen-year-old railwayman's hip on ulica Pańska!—"Uhrzeiger" had ALREADY reported the cobbler's surgical cellar on Pańska to Kroll's desk, and the ONLY reason Gestapo hadn't raided Pańska at seven p.m. on February ninth and caught Sylwia and Marek together over the bloody bench was that Kroll pulled every squad across town to Ochota at midnight to ambush Ludwig Schoeler!

Wait: *who on God's earth knew on February eighth that Sylwia was going to ulica Pańska on February ninth?!* Only three human beings: the cobbler's wife, **Marek Wolski**, and whoever upstairs in Section II handed Marek medical dispatch chits—OR somebody closer to medical/Polytechnic circles with a twenty-year-old student nephew arrested in Żoliborz last September! Wait—did Marek have a twenty-year-old nephew?! No, Marek was an only child from Kielce—Wait: *who had a twenty-year-*

old Polytechnic/medical student nephew arrested in Żoliborz in September forty-two?!

Before Sylwia's brain could pull the name out of memory, zero floorboard creaked behind her—yet cold shadow fell across green blotter leather, and a bare right hand slammed flat down onto the open mahogany drawer edge an inch from her knuckles, pinning folder and drawer immobile while hard grey wool brushed her shoulder blade and the cold blued steel muzzle of a Walther PPK pressed quiet and unmistakable below her right ribs!

"Take both hands clear of the wood, Sylwia," Ludwig said six inches behind her right ear, voice twenty degrees colder than winter Spree water. "Slowly. Leave the ear-forceps on the blotter."

Sylwia laid the curved steel forceps gently onto green blotting paper and straightened up without turning fast, feeling the seven-sixty-five-millimeter muzzle track steady against her ribs as she pivoted slow inside the narrow kneehole gap until her spine touched Judge Silberstein's mahogany edge and she looked straight up into his face.

For the first time since forty-point-four delirium she saw what Ludwig Schoeler looked like when *Abwehr* instinct took the wheel pure, stripped of Berlin history or hospital debt: eyes pale ice-slate without a millimeter of pupil softness, jaw locked white, pistol held low against his hip where nobody looking through Saski Garden trees could see steel, finger resting directly inside the trigger guard with the safety off.

"Königsberg cut off after ninety seconds," Ludwig said softly. "Evidently two minutes too early for Warsaw Section Two's photography schedule. Who sent you into my desk—the same leak who handed Kroll *Chłodna twenty-two*?"

"Put the pistol away before you ruin Silberstein's wainscot," Sylwia said without raising her voice half a note, staring straight back into ice-green murder from ten inches away while her heart hammered cold slow strokes against the gun muzzle. "I don't carry cameras, and I didn't come here to steal for Section Two. Keep your gun on my ribs while my right hand goes two inches into my outer jacket pocket—two fingers only—and look at what Section Two *did* send me here with at two o'clock Wednesday."

His eyes didn't blink—measuring angle, pocket depth, weight of her jacket hem where clearly no firearm sagged—and gave one hairline nod without shifting the Walther muzzle a millimeter off her seventh rib.

With thumb and index finger only, slow as lifting glass out of pus, Sylwia drew the small grey cardboard pill-cylinder out of her pocket, slipped its cap off one-handed against her hip, and stood the unlabelled two-milliliter amber glass ampoule upright on the green blotter squarely between her curved forceps and his left wrist.

"Two-percent procaine hydrochloride laced with forty milligrams anhydrous aconitine and strychnine," Sylwia said cleanly. "Issued verbally Wednesday afternoon in Towarowa sawmill for subcutaneous injection into your lateral pectoral scar at five-fifteen today—four minutes from now. Six to nine minutes to ventricular fibrillation after I walk down your back stairs; autopsied at Ujazdowski as idiosyncratic Novocain shock. Followed at five-forty-five by a promised Lublin escape *Kennkarte* at the Ursuline convent gate on Wiślana—outside which Kroll's *Ost-44* BMW sidecar crew has been parked cleaning spark-plugs since four-fifteen waiting to hang your murderer before she talks."

Dead, absolute silence dropped inside the study.

Out in the kitchen pantry tap water shut off with a faint brass knock; distant tram bells chimed cheerful through open chestnut leaves from Marszałkowska.

Ludwig's eyes dropped for one single second to the diamond-scratched neck of the amber ampoule glinting brown in afternoon light—surgeon's eye recognizing hand-flamed clandestine laboratory glass instantly—then came straight back up to Sylwia's calm, bloodless face.

Slowly his right thumb clicked the red-dot safety lever up on the Walther PPK and slipped the flat black pistol silently inside his trouser waistband behind his hip.

"You rode past Wiślana at four-fifteen before coming here," he said quietly.

"Number Four tram. Two *Referat IV* plainclothes men and a sidecar." She tilted her chin half an inch toward the open buff folder still pinned beneath his left palm. "Which meant *Zegar* inside Section Two pushed through a fake liquidation order to kill you before Monday—they claimed you were flying to Tempelhof Monday with Warsaw files—and dispose of me thirty minutes later on Wiślana so neither of us stayed breathing

after London's Chłodna audit started rattling Section Two's floorboards. I opened your drawer because if I walk out that door tonight without knowing how *Zegar* sits wired, I'm dead from *both* sides of Marszałkowska before Tuesday."

Ludwig looked down at the typed sheet lying exposed in the open drawer—seeing instantly where her eye had reached before he came back down the hall.

"Did you read point two and point three?" he asked low.

"Twenty-year-old student nephew arrested last September in Żoliborz radio sweep, held alive in Dachau against monthly proof-of-life postcards," Sylwia recited verbatim without glancing down, brain already racing frantically down every name she knew while point three burned white-hot behind her forehead. "And the Pańska cobbler's cellar reported on *eight February*—the day before you were shot, the night Marek and I pulled a bullet out of a railwayman's hip there!"

Wait—stop—hold the scalpel still on *twenty-year-old nephew arrested September forty-two in Żoliborz*!

Marek had no nephew—Marek's single sister died of scarlet fever at twelve in Kielce. Inżynier Stach? She didn't know Stach's family, maybe Stach had three nephews—WAIT: in February forty-three in Pavilion Three's dispensary, when Docent Mirecki had poured rectified spirit with trembling fingers and talked about Kroll's white cotton gloves, Mirecki had spoken about his cousin Bronisław from Radom… AND last October, who else in Warsaw medical/Polytechnic circles had lost a twenty-year-old nephew in the big September Żoliborz *Funkpeilung* roundup?! Half of Żoliborz intelligentsia! No—don't guess blind names without proof or you frame an innocent throat; follow the *access*: only someone inside **Section II / Kedyw dispatch** knew on February eighth that *"Szew"* (Sylwia's medical code-name, never spoken at hospital!) was booked for ulica Pańska at six-thirty p.m. on February ninth! Nobody at *Dzieciątka Jezus*—not Mirecki, not Bronka, not Halina—had *ever* heard of the Pańska cobbler's shop! Only **Section II's dispatch room** knew Pańska on February eighth!

"Only Section Two's own dispatch desk knew Pańska on the eighth of February," Sylwia breathed, confirming Ludwig's point one to the hilt. "Nobody at Lindleya ever heard that street name."

Ludwig closed the buff folder, slid it back inside the drawer, locked the brass latch with his pocket key—giving her curved Hartmann ear-forceps a single dry, sideways look that said *remind me to change nineteenth-century locks tonight*—and leaned both palms against the desk edge, thinking at combat speed.

"What happens tomorrow morning when I'm still eating breakfast upright and you haven't reported to Wiślana?" he asked sharply.

"If I have zero excuse for not injecting you between five and five-twenty today," Sylwia said, "Marek reports an aborted Special Court execution by nine a.m., and whoever sits above him sends pistols to Lindleya gate before noon—while pulling Kroll's sidecar off Wiślana to hunt me at Koszykowa."

"And what excuse satisfies an engineer without burning your pass?"

"Witnesses in the room," Sylwia answered inside two heartbeats. "Nobody injects strychnine-aconitine with six minutes' onset when three armed Wehrmacht officers are sitting round the patient's table with briefcases open and an orderly pouring tea at his elbow! If your courtyard gate-sentry logbook and building register show two or three officers from Saski Square arrived here at *four-fifty-five* for an unscheduled cipher-briefing and stayed until *five-forty*, so Frau Doktor did five minutes' dry pulse check in the anteroom under three pairs of German eyes without opening her syringe case—"

Ludwig was already moving toward the hall telephone extension before she finished the word *case*.

"Bruno!" he called once toward the pantry. When Mekelburg appeared wiping wet hands on a dish-towel: "Run across Saski Garden—don't telephone—tell Hauptmann von Berg and Leutnant Rademacher I want them upstairs here with the Minsk transport maps inside seven minutes, signing the downstairs sentry sheet *four-fifty* in back-dated pencil—give Corporal Weber at the gate twenty cigarettes to smudge the four-fifty line above Frau Doktor's five-o'clock entry. Move!"

Mekelburg grabbed his field cap off the peg and took the back stairs four steps at a bound.

Alone again inside the quiet room, green chestnut shadow seemed suddenly twice as thick now that steel and poison sat naked on green blotter leather between them.

Ludwig walked slowly back around the corner of Judge Silberstein's desk until he stood two feet in front of Sylwia, picking up the tiny amber glass ampoule between thumb and forefinger and holding its clear, innocent-looking colorless fluid against the window glare. Forty milligrams—enough to stop four grown men's hearts in hideous opisthotonic convulsions while awake.

"You didn't hesitate long at the tram window," he remarked quietly, eyes dropping from the deadly glass cylinder straight into hers. "Suppose you'd ridden Number Four down Wiślana at four-fifteen and seen *nobody* parked outside the convent wall—just nuns raking gravel and clean Lublin travel papers waiting on Sister Teresa's table?"

There sat the ugly, unvarnished question neither saint nor patriot wanted asked aloud in daylight.

Had Wiślana looked completely clean at four-fifteen—had Section II's order been genuine Polish underground justice rather than a traitor's double murder—would Sylwia Kotarska have walked up Judge Silberstein's stairs at five o'clock today, drawn two milliliters of colorless monkshood poison into her boiled glass syringe while looking into winter-green eyes across scarred muscle *she* had rebuilt stitch by stitch out of pride and blood, slid the needle home above his collarbone, and walked down to Lublin?

Sylwia looked straight back at him without dropping her chin half a millimeter—giving him the merciless truth he always stripped out of her anyway.

"I rode past Wiślana to check *who* sent me," she said, voice low and steady as rock, "not to decide whether I was going to put strychnine into my own Carrel repair. Had I wanted you dead on a table, Ludwig, February ninth cost zero ampoules and zero nuns."

For five long seconds neither of them breathed.

Something dark, fierce, and shockingly unguarded flared deep behind the grey-green slate of Ludwig's irises—closer than April's splint room, stripped now even of surgical excuse because four inches to his left lay a loaded pistol in his waistband and right between his fingers sat the poison she had carried across Warsaw straight onto his blotter rather than into his veins.

Slowly he set the unbroken amber ampoule back inside its grey cotton-lined cardboard cylinder, capped it, and pressed it back into *her*

palm—closing his warm bare fingers hard around her closed fist for three silent beats before letting go.

"Dump the liquid into a sewer grate three streets away—not here—and keep the broken glass neck if your handler demands to see why you aborted," Ludwig instructed quietly, brain already guarding her flank two moves further down the board than she had calculated herself! "Tell him when von Berg and Rademacher walked in at five, your bag got bumped off the pantry chair onto tile and cracked the ampoule neck inside its cotton tube—so even if he searches your bag tomorrow he smells wet procaine cotton and sees broken diamond-scratched amber glass instead of refusal."

Sylwia stared at the small cardboard tube in her hand—stunned for half a beat by the sheer effortless perfection of *cracked inside its cotton tube when bumped onto pantry tile*, which spared even having to explain why she hadn't left the intact ampoule ready for Tuesday!

Down in the front vestibule two minutes later, heavy boots echoed up the main marble stairs followed by the front bell ringing twice: Hauptmann von Berg and young Leutnant Rademacher arriving winded from Saski Square with rolled map-cases under their arms and four-fifty inked neatly onto Corporal Weber's gate sheet downstairs.

Sylwia had her charcoal jacket already buttoned and her stethoscope coiled inside her bag when Ludwig opened the double hall doors to admit his officers—pausing deliberately in the open foyer under both Germans' eyes to say in crisp, irritated official tones:

"Forget the nerve-block infiltration today, *Frau Doktor*, my staff will be an hour on Minsk rail returns—leave your ointment jar and come Tuesday at five when my room isn't a railway station. Mind that narrow pantry chair, Bruno knocked your bag off it earlier."

"Tuesday at five, *Herr Oberstleutnant*," Sylwia answered stiffly in full view of Hauptmann von Berg's monocle, picking up her bag and walking out down Service Stair B past three witnesses whose sworn German signatures would confirm to any spy on earth—including Kroll's clerk if *Zegar* checked!—that nobody could have stuck a poisoned needle into Ludwig Schoeler inside *Wohnung 4* on Friday the fourteenth of May.

* * *

At ten-forty-five that night, under damp starless cloud cover smelling of lilac and pine-tar, a horse cart heaped high with dry peat-turf slabs backed silently up to the contagious mortuary lane behind *Dzieciątka Jezus*.

Four days of silver-nitrate tannic eschar, massive oral sulfathiazole, and six liters of sweet salted fluid slipped down by Halina at midnight had pulled twenty-four-year-old Dawid Różański back across the cliff-edge: burn back dry black parchment without green *Pseudomonas* pus, fever down to thirty-seven nine, right eye clear enough now to count fingers at ten feet while the left stayed taped sterile under atropine pad. Buttoned into coarse peasant hemp smock with forged *Kreishauptmannschaft Grójec* woodcutter's papers Bronka's cousin had stamped for six hundred złoty, he gripped Sylwia's raw right hand once with his unburned hand in total silence before climbing down beneath the peat-turf arch toward Konstancin pine woods.

Halina stood beside Sylwia in the dark cinder lane for sixty seconds after the iron-tired wheels faded down Koszykowa without making a sound—then let out one long, shuddering breath that seemed to come all the way up from her heels, wiped her nose roughly on her cardigan sleeve like a street urchin, and walked straight back down into her cellar to feed lice without saying thank you, because *thank you* between them would have insulted sixteen-year-old Rachela buried Tuesday morning in Bródno lime.

Twenty minutes later, walking home alone down empty dark Nowogrodzka under her night surgical pass, Sylwia paused beside a cast-iron storm-sewer grate thirty yards from Emilii Plater.

Checking fifty yards forward and back along blacked-out walls—nobody awake, only a stray dog trotting silent across tram rails—she took the cardboard pill-tube out of her pocket, slipped the amber ampoule out onto the iron grate bar, wrapped it inside one layer of rag, and stepped down hard with her steel-tipped boot heel.

Crunch.

Two milliliters of colorless aconitine-strychnine procaine dripped harmless down into black rushing storm-water toward the Vistula; carefully with gloved fingertips she tucked the jagged diamond-scratched glass neck shards back inside damp procaine-smelling cotton wool inside the crushed cardboard cylinder, ready to throw onto Marek Wolski's

sawmill plank tomorrow noon with cold disgust at clumsy German orderlies knocking medical bags off pantry chairs.

Looking down through the iron bars into pitch-black water rushing seaward beneath Warsaw's streets, Sylwia felt the ground shift irrevocably under her soles.

Four months ago she had belonged to a side—exhausted, half-starved, unsentimental, yet cleanly bounded by language, blood, and uniform. Tonight an unknown Pole sitting upstairs in her own underground directorate had tried to murder her at a convent wall to protect his Gestapo Swiss francs, and the single human hand standing between her throat and two gallows belonged to a Wehrmacht *Oberstleutnant* sleeping behind stolen law-books on Królewska.

Chapter XV

The Tarpaulin Truck

Warsaw, 4 June 1943

June came down on Warsaw like a brass lid dropped onto a boiling pot: thirty degrees in the shade by noon, tar bubbling soft black beads along Marszałkowska tram-setts, horseflies thick as currants round droshky blinkers, and every unwashed courtyard smelling of sour cabbage-brine and overflowing dustbins.

At twelve minutes past one on Friday afternoon Sylwia stepped out of Jabłoński's antiquarian medical bookshop on Nowy Świat carrying six glass tubes of prewar sterile Brno catgut Jabłoński had kept hidden behind *Anatomia Człowieka* since thirty-nine, squinting against blinding white sunlight bouncing off church stucco.

Halfway to Świętokrzyska corner she noticed every pigeon along the cornice of the Ministerstwo Skarbu ledge take wing at once before human ears caught why.

Two seconds later three shrill tin police whistles blew simultaneously—north at Świętokrzyska, south at Foksal, west down Warecka—and out of side streets roared four olive-green *Ordnungspolizei* open-topped troop carriers and six high canvas-hooded Mercedes *Buda* lorries, tires screaming black rubber across hot cobbles as iron tailboards crashed down on chains!

Łapanka.

Instantly Nowy Świat turned into a kicked anthill inside a sealed glass jar. Men in linen jackets dropped briefcases and sprinted into courtyard archways only to meet grey-green *Schupo* riflemen and black-uniformed Ukrainian *Schutzmannschaft* auxiliaries already pouring out of rear passages to hammer oak courtyard gates shut with iron bars; a red Number Nine tram ground to a spark-showering halt fifty feet from

Sylwia with policemen boarding both front and back platforms simultaneously, yanking screaming shopgirls and bareheaded clerks down onto the asphalt by their coat collars.

Sylwia did not run.

Running in a *łapanka* got a Mauser round through your kidneys before you made ten yards, and inside her handbag sat triple armor: municipal *Szpital Dzieciątka Jezus* epidemic-surgeon *Arbeitskarte*, grey *Kennkarte* stamped by *Amtsarzt* Warschau, and Ludwig Schoeler's pale-green Wehrmacht *Sonderausweis* valid across every cordon in the district—today being Friday, three hours and forty-five minutes before her standing five-o'clock attendance at Królewska Sixteen!

Standing flat-footed beside a cast-iron lamppost out of the stampede trample, clutching her catgut parcel inside her handbag against her ribs, she already had both folded cards open in her right hand when a heavy, sweat-purpled *Scharführer* in field-grey police wool—Sudeten or Austrian borderlander by his thick *k.u.k.* barrack vowels, tunic dark under both armpits, breath reeking of warm plum schnapps from ten paces—shoved an old piano-tuner past him toward the nearest canvas lorry and swung his slung Karabiner rifle sideways across Sylwia's chest.

"Links in den Wagen—schnell, weiter!"

"Chirurgin im Seucheneinsatz," Sylwia said clearly, holding the pale-green Wehrmacht *Sonderausweis* and her hospital card steady at eye level without flinching from the hot gun barrel brushing her blouse. "Städtisches Krankenhaus Kindlein Jesu und *Ärztlicher Außendienst* der Wehrmachtkommandantur. Prüfen Sie den Stempel, *Herr Scharführer*."

Had he been sober, or Prussian, or alone, violet *Abwehrstelle* ink would have ended the conversation inside five seconds.

Instead two junior Ukrainian auxiliaries stood grinning behind his elbow watching to see whether a sharp-voiced Polish woman in clean grey linen could talk a German sergeant out of street quota—and across the sergeant's left cheek sat three fresh strips of white sticking-plaster from whatever brick or partisan glass-splinter had put four *Schupo* patrols in foul murder-temper since dawn on Praga bridge.

His bloodshot little eyes dropped to *Kotarska, Sylwia — Polin* on her grey *Kennkarte*, slid across to the pale-green Wehrmacht pass authorizing five-o'clock visits to an *Oberstleutnant*'s private apartment on Królewska, and twisted into an ugly wet sneer.

"Außendienst um fünf Uhr beim Herrn Oberstleutnant," he mimicked loudly so both auxiliaries sniggered, snatching the pale-green card out of her fingers before she could pull back. "Für polnische Offiziersmatratzen gibt's heute Sonderzug nach Osten—da kannst du Feldwebeln die Stiefel wischen!"

With two fat, sweaty thumbs he ripped Stabsarzt Vesper's and Hauptmann von Berg's stamped green Wehrmacht *Sonderausweis* straight down the middle, tore the halves across a second time, and tossed all four pale-green scraps fluttering into horse-piss and gutter dust beside the kerb!

Fury—pure, blinding, suicidal Berlin reflex before survival sense caught her wrist—made Sylwia lunge half a step down toward the torn green quarters in the gutter: "Call *Ortskommandantur* Saski Square before you tear Wehrmacht stamps, you drunken idiot—!"

The flat walnut butt-plate of his Mauser rifle swung short and vicious into her left shoulder blade—not full bone-cracking swing, half-arm cattle-prod blow heavy enough to knock every cubic inch of breath roaring out of her lungs and pitch her to one knee on burning cobbles, scraping skin raw through her left stocking while one glass tube of Brno catgut snapped sharp inside her handbag!

Before she dragged half a breath back through dusty teeth, two pairs of rough hands grabbed both her upper arms from behind, hoisted her bodily off the asphalt, and flung her sprawling over the iron-bound oak tailboard onto the splintered wooden floor of the third *Buda* lorry.

Up slammed the tailboard; iron pins dropped *clang-clang* through staples; heavy green tarpaulin flaps laced shut over the rear hoop, plunging thirty-eight jammed human bodies into ninety-degree canvas twilight smelling of hot axle-grease, unwashed sweat, crushed garlic, and terror.

With a grinding lurch the Mercedes diesel roared away eastward down Ordynacka plunge toward Poniatowski Bridge.

Sylwia hauled herself upright onto bruised knees between a grey-haired notary clutching a crushed straw panama hat to his chest and a terrified girl no older than sixteen in a blue school gym-tunic whose bronchial tubes whistled dry asthmatic wheezes like reeds with every breath in the airless canvas oven. Through her torn left stocking blood trickled warm down Sylwia's shin; behind her left scapula a palm-sized hematoma was already stiffening muscle hot and dull where the rifle-butt had landed.

Nobody inside a *Buda* lorry talked loud because two armed guards rode perched on the rear step outside the laced canvas. Women prayed *Pod Twoją obronę* under their breath; a twenty-year-old boy in baker's white trousers tried slicing a ventilation slit through the tarpaulin with a pocket razor-blade until three men dragged his wrist down in panic lest the rear guards fire blind through the canvas into packed backs.

Ten minutes across the river; rattle over Targowa tram-tracks; sharp right turn through tall brick schoolyard gates ringed triple-deep with barbed wire along **ulica Skaryszewska**.

Every soul in Warsaw knew *Skaryszewska 8*. Prewar municipal high school turned *Arbeitsamt* transit pen—where street *łapanka* catches were sorted like slaughterhouse calves inside twenty-four hours: healthy young hands shoved onto night freight cars west to Essen Krupp works or Peenemünde marshes; anyone coughing, crippled, Jewish-featured, or carrying "suspicious" papers culled left into closed cattle-wagons bound south-east for Majdanek or Oswiecim.

By half-past two Sylwia stood penned with two hundred and ninety other women inside the former third-floor gymnasium under tall wire-meshed windows baked white by afternoon sun.

Zero water taps worked on the third floor; one overflowing zinc slop-tub sat in the corner behind a torn blanket for three hundred bladders; chalk dust and chloride of lime rose off dry parquet with every shifting shoe until throats burned raw and the sixteen-year-old schoolgirl in the blue gym-tunic—*Zosia*, daughter of a tram-conductor on Solec, caught buying thread after school—sank down onto the floorboards beside Sylwia's ankles, blue-lipped and clawing at her own collar in full status asthmaticus panic.

Sylwia knelt immediately beside her, snapping open her battered handbag—thank Christ *Schupo* street sweeps didn't confiscate handbags until downstairs sorting tables!—checking past the one broken catgut tube for her emergency ampoule pocket. One solitary milliliter ampoule of one-in-a-thousand *Adrenalinum Parke-Davis* sat wedged beside her boiled metal-cased pocket syringe!

No alcohol swab, no boiled water—spit on thumb or dry skin beat suffocation inside ten minutes. Sylwia snapped the glass ampoule neck inside her skirt hem, drew three-tenths of a milliliter into her pocket needle, pushed Zosia's damp blue sleeve above the deltoid, and slid sub-

cutaneous adrenalin clean into the shaking arm while holding the girl's chin up out of floor lime.

"In through the nose, four counts—out through pursed lips, six counts," Sylwia ordered quietly in her calmest ward voice, pressing two cool fingers gently against Zosia's racing carotid until five minutes later smooth muscle relaxed along bronchioles, whistling eased from stridor to dry wheeze, and pink crept back into the child's lips.

"If they hear me wheezing downstairs at the doctor's table," Zosia whispered against Sylwia's bruised shoulder, trembling like a wet rabbit, "they mark *Krank* in blue pencil—my cousin got marked blue in January from Skaryszewska and went to Lublin instead of Saxony, and her mother got ashes notice in March—"

"Nobody marks you blue while you hold my bag," Sylwia said grimly, glancing up at the round electric Siemens wall-clock bolted high above the gymnasium basketball backboard—dead unplugged since thirty-nine, so she checked her own pinned lapel watch instead.

Four-forty-five.

Fifteen minutes until five o'clock.

Walk through the mechanics cold, without fairy tales: At five-zero-zero, Sylwia did not ring Service Stair B at Królewska Sixteen. At five-fifteen—Ludwig tolerated ten minutes' Warsaw tram delay, never fifteen—Bruno Mekelburg walked down to the courtyard gatehouse telephone and rang *Szpital Dzieciątka Jezus* gate-lodge on Lindleya. Old Walenty or Bronka answered: *Pani doktor went out at twelve-thirty to Jabłoński's bookshop on Nowy Świat for catgut and was due back for three-o'clock rounds—she never came back, and word came in at two that Nowy Świat between Foksal and Świętokrzyska was swept clean by Buda trucks!*

Wait: what if Ludwig wasn't even inside *Wohnung 4* today?! What if Tirpitzufer called him to Minsk this morning, or an afternoon briefing at Palais Brühl ran till eight p.m.—and by eight p.m. Friday's six-thirty Lublin/Reich freight train at Dworzec Wschodni was already forty kilometers out of Warsaw with wooden doors wired shut from outside?!

Five-ten. Downstairs in the school courtyard lorry engines revved; iron whistles blew twice; heavy boots tramped up the stone stairs and flung the double gymnasium doors wide.

"Alle aufstehen! Zu zweien antreten—Kennkarten in die linke Hand, Taschen öffnen!"

Two *Arbeitsamt* civilian clerks in brown linen dust-coats flanked by four Latvian or Ukrainian guards began driving the line down two flights to the long trestle sorting-tables set up across the sunlit asphalt courtyard under horse-chestnut trees, where a fat balding German camp physician in shirt-sleeves with a stethoscope dangling untouched round his neck glanced two seconds per woman—teeth, hands, ankles—chalking *A-1* (Reich heavy agriculture/munitions) on backs of coats in white chalk or jerking his chin left toward the closed brick shed (*Sonderbehandlung / Polizeiüberprüfung*) whenever papers looked irregular or lungs rattled.

Five-thirty-two. Twenty women ahead of Sylwia and Zosia in the shuffling double column down the hot stone stairs.

Five-forty-one. Six women ahead. Out in the glaring courtyard beyond the open vestibule doors, Sylwia could already see two long covered lorries idling to ferry the *A-1* chalked batch eight hundred meters across to Dworzec Wschodni freight ramps for the six-thirty departure. Without her torn green Wehrmacht pass, carrying five unbroken surgical catgut tubes, a hypodermic syringe, and three scalpels inside her handbag—what happened the second the *Sonderdienst* table guard dumped three surgical scalpels out onto the sorting board in front of Security Police clerks?! Straight left into the brick shed as an underground partisan medic!

"Drop three paces behind me if they open my bag," Sylwia whispered barely moving her lips to Zosia clinging white-knuckled to her sleeve. "Say you never saw me before the truck."

"Nächste—vortreten!" barked the sorting clerk.

Sylwia stepped out into blinding five-forty-six June sun before Trestle Two, laying her grey *Kennkarte* and municipal hospital *Arbeitskarte* flat on the scarred pine planks just as the Ukrainian guard grabbed her scuffed Gladstone bag upside-down and dumped scalpels, arterial forceps, stethoscope, and catgut tubes clattering loud across the wood!

The fat camp doctor blinked over sweaty spectacles: "Was zum Teufel —Messer im Transportlager?!"

"Municipal surgeon on epidemic typhus duty at *Dzieciątka Jezus*, swept unlawfully off Nowy Świat while carrying theater suture stock," Sylwia said clearly in icy Berlin German—gambling everything left in her lungs on buying three minutes' bureaucratic hesitation—"and scheduled at seventeen hundred hours under *Wehrmachtkommandantur* order at *Abwehrstelle Warschau*—"

"Every third Polack caught with knives works personally for Field Marshal Keitel," the brown-coated *Arbeitsamt* supervisor sneered, picking up his red-lead police pencil to mark her *Kennkarte* straight for the Aleja Szucha van waiting by the shed. "Left into the brick—"

Out at the main Skaryszewska iron gatehouse fifty yards away, tires screamed across hot cobbles hard enough to make every guard in the yard whirl round toward the street!

A heavy black-and-grey Wehrmacht staff Mercedes-Benz 260 crashed straight up to the lowered red-and-white wooden pole without waiting for the gate-guard's whistle; before the pole finished rising halfway, Bruno Mekelburg leaped out of the driver's seat one-handed to yank the barrier pin clear himself while the right rear door swung open and **Oberstleutnant Ludwig Schoeler** stepped out onto Skaryszewska asphalt.

Sylwia had never seen him walk inside German ranks before.

Buttoned to the throat in immaculate field-grey gabardine tunic with silver braided *Oberstleutnant* shoulder-boards blazing white in low June sun, Iron Cross First Class gleaming cold over his left pocket, peaked cap visor pulled low and lethal above winter-water eyes, gloves slapped flat in his left fist—he didn't hurry, didn't shout, didn't waste one syllable on Ukrainian riflemen. Walking straight across fifty yards of sorting yard as if three hundred prisoners and ten *Arbeitsamt* clerks were weeds growing through gravel, he stopped directly in front of Trestle Two while the fat camp physician scrambled hastily off his kitchen chair trying to button his shirt-collar!

"Who commands this cattle-pen?" Ludwig asked—voice quiet, clipped, carrying thirty yards across dead-silent asphalt like a steel ruler snapped over marble.

Out of the ground-floor office hurried Camp *Lagerführer* Hanke—fifty, bloated belly inside SA-reserve brown breeches, wiping beer foam off his lip and puffing up until he got close enough to read silver general-staff rank *plus* the small silver-chained Wehrmacht high-command warrant credentials Mekelburg stepped forward two paces to hold open six inches from Hanke's nose!

"*Herr Oberstleutnant*—Lagerführer Hanke, *Arbeitsamt Warschau*—"

"At thirteen-fifteen hours today on Nowy Świat," Ludwig said without acknowledging Hanke's name or raised arm by half a blink, "one of your drunken street-sweepers tore up a stamped *Wehrmachtkommandantur*

and *Abwehrstelle* specialist pass issued over *Sanitätsabteilung* seal, struck an epidemic-ward vascular surgeon under direct Wehrmacht requisition with a rifle stock, and dumped her into this yard while six typhus-isolation beds and a senior staff medical inspection waited." His eyes dropped once to Sylwia's surgical scalpels scattered across dirty trestle planks, then lifted cold as arctic brine back into Hanke's sweating red face. "Give me the name and company number of the *Schutzpolizei Scharführer* who commanded the Nowy Świat sweep at thirteen-fifteen. Right now, on that pad, before I telephone General Stahel's military-court duty judge from your own desk."

Every drop of beer-pink drained gray out of Hanke's jowls. *Arbeitsamt* civilian bullies ruled Poles like gods; cross Wehrmacht counter-intelligence and military-governor epidemic statutes in the same afternoon, and forty-eight-year-old *Lagerführer* found themselves transferred to clearing partisan swamps behind Pripyat!

"A regrettable street-confusion by *Ordnungspolizei* auxiliary detachments not under my direct table, *Herr Oberstleutnant*!" Hanke stammered furiously, snatching Sylwia's *Kennkarte* out from under his terrified clerk's red pencil before a mark touched it and shoving her scalpels and catgut tubes back into her Gladstone bag with his own plump hands! "Naturally municipal epidemic surgeons enjoy full Reich exemption—Frau Doktor is released immediately with apologies of the Directorate!"

Ludwig took the bag out of Hanke's hands himself—checking calmly inside that nothing steel was missing—and handed it to Sylwia without touching her bruised arm in front of ten German eyes.

Sylwia took the bag, did not move half an inch toward the waiting Mercedes, and hooked her left hand firmly round sixteen-year-old Zosia's trembling blue gym-tunic elbow right behind her.

"And my typhus-laboratory technician," Sylwia said coldly in German straight at Hanke's nose. "Carrying four boxes of slide cover-slips in my pocket when your patrol split us on the kerb—without her washing infected glass tomorrow morning, my basement diagnostic bench closes."

For one fraction of a second Hanke's little pig-eyes narrowed at sixteen-year-old Zosia's schoolgirl collar and book-satchel—any blind idiot saw she was a high-school pupil caught on Solec, not a typhus technician!—and glanced nervously toward Ludwig to see whether the

Oberstleutnant knew the Polish doctor was lying through her teeth right under his visor.

Ludwig didn't even turn his head to look at the girl.

"Did I stutter on *full epidemic staff*, Hanke?" Ludwig asked softly. "Stamp the girl's release slip before my driver loses his temper."

Purple rubber stamp hit paper twice—*BUM, BUM*—faster than machine-gun bolts.

Ninety seconds later the black-and-grey Mercedes rolled smoothly back out Skaryszewska's iron gates—leaving three hundred white faces staring silent after them through wire mesh in burning dust, a sight that stayed jammed like ragged tin down Sylwia's throat—turned three corners south to a quiet tram-island off Targowa out of sight of camp guards, and paused five seconds while trembling Zosia scrambled out whispering broken sobs over Sylwia's knuckles with two hundred złoty Sylwia shoved into her school pocket to get home before dark.

* * *

Mekelburg didn't drive straight across Poniatowski Bridge into town.

Down the cobbled riverside ramp beneath the towering stone viaduct arches along Wybrzeże Szczecińskie—where willow scrub screened the dusty embankment from bridge traffic overhead and dirty green June river-water lapped sluggishly against sunken nineteen-thirty-nine barge ribs—Mekelburg pulled the Mercedes into deep stone shadow, murmured something wooden about checking the left front brake-drum for dragging shoes, stepped out with a wrench, and walked forty paces upwind round the masonry pier out of sight and earshot.

Inside the spacious grey wool-upholstered back seat of the staff car, heat sat trapped and motionless, smelling of sun-baked German leather, warm motor oil, and the sour Skaryszewska chloride-of-lime dust clinging to Sylwia's hair and torn left stocking.

All afternoon—under rifle-butts, inside stifling tarpaulin, kneeling in lime dust beside choking girls, facing red pencils at Trestle Two—adrenalin and iron self-command had kept her hands steady as slate. Now, sitting three feet from Ludwig Schoeler on plush Wehrmacht cushions with safety suddenly locked round her like a velvet collar, every humiliated, furious, raw nerve in her body detonated at once.

Ludwig took off his peaked cap, tossed it onto the jump-seat ahead, and turned sideways toward her—grey-green eyes raking rapidly, clinically down from the loosened dark hair straggling dusty across her cheek, past the grey boot-print bruise darkening the left shoulder of her linen jacket where the Mauser butt had hit her, down to the dried crimson crust where cobbles had torn skin open below her left kneecap through ripped lisle stocking.

Without asking, he reached his ungloved right hand across the seat to ease the dusty lapel of her jacket half an inch back off her bruised left shoulder-joint to feel whether bone creaked.

"Did that pig crack your scapula or—"

Before his fingers touched linen, Sylwia swung her open right palm —not pushing him off, full whip-crack shoulder-turn backhand—square across his mouth!

Bone and raw mercury-roughened knuckles struck his jaw and lower lip with a sharp crack loud as a pistol cap inside the closed car, splitting the pale February scar-ridge on his lower lip open instantly in a bright crimson bead while knocking his head twenty degrees sideways!

Sylwia tried grabbing the chrome door-handle behind her hip with shaking fingers to get out onto river stones where she could breathe air that didn't belong to his army—and never got the latch half-way up.

Ludwig didn't strike back, and he didn't shout. Faster than Schöneberg ropes, his right hand caught both her wrists together in one iron ring before her second swing cleared her lap, twisting her clean round off the door-latch until her back hit the angled grey corner-upholstery hard and his six-foot frame came straight over her across the seat—left knee wedged onto leather beside her thigh, left hand bracing high against the window pillar despite the missing collarbone strut while his right fist pinned both her trembling wrists flat against the wool cushion beside her ear!

Ten inches above her face, a thin bright thread of scarlet ran from his split lower lip down toward his chin; his pupils were black flint-chips inside blazing green ice, breath coming hot and ragged straight into her face.

"Go ahead and scream at me if it washes the lime out of your throat, *Kotarska*!" he snarled low in Berlin German, stripped bone-raw of every cool officer mask—voice shaking for the first time in ten years with

genuine, white-hot terror that had been eating his own stomach since five-fifteen when Lindleya's porter said *Nowy Świat, Buda trucks*! "Fifteen minutes later onto that siding and Hanke's cattle-cars wired shut for Majdanek—where forty stamped passes from Tirpitzufer wouldn't pull your ashes out of a pit! You think I enjoyed walking in there wearing their silver cord so three hundred Polish women watched you climb into a German car?!"

"Let go of my wrists!" Sylwia gasped, arching upward off the seat cushions so furiously her breasts crushed hard against the silver-buttoned wool of his tunic chest and her torn knee scraped rough grey breeches between his legs, hating him—hating the blood she had just drawn on his mouth, hating that when those iron gates swung open at five-forty-six and she saw his tall grey coat walking across sunlit asphalt toward her trestle, something traitorous and animal deep inside her belly had leaped alive before her brain could strangle it! "I didn't ask you to come across the river—!"

"No—you'd have gone upright into a Lublin gas-shed biting your tongue rather than owe Ludwig Schoeler twenty minutes' breath!"

He shoved her pinned wrists half an inch deeper into hot wool upholstery, leaning down six inches until the blood-bead on his lower lip hovered two finger-breadths above her parted mouth and she smelled copper blood, hot gabardine wool, sun-warmed skin, and forty minutes of pure panic sweating off him under iron control.

Neither of them moved for eight pounding heartbeats while overhead on Poniatowski Viaduct a Number Seven tram thundered past shaking fine dust off the stone arch onto the car roof.

Sylwia's chest heaved tight against his; every breath dragged her thin linen blouse across his Iron Cross pin until metal bit skin right above her left breast. Looking straight into his bleeding mouth two inches away, she felt the terrifying physical pull between them—uglier than gratitude, older than war, sharpened to razor wire by four months of blood and near-death—coiling so tight low in her groin that one more second pinned under his weight on hot leather meant pulling his bleeding mouth straight down onto hers with her teeth!

Ludwig felt the exact shift in her breathing—saw her dark pupils swallow her irises black, felt her thighs stop kicking against his knee and

go dangerously, burningly still—and froze rigid as stone two inches above her lips.

Not out here—not in broad six-o'clock daylight under a bridge arch with a bruised shoulder, Skaryszewska lime in her hair, a twenty-two-year-old corporal knocking stones forty yards away, and gratitude muddying the water between them so tomorrow morning she could tell herself shock made her do it!

With a violent, jaw-locked wrench of willpower, Ludwig let go both her wrists at once and shoved himself upright back into his own corner of the seat, pulling a folded grey service handkerchief out of his cuff to press hard against his split lower lip without taking his blazing eyes off her.

"Button your collar," he said raw through bloodstained linen, chest still rising fast beneath grey gabardine. "Mekelburg's driving you as far as Emilii Plater alley—not Koszykowa, not Lindleya gate. I'll have a duplicate green *Sonderausweis* stamped over General Stahel's own garrison block delivered to Docent Mirecki's safe tomorrow morning—let's see a drunken *Schupo* tear Stahel's signature without losing both thumbs."

Sylwia sat bolt upright in the opposite corner, pulling her torn jacket lapel closed with fingers that still shook slightly and refusing to wipe the smudge of Skaryszewska white chalk off her skirt until she reached her own room.

All the way back across the sunlit Vistula behind Mekelburg's silent neck, neither of them spoke another word, sitting thirty inches apart on grey German wool while Ludwig held red linen to his lip and Sylwia stared straight out through bulletproof glass at her conquered city—both of them knowing now, without a shred of illusion left to hide behind, that the next door that locked behind the two of them was not going to open clean.

Chapter XVI

Spiska Street and Blackout

Warsaw, 30 June 1943

Nobody fired a single pistol shot on ulica Spiska that Wednesday morning, which was how people along Grójecka knew inside twenty minutes that something catastrophic had been taken alive.

When *Kedyw* boys got cornered in safe-flats, staircases exploded with Filipinka grenades, roof tiles rained into gutters, and ambulances clanged for two hours afterward hauling dead gendarmes under canvas. At nine-forty on the thirtieth of June—six hundred meters southwest of Pavilion Three's laundry gate, close enough that Sylwia walking between Wards A and B with morning pus charts heard the sudden three-street cordon of police horns seal Niemcewicza, Grójecka, and Aleje Jerozolimskie simultaneously—six grey Gestapo *Sturmbanne* lorries and three passenger sedans slid around Number Fourteen Spiska like pike closing on a tench in still water, walked upstairs to the second floor without breaking a lock, and drove off twelve minutes later toward Aleja Szucha with sirens screaming triumph clear down Ujazdowskie.

By noon Pavilion Three's corridors smelled of scorched paper despite thirty-one degrees of suffocating June mugginess outside.

Nobody spoke the name *Grot* above breath-level, yet even nineteen-year-old probationer nurses who didn't belong to a platoon knew within two hours when Warsaw's ground lost gravity: pale couriers arrived at kitchen gates whispering three words to porters and vanishing; upstairs in the surgical dressing room Docent Mirecki locked the door for ten minutes to burn six forged *Arbeitskarte* blanks in an enamel kidney basin, fanning grey ash down the drain with shaking pince-nez misted white by sweat.

Spiska.

Standing at the open third-floor landing window where hot dusty wind off Ochota carried zero oxygen and distant thunder grumbled behind yellow haze over Wola, Sylwia gripped the warm iron sill until her knuckles turned chalk-white.

Chłodna zweiundzwanzig—nicht vor dem Zehnten zum Optiker—wenn Kroll den Uhrzeiger hat, brennt das ganze Netz bis zur Spiska.

Four months ago to the day—twenty-eighth of February at two-fifteen in the morning, shaking at forty degrees point four under vinegar cloths—Ludwig Schoeler had spoken *Spiska* straight into her palm before passing out. He hadn't known apartment fourteen, hadn't known *Grot* Rowecki used a modest two-room clerk's flat six hundred yards from *Dzieciątka Jezus*—had Ludwig known *Grot*'s house number, even an anti-Szucha *Abwehr* colonel couldn't have carried Warsaw's supreme underground commander unlogged—yet Ludwig's dead Ochota railway courier had already smelled back in February that *"Uhrzeiger" / "Zegar"* was trailing threads toward a major high-command hideout on Spiska Street!

And today *Zegar* had cashed his fattest Danzig cheque of the war.

At twelve-forty-five Sylwia stripped off her ward smock two hours before shift change, told Bronka to hand afternoon appendicitis admissions to Jankowski, and walked fast down baking Nowogrodzka asphalt toward Koszykowa Thirty-Three to clear the three remaining ampoules of stolen Wehrmacht morphine and Halina's spare false birth-blank out of her loose floorboard cache before post-arrest dragnet ripples hit surrounding blocks.

Halfway up the third-floor rear service flight at Koszykowa, she smelled wood-smoke and charred rag-paper leaking down from the fourth landing.

Nobody lit ceramic room-stoves at one o'clock on the thirtieth of June unless the flat was burning down or files were going up the flue.

Sylwia drew her four-inch brass corridor key silently, paused three seconds outside her own beaverboard-partitioned door—listening past the pounding blood in her ears to rapid iron poker-scrapes rattling inside her green tiled stove—and turned her key in the lock in one swift snap, kicking the door wide.

Marek Wolski crouched on one knee before the open brass firebox door of her cold ceramic stove in shirtsleeves, sweat soaking dark triangles between his shoulder-blades, feeding bundle after bundle of thin blue

and white rice-paper cipher strips out of a slashed leather dispatch-case into roaring yellow flame with her iron coal-tongs.

He spun half-round on his heel—right hand jerking instinctively toward the Walther PP resting cocked on the rag rug beside his knee—before lowering the muzzle two inches when he saw Sylwia step inside and bolt the door behind her back.

"How the devil did you get off rounds before three?" Marek snapped, voice tight and hoarse with smoke and shock, turning immediately back to cram another fistful of typed tissue-slips into the grate. Because summer chimney flues stood air-locked with thirty-degree heat above the roof, thick grey smoke belched backward out of the stove mouth into the tiny room instead of drawing cleanly upward, stinging eyes raw and coating Goldfeder's cut-down brass bedstead in swirling black soot-flakes. "Don't open the window—patrols on Koszykowa watch chimneys for burn smoke after big hits! They took *Grot* on Spiska at nine-forty."

"How did you get inside my room without a key?" Sylwia asked, not moving two paces inside the bolted door, black handbag held low at her left thigh.

"Made a wax impression off your coat pocket in January—every District reserve safe-room has duplicate emergency entry for forty-eight-hour burn protocol," Marek muttered impatiently without apology, stabbing fiercely with the iron poker to break up a thick carbonized wad of folded ledger sheets so oxygen reached the middle. "Stach ordered every Section Two sub-archive south of Aleje Jerozolimskie reduced to ash before two p.m. in case Spiska carried cross-index numbers—my room on Hoża had police whistles at the corner at eleven, so I came straight up your back stairs."

A hot draft belched backward down the flue pipe—*whoof*—blowing three half-curled, brown-scorched onion-skin squares fluttering out past the brass fender onto the scrubbed floorboards six inches from Sylwia's shoe.

Marek lunged forward with the iron tongs to snatch them back into the fire.

Sylwia's leather boot-sole stepped flat down onto the outermost scorched square two tenths of a second before his iron tongs reached it.

"Get your foot off, Sylwia—that's Section Two street-watch routing!"

She didn't lift her heel—stooped swiftly, picked up the warm brown-edged slip between bare fingers while holding Marek back by sheer murderous glare across two feet of smoke, and read four lines written in Marek's own cramped, unmistakable Polytechnic-engineer block capitals dated *27.VI.43 — dla Inż. Stacha*:

1. *Obserwacja kwartału Niemcewicza / Spiska — ruch łączniczek potwierdzony godz. 17:15 (zob. szkic B).*
2. *Kontakt med. "Szew" (Lindleya) — po zwolnieniu ze Skaryszewskiej 4.VI osobiście przez ppłk. Sch. (Abw.) traktować jako spalony / pod obserwacją kontrwywiadu; wstrzymać zlecenia do decyzji Sądu.*

Silence roared inside the smoke-choked nine-foot room louder than February blizzards.

Sylwia stood slowly upright holding the charred paper square between two fingers.

Point One: seventy-two hours before Gestapo trucks rolled straight up to Spiska Fourteen without firing a shot, Marek had been mapping courier traffic across *Niemcewicza and Spiska* for **"Inżynier Stach"**!

Point Two: for twenty-six days since Ludwig pulled her out of Skaryszewska cattle-cars on the fourth of June—twenty-six days during which Marek had smiled dryly across vegetable stalls twice to accept her broken-ampoule report and harmless hospital numbers—Marek had entered *Sylwia Kotarska ("Szew")* onto Section Two's burned-asset slate behind her back as *"compromised by personal intervention of Oberstleutnant Schoeler, pending Special Court disposition"*!

Marek got slowly up off his knee beside the smoking stove, iron coal-tongs hanging in his right hand, Walther PP lying three feet behind his heel on the rug. Soot streaked his wet forehead; through stinging grey smoke his narrow grey eyes hardened from haste into cold, defensive stone.

"Give me that slip, Sylwia."

"Who ordered you to map courier traffic round Niemcewicza and Spiska on Sunday, Marek?" she asked, voice so quiet and flat it cut straight under the crackle of burning paper.

"Counter-surveillance check!" Marek barked low, stepping half a pace forward. "Stach told my team we were checking whether German radio-vans had noticed too many girls carrying parcels off Grójecka so we could warn headquarters to move *Grot* before July!"

Sylwia let out a single short laugh so ugly and merciless it stopped Marek's boot mid-step.

"You poor, blind, rule-book fool," she said softly. "You mapped *Grot*'s courier approaches yourself on Sunday night with a slide-rule and handed Sketch B straight into *Zegar*'s hand so Reinhart Kroll could drive six lorries up to Number Fourteen at nine-forty this morning without losing a single German fingernail!"

Blood drained grey out of Marek's flat cheekbones; his fingers tightened white round the iron coal-tongs. "Watch your mouth! Inżynier Stach fought in nineteen-twenty and lost his brother's boy in Żoliborz last autumn—"

Sylwia froze dead cold from scalp to heels.

Lost his brother's boy in Żoliborz last autumn.

2. *Anwerbung Okt. 42 über Pawiak-Erpressung: Neffe (Medizin- od. Polytechnikum-Student, ca. 20 J., verhaftet Sept. 42 bei Funkpeilung Żoliborz) heimlich nach Dachau überstellt statt erschossen; Lebenszeichen monatlich gegen Lieferungen.*

There it was. Dropped whole onto her floorboards out of Marek's own loyal, indignant teeth: *Inżynier Stach's twenty-year-old nephew arrested in last September's Żoliborz radio-direction raid*, alive right now in Dachau camp block against monthly postcards while Uncle Stach traded *Chłodna 22*, *Elektoralna 14*, *Wiślana's convent ambush*, and this morning **General Stefan Rowecki himself** into Reinhart Kroll's white cotton gloves!

And Marek—standing four feet away staring at the sudden terrible comprehension blazing across Sylwia's face—realized inside two seconds that she knew something about Stach's nephew nobody outside German counter-intelligence files could possibly know!

"Where did you hear about Stach's nephew?" Marek whispered, grey eyes narrowing to razor slits as his left hand shifted three inches downward toward the Walther on the rug behind him. "Only Schoeler's desk at Saski Square—"

Before Marek's fingers bent halfway toward the rug, Sylwia's right hand cleared her open Gladstone bag holding eight inches of heavy, single-piece Krupp forged steel—Liston's minor amputation knife, honed Saturday by old Walenty until light vanished along its belly—point leveled dead steady six inches from Marek's external carotid artery while her

left boot kicked his Walther PP spinning across waxed pine clean under Goldfeder's low brass daybed!

Marek froze half-crouched with iron coal-tongs raised uselessly against surgical steel. Engineers knew blades when blades sat inside an arm's-length room held by someone who cut human thigh-bones before breakfast.

"Touch that rug," Sylwia said without raising her voice above conversational ward tone, "and I open your subclavian and carotid in one draw before your knees hit wood, roll you in Goldfeder's oilcloth after dark, and send you to Bródno pit under a typhus tag."

Smoke curled grey between their faces; down in the courtyard four floors below, somebody cranked an iron pump-handle squeaking for wash-water.

"He pulled you out of Skaryszewska himself," Marek hissed, sweat running black with soot down his temple, horror and fanatic self-righteousness twisting his mouth as thirty pieces of wrong arithmetic added up backward in his skull. "You didn't drop that aconitine ampoule in his pantry—you're fucking Canaris's colonel, or working his string!"

"I haven't touched him," Sylwia said coldly—true to the physical letter at one-fifteen in the afternoon, sharp enough to ring like iron—"whereas you've been carrying water since October for the Gestapo traitor who just sold *Grot* Rowecki to Aleja Szucha! Listen to me, Marek, because I am saying this once for November forty-two's sake and never again: *Chłodna twenty-two* went straight from your mouth to Stach and landed Kroll's *Ost-44189* Adler outside the optician's inside thirty-eight hours. *Elektoralna fourteen*—an empty bombed shed I invented out of whole air beside Saski sundial to test your leak!—brought that identical Gestapo car inside forty-six hours. Wiślana convent had Kroll's sidecar waiting ninety minutes early to hang me after I poisoned the single German officer in Warsaw whose files prove Stach's nephew wasn't shot at Pawiak in October—he's alive in Dachau Block Seventeen against monthly Swiss-franc deliveries!"

Marek stared at her as if the floor planks had split open down to cellars. Every muscle round his jaw twitched violently—remembering *Elektoralna fourteen* spoken solely between the two of them beside the hornbeam hedge, remembering Stach personally cancelling Thursday's inquiry into Elektoralna afterward with *"false alarm, drop it,"* remember-

ing Sunday's courier sketch of Spiska Street handed personally into Stach's hand forty-eight hours before six Gestapo lorries rolled unopposed to Number Fourteen!

Sylwia tossed the scorched onion-skin square onto the dying embers inside the stove so it flared orange and crumbled black.

"Pick up your dispatch bag—leave the pistol under my bed till tomorrow, or take it unloaded—and get down my stairs," Sylwia said flatly. "Go check Stach's Dachau postcards yourself through London's independent courier if you've got half an engineer's spine left. Send one boy from Section Two near Koszykowa or Lindleya to 'liquidate a compromised medic,' and within four hours London's W-Four channel *and* every district commander in Warsaw receives Stach's full name, *Ost-44189*, and your Sunday Spiska sketch by registered drop. Leave my wax key on the table."

For ten seconds Marek stood breathing ragged smoke, staring at the dark-eyed woman holding eight inches of bright surgical steel across the tiny room where four months ago they had lain tangled in winter coats before curfew. Whatever human scrap had ever connected them lay burned greyer than the paper in the grate.

Slowly he reached into his trouser pocket, dropped a dull lead-alloy duplicate corridor key clinking onto her table beside the cold tea glass, fished his Walther out from under the daybed by two fingers on the barrel, ejected the magazine and chambered round onto his palm before pocketing both separately, picked up his empty slashed leather case, and walked out the back service door without looking back.

Sylwia bolted the lock twice, shoved the heavy washstand chest squarely across the beaverboard door panel, pulled her hidden floorboard morphine ampoules and Halina's blank *Kennkarte* into her surgical bag, left Koszykowa by the front courtyard arch ten minutes later after checking both kerbs from the cellar grating, and never slept beneath Advocate Goldfeder's broken plaster rosette again.

* * *

By five o'clock the sky above Warsaw had bruised the livid yellow-violet of an old hematoma about to burst, pressing hot stagnant air down

between tenements until horses foamed white along their harness straps and pedestrians gasped like carp in warm bucket-water.

Every major intersection between Lindleya and Marszałkowska bristled with doubled *Feldgendarmerie* checkpoints and armored scout cars following the morning's capture on Spiska; three times inside twelve blocks Sylwia had to open her freshly re-issued pale-green *Wehrmachtkommandantur* pass—bearing General Stahel's own garrison adjutant counter-seal now, delivered as Ludwig had promised on June fifth—while sweaty troopers checked her face against her grey *Kennkarte* photograph and peered inside her bag at rolled bandages.

Today was Wednesday, not Tuesday or Friday. Walk across Królewska's sawhorses on an unscheduled Wednesday afternoon when half Warsaw was crawling with SD cordons, and any curious sentry might lift a telephone; yet Section Two's burned-asset slate meant Koszykowa was poisoned ground tonight, Docent Mirecki's hospital quarters were crawling with Stabsarzt Vesper's nervous clerks, and one sentence sat burning inside her skull that couldn't wait forty-eight hours until Friday.

Nobody at Królewska barrier telephoned anybody—Stahel's garrison seal waved her straight past under rumbling dry thunder. Up Service Stair B at Number Sixteen, nobody answered her first ring at the cream pantry door; ten seconds after her second ring—two short, one sharp—footsteps crossed bare oak parquet inside not with Mekelburg's country clump, with Ludwig's longer, lighter stride, and the pantry latch clicked inward.

Mekelburg wasn't there. Kitchen tiles stood spotless and empty, shutters half-drawn against oppressive five-thirty glare.

Ludwig stood inside the doorway without tunic or tie, white shirtsleeves rolled sloppy past his forearms, collar open wide exposing the glossy purple-red keloid star beneath his missing collarbone strut, hair raked damp off his forehead where sweat shone faint in thunder-heat—holding a short glass tumbler half-full of clear Pomeranian grain *Korn* in his left hand.

He took one look at Sylwia's white, soot-smudged cheekbones, the bulging Gladstone bag weighted with everything she couldn't leave on Koszykowa, and the Wednesday calendar date, pulled her inside by the elbow, and double-bolted the heavy iron security bar across the pantry door himself.

"Mekelburg's at Modlin ammunition depot signing petrol vouchers till tomorrow noon," Ludwig said low, locking the front foyer inner hall door as well before leading her straight into the green-shadowed study where the iron wire burn-basket beside the stove overflowed twice its usual height with cold black paper-ash. "Did Kroll's sweep touch Lindleya after Spiska?"

"Not Kroll—Marek," Sylwia said without preface, dropping her heavy bag onto the parquet with a dull thud of steel instruments. "Burning Section Two dispatch slips in my stove on Koszykowa at one o'clock with a duplicate key—including my name flagged for Special Court disposal since the afternoon you walked into Skaryszewska."

Ludwig set the *Korn* tumbler down hard on Silberstein's desk. "Did anyone follow you out of Koszykowa?"

"No. And Marek won't send shooters tonight because I just broke his nose open with his own boss's Dachau nephew—*Inżynier Stach*, Section Two Warsaw District desk, nephew arrested in September's Żoliborz radio raid, alive in Dachau Block Seventeen!"

Instead of triumph lighting Ludwig's face at hearing *Zegar*'s cover-name cracked wide open at last, his jaw set into grim, bleak iron.

"Too late to save Rowecki," Ludwig said quietly. "Kroll's grey cars took General Rowecki alive out of Spiska Fourteen at nine-forty this morning—and twenty minutes ago Berlin put him aboard a special Ju-52 under heavy SD escort straight to Prinz-Albrecht-Straße. Himmler's already dining out on it at Rastenburg while Tirpitzufer sits wiping egg off its chin."

Thunder cracked loud over Mokotów—closer now, without rain yet, turning the study darker green until Judge Silberstein's gilt law spines gleamed dull like tarnished brass.

All afternoon's bottled terror, rage, smoke, and homeless fury boiled straight up Sylwia's throat at once. She took two fast steps across the parquet until she stood toe-to-toe in front of his desk.

"You said *Spiska* on the twenty-eighth of February!" she blazed at him low in German, fists clenched white at her sides. "Four months ago in Room Fourteen—*wenn Kroll den Uhrzeiger hat, brennt das ganze Netz bis zur Spiska!* You knew *Zegar* was hunting *Grot* Rowecki along Spiska Street back in winter, and for sixteen weeks while I washed pus out of your chest

and carried your filthy lead letters down Chłodna, you never breathed one word so anyone could move him!"

"I didn't know *Grot* Rowecki was within five kilometers of Spiska Street until eleven o'clock this morning!" Ludwig snapped back, stepping round the mahogany corner until six inches of hot thunder-air separated their chests, winter-green eyes flashing cold steel right back into hers. "On eight February my dead railway cut-out brought me *three fragments* off Kroll's typist carbon: Swiss francs, a Dachau student nephew, and an unnamed Polish courier drop watched near *Spiska corner*! Had I whispered 'Spiska' to you awake in March or April while every word you handed your engineer walked straight into Kroll's lap inside thirty-six hours, what do you think *Inżynier Stach* would have done, Sylwia?! Realized somebody inside Lindleya heard *Spiska* out of my mouth, panicked four months early, and had *you* shot in an alley before Easter!"

"You still let me walk round Warsaw blind while you moved pieces across your board—!"

"Every piece I moved since February ninth kept rope off your neck!" His voice dropped rough and savage, zero military polish left, stepping two inches closer until she smelled raw Pomeranian *Korn* grain-spirit and hot skin rising off his open collar. "You think Tirpitzufer gave a damn whether one Polish hospital surgeon got swept into Majdanek cattle-cars on the fourth of June? Taking a staff car across Skaryszewska's gates under my own warrant-number put a four-page disciplinary query from *Reichssicherheitshauptamt* onto Admiral Canaris's desk last Monday asking why *Abwehrstelle Warschau* pulls Polish women with scalpels out of police transports! One more query like that and Reinhart Kroll doesn't need *Zegar*—he signs a Protective Custody slip for both of us!"

Sylwia's breath stopped ragged halfway into her lungs.

He hadn't breathed a syllable on Tuesday or Friday for three weeks about Berlin filing RSHA disciplinary inquiries against his own head over Skaryszewska!

Before she could answer, eighty outdoor compressed-air sirens mounted across Saski Palace, Palais Brühl, the Main Post Office, and Marszałkowska rooftops erupted simultaneously into the rising-and-falling animal wail that froze every wheel in central Warsaw:

Wuuuuuuuuuu—wuuuuuuuuuu—wuuuuuuuuuu!

Fliegeralarm. Not practice noon test—eight-twelve at dusk under low storm cloud, followed inside forty seconds by the deep, unmistakable unsynchronized *thrumm-thrumm-thrumm* of high-altitude Soviet twin-engined Ilyushins droning west across Praga from behind Smolensk, and then an ear-splitting triple crash right off the Saxon Palace flak-towers two hundred yards away as eighty-eight-millimeter anti-aircraft batteries opened fire straight overhead!

Windowpanes rattled violently in oak frames; two seconds later the district master-switch at Powiśle dropped dead to deny bomber flare-markers city grids, plunging Królewska into total blackout cut through every four seconds by blinding orange-white Flak muzzle flashes and probing blue searchlight pillars slicing between thunderheads!

Automatic air-raid lockdown rules across the German Government Quarter: steel courtyard gates chained shut from inside by air-warden sentries until *Entwarnung* all-clear; anyone stepping onto Królewska asphalt during flak barrage shot on sight by Feldgendarmerie patrols without challenge.

And right on the heels of the second eighty-eight salvo, the June storm finally broke open overhead—sheets of warm torrential rain and hail smashing sideways against Judge Silberstein's tall casements so hard water hissed through the lower putty seam onto the parquet.

Ludwig reached past Sylwia's shoulder in the flashing orange-and-black dark to pull the heavy wooden interior blackout shutters latched across both windows, cutting off Flak glare until absolute, suffocating darkness dropped inside the study, broken only by hairline chinks of orange lightning pulsing around the shutter hinges and the roar of rain and cannon outside.

In the blackness six inches from her face, his bare arm brushed hers and stopped.

Sylwia stood frozen beside the mahogany desk—nowhere left to go in all Warsaw tonight, Koszykowa dead behind her, hospital cut off behind twenty flak cordons, soaked in stove-smoke from Marek's treachery and roaring thunder-heat—listening to Ludwig's breathing ten centimeters away in pitch dark.

Slowly she reached out blind in the dark—not defending, testing reality—until her raw left palm touched rough linen and then bare, burning skin directly over the thick keloid star beneath his resected collarbone,

where under five millimeters of scar her twenty-four tiny bites of black vaselined silk slammed *thud-thud-thud* at a hundred and twenty beats a minute straight into her palm.

* * *

Ludwig's right hand closed over the back of her hand pressed to his chest —not pushing her fingers off the scar, crushing them flat and motionless against his hammering heart for two silent seconds while orange Flak-flash lit a razor sliver of his cheekbones and black-dilated eyes through the shutter crack.

Then his left arm—the arm she had rebuilt out of shredded muscle and broken free across leather tables—swept hard round the small of her back, hauling her body flush from collarbone to thigh against his in the dark as his mouth came down on hers.

Twelve years since July storm-water on Luisenstraße slate, and zero civilization survived the first collision.

Sylwia didn't yield—she met his mouth open and starving, teeth scraping hard across the barely healed ridge of his lower lip until faint salt copper broke between their tongues while both her hands tangled fistfuls of his sweat-damp shirt front, yanking linen sideways until three horn buttons popped pinging across bare oak parquet! He backed her two blind steps straight into Judge Silberstein's glass-fronted law bookcases —leaded panes rattling loud behind her head alongside the *boom-boom-boom* of eighty-eight Flak guns outside—kissing her jaw, throat, and the hollow above her sternum with rough, open-mouthed heat while she tore his unbuttoned shirt clean off both shoulders down his arms, her fingernails raking sharp down bare scarred muscle across his back.

"Take this off," Ludwig muttered ragged in German against her collarbone, hands ripping clumsy and impatient at the small mother-of-pearl buttons of her smoke-smelling linen blouse—not tearing hers only because she couldn't walk through Warsaw sentries tomorrow in ripped clothes—pushing jacket and blouse together off her shoulders down her elbows, unhooking the rusted metal clasps of her worn black cotton brassiere in two jerks until hot summer air and his bare chest hit her breasts naked skin-to-skin!

Sylwia gasped aloud into his hair at the shock of six feet of hard, corded bare male heat pressing her flat against cool bookcase wood—zero soft fat on either of them, hunger-carved ribs grinding against war-hardened sternum, her nipples scraping taut across crisp chest hair and the smooth raised ridge of her own surgical scar. His right palm cupped rough under her bare breast, thumb brushing hard across the tight peak before both hands dropped down to bunch her charcoal skirt straight up round her waist, gripping bare starved hips above her garter straps and hoisting her up against the bookcase glass just like twenty-one-year-old slate on Luisenstraße—except tonight Krause wasn't knocking on any padlock on earth!

"Not against glass—bed," Sylwia bit out against his ear in tangled German-and-Polish breath, kicking one heeled shoe and then the other clattering sideways off her ankles and tearing at his leather officer's belt buckle herself with trembling surgical fingers that knew buckles blind.

He never used Maurycy Silberstein's wide mahogany marriage bed in the front bedroom; half-carrying, half-stumbling together ten blind paces down the dark dressing-passage where flak concussions thudded through brick walls under their bare feet, they hit the narrow iron Wehrmacht campaign cot unfolded beneath the unshuttered air-shaft transom—falling together across rough grey army blanket in a tangle of half-stripped wool and bare limbs!

Sylwia shoved his unbuttoned riding breeches and linen drawers hard down lean scarred hips with both palms and bare heels while he dragged her cotton knickers down past gartered stockings—leaving stockings on in frantic haste—coming back over her heavy and scorching hot between her parted thighs, supporting half his weight on his right forearm beside her pinned dark hair spilling loose out of steel *szpilki* pins across the coarse pillow.

Down between them his cock pressed thick, iron-hard, and slick against her bare vulva—wet already, shockingly, shamelessly soaked despite terror and sweat and soot, four months of unbearable tension coiled so tight inside her pelvis she arched upward off the grey blanket digging bare heels into the hard muscle of his buttocks and wrapping one hand tight behind his neck to pull his mouth down:

"*Komm schon—mach schon, du Hund—*"

He drove straight inside her to the hilt in one long, brutal, breath-stopping stroke that tore a raw open-throated cry out of both of them at once!

Nothing like Marek's silent twenty-second winter economy—size, heat, bone-deep stretch filling her so completely after months of half-dead numbness that for three seconds Sylwia's nails sank straight into his right deltoid drawing four red half-moons while her inner walls clamped spasmodically tight round him and Ludwig froze buried to the root inside her, forehead pressed slick against hers, jaw locked white, shuddering from shoulders to thighs at the scalding wet vise gripping him.

"Look at me," Ludwig rasped six inches above her face as orange Flak-fire flashed pale across the air-shaft ceiling—speaking low, rough, breathless Berlin German straight into her mouth when her eyelids fluttered half-shut. "*Mach die Augen auf, Sylwia.*"

She forced her dark eyes wide open straight into his winter-green stare—refusing to hide behind darkness, watching every stripped line of his face shatter inches above hers as he pulled nearly out and slammed back deep, setting a relentless, bruising rhythm that drove the iron cot-legs hammering hard against Judge Silberstein's dressing-room wainscot underneath the roar of roof artillery!

Every thrust ground his pubic bone hard and deliberate against her swollen clitoris; zero gentleness asked or offered—she bit down hard on the uninjured curve of his right trapezius tasting pure salt sweat while sliding her left hand flat between their slick, slapping chests to press palm-down over his left pectoral scar, feeling every savage jackhammer beat of his heart and the living pulse of the artery *she* had sewn together pumping hot life straight through him into her belly! He hooked his left forearm—aching scar damned to hell—underneath her right knee, pushing her stockinged leg high against his ribs to open her deeper until every stroke hit bottom inside her pelvis in white-hot flashes that broke her voice into shameless, ragged Polish curses against his throat.

Four strokes from the edge her entire body bowed rigid off the army blanket—coming with a violent, tearing convulsion that blacked out flak guns and rain alike, inner muscles milking him so mercilessly he groaned loud and hoarse against her open mouth, teeth grazing her lip, thrusting three blinding strokes deeper through her spasms before emptying hot

and pulsing deep inside her with every muscle in his scarred back locked hard as stone beneath her palms.

Neither moved for two full minutes while rain roared steady down the zinc air-shaft and distant bomb thuds rumbled east across Praga railyards.

Sweat glued bare chests slick together; when rapid tropical air cooled their skin slightly, Ludwig didn't roll away—shifted only two inches sideways on the narrow campaign cot so his dead weight stopped crushing her bruised left scapula (remembering where the Skaryszewska rifle-butt had hit her three weeks ago even now!), keeping one heavy thigh wedged warm between hers and his face buried deep in the loosened black mass of her soot-and-carbolic hair beside her throat.

Sylwia stared straight up at faint grey storm-glimmer above the transom, heart still thudding past a hundred, feeling hot semen leak slow onto rough grey Wehrmacht wool between her thighs—no Esmarch douche bulb within two miles tonight, reckless lunatic ruin in every drop—while four inches below her chin rested the damp blond head of an *Oberstleutnant* of German military intelligence.

And the worst horror of all—worse than *Grot* Rowecki flying chained toward Berlin tonight, worse than Marek's smoke or Kroll's white cotton gloves—was that inside twenty minutes, when Ludwig raised his head in the dark, traced two rough surgeon's fingers slowly down her bare breastbone to her hipbone scarless and starved, and she turned into him silent with teeth and open thighs a second time, slow and devastatingly thorough until dawn turned the air-shaft pale grey, not a single cell of her body regretted a millimeter of it.

PART THREE

Foreign Bodies

July – September 1943

Chapter XVII

Sublimate

Warsaw, 1–6 July 1943

Dawn after an air raid smelled of wet lime-plaster shaken loose by flak concussions, crushed linden blossoms, and ozone washed down into gutters.

Sylwia woke at twenty minutes to five without opening her eyes first, knowing where she was solely by the scratch of coarse grey Wehrmacht wool beneath her bare hip, the dull ache between her thighs where ten weeks of near-celibacy had collided twice with zero restraint against lean pelvic bone, and the steady, deep six-second rise and fall of ribs pressed warm along her spine.

Ludwig's left arm—scarred shoulder and all—lay heavy across her bare waist, fingers resting loose and possessive over the flat hollow of her stomach.

Carefully, millimeter by millimeter so iron cot springs didn't betray her, Sylwia lifted his wrist by two fingers, slid out onto cool oak floorboards, and carried her crumpled clothes barefoot into the adjoining white-tiled bathroom before looking into glass.

Above the chipped porcelain washbasin hung a beveled Venetian mirror left behind by the Silbersteins.

In pale four-forty-five pearl light, the woman staring back did not look thirty-three or surgical or composed: dark hair tangled wild down past bare collarbones with three steel *szpilki* pins still dangling crooked behind one ear; lips swollen dark plum-red and bruised along the lower vermilion border where stubble had rasped skin raw; two livid violet thumb-prints blooming low over her right iliac crest; and right in the hollow above her left clavicle—half an inch too high for an ordinary tailored blouse collar to hide unless pinned high with a brooch—a sharp crimson tooth-mark

where she had arched backward at three in the morning while his mouth bit down to keep them both quiet under the open air-shaft.

Sylwia turned both cold brass taps full on, gasped silently as icy city-main water splashed over soapsuds, and washed fiercely from throat to knees over the porcelain bidet with a hard cake of grey Wehrmacht pumice-soap until skin burned bright pink and every trace of foreign salt vanished down Judge Silberstein's lead drainpipe.

When she buttoned her smoke-faint linen blouse all the way up to the top throat hook—hiding the collarbone bruise cleanly—and pulled the bathroom door open, Ludwig stood leaning shirtless against the dressing-passage doorframe in unbuttoned grey uniform breeches, barefoot on parquet, holding a plain white enamel mug steaming with clear boiled tap water.

Not Lisbon coffee. He remembered everything.

Across his own bare right trapezius and ribcage ran four angry red parallel nail-tracks five inches long where her ungloved mercury-rough nails had dug hard during the flak barrage, and above his missing collarbone segment the purple keloid star looked flushed deep wine-dark from four hours of reckless blood pressure.

Neither said *good morning*, and neither insulted the room with nervous apologies.

Sylwia took the hot enamel mug by its rim without brushing his fingers and drank three scalding swallows straight down to clear dry soot out of her throat.

"All-clear sounded at three-forty," Ludwig said quietly, watching her pin her dark hair back into its severe surgical twist above her nape with fast, ruthless stabs of steel wire. "Mekelburg drives back from Modlin around ten. Where are you sleeping tonight if Koszykowa's burned?"

"Third-floor night-interns' dormer cubby above Pavilion Three," Sylwia said, setting the empty mug on the hall chest and pulling on her charcoal jacket. "Two iron cots under the eaves nobody uses except during winter blizzards, behind thirty typhus-suspect beds and Bronka's padlock. If Marek's friends want to climb three flights of *Dzieciątka Jezus* after dark, they'll have to step over sixty coughing men first."

Ludwig studied her closed, pale face in grey morning light—measuring the exact thickness of clinical frost she was packing back into place

around last night before stepping onto Warsaw cobbles, and refusing either to mock the frost or help her pretend nothing had broken open.

"Don't walk alone between pavilions after dusk," he said evenly, walking behind her down the silent hall to unbolt the iron security bar across Service Stair B's pantry door. "If *Inżynier Stach* hears from your engineer before noon today that you cracked his Dachau nephew open, Stach has forty-eight hours to either silence both of you or run across to Kroll for extraction."

Sylwia paused on the threshold with her Gladstone bag in her left hand. Six inches left of her shoulder sat little Róża Silberstein's five pencil height-marks notched into pine; ten paces behind Ludwig's bare scarred chest sat the rumpled grey army blanket still warm from both their skins.

"If Kroll pulls Stach inside Aleja Szucha alive," Sylwia said coldly, "Stach brings three years of Warsaw medical rosters in his head—including who treated railwaymen on Pańska."

"Which is why Stach won't reach Aleja Szucha alive if my afternoon note reaches Chłodna's church kneeler by noon," Ludwig answered with terrifying, matter-of-fact calm—meaning one three-line carbon slip from his typewriter into London's independent audit drop today put Polish counter-intelligence executioners onto *Inżynier Stach*'s doorstep before Stach finished packing a toothbrush! His winter-green eyes dropped once to her top blouse button hooked high at her throat, lingered half a beat on her bruised lower lip, and came back to hers. "Tuesday at five, *Kotarska*."

"If Vesper doesn't send me to Wola first—typhus broke out in the tram sheds yesterday," she said shortly, and went fast down the back stone steps into bright five-o'clock July sun without looking back.

Half an hour later, down in Pavilion Three's empty ground-floor sluice room before day nurses came on duty, Sylwia rolled both sleeves past her elbows, plunged bare hands and forearms into fresh one-in-a-thousand sublimate of mercury solution, and scrubbed with the stiffest hog-bristle bone-brush on the rack—one minute, three minutes, five minutes—until three winter fissures across her knuckles split wide open dripping bright pink threads into milky mercuric water.

Behind her wooden clogs clacked once and stopped. Siostra Bronisława's massive red hand reached over Sylwia's shoulder, plucked the hog-bristle brush cleanly out of her bleeding fingers without a word,

tossed it clattering into the zinc basin, and wrapped a dry boiled linen towel tight round both raw hands.

Sylwia stood staring down at red spots soaking through white linen without lifting her chin.

Bronka looked sideways at the top throat-button fastened tight despite twenty-four-degree morning air, glanced once at the swollen plum mark on Sylwia's lower lip that no dental spoon had made, and let out a single low grunt through her gold eyetooth—containing zero convent sermonizing and forty-six years of Wola butcher-shop realism about what men and women did when death sat on every roof.

"Interns' cubby upstairs has clean ticking laid out already, pani doktor," Bronka muttered gruffly in Polish, pumping hot water into an enamel kettle for acorn coffee. "Old Walenty carried your spare coat and books over from Koszykowa in a laundry sack at six yesterday evening after your landlady said some fellow in grey smoked up your stove and left the door-latch loose. Drink something hot and sleep two hours before Mirecki comes in—you look like three days drowned."

* * *

By Sunday afternoon the fourth of July, Warsaw's heat had climbed to thirty-four degrees in the sun, turning the sprawling corrugated-iron roofs of the **Municipal Tramway Repair Workshops** out on ulica Młynarska in Wola into five-hundred-foot baking tins where air shimmered visibly above oily steel pits.

Normally municipal epidemic calls went to junior sanitary inspectors; when six skilled armature-winders and two lathe-fitters collapsed inside forty-eight hours at the main motor-rewinding bay—threatening Monday morning's tram schedule carrying forty thousand armaments workers across Warsaw—Stabsarzt Vesper panicked lest General Stahel blame *Sanitätsabteilung*, commandeered Docent Mirecki's fastest diagnostician plus "Panna Kwiatkowska" with her portable slide-box, and stayed safely outside in his open-topped staff car fifty yards upwind holding a lavender-scented handkerchief over his fat nose!

Inside Shed B, heat hit Sylwia's face like opening an autoclave door too early: forty degrees under rust-eaten iron skylights, reeking of hot

transformer varnish, rancid whale-oil cutting fluid, sour unwashed shirts, and burnt ozone.

Along the rear brick wall on greasy tarpaulins lay four men in grey canvas overalls shivering violently under coats despite forty-degree furnace air, faces dusky mahogany-flushed, conjunctivae bloodshot red like rabbit eyes, dry brown sordes crusting cracked tongues, and across their sweaty flanks when Sylwia unbuttoned stiff grease-caked shirts—unmistakable dull rose-pink maculopapular spots fading momentarily on glass-slide pressure where older petechial hemorrhages had already turned dark purple.

Classic day-six louse-borne *Typhus exanthematicus*.

Standing six paces upwind beside two nervous German works guards stood *Herr Betriebsleiter* Direktor Krehl from Essen—sixty, iron-grey crewcut, gold Party badge pinned neat onto white linen dust-coat—flanked half a step rearward by **Inżynier Stefan Bielski**, sweating streams down plump grey cheeks as he held workshop attendance clipboards like shields in front of his stomach.

"Malingering hangover grippe half the time with these Wola fellows after payday, Frau Doktor," Direktor Krehl barked across the oily pit, refusing to come closer than twenty feet to the tarpaulins. "Whoever can't stand at a winding bench goes straight into the Skaryszewska sanitation transport lorry waiting outside the gate so healthy crews keep forty cars rolling by six a.m.!"

Sylwia didn't answer Krehl yet. Kneeling beside the youngest patient—a boy barely sixteen with shaved apprentice skull, burning past forty degrees and picking deliriously at invisible threads in the air (*carphologia*, classic typhus brain congestion) while two live grey body-lice crawled right out of his warm collar seam onto Sylwia's white sleeve cuff—she plucked both lice deftly with fine forceps into Halina's alcohol vial, checked the boy's spleen two finger-breadths palpable below left ribs, and stood up slowly.

Forty feet down the silent aisle of idle lathes stood sixty gaunt Polish fitters and blacksmiths watching in dead silence—caps in calloused hands, eyes sunken black in grease-smudged faces—waiting to see whether a Polish woman doctor speaking Berlin German signed four delirious comrades onto a Skaryszewska lorry (where typhus suspects got shot in

gravel pits behind Lublin inside forty-eight hours rather than treated) while Stefan Bielski held the clipboard!

And at the front of that silent workman's rank, leaning one scarred knuckle on a turret-lathe tailstock while staring not at Krehl—staring cold, unblinking executioner's lead straight through the back of **Stefan Bielski's** damp white dust-coat—stood two lean forty-year-old Wola toolmakers Sylwia recognized instantly by posture alone as shop-floor *Armia Krajowa* industrial-sabotage cell elders.

Sylwia walked deliberately past Stefan—ignoring his pleading, terrified whisper (*"Sylwia, be reasonable, Krehl reports straight to Governor Fischer's transport office"*)—and stopped four paces from Direktor Krehl, holding up the clear glass alcohol vial where two fat grey *Pediculus humanus* lice floated legs-up at eye level!

Krehl took two hasty steps backward so fast his heel nearly went down into the grease inspection pit.

"Confirmed clinical *Fleckfieber* in second week of bacteremic rickettsial dissemination, *Herr Direktor*," Sylwia announced in ringing German clear enough for Vesper's clerk by the door to hear every syllable. "Load these four men into an open lorry through Warsaw streets or dump louse-infested overalls into Skaryszewska transit barracks, and inside twelve days three hundred Reich railway guards and every German passenger riding red front-compartments on Tram Lines One, Nine, and Seventeen comes down with forty-degree spotted typhus—with fifty percent mortality over age fifty!"

At *fifty percent mortality over age fifty*, sixty-year-old Krehl turned the exact grey-green of sour curds.

"Under Generalgouvernement Epidemic Decree Paragraph Seven," Sylwia pressed home mercilessly, pulling Vesper's pre-stamped municipal quarantine pad out of her pocket, "these four patients transfer immediately by closed municipal typhus-hearse to Infectious Ward Six at St. Stanislaus Hospital—*not* Skaryszewska—while Shed B closes forty-eight hours for mandatory hydrocyanic or sulfur delousing of every locker, overall, and tram cushion! And if I learn—as two men on that floor just whispered—that workshop clerks here have been docking bread-and-fat ration cards from feverish workers on day one so men with thirty-nine-degree typhus ride crowded trams to work three days shedding lice rather than starve their children, Stabsarzt Vesper's Monday epidemic report

names *Wola Workshop Administration* personally to the Wehrmacht Garrison Surgeon!"

Out in the yard twenty minutes later, while municipal infectious-ward orderlies lifted all four typhus workers gently onto clean stretchers bound for Polish hospital beds at St. Stanislaus rather than SS gravel pits, Stefan Bielski caught Sylwia's elbow behind the brick transformer hut out of Krehl's sight, face mottled purple-white with panic and fury.

"Are you trying to put me against a wall, Sylwia?!" Stefan hissed, dabbing gray sweat off his moustache with a shaking silk handkerchief. "Krehl just told me if Shed B loses forty-eight tram-hours this week, Berlin audits *my* absentee sick-lists back to April! It wasn't my rule docking three-day bread cards—Ostbahn labor office ordered strict anti-absenteeism deductions in May, I merely counter-signed routine payroll sheets!"

Sylwia looked coldly down at his soft pink fingers gripping her white sleeve until he dropped his hand.

"Look behind you through that doorway at the third turret lathe on the left, Stefan," she said very quietly in Polish. "See those two toolmakers in blue caps watching your back right now? Four workers from your April sick-sheets never came home from Skaryszewska—two died at Majdanek in June. Keep counter-signing Krehl's absentee lists to save your green *Kennkarte* butter ration, and German auditors will be the very least of Wanda's widow troubles before autumn."

She climbed back into Halina's municipal sanitary van without waiting for his answer, leaving Stefan standing alone beside humming sixty-thousand-volt transformers in blinding July dust.

* * *

At five minutes to five on Tuesday the sixth of July—six days since the air-raid storm—Sylwia climbed Service Stair B at Królewska Sixteen with dry palms, clean unwrinkled grey linen, hair pinned steel-tight, and every defensive wall inside her skull mortared six bricks thick.

On the walk across Marszałkowska she had sworn three separate iron rules to herself: 1. Twenty minutes strict clinical check, sitting upright in wooden chairs. 2. Zero step past the study threshold toward that back dressing-room passage. 3. Treat Wednesday night exactly for what wars

made it: two trapped animals colliding under flak guns when lightning knocked out lights—finished at dawn Thursday without romantic drivel or bourgeois encore.

Bruno Mekelburg opened the pantry door wearing his usual clean braces and calm country face—zero sly grin, zero awkwardness, handing her a clean glass of cold well-water from an earthen pitcher because Warsaw sat at thirty-two degrees today and walking from Lindleya left salt damp along her temples.

"He's in the study, *Frau Doktor*," Mekelburg said, picking up his market string-bag from the table. "I'm going down to Hale Mirowskie for sour cherries before they close—back at quarter to six."

The pantry door clicked shut behind Mekelburg's boots, leaving forty-five empty minutes echoing loud down sixty feet of sunlit oak parquet.

Damn the boy to East Prussian marshes, Sylwia cursed silently, setting her half-drunk water glass down hard on the tiles and walking straight down the hall into Judge Silberstein's study with her chin up and her Gladstone bag held in front of her like an iron shield.

All four windows stood open behind drawn thin ecru net curtains today to catch faint garden breeze through chestnut leaves; bright golden five-o'clock light flooded across Biedermeier mahogany and bare floorboards without a single shadow left to hide inside.

Ludwig stood at the side filing-table in grey uniform trousers and thin white cotton sleeveless undershirt—heat had stripped even German colonels down to vests behind closed shutters—burning two short teleprinter ribbons over the wire basket with a brass petrol lighter. In sleepless full daylight, tanned across neck and shoulders from two days' open-car inspection out toward Modlin, scarred left clavicle dipping asymmetric above lean corded pectoral muscle, he turned his head as her leather heels stopped three paces inside the open doorway.

Five seconds of dead silence stretched across sunlit parquet while two pairs of eyes measured each other bare in broad five-o'clock light—neither drunk, neither terrified by sirens, every remembered detail of Wednesday night sitting stark and undeniable right on top of the sunlit air between them.

"Close the hall door," Ludwig said quietly, snapping his brass lighter shut and brushing black ash off his fingers. "Draft blows ash onto the rug."

Sylwia kicked the double study door shut without turning her back, walked briskly to the straight wooden chair beside the desk, and didn't sit down.

"Before you ask about my stairs," she said in crisp, clipped Berlin ward-German, "nobody from Section Two came near Lindleya or Koszykowa all week. Have your Szucha typist carbons shown why?"

Ludwig walked round to the front of Judge Silberstein's desk and picked up two narrow pink teleprinter duplicate slips clipped together with a steel pin, handing them across without touching her fingers.

Sylwia read four lines of terse German police shorthand dated *Montag, 5.VII.43, 07:40 Uhr*:

Polizeirevier XII (Mokotów) meldet Leichenfund ul. Puławska 94, Hinterhof: poln. Zivilingenieur Stanisław Kownacki (geb. 1898), Genickschuss aus Kal. 9mm Parabellum. Keine Papiere entwendet. Referat IV N übernimmt Vorgang unter Sperrvermerk (V-Mann "Uhrzeiger" liquidiert).

Stanisław Kownacki — "Inżynier Stach." Found at seven-forty Monday morning in a Mokotów back courtyard with a single nine-millimeter Parabellum execution round through the base of his skull, wallet untouched—signature sentence of *Armia Krajowa*'s Special Court once London's Thursday Chłodna audit cross-checked Marek Wolski's sudden horrified revolt!

"Your engineer didn't run," Ludwig observed calmly, leaning back against the stout front edge of Judge Silberstein's mahogany desk two feet from where she stood holding the pink slip. "Once you cracked his boss's Dachau nephew open on Wednesday, he checked the Danzig mail dates himself inside forty-eight hours and handed *Inżynier Stach* to your own executioners on Sunday night."

"Which means Kroll knows since seven-forty yesterday morning that *Uhrzeiger* was unmasked from German files," Sylwia said sharply, laying the pink slip back onto green blotter leather. "And Marek himself—"

"—is running underground on false papers from *both* Kroll's vengeance teams and his own frightened committee until they decide how much he leaked unwittingly," Ludwig finished. "He won't touch Lindleya while Stach lies dead with nine-millimeter proof round his neck —unless Kroll catches Marek alive first and squeezes him on Szucha."

Silence fell back across the bright room—out of politics, out of dead traitors, leaving twenty-nine minutes on the brass desk-clock and two

feet of sun-warmed July air between her grey linen skirt and his grey wool knees braced wide against mahogany.

"Turn toward the window so I can check whether you tore deep fibers Wednesday night," Sylwia said flatly, reaching toward her Gladstone clasp for clinical armor.

Ludwig didn't turn toward the window.

His right hand reached out slow—giving her three whole seconds to step backward or slap him off if she genuinely wanted twenty minutes of medical theater—and closed warm and steady round her bare wrist before her fingers touched the leather bag clasp, drawing her half a step forward until the hem of her grey linen skirt brushed between his spread knees against the desk edge.

"Nothing tore Wednesday night," Ludwig said low, winter-green eyes looking straight into hers in unsparing golden daylight, zero hiding-place left on earth. "Except whatever ridiculous vow you just spent thirty minutes rehearsing on the walk down Marszałkowska."

Colour flared hot and furious across Sylwia's high cheekbones—hating to death how effortlessly he read the three iron rules behind her forehead before she opened her mouth!

"Let go my wrist, Schoeler. Your corporal comes back with cherries at quarter to six, and it's broad daylight."

"Thirty-eight minutes," he murmured, thumb sliding up her inner forearm across the exact pulse point jumping rapid beneath pale mercury-chapped skin while his left hand came up gently—shockingly gentle for a man built out of wire and spite—to unhook the single hot mother-of-pearl button fastened tight under her chin, parting her linen collar half an inch in warm sun to uncover the fading violet-yellow shadow of his own Wednesday night tooth-mark above her left collarbone.

Sylwia's breath caught dry in her throat; she didn't step back.

Looking down at that fading purple mark on her pale Polish skin in full daylight did something dangerous to Ludwig's face—tightening his jaw white while darkening his eyes to deep river-slate. Slowly he bent his head six inches and pressed his warm, dry mouth—no teeth today, open lips silent and burning hot—directly over the fading bruise he had left on her collarbone, breathing her skin in through soap and summer salt while both hands slid round her waist to lift her sitting onto the cool

cleared edge of Judge Silberstein's mahogany desk right over German teleprinter ash.

Rule One, Rule Two, and Rule Three went up like dry straw touched to phosphorous.

Sylwia's hands didn't push his shoulders off—they locked fierce into the damp dark-blond hair at the back of his skull, pulling his mouth straight up from her collarbone onto hers in blinding five-o'clock sun while her knees parted shamelessly round his lean waist on polished mahogany! No blackout sirens covered a sound today: every slick catch of breath, the sharp metallic rasp of his trouser fly-buttons giving under both their hands together in sunlit quiet, her grey linen skirt bunched above bare thighs pale above dark lisle stocking-tops while she tore thin cotton drawers aside rather than waiting ten seconds to step out of them!

Standing braced between her spread thighs at the desk edge in white sleeveless vest, Ludwig gripped both bare undersides of her buttocks in hard surgeon's palms, tilting her pelvis forward off smooth mahogany into broad green-gold afternoon light where both of them saw everything —her dark eyes wide open and black-dilated on his, his heavy flushed length sliding hot through slick folds straight home inside her in one slow, devastatingly deep push while neither looked away by half an inch!

Sylwia bit hard onto the heel of her own hand to muffle the sharp moan rising up her chest—chestnut leaves rustling ten feet away outside net curtains, German boots clicking faintly down Królewska pavement two floors below!—until Ludwig pulled her wrist away from her teeth and covered her mouth with his own, swallowing every ragged sound directly down his throat while moving inside her with long, deep, unhurried strokes twice as lethal in daylight silence as storm frenzy had been in the dark.

Every slow roll of his hips ground rough wool breeches against her bare inner thighs and pressed heavy, inescapable friction square across her clitoris; wrapping both stockinged legs tight round his waist and hooking bare heels behind his belt-loops, Sylwia arched back onto one elbow among Silberstein's inkwells—blouse pulled wide off one bare breast gleaming white in sunlit green reflection—watching Ludwig's eyes drop half-dazed to her breast before his head bent to take her nipple hot into his mouth while his right thumb slid wet between their joined bodies to stroke tight, merciless circles right where he stretched her widest!

She shattered inside ninety seconds in total, suffocating silence—biting clean through the cotton shoulder-strap of his undershirt with locked teeth while tears of pure physical overload stung hot behind her lashes and fierce rhythmic contractions clenched so hard round him that Ludwig's breath tore ragged against her breast, gripping the mahogany desk-lip white-knuckled beside her hips as he drove four deep, shuddering thrusts home and spent hot inside her with his damp forehead dropped heavy against her bare sternum.

For sixty quiet seconds sunlit dust motes drifted lazy gold across books and bare thighs while downstairs in the courtyard someone beat a carpet rhythmically—*whack, whack, whack*—with a wicker beater.

At twenty-four minutes to six—nine whole minutes before Mekelburg's boots touched back stairs with sour cherries—Sylwia stood washed, combed, buttoned neat to the throat in front of the Venetian mirror, every hairpin straight as bayonets, sliding her untouched stethoscope back into her bag.

When she walked out past Ludwig leaning clothed against the pantry lintel, neither pretended this was the last time anymore.

"Friday at five," Ludwig said quietly.

"Bring boiled water and lock the desk," Sylwia answered without smiling, and walked down into baking July sun feeling utterly steady, utterly damned, and sharper awake than she had felt since twenty-two.

Chapter XVIII

Luisenstraße, 1933

Warsaw, 14 July 1943 — Berlin, February–March 1933

Stabsarzt Doktor Kurt Vesper always smelled heaviest of Yardley lavender water on mornings when somebody from Aleja Szucha had frightened his bowels loose before lunch.

At twelve-twenty on Wednesday the fourteenth of July, Vesper sat sweating inside Docent Mirecki's ground-floor consulting room—commandeered whenever Vesper visited Lindleya because Mirecki's leather armchair had softer springs than the dispensary stool—pouring himself two fingers of Martell cognac out of a flat pocket-flask into Mirecki's water tumbler while Sylwia stood across the blotter waiting for his signature on forty typhus-vaccine requisitions for Wola.

Spread open to the left of Vesper's cognac glass lay a thick, buff-colored Reich archival registry folder bound with red-white-black string and stamped across its top cover in purple Gothic block letters:

REICHSÄRZTEKAMMER BERLIN — ZENTRALARCHIV DER FRIEDRICH-WILHELMS-UNIVERSITÄT (AUSZUG FÜR K.D.S. WARSCHAU / REF. IV A).

K.d.S. Warschau / Referat IV A. Reinhart Kroll's desk on Aleja Szucha.

Sylwia kept her eyes politely fixed on Vesper's fountain pen without letting her gaze stray two millimeters leftward toward the buff folder, though upside-down from three feet away she had already read her own maiden matriculation line inside half a heartbeat: *Kotarska, Sylwia Helena — geb. 14.XI.1910 Posen — Matr.-Nr. Med. 28/412.*

"Routine credential harmonization across all municipal epidemic establishments serving Wehrmacht billets," Vesper muttered pompously, blotting his violet signature crooked across the Wola vaccine sheet while his stomach gave a loud, sour cognac rumble. "Berlin is gratifyingly

thorough even in wartime, Frau Doktor—every foreign-trained physician working under Generalgouvernement license verified back to semester rolls! Excuse me one moment—something in that casino mayonnaise last night was decidedly off."

Clutching his soft pigskin gloves out of habit even on a trip to the doctors' lavatory down the hall, Vesper hurried out and shut the door—leaving the red-white-black stringed Berlin archive folder lying open six inches from Sylwia's hip!

Lavatory cistern down the passage took ninety seconds to fill after flushing, plus thirty seconds if Vesper checked his moustache in the mirror.

Sylwia didn't step behind the desk—stepping behind the desk trapped you if the handle turned early—simply leaned six inches over the front edge on silent leather soles and turned two stiff photostat leaves with the dry tip of her little finger.

Page One: her own nineteen-twenty-eight Charité matriculation card, signed at the bottom in faded brown iron-gall ink by *Geheimrat Prof. Dr. V. von Halden* confirming state surgical examination passed *mit Auszeichnung*, 24 February 1933; certificate noted at the bottom margin in red clerk's ink: *Nicht abgeholt — Kandidatin abgereist nach Polen 9.III.33.*

Page Two: **Schoeler, Ludwig Heinrich** — *geb. 3.IV.1909 Kiel — Matr.-Nr. Med. 27/889.* Identical faculty advisers, identical surgical clinic rotations under von Halden 1930–33, identical Virchow Medal notation, followed by transfer stamp dated *8.III.1933*: *Übertritt Sanitäts-Sonderdienst Reichswehrministerium (Abt. Abwehr), Berlin.*

Reinhart Kroll wasn't harmonizing municipal epidemic credentials; Reinhart Kroll had smelled something uncanny inside Room Fourteen back in February and March—two people speaking the exact clipped Berlin clinic cadence over smashed watches and coughed blood—and had waited patiently four months for Berlin's bombed-around university registries to ship photostats proving *Oberstleutnant* Ludwig Schoeler and *Dr. Sylwia Kotarska* had spent five years side by side under the same roof on Luisenstraße!

Wait: why had Kroll sent the folder across to *Stabsarzt Vesper* today instead of keeping it locked on Aleja Szucha? Attached to the inside front cover by a paperclip sat Kroll's polite Saxon routing slip: *Herrn Stabsarzt Dr. Vesper zur vertraulichen Kenntnisnahme und Rückäußerung*

betr. dienstliche Notwendigkeit weiterer ambulanter Behandlung Królewska 16 — Rückgabe bis 15.VII. mittags.

Kroll was inviting Vesper to confirm on paper whether Schoeler's shoulder *really* needed twice-weekly house calls from an old Berlin classmate five months after February!

And tucked into the vellum pocket pasted inside the back cover —marked in pencil *Anlage B: Polizeipräsidium Berlin Abt. IA (Politische Polizei) — Alt-Akte März 1933, Mikrofilm-Duplikat*—protruded two identical strips of thirty-five-millimeter safety microfilm six frames long! Why two identical strips? Archive camera operators in Berlin routinely snipped duplicate six-frame negative test-strips into pockets when copying old Political Police ledgers in case one scratched in transit!

Down the corridor the cast-iron lavatory cistern roared loud with rushing water.

Moving faster than suturing silk, Sylwia pinched *one* of the two identical six-frame thirty-five-millimeter microfilm strips out of the back vellum sleeve—leaving the first strip untouched in place so Vesper (who didn't even own a microfilm reader!) and Kroll's return clerk counting one attachment per pocket wouldn't notice a duplicate missing—slid the celluloid ribbon flat down inside her starched cuff, and stepped two paces back to the window just as Vesper bustled back in smelling freshly of lavender water and buttoning his tunic pocket.

"Where were we—ah, Wola vaccine receipts," Vesper puffed, snapping the Berlin archive folder shut without glancing inside the back flap and locking it pompously into his pigskin briefcase. "By the way, Frau Doktor —speaking purely collegially—*Oberstleutnant* Schoeler's clavicular scar must surely be soundly consolidated by mid-July, wouldn't you say? Five months!"

Drop the pass meekly right now on Vesper's cue, and Kroll smiled into his white cotton gloves knowing she dropped it the afternoon Berlin's file arrived; cling too fiercely, and Vesper smelled personal attachment.

"Consolidated in bone callus since May, *Herr Stabsarzt*," Sylwia answered in her driest, most bored clinical tone, handing him his fountain pen cap off the blotter. "As I told *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler himself in May, once-monthly neurological review for brachial-plexus scar causalgia at *Lazarett Ujazdowski* would be wholly sufficient—if *Abwehrstelle*

headquarters cared to release me from wasting two afternoons a week crossing your sentries."

Vesper beamed instantly from ear to ear: *she disliked going!* That saved Vesper having to cross *Abwehr* colonels while letting him write Kroll a splendidly pompous medical opinion recommending termination of outpatient visits by August first!

Yet walking upstairs five minutes later with that cold strip of nineteen-thirty-three Berlin Political Police celluloid burning flat against her radial pulse inside her white cuff, Sylwia smelled neither July heat nor hospital lysol—she smelled wet charred paper blowing across snow off the Spree on the morning of the twenty-eighth of February nineteen-thirty-three.

* * *

Berlin, 28 February – 9 March 1933

When the Reichstag dome burned orange against low winter clouds on the night of Monday the twenty-seventh of February, Sylwia had been sitting fully dressed in her coat at Widow Pohl's kitchen table off Savignyplatz drinking weak linden tea to celebrate passing her final oral surgical state board (*Staatsexamen*) seventy-two hours earlier under Geheimrat von Halden.

At seven-thirty Tuesday morning, walking east from Friedrichstraße station along the freezing canal quay toward Luisenstraße, she found fine black flakes of burned parliamentary shorthand paper still drifting onto dirty snowbanks, and two truckloads of young men in brown SA shirts wearing brand-new white linen *Hilfspolizei*—Auxiliary Police—armbands parked directly inside the main iron gates of the *Charité*.

Overnight Berlin's skin had turned inside out like a gutted rabbit.

Inside Surgical Pavilion Two nobody looked anybody else straight in the eye at eight-o'clock rounds. Fat Kleist—who had scraped through state boards with a miserable *genügend* three weeks behind Sylwia and Ludwig—marched down the tiled corridor wearing shiny brown riding-boots underneath his white clinic smock, whispering beside the radiator with two orderlies who wore Nazi party pins openly on their lapels now instead of hidden behind collars.

Only upstairs in the red-brick *Neuroanatomisches Laboratorium* annex at the rear of the courtyard did sixty-two-year-old **Professor Doktor**

Jakob Mandelbaum put on his ink-stained black alpaca laboratory coat at nine sharp as he had done every weekday morning since nineteen-oh-eight, adjust his round gold-wire spectacles over gentle, near-sighted brown eyes, and set thirty serial celloidin brain-stem sections staining in Weigert's hematoxylin.

Sylwia loved Jakob Mandelbaum the way unsentimental fatherless girls loved the single adult in a hard city who never asked favors or told lies.

When Kazimierz Kotarski's diplomatic remittance stalled for three months during the thirty-one banking crash and twenty-one-year-old Sylwia lived on two boiled potatoes a day rather than beg Mommsenstraße charity, Mandelbaum had invented twelve hours a week of paid "histological slide-indexing" at two Reichsmarks an hour out of his own private textbook royalties—pretending furiously that nobody in Prussia except a stubborn Polish girl could read faded Russian labels on his St. Petersburg myelin slides. Even Ludwig—who respected roughly four living brains in Berlin—never sharpened his teeth on Mandelbaum, spending Tuesday evenings after surgical clinic arguing spinal-tract degeneration across Mandelbaum's Bunsen burner while eating Frau Mandelbaum's caraway seed-cake.

One foolish thing—foolish only once wolves took the police stations—sat locked inside the bottom drawer of Mandelbaum's roll-top oak desk: since autumn thirty-one, two evenings a month down in Wedding behind Nettelbeckplatz, Mandelbaum had run an unpaid night dispensary stitching split scalps and setting broken ribs on unemployed metalworkers and Communist *Rote Hilfe* street casualties whom municipal hospitals reported straight to detectives. Twice in thirty-two, when Mandelbaum had influenza, Sylwia had gone down to Wedding in an old shawl to suture torn ears herself—signing two narcotics-and-tetanus stock receipts at the Wedding pharmacy in her own neat hand: *i.V. S. Kotarska, cand. med.*

On Monday the sixth of March—the morning after Hitler's Reichstag election ballots were counted—Sylwia met Ludwig on the icy gravel path between Surgical Clinic Two and Pathology.

They hadn't exchanged five civil words since New Year's; twenty months after that July thunderstorm in the dog-house, their rivalry had hardened into cold adult steel—tied neck-and-neck for the single

salaried Junior Assistantship (*planmäßige Assistentenstelle*) opening on von Halden's surgical service on April first. Everyone on Luisenstraße knew von Halden preferred Ludwig's vascular audacity on Mondays and Sylwia's diagnostic ice on Thursdays; only one contract sat in the Ministry budget.

Except that Monday morning Ludwig wasn't wearing a clinic smock. He came down the steps of the Administrative Deanery walking fast beside a tall, monocled Reichswehr *Major* in field-grey wool from Bendlerstraße, Ludwig's jaw locked white and sleepless in winter glare. When he spotted Sylwia ten yards off by the leafless linden tree, he broke step abruptly from the Major, intercepted her elbow out of earshot, and spoke without preface:

"Has Mandelbaum burned his Wedding dispensary receipts yet?"

Sylwia stiffened instantly, yanking her elbow clear of his glove. "What business is Professor Mandelbaum's private charity of yours—or of Reichswehr majors?"

"Don't play proud idiot with me this week, Sylwia!" His voice cut low and furious through freezing wind, winter-green eyes bloodshot at the rims as if he hadn't slept since Friday. "Göring's *Abteilung IA* Political Police copied the Wedding pharmacy narcotics-book on Saturday night—Kleist's brother-in-law works clerk on Alexanderplatz and boasted in the doctors' mess twenty minutes ago that detention lists for Charité 'Marxist medical helpers' are being typed for signature tomorrow! Tell Jakob tonight to pack two bags with his wife, leave his damned myelin jars behind, and get on the morning express from Anhalter Bahnhof to Prague before Wednesday noon!"

Cold fear went straight down Sylwia's spine—half believing him, half poisoned by five years of watching Ludwig calculate every chessboard three moves deep. Wait: if Mandelbaum fled to Prague and Sylwia's own Wedding pharmacy signature (*S. Kotarska*) forced *her* across the Polish border before April first, who inherited von Halden's solitary salaried Surgical Assistantship unopposed without lifting a finger?!

Even so, she ran straight up to the Neuroanatomy Annex at five p.m. and begged Jakob Mandelbaum for forty minutes over his cooling Bunsen burner to take the Tuesday morning Prague train.

Mandelbaum only smiled sadly behind thick round lenses, patting her chapped hand with fingers stained purple by hematoxylin. "Run away like

a pickpocket at sixty-two, child, because noisy beer-hall hooligans wave flags for three months? I held an Iron Cross First Class at Verdun digging shrapnel out of Prussian skulls under shellfire. Geheimrat von Halden assured me personally at noon that Prussian university professors stand under Ministry protection. As for those two Wedding tetanus receipts with your name—don't fret, Sylwia, the ledger sits locked in my private roll-top drawer here, not on Alexanderplatz."

Forty-eight hours later—Wednesday the eighth of March at twelve-fifteen noon—snow began falling wet and grey across Charité courtyard gravel.

Sylwia was crossing from Surgical Clinic One carrying blood-agar plates when two open green police lorries packed with SA *Hilfspolizei* in brown shirts and chin-strapped shakos screeched to a halt directly outside the red-brick Neuroanatomy Annex.

She dropped her wooden slide-tray onto snow and ran toward the annex steps until old porter Krause grabbed her white smock from behind a brick buttress, clamping one calloused hand hard over her mouth: *"Still, Fräulein Kotarska, um Gottes willen—sie haben Listen!"*

Through falling snow twenty yards away, the oak annex doors banged wide.

Two twenty-year-old storm-troopers who smelled of wet leather from across the yard dragged Professor Jakob Mandelbaum out by both black alpaca elbows without letting him put on his winter overcoat. Somebody had already struck him across the bridge of the nose upstairs; blood trickled thin scarlet down into his trimmed white moustache, and as his rubber galoshes slipped on the icy top marble step, his round gold-wire spectacles flew off his face onto the stone landing.

"Meine Brille—bitte, meine Herren, ohne Brille sehe ich die Stufen nicht—" Mandelbaum stammered mildly, groping blind with hematoxylin-stained fingers toward the wet marble.

The taller SA man—laughing over his shoulder at fat Kleist standing just inside the vestibule doorway—stepped deliberately sideways onto the gold-wire frames with his hobnailed boot-heel, grinding both thick convex lenses into white glass powder against the stone before hauling the half-blind old man down into the lorry tailboard!

And forty feet higher up—standing behind the tall second-floor arched corridor window of Geheimrat von Halden's Surgical Pavilion directly

overlooking the annex steps, flanked on the left by von Halden's white beard and on the right by that identical monocled Reichswehr *Major* from Monday morning—stood **Ludwig Schoeler**.

Sylwia saw his pale, immobile face framed crystal-clear behind wet window-glass looking straight down onto Jakob Mandelbaum's smashed spectacles in the snow—not shouting, not running down the stairs, turning three seconds later back into von Halden's corridor alongside the Reichswehr major before the police lorry gears ground away toward Alexanderplatz!

By nine o'clock that evening, behind bolted shutters in Widow Pohl's cold fourth-floor back room off Savignyplatz, Sylwia had two battered leather suitcases open on Widow Pohl's iron cot, stuffing anatomy atlases and winter stockings inside with numb hands because Polish Legation counselor Lipski's clerk had telephoned at six advising Polish nationals connected with University clinics to clear Berlin temporarily until street "excesses" subsided.

At nine-twenty someone hammered frantic knuckles on her landing door: Lotte Bergmann tumbled inside wearing a snow-soaked green velvet cloak over an evening slip, pupils pinprick-small with morphine, mascara running black rivers down hollow white cheeks.

"They took Jakob to Columbia-Haus or Sonnenburg cellar—Frau Mandelbaum's sitting at my flat right now staring at walls!" Lotte gasped, gripping Sylwia's arms with icy claw-fingers. "And do you know who came out of Jakob's locked annex office at *eleven-thirty* this morning—forty-five minutes before the brown trucks pulled up—carrying Jakob's private black oilcloth dispensary ledger under his coat straight over to the Reichswehr car waiting behind Pathology?! *Schoeler!* I saw him with my own two eyes from the library stair-window, Sylwia—Kleist unlocked the annex door after him, and by four o'clock this afternoon Fräulein Weber typed Ludwig's transfer commission straight into Bendlerstraße!"

Every word hit Sylwia's stomach like molten lead poured down a funnel.

Eleven-thirty a.m. Forty-five minutes before the SA lorries arrived, Ludwig had unlocked Mandelbaum's roll-top desk, walked out carrying the Wedding dispensary ledger, stood watching behind upstairs glass at twelve-fifteen while storm-troopers ground Jakob's spectacles to powder, and collected his Reichswehr officer's commission by four o'clock!

Lotte slipped down the back stairs at ten when heavy single boots sounded coming fast up Widow Pohl's front staircase.

Sylwia stood alone beside her open trunk with her pawnshop ebony Collin scalpel box gripped unopened in both hands when two crisp raps struck the pine panel.

She pulled the door open without chain.

Ludwig stood under the dim landing gas-jet wearing a brand-new, uncreased field-grey Reichswehr officer's greatcoat—silver buttons gleaming cold, dark blond hair wet with sleet, gaunt face carved out of grey granite without a flicker of expression around his mouth. Under his right cheekbone, pale against wind-chapped skin, shone the three-centimeter crescent scar she had stitched with juniper schnapps in Schöneberg snow.

"You're packed," he said quietly, stepping one pace across the threshold without taking off his gloves and laying a long green-and-buff stamped cardboard *Mitropa* ticket envelope onto the lid of her closed leather suitcase. "Good. Twenty-three fourteen express from Friedrichstraße—not Zoologischer Garten, SA auxiliary patrols are checking foreign passports at Zoo tonight. Lipski's attaché car is downstairs at the corner of Kantstraße right now to take your trunks through diplomatic lane. Don't go back to Luisenstraße tomorrow morning for your state diploma—leave it."

Sylwia could barely hear his words through the black roaring blood behind her eardrums, staring at that spotless field-grey German uniform coat smelling fresh from the military tailor's iron while Jakob Mandelbaum bled blind without spectacles on wet concrete three miles east.

"Lotte saw you come out of Jakob's annex at half-past eleven this morning," Sylwia whispered, voice shaking so violently she barely recognized her own German, "carrying his black Wedding ledger forty-five minutes before the storm-troopers dragged him down the steps."

Something flickered behind Ludwig's bloodshot winter-green eyes —one split-second spasm as if she had driven steel between his ribs, followed instantaneously by shutters slamming down twice as cold and impenetrable as iron plate.

He didn't explain. Didn't say *Anhalter Bahnhof*, didn't say *warrant*, didn't utter one syllable of defense.

"Lotte Bergmann puts three grains of morphine up her arm before noon and talks through every keyhole in Berlin," Ludwig said in a voice dead flat as coffin-zinc. "If you're still inside Prussia at seven o'clock tomorrow morning when Alexanderplatz opens Thursday's University supplement list, Lipski's passport won't save you five minutes. Pick up your bag and walk downstairs, Sylwia."

"How much did Bendlerstraße pay for the ledger, *Herr Leutnant*?" she breathed, stepping six inches from his new silver buttons, shaking from head to heel with pure twenty-three-year-old agony and loathing. "Or did you hand Kleist the names free so nobody Polish stood between you and von Halden's table?!"

His jaw locked white as chalk under the gas-lamp; not one word came past his teeth.

Sylwia spat square across his right cheekbone—right across the white ladder-marks her own needle had put into his skin—snatched the *Mitropa* ticket off her trunk, tore it once across, threw both halves at his polished new boots, and hauled both heavy suitcases out onto the landing herself, walking down four flights past him into Berlin sleet to catch the midnight fourth-class wooden bench train from Friedrichstraße on her own last four Reichsmarks sixty without once looking back across ten years of fire.

* * *

Warsaw, 14 July 1943

At eleven-thirty at night inside the stifling slant-roofed night-interns' dormer cubby on the third floor of Pavilion Three—forty degrees of baked slate heat still radiating six inches above her hair while moths batted dry wings against the blue blackout paper—Sylwia locked the pine door, wedged a wooden chair-back tight under the brass knob, and screwed Halina's borrowed twenty-power dissecting hand-loupe into its wire eye-frame.

Behind a tin biscuit box shielding light from the keyhole burned one bare sixty-watt hospital bulb.

With fine anatomical thumb-forceps she lifted the stolen duplicate six-frame strip of thirty-five-millimeter Berlin archival microfilm out of her starched cuff and held Frame One two centimeters in front of the frosted glass bulb while bringing the twenty-power lens close to her right eye.

White negative print reversed black-on-clear across tiny photographed police foolscap—too cramped on body paragraphs without a darkroom projector enlarger to decipher blurred carbon third-copies, yet the bold stamped letterhead and top three inked lines of Frame One leaped into crystal-sharp focus through twenty-power optical glass:

POLIZEIPRÄSIDIUM BERLIN — ABTEILUNG IA (POLITISCHE POLIZEI) *Vorläufiges Schutzhaft-Verzeichnis — Charité / Wedding ("Rote Hilfe" Unfallstelle) Ausgefertigt: Berlin, den*

7. März 1933

, 18:00 Uhr.

Sylwia's forceps trembled half a millimeter against warm glass.

Seventh of March, nineteen-thirty-three, six p.m. Twenty-eight hours *before* Jakob Mandelbaum was arrested—eighteen hours *before* Lotte Bergmann saw Ludwig carry that black oilcloth ledger out of the Neuroanatomy Annex at eleven-thirty on the eighth! Alexanderplatz *already* had its arrest list typed at six p.m. on Tuesday the seventh—just as Ludwig had warned her on the gravel path Monday morning!

Heart hammering hard against her ribs in the airless attic, she shifted the celluloid strip four millimeters left to center the numbered arrest roster on **Frame Two**—where somebody's heavy fountain pen had drawn a thick black deletion cross and a marginal Reichswehr counter-stamp across Entry Number Two:

1. *Dr. med. Jakob Mandelbaum, a.o. Prof., geb. 1871 (Jude) — festgenommen 8.III. 12:15.*
2. *[GESTRICHEN LT. VERF. RWM / ABW. II VOM 8.III.33, 11:45 UHR — AKTE ENTFERNT]*

— and faintly legible *underneath* the heavy black deletion cross-hatching, typed in Alexanderplatz's original seventh-of-March purple ribbon before someone scrubbed the ledger and stamped Reichswehr preemption over it fifteen minutes before noon on the eighth:

Kotarska, Sylwia Helena, cand. med. (poln. Staatsang.) — Wedding-Rezepte Nr. 114, 119.

The tin biscuit box rattled loud as Sylwia's elbow hit the deal table.

8.III.33, 11:45 Uhr.

At eleven-thirty on the morning of March eighth, Ludwig hadn't stolen Jakob Mandelbaum's Wedding ledger to sell names to the Gestapo! Ludwig had broken into Mandelbaum's office forty-five minutes before

the SA trucks rolled—after stubborn old Jakob ran back from Anhalter Bahnhof at ten a.m. refusing to leave his brain-stem jars for Prague!—ripped Sylwia's signed Wedding pharmacy receipts *out* of the black ledger before Kleist's storm-troopers seized the desk, carried them straight across the courtyard to that monocled Reichswehr intelligence major at eleven-forty-five, and traded **his own surgical career—signing a seven-year Reichswehr Abwehr commission on the spot!**—as the price for Bendlerstraße slapping an official military-intelligence preemption deletion over *Kotarska, Sylwia Helena* on Alexanderplatz's arrest sheet fifteen minutes before noon!

And ten hours later, when twenty-three-year-old Sylwia stood in Savignyplatz spitting across his cheekbone scar and calling him Judas who sold Jakob for silver buttons, Ludwig Schoeler had stood stone-still in his two-hour-old uniform coat—unable to tell her he had just sold his own life to Bendlerstraße to strike her name off a concentration-camp warrant without making proud, penniless Sylwia Kotarska refuse to get on the midnight train out of misplaced honor!—so he had taken her spit clean across his face in silence to drive her safely across the Polish border alive!

Sylwia sat down hard on the narrow iron attic cot in the dark, thirty-five-millimeter celluloid ribbon clenched lightly inside forceps while sweat ran cold down her spine despite suffocating July slate-heat.

Wait—don't faint like a Victorian schoolgirl; read **Frame Six** before hiding the strip! Why had Reinhart Kroll sent this film across Warsaw today?

She held Frame Six against the bulb: Kroll's own typed *Referat IV A* request note dated *10.VII.1943* querying Prinz-Albrecht-Straße Central Registry why *Abwehr* deletion stamp *8.III.33* hid Polish national *S. Kotarska*—marked at the bottom: *Original-Belegmappe März 33 folgt per Kurier aus Berlin Ende August.*

Original voucher-file arriving by Berlin courier end of August. Meaning Kroll didn't have the full unredacted text under the ink cross-out *yet*—only the blurry microfilm copy until Berlin's dusty basement clerk dug out the physical 1933 Wedding receipt slip in six weeks!

Ten years of pure, distilled, righteous hatred—the iron spine Sylwia had leaned against whenever loneliness or hunger or Tuesday afternoons

on Królewska terrified her—had just cracked clean in half in a third-floor hospital attic.

And she couldn't even run across town tonight after curfew to scream at him for stealing ten years of her life with a lie, because downstairs in Pavilion Three's scrub corridor frantic night bells were suddenly clanging twice—*emergency laparotomy*—pulling her back into white linen before her hands stopped shaking.

Chapter XIX

The Curette

Warsaw, 24 July 1943

Even in late July the zinc post-mortem table down in Pavilion Three's basement morgue stayed cold enough to numb bare elbows inside five minutes.

Around the single green-shaded porcelain pendant lamp stood six nineteen-year-old Polish boys and girls wearing white linen aprons tied over shabby summer shirts—nominally enrolled upstairs by day as orderlies and sterilizer clerks under Docent Zaorski's German-permitted *Private Trade School for Auxiliary Sanitary Personnel*, actually third-year clandestine medical students of the Underground University of Warsaw cramming topographical surgical anatomy between ten p.m. and midnight on unclaimed charity-ward cadavers before morning lime carts rolled to Bródno.

"Show me Hunter's canal again without tearing the saphenous nerve, Panna Zofia," Sylwia murmured, tapping the edge of the retracted sartorius muscle with the blunt butt of her scalpel. "On a street barricade you won't have electric retractors or Corning's atlas open beside the stretcher. Cut two centimeters too medial looking for a severed superficial femoral artery and you slice the long saphenous vein longitudinally in dark mud—which bleeds black like tar and blinds your field inside ten seconds."

Slim, spectacles-wearing Zofia—no relation to little asthmatic Zosia from Skaryszewska, an architect's daughter from Żoliborz whose older brother had died at Auschwitz in forty-one—slid blunt curved scissors neatly beneath the aponeurotic roof of the adductor canal and lifted the tough white fibrous band clean off the underlying artery without nicking a twig.

"Good," Sylwia said, allowing one millimeter of rare approval that made all six starved nineteen-year-old faces glow brighter than roast beef. "Memorize the thumb-breadth behind the medial condyle before—"

Up at the head of the basement stone ramp, Bronka's heavy iron key rapped four urgent staccato beats against the heating pipe—*scatter!*

Zero panic, zero chatter: six months' drill moved like greased clockwork. In forty-five seconds flat Zofia draped the dissected thigh smoothly beneath its sewn linen burial shroud as post-mortem typhus spleen-inspection required; five boys swept notebooks and pencils inside their bootlegs, blew out the side spirit-lamp, and vanished noiselessly down the dark boiler coal-tunnel toward Koszykowa's broken fence-post while Sylwia rinsed her hands in carbolic and walked calmly up the basement steps drying her wrists on a towel.

Out in the ground-floor night vestibule nobody from Aleja Szucha stood waiting.

Instead, leaning half-collapsed against Walenty's oak admissions counter with his uniform cap askew, grey summer tunic unbuttoned over a sweat-drenched silk shirt smeared bright scarlet across the belly, stood **Stabsarzt Doktor Kurt Vesper**.

And sagged limp across two hurriedly pushed-together wheeled stretchers beside him—fair Bavarian braids trailing undone down toward the black-and-white tiles, bare white legs streaked dark crimson from thighs to ankles beneath a twisted, blood-sodden linen bedsheet stamped in blue laundry thread *HOTEL EUROPEJSKI WARSCHAU*—lay a girl no older than Sylwia's medical students downstairs.

"Lock the outer courtyard gate, Walenty," Vesper choked out in a shrill, wet Munich falsetto that smelled from eight feet off of fifty-percent Martell cognac and sheer animal terror. Hands shaking so violently he dropped his pigskin gloves twice trying to pocket them, he grabbed Sylwia's clean white sleeve with blood-sticky fingers. "No clerk entries—nobody telephones *Lazarett Ujazdowski*! Theater One immediately, Frau Doktor—wake Docent Mirecki himself, nobody else on the floor!"

Sylwia didn't waste half a second shaking Vesper's filthy fingers off her cuff; one two-second sweep of eyes and fingertips over the girl on the stretcher told the entire sordid Saturday-night story louder than confessionals.

Eighteen or nineteen; grey Wehrmacht *Nachrichtenhelferin*—Signals Corps telephone switchboard auxiliary—skirt and grey rayon blouse stuffed crumpled at the foot of the stretcher; skin dead tallow-white down to blue nailbeds; radial pulse barely palpable at one-forty-six and thready as cobweb; lower abdomen above the pubis no longer soft—doughy, distended, fiercely rigid to lightest touch even through pre-terminal hemorrhagic stupor, while dark venous blood mixed with unmistakable watery brownish-green small-bowel content leaked slow out between cold thighs onto the Hotel Europejski sheet!

Small-bowel content out a vagina.

Even first-semester midwives in Wola knew how small-bowel content reached a nineteen-year-old vagina at eleven-twenty on a Saturday night: some drunken panicked gynecologist working blind without speculum light on a soft hotel mattress at twelve weeks' gestation had shoved a sharp steel Hegar dilator or Sims curette straight through the boggy posterior wall of a retroverted pregnant uterus into the peritoneal cavity —felt something soft yield, pulled down with ovum-forceps thinking he held placental tissue, and *dragged a loop of living maternal ileum down through the torn uterine rent to avulse and lacerate it!*

"Bronka—Theater One lamps full on, four bricks under foot-end, boil laparotomy set and two vascular clamps in three minutes!" Sylwia snapped, already wheeling the stretcher straight toward the glass operating-room doors herself while Walenty ran upstairs to bang Mirecki's quarters. She turned cold black eyes onto Vesper stumbling behind her. "What blood group is her *Soldbuch*?"

"A—Group A—I think—her bag's still in Room Two-Twelve at the Europejski—" Vesper babbled, wiping grey sweat off his upper lip and leaving a streak of the girl's blood across his own toothbrush moustache. "It was an incomplete spontaneous miscarriage—she telephoned my quarters at nine bleeding heavily, begged me as a compatriot from Munich —"

"Save your bedtime fairy tales until she has a blood pressure, *Herr Stabsarzt*," Sylwia cut him off like an axe dropping through fat. "How many minutes ago did you pull bowel through the fundus?"

Vesper's fat pink knees literally buckled two inches against the porcelain scrub-trough rim; a dry whimper came out of his throat. "Thirty

—maybe thirty-five minutes—the lamp beside the bed fell over when she jerked, I thought it was thickened decidua until—"

"Stay away from my sterile table and go scrub if you want to stay out of chains."

Docent Mirecki arrived four minutes later wearing grey flannel trousers pulled hurriedly over striped pajama bottoms, bare ankles stuck inside leather bedroom slippers, pince-nez crooked over grey sunken cheeks that had looked pinched all week in July's wet heat. One look past the ether screen at nineteen-year-old Ilse Lindner's wax-white German face above the Hotel Europejski sheet—and Vesper retching dry cognac bile over the corner slop-sink—made Mirecki cross himself invisibly behind his apron bib before plunging bony hands into sublimate beside Sylwia.

"If a Reichsdeutsche switchboard girl dies on Polish municipal iron at midnight without admission papers," Mirecki whispered grayly under running tap water, "Vesper tells Aleja Szucha by seven a.m. that *he* brought her in after a Polish street abortionist botched her—and hangs both of us to save his Bavarian wife's allowance."

"Which is why she isn't going to die on my iron," Sylwia whispered back grimly, holding dripping arms up for Bronka to tie sterile tape behind her waist. "Put light open-drop ether plus full oxygen cylinder flow on the mask once I prep—zero chloroform on a shocked heart—and run six hundred milliliters warm gum-acacia saline plus Bronka's universal Type O citrate bottle wide open into an ankle cut-down!"

At eleven-thirty-eight Sylwia drew a single swift subumbilical midline stroke from umbilicus to pubic symphysis with a #20 belly blade, parted linea alba almost bloodlessly—hypotension below sixty systolic barely bled skin—and opened the peritoneum.

Dark purple liquid blood and black clots the size of fists surged up over wound towels onto rubber floor-mats: easily sixteen hundred milliliters free inside the peritoneal cavity!

Sylwia scooped four double handfuls of warm jelly-clot straight out into Bronka's basin to reach the pelvis—and across the table Docent Mirecki gave a sudden sharp, whistling intake of breath that had nothing to do with surgical pathology.

"Tadeusz?" Sylwia glanced up one tenth of a second over her gauze mask.

Mirecki's face above his mask had turned the exact blue-grey of wet slate; cold sweat stood out in huge round beads from brow to hairline, and his right hand holding the broad Doyen bladder-retractor unlocked helplessly, dropping half a pound of stainless steel clattering off the table rim onto tiles as his left hand clawed inward at his own sternum through his sterile gown!

"Sylwia—vise—down left arm—" he gasped, knees folding slowly sideways behind the ether screen before Bronka caught his bony armpit with one massive matron's arm and lowered him flat onto the tiled floor away from blood!

Acute coronary thrombosis. Right in the middle of an open, exsanguinating German abdomen with a lacerated uterine artery pumping scarlet deep in the broad ligament and torn ileum leaking green chyme across pelvic peritoneum!

"Bronka—crush two amyl nitrite pearls under his nose right on the floor, give fifteen milligrams morphine subcutaneous, don't lift his head!" Sylwia barked, shoving two wide packs down against the girl's bleeding right parametrium with her own left fist to hold pressure solo while turning murderous dark eyes straight across Theater One onto Stabsarzt Kurt Vesper shivering green-faced in shirt-sleeves by the door! "Vesper! Get two pairs of sterile gloves or raw alcohol over those fat hands inside *twenty seconds* and stand across this table holding my Doyen retractor—or watch Munich's military prosecutor read your hotel room towel numbers over a dead nineteen-year-old girl!"

Terror moved forty-one-year-old Party gynecologists faster than duty ever did.

Slopping raw spirit frantically up to his elbows without stopping to brush nails, Vesper stumbled across wet floor-clots into Mirecki's empty spot—hands trembling like aspen leaves in wind as Sylwia shoved the spare sterile Doyen retractor handle into his right grip and the ether drop-bottle into his left!

"Pull suprapubic wall straight toward her knees—don't wobble into my silk or I stick this needle through your thumb!" Sylwia snarled in Berlin German ferocious enough to freeze his tremors down to half an inch. "Ten drops ether a minute on the gauze whenever her eyelids twitch, oxygen valve three liters!"

For forty-eight minutes inside midnight heat where moths fried snapping against the surgical skylight glass and Docent Mirecki lay grey and silent under an oxygen mask on a floor mattress ten feet behind her heels with Bronka counting his irregular radial pulse between passing Sylwia boiled clamps, Sylwia operated four-handed with two hands of her own.

First, life: deep in the right side of the twelve-week boggy uterus yawned a ragged three-centimeter perforation extending laterally straight through the ascending branch of the right uterine artery inside the broad ligament! Trying to stitch ragged, friable pregnant myometrium torn open by an unsterile hotel curette guaranteed fatal puerperal peritonitis by Wednesday even if bleeding stopped. One road kept a nineteen-year-old girl breathing: swift subtotal supravaginal hysterectomy.

Kocher clamp across right round ligament and tube, snip; clamp left, snip; push bladder peritoneum cleanly downward off cervix with wet gauze sponge so ureters drop two centimeters safe out of harm's way—never clamp a ureter blind in blood, even von Halden's panic rules held sacred!—double heavy #2 chromic catgut ligatures driven tight through both uterine artery pedicles at the internal os. Instantly the deadly bright arterial welling from the pelvic floor stopped dead! Across the cervical stump she whipped six clean interrupted mattress stitches, burying raw mucosa smooth under bladder peritoneum.

Second, filth: twelve centimeters proximal to the ileocecal valve hung the five-centimeter loop of small intestine Vesper's curette had dragged halfway into the womb and ripped open across its mesenteric border, bruising three mesenteric arcade vessels blue-black. Leave bruised devascularized bowel inside a belly and it sloughed open on day four.

"Intestinal Doyen clamps—soft rubber-shod!" Sylwia snapped over her shoulder to Bronka rising briefly from Mirecki's side.

Eight centimeters of ruined ileum came cleanly out between soft clamps; two-layer end-to-end anastomosis—inner continuous Connell inverting stitch in fine catgut, outer interrupted Lembert seromuscular bites in black silk that tucked peritoneal edges neat and watertight as a purse seam—mesenteric window closed, pelvic cavity washed thrice with two full liters of warm sterile saline before pouring ten grams of crystalline sterile sulfanilamide suspension straight across the cul-de-sac

and closing fascia with rapid figure-of-eight stainless wire so distension couldn't burst her belly open if ileus hit!

At twenty-six minutes past midnight Bronka's universal Type O donor blood finished dripping; at zero-zero-forty Ilse Lindner's radial pulse under Vesper's terrified thumb climbed down from one-forty-six to one-sixteen, systolic pressure reading eighty-eight over fifty-four on the mercury cuff, warm pink returning faintly to small Bavarian earlobes.

Only Room Fourteen down the empty east annex still had clean single-bed privacy away from Polish ward ears; there orderlies wheeled nineteen-year-old Ilse under hot bricks while upstairs on the third floor Sylwia and Bronka settled Docent Mirecki—chest pain easing slowly from crushing iron down to dull lead under morphine and oxygen, pulse irregular with occasional ventricular extrasystoles yet holding seventy-six—into his private corner room with strict absolute bed-rest orders for six weeks.

* * *

At three-fifteen on Sunday morning, when birds were just beginning to stir sleepy notes inside courtyard lilacs before light greyed the sky, Sylwia walked back down into Mirecki's ground-floor consulting room without washing two dried rust streaks of Ilse Lindner's blood off her white apron front.

Stabsarzt Kurt Vesper sat slumped at Mirecki's mahogany desk in the exact chair where Reinhart Kroll had sat scratching white cotton wrists in February. Vesper's face looked deflated like a pig's bladder pricked with a pin; his hair stood tufted damp where he had dragged fingers through brilliantine, and the pocket cognac flask lay dry upside-down on the blotter.

Without speaking a word, Sylwia laid two sheets of paper side by side under the desk lamp directly beneath Vesper's red-rimmed eyes.

On the left lay a blank municipal-and-Wehrmacht emergency operative report sheet already filled out in Sylwia's crisp black script:

Patientin: Lindner, Ilse, Nachr.-Helf., 19 J. Diagnose: Graviditas interstitialis rupta dextra cum haemorrhagia intraabdominali gravissima; laesio secundaria serosae ilei per adhaesiones antiquas. Therapie: Laparotomia

mediana, amputatio uteri supravaginalis, resectio ilei (8 cm), transfusio sanguinis.

Ruptured right interstitial ectopic cornual pregnancy with massive intra-abdominal hemorrhage and secondary ileal tear from old appendicular adhesions. Zero criminal abortion, zero curette perforation, zero Paragraph 218 Reich penal felony carrying eight years' Zuchthaus and military cashiering to the Eastern Front! Even if another German physician examined Ilse's scar next month, interstitial cornual rupture clinically mimicked uterine-horn tear down to requiring emergency subtotal hysterectomy, and the excised specimen had already gone straight into Bronka's boiler firebox ten minutes ago!

On the right lay four blank grey-green *Sanitätsabteilung Warschau* movement-and-requisition vouchers bearing official eagle watermarks from Vesper's own unlocked briefcase, plus Kroll's July fourteenth routing query asking whether *Dr. S. Kotarska*'s outpatient attendance on Królewska remained medically indicated and whether Berlin's 1933 university registry file raised "any administrative reservation."

Vesper stared from the left-hand salvation sheet to the right-hand stack for ten silent seconds while sweat trickled slow down his fat neck into his wilted collar.

"Interstitial ectopic rupture," Vesper whispered hoarsely, wetting dry grey lips with his tongue. "The girl herself—when she wakes—"

"She's nineteen, terrified to death of losing her Signals badge and breaking her Catholic mother's heart in Rosenheim, and grateful to still own bowel and breath," Sylwia said coldly, standing straight above him smelling of blood and ether. "When I wake her at eight this morning alone in Room Fourteen, I will inform her calmly that an unruptured ectopic horn blew open spontaneously in her hotel room, that *Herr Stabsarzt* Vesper heroically drove her here inside twenty minutes saving her life, and that unfortunately scarred tubes mean she won't carry babies —which beats ten years in Aichach women's penitentiary for wartime self-abortion. She'll kiss your boots till Judgment Day."

Vesper closed his eyes for two seconds with a wet, shuddering exhalation that nearly turned into a sob. Reaching blind for his fountain pen, he uncapped it with trembling fingers.

"Before your pen touches paper, *Herr Stabsarzt*," Sylwia said very softly, placing two raw fingers squarely on top of the right-hand sheets

so they couldn't move, "let us make sure Munich and Warsaw speak clear German. First: while Docent Mirecki recovers upstairs over the next eight weeks, I hold full acting chief surgical authority in Pavilion Three—zero outside Reichsdeutscher or Volksdeutscher locum brought into my wards or basement laboratories."

"Agreed—naturally, you know the pavilion routines—"

"Second: those four *Sanitätsabteilung* drug-and-movement vouchers get your signature and official round rubber stamp *blank* on lines two through five—for epidemic insulin, sulfonamide, and rural sanitary transport as municipal need arises."

Vesper swallowed hard once—four blank Wehrmacht medical movement vouchers could move three typhus patients or forty kilos of contraband clean past county gendarmes to Kielce!—glanced once at the dried blood of nineteen-year-old Ilse Lindner on Sylwia's apron front, and signed *Dr. K. Vesper, Stabsarzt* four times in rapid violet ink, thumping his round eagle pocket-stamp beside each signature.

"Third," Sylwia finished, sliding Kroll's Aleja Szucha inquiry slip last beneath his nib: "You reply to *SS-Hauptsturmführer* Kroll Monday morning that Berlin's nineteen-thirty-three Charité registry confirms purely orthodox academic surgical training under Geheimrat von Halden, zero political notations attached, and that *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler's post-traumatic brachial-plexus causalgia continues to require specialist neurological-vascular review under *Sanitätsabteilung* oversight through autumn."

Vesper wrote six cramped, obsequious bureaucratic lines certifying every syllable, blotted them dry, and looked up at her with watery, bloodshot eyes in which craven relief was already curdling into lifelong terror of the tall dark Polish woman locking his blank stamped passes inside Docent Mirecki's steel safe.

"The excised tissue from Theater One—?" he breathed.

"Ash in Boiler Two since one-fifteen," Sylwia said calmly, handing him his signed ectopic copy and opening the office door into grey dawn light. "Go wash your shirt before your orderly sees Hotel Europejski linen in your car, *Herr Stabsarzt*. I'll let you know at noon when Fräulein Lindner can drink tea."

* * *

At seven-thirty on Monday morning the twenty-sixth of July, nineteen-year-old Ilse Lindner lay awake against two flat pillows in Room Fourteen—hair re-braided neat across grey hospital ticking by Bronka, skin still translucent porcelain-white round blue-shadowed eyes, staring terrified at the high cracked ceiling plaster where five months ago Ludwig Schoeler had counted hairline water-stains.

Sylwia locked the door quietly from inside, checked the dressing—bone-dry, abdomen flat, soft laterally with faint returning bowel clicks already audible below the left costal margin, radial pulse steady at ninety-two—and gave the girl two teaspoons of lukewarm weak chamomile tea off a porcelain spoon before speaking in calm, unhurried Berlin German:

"Your ectopic pregnancy ruptured spontaneously through the right uterine horn on Saturday evening, Fräulein Lindner. Had *Stabsarzt* Vesper arrived fifteen minutes later, nothing could have saved your life. Because hemorrhage tore deep into the uterine wall and old appendicular adhesions nicked an adjacent bowel loop, removing the damaged uterine body was unavoidable; your ovaries remain completely intact, so your body and face will age normally, though you will not carry pregnancies."

Watching nineteen-year-old Bavarian eyes widen first with stunned disbelief—waiting for police handcuffs, military disgrace, Rosenheim shame!—and then fill abruptly to overflowing with hot, silent, trembling relief that spilled straight sideways into her fair braids, Sylwia felt zero satisfaction over blackmail, only dry professional mercy for girls caught underneath men's boots in every tongue.

"Does—does my unit matron see—" Ilse whispered, voice cracking smaller than Zosia's.

"Your unit matron sees *Graviditas interstitialis rupta*—a natural anatomical misfortune that happens to married countesses and convent novices alike," Sylwia said evenly, laying two cool fingers once across the girl's wrist to stop her trying to lift her head. "Keep your knees bent flat until Wednesday so your stitches hold, say nothing about Hotel Europejski room numbers to inquisitive roommates when you transfer to *Ujazdowski* convalescent ward on Friday, and next time a forty-year-old married officer offers Martell cognac after switchboard shift, walk home in the rain."

Ten minutes later, promptly on the stroke of eight, Sylwia walked upstairs into Pavilion Three's sunlit doctors' conference room and sat

down—not on her accustomed second bench beside the window, squarely in **Docent Mirecki's high-backed leather armchair** at the head of the scarred oak table.

Four male Polish surgeons stood round the cold samovar in starched white coats: gentle fifty-year-old **Doktor Jankowski**, two tired junior assistants from Pavilion One covering summer leave, and fifty-two-year-old **Doktor Stanisław Zawadzki**—a portly prewar reserve medical major from Kalisz with waxed grey moustaches who operated slow as cold molasses, hated women holding scalpels above minor outpatient boils, and had spent six months muttering over spirit-lamps whenever Sylwia's green German pass took her out early on Tuesdays.

Conversation died dead when Sylwia pulled the heavy leatherbound Operating Theater Schedule book across the oak table toward her blotter.

"Docent Mirecki's electrocardiogram shows anterior myocardial infarction," Sylwia stated cleanly without preamble. "He stays flat upstairs six weeks minimum. Municipal Health Directorate and *Sanitätsabteilung Warschau* confirmed my acting service authority through September; morning trauma triage stays mine, elective hernia and gall-bladder lists divide equally between Doktor Zawadzki and Doktor Jankowski. Let's walk Men's Ward B before Theater One heats."

Zawadzki didn't sit—he puffed his starched chest two inches wider above his grey moustache, hooking two stubby thumbs inside his white belt with an indulgent barracks smile aimed sideways at the two junior men.

"Delighted *Sanitätsabteilung Warschau* trusts your administrative versatility so warmly, Pani Koleżanko," Zawadzki drawled, letting *Sanitätsabteilung* hang greasy in the sunlit air for half a beat so nobody missed the dig. "Though before rewriting major abdominal lists, perhaps junior colleagues recall municipal statutes require ten years' post-habilitation seniority for independent laparotomy sign-off. In Ward B just now I examined Bed Nine—the eighteen-year-old brewery dray-boy kicked below the ribs by a shire horse at five a.m.—simple right flank abdominal-wall contusion without peritoneal rigidity; I ordered twenty drops tincture of opium and ice-bags until tomorrow."

Every junior eye flicked straight from Zawadzki's waxed moustache to Sylwia's white-coated shoulders: yield Bed Nine's opium order on Minute Three of Day One to keep polite peace with a fifty-two-year-

old man's vanity, and for eight weeks Pavilion Three had no chief—just squabbling committees while underground boys bled in the annex.

Sylwia stood up smoothly without raising her voice half a decibel. "Show me Bed Nine before a single drop of opium crosses his teeth, *Panie Doktorze*."

Out in Men's Ward B, eighteen-year-old Franek lay curled slightly onto his right side beneath coarse grey blankets, sweating lightly round the nostrils. True enough, when Zawadzki pressed four pompous fingers flat across the boy's anterior belly—*"Observe, gentlemen: soft left iliac fossa, zero board-like defense, pulse eighty-four!"*—the anterior rectus wall yielded soft enough to fool lazy thumbs.

Sylwia didn't poke the anterior belly first.

Warming her palm two seconds against her own sleeve, she slipped left fingertips gently behind the boy's right twelfth rib into the costovertebral angle while tapping three light percussive flicks over the upper right flank above the iliac crest, leaned low with Mirecki's ivory monaural stethoscope pressed over the right para-umbilical quadrant for fifteen silent seconds, and finally smelled the enamel kidney-dish beside the pillow where the boy had spat two tablespoons of frothy yellow-green mucus at six a.m.

Then she took her skin-marking indelible pencil and drew a neat cross over the right transpyloric plane.

"Did you percuss his right retroperitoneal flank or palpate rectally for pelvic crepitus before ordering opium to mask his pain, Doktor Zawadzki?" Sylwia asked cleanly across the iron bedstead.

Zawadzki reddened up into his bald crown. "With pulse eighty-four and a soft anterior wall—"

"Pulse sits low at hour three because retroperitoneal bile irritation stimulates vagal tone before bacterial peritonitis floods the general sac at hour ten," Sylwia said, voice crisp and surgical as Luisenstraße lecture-slate so the two young assistants drank every syllable wide-eyed. "A shod brewery horse kicking upward against the right costal cartilage drives the fixed second portion of the duodenum straight backward against the second lumbar vertebral body and splits its posterior extraperitoneal wall wide open! Right psoas sign is fiercely positive, obliteration of right kidney dullness shows retroperitoneal gas-bubbles crepitating already under my fingers, and give him twenty drops of opium till tomorrow

morning and you wheel him down to Bródno black-bellied by Thursday! Bronka—cancel the nine-o'clock varicose veins; Bed Nine goes onto Table One inside twenty minutes, and Doktor Zawadzki scrubs first assistant so we inspect his 'simple wall contusion' together."

Thirty-two minutes later under Theater One's blazing morning skylight, when Sylwia incised posterior peritoneum lateral to the ascending colon—performing a textbook Kocher mobilization that flipped the bruised duodenum smoothly medialward before four pairs of masked eyes—out hissed foul, greenish-brown bile-foam mixed with trapped retroperitoneal air-bubbles pouring straight out of a ragged **two-and-a-half-centimeter blowout laceration across the posterior duodenal wall** invisible from the front of the belly!

Above his gauze mask Doktor Stanisław Zawadzki went dead silent—ears purple, holding Sylwia's broad liver-retractor steady with both fat hands without uttering one single pompous syllable for the remaining forty-five minutes while she closed the duodenal rent transversely in two neat watertight layers so the lumen wouldn't stricture, buttressed omentum clean over the repair, and laid a soft rubber cigarette-drain out the right flank stab-wound!

When Sylwia stripped off her wet rubber gloves at quarter past ten and wrote her neat initials **S.K. (p.o. Ordynatora)**—*Acting Chief*—at the bottom of the operative register, Zawadzki bowed two stiff inches from the waist before shuffling meekly off to lance outpatient carbuncles, and Jankowski hid a quiet, delighted grin behind his hand-towel. Pavilion Three belonged to Sylwia's two hands from cellar coal-chute to third-floor rafters—leaving her clear deck for Sunday's drive into the pines.

Chapter XX

Pine Needles and Ether

Świder — Warsaw, 8 August 1943

Five kilometers past Wawer the brick tenements gave out altogether, and when Sylwia rolled the rear window of the Wanderer staff car down three inches, air rushed in smelling not of lysol, unwashed wool, or pulverized lime, but of hot dry sand, crushed wild thyme, and pitch baking in streaks down red-barked Masovian pines.

So fierce was the shock of clean resin hitting four-year-starved lungs that for ten seconds Sylwia sat dizzy against the warm grey upholstery with her eyes half-shut against the green flicker of tree-trunks rushing past at sixty kilometers an hour.

Up ahead behind the wheel, Bruno Mekelburg drove bareheaded with his field cap wedged beside the speedometer and his three-fingered left hand resting light on the ten-o'clock spoke, whistling some flat East Prussian harvest tune under engine roar. Beside Sylwia—keeping decorous six-inch military distance while passing Falenica gendarmerie posts—Ludwig wore open-necked summer field-grey cotton drill without heavy wool lining, map-board across his knees showing municipal and Wehrmacht convalescent wells marked in blue pencil between Józefów and Otwock.

"Your Stabsarzt Vesper has developed touching enthusiasm for preventive hydrology since late July," Ludwig remarked dryly without looking up from the contour sheet as another gendarmerie post waved their Wehrmacht pennant straight through without slowing. "Four countersigned sanitary transport authorizations in one fortnight, and yesterday afternoon he assured Hauptmann von Berg over iced vermouth at the Europejski that your clinical judgment is unimpeachable from Charlottenburg to Cracow. What did you catch him doing on the twenty-fourth

—stealing hospital morphine, or scraping out one of his switchboard girls?"

Sylwia kept her eyes coolly on passing pine scrub. "Ilse Lindner goes back to light switchboard duty next Monday with an intact small intestine and a textbook ectopic scar. What Stabsarzt Vesper puts in his conscience between Munich and Rosenheim belongs to his confessor."

Ludwig's mouth twitched half a millimeter at the corner—needing zero further footnotes on *intact small intestine* to reconstruct a perforated twelve-week fundus inside three seconds flat. "Remind me never to let you save my career on Table One, *Kotarska*. Vesper turns pale green whenever somebody mentions Lindleya."

At half-past twelve Mekelburg swung left off the paved Otwock highway down a rutted white-sand fire-lane flanked by bilberry bushes dusty from August drought, stopping before warped wooden double gates painted peeled turquoise in Warsaw's old *Świder-style* fretwork scroll-saw ornament: **PENSJONAT LEŚNY ZACISZE**.

Before thirty-nine, prosperous Warsaw lung specialists and bank clerks rented fretwork wooden villas along the Świder river-bluffs every August so tubercular wives and rickets-pale children could breathe pine turpentine among hammocks; in forty-one the Luftwaffe had requisitioned *Zacisze* for night-fighter rest quarters, abandoned it last autumn after two pilots caught paratyphoid B from the shallow sand-point pump, and left it padlocked behind rusty wire ever since under nominal Wehrmacht *Quartieramt* key.

First came honest work—neither Sylwia nor Ludwig ever faked cover mechanics when three real glass sample-bottles took fifteen minutes to fill properly.

While Mekelburg propped the Wanderer's bonnet open under pine shade by the outer lane gate with a grease-gun and a tin of cold army meat, Sylwia took sterile ground-glass-stoppered liter bottles out of her sanitary canvas crate, flamed the cast-iron pump spout in the mossy rear yard with burning spirit-cotton, pumped forty strokes of rust-brown sand water out onto dry nettles until cold crystal groundwater ran clear, and sealed two samples labeled *Świder Q-14* for Halina's typhoid bismuth-sulfite plates tomorrow morning.

"Wait five minutes by the pump," Sylwia told Ludwig quietly, picking up a flat brown-paper parcel wrapped separately at the bottom of

her crate. “Your well drains down-slope toward the river footpath—I’m checking whether septic seepage reaches the lower spring.”

Ludwig glanced once at the brown-paper parcel—exact size and weight of four ten-gram sulfonamide tins, six sterile eye-pads, and folded cardboard papers—and didn’t ask a single word about hydrology, turning calmly toward the villa porch steps with his brass padlock key. “Mind the dry pine needles on the bank—slippery as soap in leather soles.”

Seventy yards down the sun-baked sandy bluff, where shallow amber Świder water murmured knee-deep over white sandbars behind dense alder scrub invisible from villa or road, a barefoot boy of fourteen with a fishing pole devoid of hooks sat whittling willow bark.

Sylwia paused to rinse her hands in warm river water two yards from his bare heels. “Do perch bite low in August?”

“Only below Grójec bridge when rain comes,” the boy recited dutifully—Bronka’s sister’s youngest from Konstancin—sliding her brown-paper parcel inside his linen fish-creel in one smooth flick and handing back a folded beech-leaf holding one penciled scrap without signature: *Burn closed clean; right eye reads newsprint; carving wooden spoons under pine trees. Tell H. don’t starve for lice.*

Sylwia tucked the scrap inside her shoe-lining for Halina’s stove tonight and climbed back up the hot pine-needle path through shimmering resin heat toward the silent wooden villa.

* * *

Before climbing upstairs, they ate cold noon rations out on the shaded rear ground-floor veranda overhanging the pine ravine, where trellised wild hops screened the table completely from the sand lane two hundred yards west.

Out of a battered wicker game-basket Mekelburg had stowed in the boot came half a round of dark East Prussian pumpernickel, hard yellow Tilsit cheese sweating tiny oil-beads in thirty-degree heat, two green sour cucumbers pickled in dill by some garrison mess-woman, and a squat green bottle of dry Mosel wine cooled forty minutes down at the bottom of the icy iron pump-bucket. Halfway through uncorking the bottle, rustling footsteps shuffled round the lilac bushes from the caretaker’s shed next door: seventy-year-old **Pan Ignacy**, deaf as an oak post since

artillery service at Przemyśl in nineteen-fifteen, wearing patched linen drawers and carrying three freshly smoked silver river-bleak laid neat on a horseradish leaf.

Ignacy squinted bleary rheumy eyes first at Ludwig's unbuttoned field-grey drill collar—spitting sideways into dry nettles out of sheer seventy-year-old Masovian principle without caring who wore silver eagles—then peered closer at Sylwia's raw carbolic-scrubbed hands unscrewing glass water-sample caps and grinned three yellow teeth wide, laying the smoked river-fish in front of *her* elbow rather than the German's:

"*Woda czysta jak łza, Pani Doktor—piloci brzuchy mieli słabe od sznapsa, nie od studni!*" (*Water's clear as a tear, Doctor—those flyers had weak bellies from schnapps, not from the well!*)

"Thank your river for the fish, Grandfather," Sylwia shouted clearly into his good left ear, pressing a ten-złoty note plus two cubes of scarce ration sugar into his knotted palm before the old man shuffled contentedly back under his apple trees.

Across the unpainted pine table Ludwig watched her peel silver smoked skin deftly off tiny river-fish ribs with bare fingers, pouring four inches of cold pale-gold Mosel into two thick kitchen tumblers.

"You look ten years younger the instant brick walls drop below the horizon," Ludwig observed quietly, leaning back in his creaking wicker chair with long booted legs stretched into green hop-shadow. "Less like Poznań granite—more like how you looked walking back from Dahlem botanical gardens when chestnuts bloomed."

Sylwia paused with white fish-flake at her lip, narrowing dark eyes sharply across sunlit tumblers. "When did you ever see me walk back from Dahlem botanical gardens? Pathological anatomy met four miles north on Luisenstraße."

A faint, dry curve touched the corner of Ludwig's mouth—not victorious, almost rueful at giving away old cover after fourteen years.

"Spring twenty-nine—May, right after you came back from Poznań in black mourning bands for your mother and stopped speaking to everybody in Waldeyer's hall for six weeks," Ludwig said evenly, swirling pale wine once in thick kitchen glass. "I took the Wannsee suburban train out to Dahlem twice on Sunday afternoons to borrow Professor Warburg's respiration-manometer reprints—and saw you sitting alone on the stone bench behind the Carpathian birch-grove reading Sauerbruch's *Thorax-*

chirurgie with black ribbon stitched across your grey lapel, eating one dry roll out of waxed paper so furiously you looked ready to bite the squirrels if one begged crumbs."

Sylwia stared at him across green hop-filtered light—genuinely stunned silent for three seconds because she remembered that stone bench behind Dahlem's Carpathian birches down to the birch-bark smell after Helena Kotarska's funeral in April twenty-nine!

"And you didn't come down the path to gloat or pick an argument over Warburg's numbers?" she asked slowly.

"Started down the gravel once," Ludwig admitted dryly. "Got within twenty yards, saw your chin go up three inches at two harmless theology students who merely tipped straw hats passing your bench, decided even my skull wasn't thick enough to interrupt Polish mourning with German grammar, and walked out the south gate instead." He took a slow sip of cold Mosel, green eyes turning graver over the rim. "What was your father like in Poznań before thirty-seven? Berlin's foreign-student card listed *Kazimierz Kotarski, Legationsrat a.D.*—retired diplomatic counsellor—nothing else."

Nobody inside occupied Warsaw had asked Sylwia to speak aloud of her father as a living human man since October thirty-nine; hear a dead parent's name spoken casually across sunlit pine boards with sour dill and Mosel smelling like peacetime summer, and something long-calcified inside her chest creaked painfully shifting weight.

"Quiet, ironic, impeccably shaved at six-thirty every morning even when angina kept him sitting propped in chairs all night," Sylwia said after a beat, tracing condensation wet down cold tumbler glass with one forefinger. "Served twelve years in Vienna before nineteen-eighteen under Austro-Hungarian parliamentary delegations, then eight years on the Polish-German Upper Silesian Mixed Boundary Commission settling coal-mine shafts cut in half by frontier posts—half a seam in Katowice, air-shaft in Beuthen. He insisted I study surgery in Berlin rather than Cracow or Paris."

Ludwig raised one brow slightly. "Why Berlin, after boundary commissions?"

"'Because Frenchmen think charm cures sepsis, Sylwia,'" she quoted her father's dry, precise baritone straight into pine-scented air, feeling an unexpected ghostly warmth sting behind her nose, "'whereas Prussians

keep meticulous autopsy statistics even while planning to steal your horse—and if a neighbor four hundred miles wide shares five hundred miles of unfenced flat sand with your kitchen door, know how his hands work inside out before dark falls.'" She looked straight across the pine table into Ludwig's stripped, unguarded face. "He died of his third coronary in November thirty-seven—two years early enough to think he'd merely taught me vascular sutures."

"And your naval captain in Kiel?" she turned the blade cleanly back across pine boards—watching whether Ludwig shuttered up the instant his own dead entered the porch. "Frame Three on that thirty-five-millimeter strip said you handed Major von Bredow your father's nineteen-eighteen naval files."

Ludwig didn't flinch or look away into the pines; only his jaw settled quiet and clean.

"Corvette-Captain Heinrich Schoeler commanded torpedo-boat *V-69* through Jutland and Ostend without losing a boiler," Ludwig said simply. "In October nineteen-eighteen, when Kiel Admiralty staffs ordered one suicide sortie into the Thames purely so admirals could dine in honourable captivity while forty thousand twenty-year-old stokers drowned six days before an armistice already wired to Wilson, my father locked his firing-keys inside his cabin safe and steamed his flotilla back inside Wilhelmshaven mole without shooting mutinous boys or lowering his ensign. Died of Spanish influenza complication in twenty-one with court-martial papers still pending unclosed in naval archives—meaning until thirty-three my mother's widow's pension hung on Weimar ministerial grace every January." His thumb rested steady against cool green bottle glass. "Handing von Bredow my father's unpublished Wilhelmshaven log-notes gave *Abwehr*'s naval historians their neat cautionary archive file—and closed my mother's pension audit permanently before she died in thirty-eight. Cheap trade, considering."

Silence hung warm and vast across the shaded veranda—woodpeckers tapping high in red-barked trunks, river water rustling silver below the sandy bluff, neither pretending thirty-nine hadn't happened, yet sitting two yards apart across bread and smoked river-fish realizing with quiet, bone-deep shock that both of them had grown straight out of dead men who refused to drown boys for flags.

Down by the outer gate two hundred yards away, Mekelburg lay stretched contentedly on a canvas groundsheet beneath the car axle smoking pipe-tobacco at white summer clouds. Up on the wide first-floor fretwork veranda of the villa, every tall shutter stood latched against August glare save one half-open French door leading into the corner upstairs bedroom overhanging the pines.

Inside, the house smelled zero percent of war—only baked resinous pine-plank, dried lavender sachets left behind four summers ago inside empty wardrobe drawers, and hot dust sleeping in golden tiger-stripes across bare scrubbed deal floorboards where afternoon sun sliced through angled wooden shutter-slats.

Ludwig had stripped off his field-grey drill tunic, belt, holster, and boots—hanging pistol and silver shoulder-boards deliberately *outside* on a hall peg so nothing grey or metallic entered the corner room—standing barefoot in loose summer linen shirt unbuttoned to the waist beside a wide prewar maple bedstead covered only in one clean unbleached linen dust-sheet he had shaken fresh out the veranda rail.

Sylwia shut the French door softly behind her, turned the small brass thumb-latch, and stood still in the striped amber light.

For twenty-five days since the fourteenth of July—through three hurried twenty-minute Tuesday-and-Friday collisions on Królewska where clocks ticked loud and German boots passed outside—she had carried *Polizeipräsidium Berlin, 7. März 1933, Haftbefehl gestrichen lt. RWM 11:45 Uhr* locked behind her ribs without breathing one syllable aloud. Partly because until Berlin's August courier packet cleared Kroll's desk she couldn't afford shaking Ludwig's focus by half an inch; deeper and truer, because once you admitted aloud to Ludwig Schoeler that for ten years you had spat on him for saving your life with seven years of his own skin, the last wall standing between your pride and total free-fall vanished into air.

"Two hours before Vesper's driver log expects us past Wawer," Ludwig said quietly across twelve feet of warm pine floor, noticing how motionless she stood in the golden slats. "You don't have to hurry your hairpins today."

Sylwia didn't reach for her hairpins first; walking slowly across sun-warmed bare planks that creaked gentle summer resin under her steps, she unbuckled her thin leather wristwatch—the watch she checked

clamping minutes and curfew bells on twenty times a day—and laid it face-down on the windowsill so neither dial nor ticking existed in the room.

Then she kicked off her dusty leather walking shoes, unrolled both dark lisle stockings down pale calves bare to warm forest air, and stood still when Ludwig stepped close in front of her to unbutton her plain grey cotton summer dress himself from throat to hem.

Nothing rushed today. Every button slipping slow through linen sounded distinct in dead pine-wood hush punctuated only by woodpeckers hammering dry bark fifty yards down the slope and wind sighing continuous sea-waves through tall crowns overhead.

When grey cotton slid off her shoulders pooling round her bare ankles on warm wood, wearing only worn white batiste slip—she owned no silk—she raised both hands to pull the steel *szpilki* pins one by one out of her heavy dark coil until thick black hair tumbled past her shoulder-blades down to her ribs, longer than anyone in Warsaw except her washbasin ever saw it.

Ludwig's fingers tangled slowly into that dark loose weight on both sides of her neck, thumbs resting light along her jawbone as he looked down at her in warm slatted light without a trace of Berlin armor left round his eyes.

"Turn round a second," he murmured.

Still bruise-sensitive? Four weeks ago on Nowy Świat that drunken *Schupo*'s rifle-butt had left green-yellow shadow across her left scapula; when she turned half-round, pulling her thin batiste slip clean over her head and tossing it onto a wicker chair so she stood completely naked in tiger-striped sunlight, warm rough fingers traced gently across the healed smooth skin of her left shoulder-blade—finding zero bruise left, only clean muscle and sharp starved ribs showing individual ivory arches whenever she drew breath—followed a heartbeat later by his warm mouth pressing slow, open kisses down each protruding thoracic vertebra from nape to small of back.

Sylwia closed her eyes with a sharp, silent shiver despite thirty-degree August warmth, leaning back half an inch against his bare linen chest until his hands slid forward round her ribs—cupping both bare breasts full in rough palms, thumbs rolling slow across tightening dark nipples

while he backed her three unhurried steps onto the sun-warmed linen sheet of the wide maple bed.

He pulled his own linen shirt over his head and stripped trousers down lean sun-browned legs—white only across narrow hips and groin between July tan and that jagged white forty-one shell-scar above his right hipbone—coming down onto one elbow beside her across six whole feet of wide mattress where nobody bumped iron cot-rails or watched clocks!

For ten minutes he didn't enter her at all—simply studied her bare body stretched in golden shutter-stripes as if memorizing topography before dark fell, picking up her left hand from the sheet and turning her raw, mercury-fissured palm face-up to press his thumb gently over the four tiny white twelve-year-old stitch-scars across her thumb base.

"Still clean," Ludwig murmured almost inaudibly, bending his head to kiss the scarred base of her left thumb once—warm lips lingering over his own nineteen-thirty-one needlework—before his mouth traveled up the inner aspect of her bare forearm, across her bicep, onto her breastbone, taking her left breast deep and hot into his mouth while his hand slid slow down the flat plane of her belly into thick dark hair between her thighs.

Sylwia's breath broke audible into the high wooden rafters—no sentries outside, no walls with ears, terrifying luxury of letting sound leave her throat!—arching her spine upward off warm linen as two clever, unhurried surgeon's fingers parted slick wet folds, sliding deep inside her while the pad of his thumb found her clitoris wet and unguarded.

When his mouth left her breast to trail slow, biting heat down her ribs, across her navel, and straight down between her spread knees—pushing both her bare thighs wide across sun-striped linen with broad shoulders and settling his mouth hot and open directly against her—Sylwia's hands flew instinctively to grab his blond hair, half pulling him off in fierce, shocked reflex because nobody in ten gray years had looked at her there in broad afternoon sun, before a long, flat, devastating stroke of his tongue straight up through wet heat made her head slam back into the pillow with a choked Polish cry!

He held both her writhing hips pinned firm to the mattress with hard palms so she couldn't twist away from the unbearable precision of his mouth—tongue circling slow, relentless, sucking swollen flesh lightly between smooth lips while two fingers curved upward inside her against

the exact anterior wall until every nerve from thighs to solar plexus pulled taut as violin gut about to snap. Stripped of every shred of control in broad amber light, fingers knotted white in his hair, Sylwia came apart violently under his mouth—hips bucking helplessly against his face with a long, broken gasp that echoed off pine rafters while waves of blinding heat clenched empty and aching round his fingers!

Before the last aftershock ebbed out of her thighs, Ludwig came straight up the length of her trembling body—mouth slick and salty with her own taste crushing down onto hers so she tasted herself hot on his tongue—parting her knees wide with his thighs and sliding thick, burning-hard, and unhurried all the way home inside her in one long continuous glide that joined them chest to chest, hip to hip, mouth to mouth.

No frantic bruising race today: deep, slow, rolling strokes in resin-scented quiet where sweat slicked skin gold in shutter-bars and neither looked away for thirty heartbeats at a stretch. Wrapped tight round him —legs locked high across his lean scarred flanks, raw hands sliding over smooth corded muscle across his shoulders down to the sunken purple keloid star beneath his missing collarbone where his blood hammered hot against her breast—Sylwia watched every defensive seam in Ludwig Schoeler's face come undone six inches above hers: grey-green eyes dark and unguarded down to sixteen-year-old bone, breath catching ragged in her throat whenever she clenched deliberately round him on the out-stroke, dragging it out slow and merciless until sweat dripped off his brow onto her cheek, his rhythm broke rough and deep driving hard against her cervix, and a second deeper, slower climax rolled straight up from the base of her spine—pulling him right over the cliff with her, burying his face hard against her neck with a low, torn groan as he pulsed hot and endless deep inside her.

* * *

At quarter past four shutter-stripes had shifted forty degrees eastward across the ceiling planks, turning deep honey-amber.

Outside on the upper veranda sill sat an enamel wash-basin full of small dark-purple wild wood-plums (*lubaszki*) Mekelburg had picked off overgrown orchard trees down by the lane gate at three o'clock and left

silently outside the downstairs screen door before going back to sleep under a pine tree—discreet as an old sexton.

Wrapped in nothing except the single rumpled linen bedsheet pulled lazily across one hip and Ludwig's bare thigh, Sylwia sat propped against the maple headboard spitting plum stones *ping, ping* into a tin soap-dish while purple plum-juice stained her thumb and lower lip dark wine.

"Sour as vinegar," she observed, tossing him a bruised black one anyway.

Ludwig caught it left-handed—effortless overhead snag without shoulder hitch!—bit half off round the stone, winced dramatically, and swallowed it anyway. Lying flat on his back beside her hip with his right arm folded behind his sun-streaked head and left palm resting warm and idle atop Sylwia's bare knee, thirty-four vanished ten minutes at a time: flat stomach relaxed, chest scar fading paler violet in cool shade, three faint white laugh-creases at the outer corners of his eyes she hadn't seen since Wannsee before thirty-three.

"Better than Frau Geheimrat von Halden's Wannsee plum tart in thirty-one," Ludwig said dryly. "Remember when Oberarzt Weber dropped half his plate overboard trying to salute the Geheimrat from a tipping dinghy—"

"—and von Halden's fat dachshund *Waldmann* jumped straight off the dock thinking plum tart was liverwurst," Sylwia picked up before she could stop herself, "and had to be fished out of Wannsee weeds with a boat-hook by Kleist while barking like a seal!"

Ludwig's chest shook first; half a second later—catching the grotesque mental picture of fat Kleist slipping nose-first into green duckweed in white flannel trousers while holding a wet dachshund by the tail—Sylwia snorted purple plum juice onto the back of her wrist, and **both of them burst out laughing aloud at the exact same instant**.

Real laughter—loud, rusty from years of disuse, helpless belly-laughter bouncing strange and bright off dry pine walls while sunlight glinted off bare shoulders and Sylwia wiped plum juice off her chin with the sheet corner!

Three seconds it lasted. Maybe four.

Then the sound of their own two voices echoing cheerful and carefree inside four walls—twenty-five kilometers from Pawiak cells, burnt Muranów brick-pits, and nine-millimeter execution rounds in Mokotów

courtyards—hit both pairs of ears simultaneously like cold iron dropped onto glass.

The laugh died cleanly off Ludwig's mouth; Sylwia's hand stopped halfway down from her chin.

Looking sideways at each other across twelve inches of sunlit sheet in the sudden ringing quiet of the pines, Sylwia felt a cold, piercing ache sharper than any scalpel cut she had ever taken—realizing for one naked, terrifying second what two ordinary human lives in peacetime Berlin or Poznań might have sounded like at thirty-three on an August Sunday afternoon if nineteen-thirty-three had never burned down the sky, and hating history so fiercely for showing her four seconds of it that her throat closed tight.

Ludwig didn't pretend he hadn't felt the exact blade twist.

His left hand tightened quietly once over her bare kneecap—not speaking a word to cheapen the silence—before swinging his legs off the maple bedstead to pick up his summer cotton shirt off the floor.

"Quarter to five," he said softly, handing her watch back off the windowsill without turning it face-up. "Mekelburg needs forty minutes before dusk checkpoints tighten at Grochów."

Twenty minutes later, hair pinned severe again, grey cotton dress buttoned neat to the collar over skin still smelling faintly of pine resin and salt, Sylwia sat three inches clear of his sleeve in the back seat as the Wanderer rolled smoothly north along the paved Wawer highway toward Warsaw's darkening smoke-haze.

Three kilometers short of Grochów toll-bar, traffic slowed to five kilometers an hour around two smoldering farm cottages beside the ditch whose thatched roofs had been torched since noon—grey greasy smoke curling low across potato rows while two dead farm-dogs lay stiff by the gatepost and four fresh pink-paper *Bekanntmachung* placards glistened wet with flour-paste on telegraph poles: *For harboring armed bandits and failing to report railway sabotage tools, the farmstead of Jan Kowalski has been burned and six male inhabitants shot under martial law, 8 August 1943.*

Inside the rolling staff car nobody turned their head away from the glass, and nobody reached across the grey wool cushion between them.

Sylwia stared straight out at the wet pink paper flashing past the window with cold black eyes while her bare left palm rested closed around Halina's beech-leaf note inside her pocket—carrying two irreconcilable

worlds back inside Warsaw's gates without letting either kill the other before dark.

Chapter XXI

The Sentence on Filtrowa

Warsaw, 19–20 August 1943

Wanda had buttoned her blue polka-dot crêpe dress one hole crooked from the collar all the way to the waist, so the left hem drooped two inches lower than the right above dusty white kid shoes put on without stockings, and she smelled from six feet off of sour bile and *4711* lavender water splashed frantically over unwashed neck-skin.

At ten minutes past six on Thursday morning—when night orderlies were still sloshing grey lysol suds across Pavilion Three's vestibule tiles and Sylwia had just come down from her third-floor dormer cubby buttoning a fresh ward smock over dark circles—Wanda stumbled straight past old Walenty's desk without answering his *Dzień dobry*, spotted Sylwia by the staircase arch, and grabbed both her wrists with icy, clawing fingers whose pink nail-varnish was chipped half off.

"Not in the hall," Sylwia said instantly, pulling her older half-sister sideways through the narrow pine door of the ground-floor splint-and-linen closet before any probationer nurse or early German courier saw Kazimierz Kotarski's elder daughter shaking like a wet dog.

Before Sylwia even shot the inner bolt, Wanda's plump knees folded clean out from under her; she went down hard onto the scrubbed boards among stacked canvas stretcher-slings, wrapping both bare white arms tight round Sylwia's knees and pressing her damp, powder-streaked cheek flat against Sylwia's white hospital skirt while dry hiccuping sobs tore out of her chest!

"Get off the floor, Wanda," Sylwia said sharply, hooking both hands under Wanda's soft perspiring armpits and hauling sixty-eight kilos of dead sister-weight bodily up onto an upturned crate of plaster bandages.

"Stop choking before somebody hears through the transom. Is it Staś? Did his morning sugar crash?"

"Not Staś—*Stefan*!" Wanda gasped, fumbling wildly inside her beaded handbag with trembling thumbs until she tore the rayon lining and pulled out a single four-inch square of thin grey manifold tissue folded twice. "Under the front brass mat at five-thirty when the milk-woman knocked —Stefan went out in his dressing-gown for the bottle, read two lines in the hall, and threw up his coffee all over the parquet! Oh, Mother of Mercy, Sylwia, they're going to shoot him on the stairs in front of Staś—!"

Sylwia smoothed the damp grey manifold square flat across her palm beneath the single bare forty-watt closet bulb.

Typed cleanly through fresh purple carbon without a single spelling error, headed at top left with the crisp hand-stamped black anchor-P emblem (*Kotwica*) of Underground Civil Resistance:

KIEROWNICTWO WALKI PODZIEMNEJ — OKRĘG WARSZAWA Do: Inż. Stefana Bielskiego, ul. Filtrowa 68 (DVL Gr. III). Stwierdzono współudział w przekazywaniu wykazów robotników Warsztatów Tramwajowych Wola do obozu przejściowego przy ul. Skaryszewskiej w okresie IV–VII 1943 r. Wzywa się niniejszym do natychmiastowego zaprzestania czynności administracyjnych na szkodę Narodu Polskiego w terminie 48 godzin. Niezastosowanie się pociągnie wykonanie wyroku śmierci.

Forty-eight hours to cease administrative acts harmful to the Polish Nation; non-compliance brings execution of sentence of death.

Sylwia folded the grey square once along its crease, feeling zero surprise—only cold, grim recognition of those two silent forty-year-old Wola toolmakers leaning against Turret Lathe Three behind Stefan's sweaty white dust-coat on the fourth of July. Six weeks it had taken Wola's shop-floor cell to verify the Majdanek death postcards of the four April absentees against Stefan's counter-signed payroll sheets, send the file upstairs to Civil Resistance judges, and slip a polite forty-eight-hour final warning under Filtrowa's brass mat instead of shooting him blind through his coat on Monday morning.

"He got off lucky with a warning sheet," Sylwia said coldly, looking down at Wanda dabbing streaming china-blue eyes with a crumpled lace handkerchief. "Real Gestapo informers don't get forty-eight hours' notice —they get nine-millimeter lead in Mokotów courtyards before breakfast."

Wanda stared up at her in horrified disbelief, round mouth trembling open. "Lucky?! Sylwia, your own sister's husband! Stefan never hurt a fly in his life—Direktor Krehl puts thirty payroll sheets in front of him at five p.m. Fridays and screams about sabotage if Stefan doesn't initial the bottom margin! If Stefan walks into Krehl's office tomorrow morning and resigns his post without medical cause, Krehl revokes our *Volksliste* card inside two hours, hands Stefan straight to Skaryszewska himself for economic sabotage, and throws Staś and me onto the street without coal or rations! You *know* those underground boys—everyone on Filtrowa knows doctors at *Dzieciątka Jezus* hide shot boys in cellars! Go tell their commander today that Stefan only signed under German duress and keeps our child alive!"

Every word Wanda cried in that cramped linen closet smelled of turnip soup boiled with collaborator's goose-necks and closed shutters while black human ash blew onto Easter lace.

Sylwia braced one raw palm against the shelf beside Wanda's ear and leaned down until her dark eyes sat eight inches from her sister's tear-swollen face.

"Listen to me carefully, Wanda, and stop blubbering about what everyone on Filtrowa knows before you hang twenty innocent nurses," Sylwia said in a voice quiet enough to freeze boiling fat. "First: I command zero underground courts, and even if I drank tea with General Komorowski every Tuesday, nobody on earth cancels a Wola shop-floor warning while four Polish fitters' widows hold Majdanek ash-cards bearing Stefan's payroll initials. Second: if Stefan keeps sitting at that desk past Saturday morning—or worse, asks German police for armed guards—two nineteen-year-old boys in railway caps will shoot him through the stomach on Filtrowa's steps next week while Staś carries his schoolbag two paces behind him."

Wanda clapped both hands over her mouth, letting out a muffled animal keen behind her rings.

"Does Stefan know you came here?" Sylwia demanded.

"No—he locked himself in his study telephoning some *Volksdeutsche* lawyer cousin from Łódź about applying for emergency railway transfer to Breslau!"

Breslau. There sat the true measure of Stefan Bielski's spine: inside forty minutes of reading an underground warning, he wasn't figuring out

how to stop signing Polish workers onto death lorries—he was trying to bolt four hundred kilometers west into the Reich, dragging nine-year-old diabetic Staś out of reach of Sylwia's syringes into bombed German cities, or leaving wife and sick boy behind to face empty cupboards!

"Go straight home before he telephones Direktor Krehl and signs his own death warrant," Sylwia ordered, pulling Wanda upright off the plaster crate and buttoning her sister's crooked polka-dot dress straight from neck to waist with swift, pitiless surgeon's fingers as if dressing a six-year-old child. "Unplug your hall telephone wire at the baseboard junction—pull one copper screw loose with nail-scissors and tell Stefan the street line's dead—and keep him inside Number Sixty-Eight until noon. I'll come after morning amputations with my bag."

* * *

At twelve-twenty Filtrowa baked white and shadeless under August noon glare; tar smelled thick along tram-rails, and inside Number Sixty-Eight every heavy plush curtain had been drawn tight across the bay windows by Stefan lest snipers sit perched in linden trees across the street.

In the stifling green gloom of his mahogany study, Stefan Bielski sat behind his desk with an unlit prewar *Havana* cigar chewed wet and shredded at the butt between his teeth, an open leather Gladstone valise half-stuffed with starched shirts on the sofa, and a tiny nickel-plated 6.35-millimeter ladies' Browning vest-pistol—some forgotten nineteen-thirty relic incapable of stopping an angry terrier at ten paces—lying absurdly beside his blotter!

Out in the hallway behind the closed frosted-glass sliding doors of the dining room, Sylwia had glimpsed a small dark-haired shadow sitting motionless on a plush chair beside the rubber plant as she walked in: nine-year-old Staś, pretending to paste postage stamps into an album while straining both ears through cracked oak veneer to hear why Mama had vomited at six and Papa held a toy pistol in the dark.

"Unplugged!" Stefan barked hoarsely the instant Sylwia shut the study door behind her, gray-jowled face glistening oily under the shaded desk-lamp, waistcoat hanging loose because inside six hours terror had already shrunk his belly two inches. "Whole block's telephone exchange cut since seven-thirty—bandits cutting wires before an attack, I tell you! If Wanda

hadn't hidden my hat I'd have walked straight down to the *Schutzpolizei* post at Narutowicz Square by nine and demanded two gendarmes on our gate!"

Sylwia set her black leather surgical bag calmly down on the corner of his desk right beside the ridiculous nickel vest-pistol, picked up the tiny gun by two fingers, clicked its safety on—it had been lying cocked off-safe pointed straight at Stefan's own groin!—and dropped it contemptuously into his pen-tray.

"Ask Narutowicz *Schutzpolizei* for two gendarmes on a *Volksliste Three* probationer's gate," Sylwia said conversationally, "and first they laugh in your face because German police don't guard Silesian half-breeds round the clock; second, Wola's liquidation team shoots you climbing onto a tram three mornings later instead of at home—plus adds Wanda to the collaborator list for calling German rifles into a Polish stairwell."

"Then Breslau!" Stefan slammed a damp palm onto the half-packed leather valise. "Krehl's head office in Breslau offered two experienced rolling-stock engineers permanent Reich municipal transfer last month—housing guaranteed, Reich fat cards, German clinic insulin for Staś—"

"Group Three *Volksliste* poles transferred into the Reich since Stalingrad don't sit behind desks in Breslau for six weeks before Wehrmacht replacement boards reclassify men under forty-five *kv*—fit for Eastern Front infantry trenches," Sylwia cut across him like cold wire. "Within ninety days you're freezing outside Vitebsk in grey wool while Wanda cleans barracks latrines in Lower Silesia and Staś dies of diabetic ketoacidosis the first week Allied bombers hit Breslau's pharmacy depot."

Stefan sank heavily down into his swivel chair, chewing the cold wet shred of cigar leaf until brown juice stained his lip. All bluster collapsed out of his fat shoulders at once, leaving bare forty-two-year-old terror staring up at the sister-in-law he had patronized over goose-neck soup since forty-one.

"Then what in Christ's name am I supposed to do?!" he whispered raggedly. "Walk into Krehl's shed tomorrow saying *I quit*—and go to Auschwitz by Friday night for work-refusal?!"

Sylwia unlatched her black Gladstone bag and took out two small objects she had compounded down in Pavilion Three's pharmacy mortar at eleven-thirty while Bronka watched the door:

Two fat white gelatin veterinary-size cachet capsules packed solid with **one hundred and eighty milligrams each of pure, dry crystalline picric acid**—trinitrophenol, peeled straight off Halina's histology fixing shelf and Bronka's burn-ointment stock—alongside one stamped, official pale-green *Sanitätsabteilung Warschau* hospital quarantine requisition bearing **Stabsarzt Dr. Kurt Vesper's** genuine round violet eagle seal and signature from July twenty-fourth!

She laid both white capsules on a clean prescription blank under Stefan's nose.

"Swallow one capsule right now with warm water, and the second at midnight," Sylwia said calmly.

Stefan stared down at the two big white capsules as if she had laid two live hornets on his blotter. "What's inside them?"

"Three hundred and sixty milligrams total of crystalline picric acid," Sylwia said without softening a syllable. "Old nineteen-sixteen Austrian army trick from the Isonzo front—we autopsied two cases at Charité when reservists tried dodging winter maneuvers. Inside eight hours it binds reversibly to serum albumin and skin elastin, turning the whites of your eyes, every square inch of your skin from scalp to toenails, and every drop of your urine brilliant canary-chrome yellow—completely indistinguishable on bedside inspection from severe acute epidemic *icterus catarrhalis* or Weil's spirochetal jaundice."

Stefan's jaw dropped slack. "Poison?!"

"At two grams picric acid destroys red cells and kidneys; at zero point three-six grams it gives you twelve hours of authentic stomach cramps, brisk green diarrhea, mild headache, and three weeks of glorious yellow skin without damaging a single liver lobule," Sylwia said crisply. "Tomorrow morning at eight o'clock, when your eyeballs look like two boiled egg-yolks, an infectious-disease ambulance summoned on *Stabsarzt* Vesper's own Wehrmacht sanitary warrant collects you publicly from Filtrowa under diagnosis *Hepatitis epidemica contagiosa gravis — Verdacht auf Morbus Weilii.* Direktor Krehl is terrified out of his wits of infectious diseases since July's typhus scare—the second Vesper's stamped certificate lands on his desk tomorrow noon certifying minimum six-to-eight weeks' contagious isolation and permanent disqualification from crowded workshop floors due to hepatic insufficiency, Krehl strikes you

off active Wola personnel rolls himself and appoints a German foreman while leaving your *Ostbahn* sick-pay card intact for sixty days!"

Silence hung thick inside the dark green room except for the brass pendulum clock ticking steady quarters in the hall.

"And—and the people who put that grey paper under my mat?" Stefan whispered, wiping cold sweat off his forehead.

"By two o'clock tomorrow afternoon the Wola shop-committee sees Vesper's copy confirming Inżynier Bielski has been hauled away yellow as saffron into contagious isolation and permanently replaced at the sheds," Sylwia said, voice dropping flat and lethal as slate. "Recover conveniently in October into some quiet warehouse coal-tally clerkship where not one single Polish workman's name ever crosses your pen again, Stefan—because I have two capsules left in that bottle, and if you ever set foot inside Wola's sheds or touch another absentee list while this war lasts, I won't bring picric acid next time. Swallow."

She poured half a tumbler of tepid carafe water and pushed it across the mahogany.

For five seconds Stefan stared at the huge white gelatin capsule—terrified half to death that his icy-eyed sister-in-law might genuinely have packed cyanide or corrosive sublimate inside to make Wanda a respectable widow!—then remembered nine-millimeter bullets on front stairs, shut both eyes tight, shoved Capsule One onto the back of his furry tongue, and gulped half the tumbler down with a loud, convulsive *glug* that made his Adam's apple bounce like a cork.

Out in the sunny hallway five minutes later, ignoring Wanda's tearful attempts to kiss her hands by the coat-rack, Sylwia slid open the frosted-glass dining-room door three inches.

Nine-year-old Staś sat bolt upright beside his stamp album, pale knuckles locked white round his knees.

"Papa has bad liver-jaundice coming on from bad workshop water, Stasiu," Sylwia told him quietly, winking zero eyes—speaking straight dignified clinic cover a clever nine-year-old could repeat to schoolmates without shame while knowing inside his calm dark Kotarski bones that Aunt Sylwia had just nailed the roof back onto the house. "Ambulance takes him to Pavilion One for rest tomorrow morning. Check your afternoon urine sugar twice on Fridays while Mama fusses, and save me the Brazilian airmail stamps."

"Yes, Ciocia," Staś said steadily, shoulders dropping two full inches out of his ears as he let go his knees.

* * *

By nine o'clock Friday morning Stefan Bielski looked as if someone had dipped him up to the hair-roots into a vat of Easter turmeric dye —sclerae glaring bright chrome-lemon, plump jowls stained deep saffron-gold down into his striped pajama collar, groaning with completely genuine abdominal misery over an enamel slop-basin inside Pavilion One's ground-floor contagious jaundice cubicle.

Direktor Krehl, however, had not stayed fifty years in Silesian railway machine-shops by trusting Polish hospital paper sight unseen.

At half-past ten Walenty hurried across the sunny courtyard holding his cap to warn Sylwia that **Oberwerkmeister Hübner**—Krehl's bull-necked German shop superintendent from Wola, accompanied by a skeptical *Ostbahn* personnel clerk carrying absentee disciplinary forms—had just marched into Pavilion One's admissions vestibule demanding to see "this overnight liver-inflammation of Herr Ingenieur Bielski with my own two eyes before I report malingering to Railway Security!"

Sylwia didn't send a junior intern; buttoning a stiff, unbleached canvas contagious-isolation smock up to her chin and tying a carbolic-reeking gauze mask round her hair, she walked briskly out into Pavilion One's tiled vestibule carrying a freshly filled glass urinal flask glowing luminescent greenish-canary in the morning sun!

"Herr Oberwerkmeister Hübner?" Sylwia stopped three paces upwind of the red-faced German shop-boss, holding out a dripping pair of rubberized isolation overshoes and a wet carbolic mask by iron tongs. "Splendid —kindly step into rubber galoshes and sign our mandatory *Morbus Weilii* contagious-exposure waiver before entering Cubicle Three. Since Tuesday morning we have lost two municipal sewer-orderlies from Wola to acute spirochetal hemorrhagic jaundice transmitted through workshop rat-urine droplets, and *Stabsarzt* Doktor Vesper requires complete residential contact-addresses for fourteen-day military quarantine of anyone breathing within two meters of an active shed case."

Hübner's thick red hand froze halfway toward the rubber overshoes; behind him the *Ostbahn* clerk backed hastily into a potted fern.

"Rat-urine hemorrhagic—two dead since Tuesday?!" Hübner barked, squinting distrustfully past Sylwia's shoulder down the dim green-painted corridor toward Cubicle Three's small wired-glass observation pane. "Look through the glass only—five seconds from the corridor!"

"By all means—hold your breath near the transom," Sylwia invited smoothly, stepping aside so Hübner craned his thick neck twelve inches from the sealed glass pane just as Bronka inside Cubicle Three—timed down to the second on Sylwia's heel-click!—propped poor groaning Stefan upright off damp pillows into full south window-glare!

Even through thick wired glass Stefan looked horrifying: bright chrome-yellow eyeballs rolling wretchedly inside sunken saffron sockets, greenish sweat beading across a turmeric forehead before he doubled forward retching half a pint of bitter yellow water noisily into Bronka's basin!

Hübner recoiled three full paces backward off the glass as if Stefan had spat live cobras through the putty, clapping a checkered handkerchief tight over nose and mouth.

"God in heaven—he's yellower than brass!" Hübner wheezed through cotton, snatching his fountain pen out of his breast pocket and slapping the *Ostbahn* clerk's clipboard flat against his own thigh twenty yards out in open courtyard sunshine to scrawl **Dauernd abgelöst wegen Seuchengefahr — Ersatzmann sofort eingesetzt** (*Permanently relieved due to epidemic hazard — replacement assigned immediately*) across all three copies of Vesper's violet-stamped certificate before bolting out Lindleya's gate to gargle schnapps!

At quarter past two that afternoon, Sylwia got off a Number Nine tram on Młynarska in scorching white dust and stepped inside Kubiak's dark, fly-buzzing corner beer-bar opposite the tramway repair gates, ordering one small glass of sour watery *piwo* at the zinc counter two stools down from the older of the two blue-capped Wola turret-lathe toolmakers eating dry bread and lard on his shift break.

She didn't look at him, didn't speak a code-word, didn't know his name from Adam.

Taking half a sip of warm beer, she laid the carbon third-copy of Pavilion One's stamped municipal infectious admission slip—*Bielski, Stefan, Inż. — Icterus infectiosus gravis, Isolierstation I, dauernd dienstunfähig für Werkstättenbetrieb Wola*—face-up beside the salt-cellar while tying her

handbag strap, left it lying accidentally behind on dry zinc when she turned out into the glare, and saw reflected in the fly-spotted mirror behind vodka bottles one scarred lathe-turner's thumb slide smoothly sideways over the paper before her shoe cleared the doorsill.

Nobody died on Filtrowa's steps this week.

Yet when she climbed Service Stair B at Królewska Sixteen three hours later at five-ten—still carrying two faint canary-yellow pinpricks of picric acid stain deeply fixed into the horny cuticle of her right index finger where mortar dust had touched wet skin yesterday—the quiet air inside *Wohnung 4* felt tauter than violin wire before her bag touched wood.

Mekelburg wasn't polishing boots today; the boy sat cleaning the disassembled bolt and extractor spring of his Walther P38 AND a heavy Sauer rifle on oiled canvas across the kitchen table—field-kit maintenance, not garrison spit-and-polish!

Inside the study Ludwig wore full buttoned field-grey tunic even in twenty-nine-degree August heat, standing over an open dispatch-cipher box beside the cold porcelain stove while burning four thick sheaves of Tirpitzufer blue flimsies so fast grey smoke curled lazily past the flue damper.

When the double doors clicked shut behind Sylwia, he walked straight across the parquet, took her raw right hand in his, glanced once with faint dark humor at the two indestructible bright-yellow picric dots beside her nail—

"Austrian nineteen-sixteen jaundice?" he guessed instantly inside half a beat, before all humor vanished clean off his bone structure. "Good. Keep your sister's household indoors after dusk next month. Have you still got that altered black silk dress from your mother's trunk?"

Sylwia stared up at him, every nerve tightening cold. Wait: when had she ever mentioned Helena's altered nineteen-twenty-nine black silk concert dress? Once—lying half-asleep in June's air-raid dark when he asked what four things fit inside two suitcases leaving Berlin!

"Why would I wear silk in Warsaw?" she asked sharply.

"Because twenty minutes ago *SS-Hauptsturmführer* Reinhart Kroll delivered gilded pasteboard invitations through General Stahel's protocol office for next Sunday evening's quarterly German-and-Municipal Epidemic Medical Reception at the *Palais Brühl* Casino annex," Ludwig said quietly, releasing her hand to pick up a stiff cream card embossed with the

Generalgouvernement eagle off Judge Silberstein's blotter. "Mandatory attendance for Stabsarzt Vesper, Acting Surgical Chief *Dr. med. Sylwia Kotarska* representing *Dzieciątka Jezus* in Docent Mirecki's illness, and *Abwehrstelle* liaison officers."

Cold slid straight down Sylwia's spine despite August sweat.

"Oster's deputy Dohnanyi has been sitting in a Wehrmacht remand cell in Berlin since spring while Gestapo accountants pick Tirpitzufer's safe-locks open one drawer at a time," Ludwig said very low, stepping close enough that his silver-piped tunic shoulder brushed hers while his winter-green eyes cut straight down to rock-bottom truth. "And Frame Six of that Berlin nineteen-thirty-three file you lifted out of Vesper's folder on Bastille Day—"

Sylwia's breath stopped cold in her throat! *He knew she had lifted the duplicate microfilm strip off Vesper's desk five weeks ago—and hadn't said one single word at Świder while waiting for her to speak first!*

"—reaches Kroll's Warsaw desk in physical original paper by courier next week," Ludwig finished without blinking, ignoring her shock for later because combat survival came first. "Sunday night at the Brühl Casino, Reinhart Kroll intends sitting both of us under one chandelier with white cotton gloves and three glasses of Rhine wine to watch whose eyelids twitch when Berlin nineteen-thirty-three enters polite conversation. Miss that supper, and Kroll signs detention warrants Monday morning. Walk in beside Vesper wearing black silk, treat me like an obnoxious Prussian acquaintance you endured five years on Luisenstraße and six weeks in a hospital bed—and let Kroll break his teeth on bare ice."

For five silent seconds Sylwia stared straight into his cool, sleepless eyes—realizing he had known all through that golden afternoon under Świder pines that she held March eighth nineteen-thirty-three in her pocket, and had still laid himself bare under her hands without asking quarter.

"Eight o'clock Sunday?" she asked evenly, chin lifting sharp as scalpel steel.

"Eight-thirty," Ludwig said softly. "Don't wear perfume—and leave your knives at home; Brühl sentries search handbags."

Chapter XXII

White Gloves at the Brühl

Warsaw, 29 August 1943

Helena Kotarska had worn the black Lyons crêpe-de-Chine once—playing Brahms's D-minor concerto in Poznań's Aula Nova in November nineteen-twenty-eight, four months before pneumonia and thirty grains a week of hospital morphine stopped her heart—and for fourteen years since, folded between sheets of blue tissue paper and camphor blocks at the bottom of Sylwia's tin trunk, the silk had waited while everything else got sold for coal or cut up into bandages.

At quarter to eight on Sunday evening, inside Pavilion Three's slant-roofed dormer cubby under the eaves, Siostra Bronisława held a threaded darning needle between her broad thumb and forefinger, taking three rapid invisible tucks inside each side-seam while Sylwia stood motionless on a spread towel in worn cotton slip and black lisle stockings.

"Hold your breath in half an inch less or you won't swallow soup," Bronka grunted around two brass pins clamped beside her gold eyetooth. "Your mother had wider hips than you—or else people in twenty-eight ate butter on Tuesdays. Lift your arms."

Down slithered cool, heavy prewar French silk—real mulberry weight that whispered like dry water over bare shoulders—cut high boat-necked across the collarbones in front (mercifully covering every ghost of July) and dipping into a narrow V halfway between her shoulder-blades in back, where every thoracic vertebra showed sharp ivory ridges beneath pale hospital skin.

In the cracked wardrobe mirror propped against the dormer knee-wall, the stranger staring back startled even Sylwia: black silk turned her eyes coal-dark above gaunt, aristocratic Poznań cheekbones, stripping away ward calico until she looked neither like an exhausted municipal

surgeon nor like a conquered clerk—she looked like some dangerous nineteen-thirty Berlin cabaret portrait Otto Dix might have painted on wood just before the police closed the gallery.

Only her hands betrayed four winters of Lindleya: red-cracked around every nailbed from mercuric sublimate, calloused along the right thumb-web from heavy Liston bone-forceps, two tiny yellow pin-dots of Stefan's picric acid still stubbornly clinging beside the right index cuticle.

"Give them here," Bronka ordered, uncorking a small porcelain jar of pure mutton-tallow melted with glycerine and three drops of hospital lemon-spirit she had stolen from Vesper's shelf, rubbing grease fiercely into Sylwia's raw knuckles for two minutes before wiping excess shine off on clean linen. "Keep them off white tablecloths under strong bulbs if that white-gloved viper looks down. And don't drink two glasses of German wine on an empty belly—eat half this cold potato before you go downstairs so grease doesn't turn your guts inside out."

Sylwia ate the cold salted potato standing up, slipped barefoot into her sole surviving pair of black glacé kid pumps resoled twice with bicycle-tire rubber, draped Helena's threadbare black wool shawl over her bare back, and went down to Stabsarzt Vesper's waiting open Adler at the gate.

Twenty minutes' drive northeast across sultry August twilight carried them across planets.

Along Nowogrodzka and Marszałkowska dark crowds hurried home ahead of nine-o'clock curfew past boarded shopfronts and pink hostage-posters peeling in dry wind; turn left past the iron tank-traps guarding **Wierzbowa and Saski Square**, where floodlights blazed white now that no Soviet planes showed on radar, and suddenly manicured flowerbeds of red canna lilies surrounded the cream rococo wings of **Palais Brühl**, shiny black Mercedes limousines purred three deep along raked gravel, and SS sentries in spotless white summer parade belts checked embossed pasteboard cards under gilded lanterns!

Inside the Casino banquet annex behind the main palace courtyard, four Venetian crystal chandeliers blazed with two hundred unshaded candles—not candles, real sixty-watt clear bulbs burning full voltage!—above a sixty-foot horseshoe table laid in snow-white Silesian damask for forty guests: Wehrmacht sanitary colonels, civilian German *Amtsärzte* from Cracow and Radom, three nervous senior Polish hospital directors dragged along like tame bears to demonstrate "hygienic cooperation in

the Vistula space" (old Professor Orłowski from Wolski Hospital looking carved out of grey wood at the far end), and six sleek officers from Aleja Szucha in field-grey SS tunics with silver *SD* cuff-titles.

Before Sylwia was ten paces inside the double salon doors behind puffing, bowing Kurt Vesper, the physical shock of the buffet sideboard hit her solar plexus harder than Skaryszewska's rifle-butt.

Silver chafing-dishes six feet long steamed with roast Pomeranian fat goose swimming in golden crackling and apples; platters of pink Westphalian ham sliced thick around white fat rims; bowls of real yellow Mayonnaise piled over cold Vistula salmon and hard-boiled eggs; pyramids of butter—ten kilos of real yellow creamery butter carved into swans on crushed ice!—beside white wheat rolls crusted with poppyseed.

After forty-six months of grey sawdust bread, rutabaga water, and two hundred grams of rancid horse-tallow a month, merely inhaling hot roast goose-fat vapor in eighty-degree candlelit air made Sylwia's shrunken stomach contract in a violent, painful cramp that flooded her mouth with cold sour saliva—half ravenous wolf-hunger, half immediate nausea so sharp she had to lock her teeth together not to gag on the carpet.

Across the room beside the tall open French doors leading onto the dark garden loggia stood Ludwig.

He was talking quietly with grey-haired Professor Orłowski—holding a stemmed glass of pale Mosel untouched by its foot, immaculate in tailored evening dress-tunic with high silver-braided collar and silver *Oberstleutnant* shoulder-boards catching chandelier crystal. As Vesper steered Sylwia loudly toward the place-cards, Ludwig's eyes flicked once across thirty feet of uniformed shoulders—taking in Helena's black Lyons silk, the bare V of spine glimpsed as Vesper lifted her wool shawl for the cloakroom orderly, the fierce white pallor of her cheekbones—and slid smoothly back to Orłowski without changing rhythm by half a syllable, as cool and distant as if they had met twice over pus-basins in Lent.

Then Sylwia looked down at the gilt-edged place-cards beside the middle curve of the horseshoe table, and saw Reinhart Kroll's neat Dresden law-school geometry laid out across white linen:

To Sylwia's right sat terrified Kurt Vesper. Two seats down to her left—close enough that nobody could pretend deafness, far enough that every word crossed three pairs of German ears—sat **Ludwig Schoeler**. And directly *opposite* Sylwia across four feet of low red roses and crystal

wine-glasses sat **SS-Hauptsturmführer Reinhart Kroll**, white cotton gloves gleaming snowy beneath grey wool cuffs even at dinner!

* * *

For forty minutes through clear turtle consommé and cold salmon—Sylwia touching one forkful of fish dry without mayonnaise, crumbling half a white roll onto her bread-plate so fingers looked occupied while sipping plain Selters mineral water—conversation round their curve of the table stayed impeccably sanitary: Wola louse-delousing figures, autumn dysentery bacteriophage trials from Lemberg, Cracow serum production.

Only when white-jacketed waiters cleared fish plates and set slice after glistening brown slice of roast goose down before forty guests—Kroll leaving his own rich goose untouched save two spears of tinned asparagus, eating as sparingly as a seminary dyspeptic while his gloved left index finger whispered *scritch-scritch* inside his right shirt-cuff—did the Saxon lawyer smile gently across the red roses at Sylwia.

"Stabsarzt Vesper informs me, Frau Doktor Kotarska, that since Docent Mirecki's unfortunate cardiac indisposition last month you carry sole surgical command of seventy Polish beds at *Kindlein Jesu*," Kroll remarked in his soft, pleasant courtroom voice that somehow silenced two neighboring colonels' chatter inside five words. "Remarkable administrative burden—and yet Berlin's academic registries scarcely surprise one. In fact, clearing old Ministry library crates last week, one of our Berlin liaison clerks stumbled across quite a charming souvenir from Luisenstraße."

Without haste Kroll reached down beside his chair-leg into a slim black leather document portfolio, drew out a glossy octavo sheet torn or photographed from the 1932 *Klinisches Jahrbuch der Chirurgischen Universitätsklinik der Charité*, and laid it face-up on clean damask right beside the salt-cellars between them.

Sylwia didn't lean back and didn't lean greedily forward—tilted her chin four calm degrees downward to look at the twelve-year-old silver-bromide group photograph taken on sunny hospital steps in May nineteen-thirty-two:

Front center in winged starched collar sat white-bearded Geheimrat Professor von Halden looking like Jehovah after successful gallstones. Standing immediately behind his right shoulder—twenty-three, lean-jawed, unsmiling, arms folded across a dazzling white clinic coat—stood **Ludwig Schoeler**. Standing symmetrical behind von Halden's left shoulder—twenty-one, dark hair coiled severe above fierce dark eyes and a chin lifted two inches higher than any girl on scholarship had business lifting it—stood **Sylwia Kotarska**. And half a step behind the pair of them on the second marble riser, blinking benignly through round gold-wire spectacles in his ink-stained black alpaca coat, stood **Professor Doktor Jakob Mandelbaum**.

Beside Sylwia, Kurt Vesper choked slightly on a mouthful of goose skin, reaching hastily for his Mosel glass.

Two seats left, Ludwig leaned slightly forward over his untouched wine-stem to glance sideways at the glossy print—one eyebrow rising two millimeters in cool, bored recognition.

"May thirty-two, after the German Surgical Congress," Ludwig observed dryly before Sylwia even needed to speak, tapping one bare knuckle lightly near the corner of the print where fat Kleist's ear protruded behind three taller assistants. "Before Kleist bought riding-boots. God, von Halden made us stand forty minutes in bright sun waiting for the photographer's magnesium pan while two strangulated hernias waited upstairs. Where on earth did your clerk dig up clinic yearbooks, Kroll—looking for uncollected library fines?"

Kroll smiled faintly, sandy lashes unblinking as he watched *Sylwia's* face rather than Ludwig's.

"Routine background cross-referencing on Generalgouvernement epidemic license holders, *Herr Oberstleutnant*," Kroll said silkily. "Though one admits coincidence possesses a certain literary charm. Out of forty surgical clinics in the Reich and nine municipal hospitals in Warsaw, a midnight ambush in Ochota deposits *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler onto the operating table of the precise classmate standing three feet left of him in May nineteen-thirty-two—followed four months later by *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler personally extracting the same classmate from *Arbeitsamt* transit barracks at Skaryszewska."

Every knife and fork within four seats either side had stopped clicking against porcelain. Even old Professor Orłowski six places down sat

motionless behind white whiskers, listening to steel ice crack across thin river water.

Run from it—mumble excuses about blind chance—and Kroll smelled blood inside five seconds.

Sylwia picked up her Selters water glass with fingers steady as granite—Bronka's tallow-and-lemon rub hiding half the sublimate cracks under candle-glow—took one small cool sip, set crystal noiselessly back onto linen, and looked straight into Reinhart Kroll's pale eyes with a dry, wintry curl of her lip that echoed Geheimrat von Halden's nastiest Thursday rounds.

"Had you sat through five Berlin winters beside Herr Schoeler on Luisenstraße, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*," Sylwia said clearly in crisp Charlottenburg German pitched so all six neighboring officers caught every iced syllable, "you would call February ninth divine malice rather than literary charm. In December nineteen-thirty Herr Schoeler lifted three weeks of my venous-manometer figures uncredited onto a blackboard to beat me by one vote for the Virchow Medal; in forty-three he arrived uninvited at one in the morning to dump two liters of blood across my cleanest operating floor and argue suturing gauge awake."

A genuine bark of relieved, tipsy laughter burst out of Stabsarzt Vesper beside her, seconded by two Wehrmacht sanitary colonels grinning into their Mosel—men understood lifelong academic venom instantly where friendship would have smelled treasonous!

"And as for Skaryszewska on the fourth of June," Ludwig cut in smoothly across his wine-stem, voice edged with just enough cold Prussian arrogance toward Polish subordinates to make every German ear at the table nod—*"Do you imagine I rode over to Praga out of sentiment for Fräulein Kotarska's manometer notebooks, Kroll? Only three surgeons east of Breslau have successfully anastomosed a lacerated subclavian-axillary trunk without late aneurysmal thrombosis since forty-one, and Stabsarzt Vesper needed her typhus-ward signatures clean before Wola's workshops shut forty tram-lines down. Leave it to Ordnungspolizei drunks to throw scarce vascular technicians into potato trains."*

"Quite—utterly chaotic street-policing that afternoon!" Vesper chimed in eagerly, wiping goose grease off his chin, desperate to earn Tuesday's peace from Sylwia's safe. "General Stahel's own adjutant reprimanded the *Schutzpolizei* company commander personally on my recommendation!"

Across the roses, Reinhart Kroll's gentle smile did not vanish—yet underneath the table edge Sylwia heard the unmistakable dry *scritch-scritch-scritch* of white cotton rubbing faster across weeping wrist skin.

Kroll laid one gloved fingertip delicately right onto the tiny photographic head of **Professor Jakob Mandelbaum** standing behind their twenty-two-year-old shoulders on marble steps.

"And poor Professor Mandelbaum behind you both," Kroll murmured almost wistfully, tilting his sandy head three degrees. "Died of heart failure at Columbia-Haus detention center in April thirty-three after running an illegal Marxist dispensary in Wedding, if our dusty Alexanderplatz cards read straight. Curiously enough, *Herr Oberstleutnant*, the original March thirty-three arrest-ledger folder from *Abteilung IA*—where one clinic assistant's name was struck out in ink fifteen minutes before Mandelbaum's arrest under an old Reichswehr stamp—arrived in my Warsaw registry pouch yesterday morning instead of next week."

Yesterday morning instead of next week.

Not one muscle in Sylwia's face twitched; she did not blink, did not swallow, did not glance left toward Ludwig by half a degree of arc—even as ice-water flooded every vein behind her ribs! Berlin's courier had arrived *five days early*, on Saturday morning! Right now, locked inside Reinhart Kroll's green safe on Aleja Szucha Twenty-Five, lay the physical paper ledger from March seventh nineteen-thirty-three!

Wait—if Kroll had read *Kotarska, Sylwia Helena* legible under the black ink cross-hatching yesterday morning, why wasn't Sylwia sitting in chains down in Aleja Szucha's basement tonight instead of eating salmon off Silesian damask?!

Watch Kroll's pale eyes probing between the two of them like a blind needle fishing for bone: *because physical ink deletion + "[AKTE ENTFERNT — FILE REMOVED]" meant whoever at Bendlerstraße pulled those Wedding pharmacy receipts out of Mandelbaum's folder at 11:45 a.m. on March 8, 1933 had BURNED the physical receipts and scrubbed the paper fibre deeper with pumice-eraser than high-contrast microfilm ultraviolet scatter showed!* Wait—on microfilm camera copy, oblique UV/arc-lamp illumination sometimes brought faint indented typewriter strike-impressions up out of erased paper slightly clearer than naked eye saw on yellowed foolscap —OR Kroll suspected *Kotarska* under the blot without yet holding signed

Wedding pharmacy slips to prove *subversive Polish-Communist activity* past Wehrmacht epidemic protection!

"Half the professors on Luisenstraße had assistants whose uncles voted Social Democrat before thirty-three, Kroll," Ludwig said in a voice bored enough to cut glass, picking up his Mosel at last to take one tiny sip and set it down. "If *Abteilung Vier* has so few Polish bandits left to catch in Warsaw after losing your prize source in Mokotów last month that your clerks spend August reading ten-year-old Reichswehr ink-blots, General Stahel will wonder what Aleja Szucha burns petrol for."

Direct hit square into Kroll's teeth—*losing your prize source "Uhrzeiger" in Mokotów last month*!

For one half-second Kroll's pale sandy lashes dropped completely still over colourless eyes; white cotton fingers stopped moving on his wrist; politely he slid the glossy 1932 Charité photograph back inside his black leather portfolio without another word as liveried waiters wheeled in silver bowls of iced peaches and a four-man German string quartet tuned violins on the small gilt dais at the end of the hall.

* * *

Ten minutes into Schubert's *Death and the Maiden* quartet—chairs turned slightly sideways toward the musicians while blue cigar smoke curled lazily up into crystal chandeliers and half the German doctors loosened tight tunic hooks in eighty-degree air—Sylwia felt the postponed rebellion of a four-year-starved stomach hit bottom against two bites of rich salmon and hot goose-fat vapor.

Cold sweat broke fine along her nape; stay seated five minutes longer and she disgraced Poznań brains across Silesian damask.

Touching two steady fingers lightly to Vesper's sleeve with a murmur about terrace air, she rose noiselessly during the *Andante con moto*, slipped through the tall side drapery behind marble pillars—not out onto the crowded garden loggia where officers smoked, left down the cool dim vaulted marble service-gallery connecting banquet annex to main palace cloakrooms.

Inside the empty tiled ladies' retiring room she locked the stall, knelt cleanly on her handkerchief so Helena's silk touched zero dust, brought up four mouthfuls of sour Selters water without making a sound, rinsed

her mouth thrice at the porcelain tap with cold water until color settled back cold and clear in her cheeks, and stepped back out into the shadowed marble gallery to return before the movement ended.

Halfway past the deep, heavy crimson-velvet-curtained telephone alcove recessed six feet into three-foot-thick eighteenth-century palace masonry—dark because nobody lit corridor wall-sconces behind blackout portières, thirty paces round the corner from where two SS *Wachmannschaft* sentries stood immobile beneath gilt mirrors by the lobby arch—a bare right hand reached silently out between velvet folds, caught Sylwia's bare elbow, and drew her straight inside behind heavy damask curtains!

Pitch blackness smelling of old velvet dust, faint cigar smoke from down the hall, and crisp gabardine wool.

Before she drew breath to hiss fury at lunatic recklessness inside Palais Brühl itself, Ludwig's back braced against the recessed oak telephone-booth door while both his hands framed her bare shoulder-blades inside the deep V of Helena's black silk—skin burning hot against cool palms—and his mouth came down hard and silent onto hers.

Not Schubert—pure post-combat adrenaline shaking like live high-tension wire through both of them after forty minutes smiling across roses into Reinhart Kroll's white cotton gloves while Schubert violins sawed passionate minor chords thirty yards away through open doors!

"Are you out of your mind—sentries twenty yards down—" Sylwia breathed fiercely into his mouth even as her own hands locked tight onto his silver-braided collar-tabs, pulling him down instead of pushing him away.

"Change of guard takes four minutes at eleven, and everyone else is watching fiddles," Ludwig murmured raw against her throat, sliding both hands down the cool French mulberry silk over her starved ribs to bunch thin black crêpe smoothly up her thighs in pitch velvet dark until bare palms hit hot skin above garter-straps!

Five minutes. Less than five minutes—reckless, mad, utterly unforgivable thirty yards from Reinhart Kroll's back, driven by the sudden blinding certainty in both their bones that Saturday's early Berlin courier meant clocks across all Warsaw had just jumped forward six weeks!

Sylwia didn't wear knickers under bias-cut nineteen-twenty-eight concert silk because thick wartime cotton bunched ugly seams across

starved hips—when Ludwig's fingers slid past garter clasps expecting linen and met bare, slick, burning-wet heat directly in the dark, a low sharp breath tore through his teeth against her ear! Unbuttoning grey dress-trousers one-handed in two silent jerks without unbuckling sword-belt loops, he lifted her by both bare thighs four inches up against smooth cold Carrara marble wainscot hidden deep behind three folds of crimson palace velvet, guiding himself straight inside her in one deep, suffocatingly silent upward thrust while clapping his left hand lightly near her cheek as she bit clean into the shoulder wool of his *Oberstleutnant*'s tunic right beside the silver braid so not one gasp escaped into the corridor!

Cold eighteenth-century palace marble froze her bare upper back while six feet of wool-clad German officer burned white-hot between her thighs—violins rising shrill and tragic down the gallery in Schubert's *allegro*, booted heels clicking once past the outer marble arch twenty-five feet away and fading down garden steps without pausing! Every nerve in Sylwia's body screamed raw terror braided indistinguishable from blinding carnal voltage: wrapping both legs tight round his hips under falling black silk folds, grinding down furiously onto quick, shallow, ruthless upward strokes while his thumb worked slick lightning between them until heat snapped blinding behind her eyes—clenching silent and convulsive round him with her teeth locked hard in German gabardine wool five seconds before he buried his mouth against her bare neck and came deep inside her without making velvet stir by half an inch!

Sixty heartbeats later silk whispered smooth back down to her calves; trousers buttoned neat in darkness; Sylwia wiped damp thighs swiftly with his clean linen pocket-handkerchief before stuffing the square deep inside *his* own uniform pocket so he carried the evidence out past Brühl guards himself!

Before parting the crimson velvet crack half an inch to check empty marble corridor, Ludwig held her chin still in the dark for five seconds, breathing quiet now, cold tactical ice returning instant to his whisper against her ear:

"Listen carefully before you go back to your chair: first, Kroll couldn't read your full surname under that nineteen-thirty-three Reichswehr pumice-erasure on original foolscap—only *poln. cand. med.* and half a *K*—because Major von Bredow burned your signed Wedding pharmacy slips in an ashtray in front of me on March eighth before stamping the blot."

Sylwia's heart stopped once in pitch dark—hearing him confirm March eighth nineteen-thirty-three aloud out of his own mouth for the first time in ten years without giving her three seconds to answer before survival cut across it!

"Second," Ludwig whispered rapid and lethal: "because Kroll hit brick on nineteen-thirty-three today, his deputy signed an order at six p.m. scheduling a surprise *Erkennungsdienst* fingerprint-and-birth-parish audit of *all auxiliary laboratory staff* at *Szpital Dzieciątka Jezus* for the morning of **Wednesday the eighth of September**—looking for forged *Kennkarten* under your basement roof to break Pavilion Three open from underneath. Get your Jewish girl out of that cellar before midnight on the seventh."

Violins down the hall hit the final crashing minor chords of the movement; polite German applause pattered crisp across parquet.

Ludwig released her chin, stepped out first through a side smoking-door toward the gentlemen's terrace without looking back, and forty seconds later Sylwia glided serenely back into candlelit salon glare from the opposite arch in black Lyons silk—sitting down beside Kurt Vesper with cool pink cheeks and steady hands to watch Reinhart Kroll clap white cotton gloves softly together for Schubert.

Chapter XXIII

Corpse Number Seven

Warsaw, 7–8 September 1943

At four minutes past ten on Tuesday morning the seventh of September, ninety seconds of ferocious submachine-gun fire tore open the sunny autumn air south down Marszałkowska toward Zbawiciela Square—not two pistol cracks and running boots, sustained Sten and Thompson bursts answered by German MP40s and the flat *whump* of a hand-grenade blowing plate-glass shopwindows across tram-rails at Litewska corner.

By quarter to eleven, when the first shot-up *Schutzpolizei* patrol car screamed past Chałubińskiego trailing blue radiator steam, Bronka came up from the vegetable gate carrying news blacker than April smoke:

Boys with violin-cases and briefcases had ambushed **SS-Oberscharführer Franz Bürkl**—deputy commandant of Pawiak prison, famous across Warsaw for setting his Alsatian dog onto pregnant women's bellies in cellars—walking his dog with wife and child outside Litewska Four, riddling Bürkl and six accompanying SS men dead on the pavement before roaring off down Mokotowska without losing a single car!

Inside Pavilion Three's instrument room Sylwia stood staring down at Stabsarzt Vesper's signed blank green *Sanitätsabteilung* rural-movement voucher lying ready inside her pocketbook—filled out last night for Halina Różańska to board the six-fifteen evening steam train from Dworzec Główny to Kielce five hours from now.

"Every railway gate at Główny, Wschodni, and Zachodni just dropped double SS *Sonderfahndung* chains," Bronka whispered grimly, wiping cabbage-water off her red forearms onto her apron. "Walenty's nephew from the tram depot says nobody under sixty gets onto a platform today without Aleja Szucha clerks telephoning parish registries on every *Kennkarte* number."

Sylwia shut her eyes for two seconds to clear noise out of the equation.

At eight o'clock *tomorrow morning*—Wednesday the eighth of September, thirteen hours from sunset—Reinhart Kroll's *Erkennungsdienst* team arrived at Pavilion Three's basement laboratory specifically to audit the fingerprints and Łowicz parish baptismal extract of auxiliary bacteriologist **"Irena Kwiatkowska."**

Why hadn't Sylwia sent Halina out to Kielce five days ago right after Palais Brühl? Because Dawid Różański down in Konstancin woods had spiked high recurrent relapsing fever on September first requiring Halina's typed cross-matched convalescent serum harvested over four days from guinea-pigs, finished only last evening at nine!

Now look at the trap jaws closing from both ends of the street: 1. Put Halina onto a train tonight with Bürkl's blood still wet on Litewska pavement, and SS platform police catch her before Grochów. 2. Hide Halina alive inside some Warsaw attic tonight so tomorrow morning at eight o'clock "Panna Kwiatkowska" simply *fails to report for work*—and Reinhart Kroll needs zero further proof that somebody tipped Pavilion Three off! By eight-thirty Kroll arrests Acting Chief *Dr. Sylwia Kotarska* and invalid *Docent Tadeusz Mirecki* straight out of his third-floor cardiac bed for harboring a fugitive Jewish bacteriologist, circulates Halina's nineteen-forty-one *Kennkarte* photograph to every *szmalcownik* and police post in the Generalgouvernement, and tears Pavilion Three down brick by brick!

Only one door on earth stopped a police manhunt dead at eight-zero-five tomorrow morning while clearing both hospital and fugitive from every search bulletin in Poland:

When SS clerks walked through Lindleya's gate at eight a.m., **"Irena Kwiatkowska" had to be lying stone-dead inside Pavilion Three's contagious typhus morgue**, killed overnight by the very occupational terror Germans respected above God Himself—fulminant laboratory *Fleckfieber*!

Sylwia walked fast down the vaulted cellar ramp and rapped three-and-one on the iron *Fleckfieber* door.

Halina already had two small cardboard suitcases packed behind her incubator cabinet, wearing her grey moth-eaten cardigan despite mild September air, face calm and pared down to pure dark flint. "Trains are shut after Litewska, aren't they?"

"Tighter than drums," Sylwia said, locking the iron door behind her. "And if you simply vanish off tomorrow morning's roster when Kroll's clerks arrive at eight, Kroll puts your photograph on every street-post from here to Cracow and hangs Mirecki before lunch. You don't vanish tonight, Halina—you die at twenty minutes to ten this evening in Infectious Isolation Cubicle Four."

Halina blinked once below her chamomile-and-peroxide yellow parting. "Die inside what skin? Even dumb SS clerks count bodies in coffins."

"Thirty minutes ago Infectious Ward Six over at Pavilion One sent down three fresh pauper typhus deaths from Wola for tomorrow's municipal lime-lorry," Sylwia said, voice dropping flat and clinical as Philippstraße dissecting-hall slate. "Corpse Number Seven on the stone cooling-slab right now is registered as *Anna Nowak, unmarried seamstress, aged twenty-nine, evicted lodger from Górczewska, zero surviving relatives in Warsaw.* Five feet three inches, forty-nine kilos, dark brown eyes, narrow build, confluent purple day-eleven typhus petechiae from collarbones to ankles."

Halina's sharp scientist's mind leaped ahead down the checklist faster than ordinary mortals breathed, ticking fatal discrepancies off on thin fingers:

"One: my hair's bleached ash-yellow down to half-inch dark roots; hers will be brown or black."

"You have twenty-volume hydrogen peroxide and concentrated ammonium hydroxide sitting on that shelf behind your elbow—dead keratin bleaches twice as fast under heat-lamps because nobody screams when ammonia burns scalp."

"Two: Kroll's *Erkennungsdienst* clerk carries ten-print ink rollers to compare corpses against municipal *Kennkarte* right-index thumbprints filed at City Hall in forty-one!"

Sylwia's eyes glinted cold black beneath the low tin microscope shade. "Only when right-index epidermis still owns papillary ridges. Suppose yesterday afternoon during Litewska's siren panic Panna Kwiatkowska dropped a boiling two-liter Pyrex flask of eighty-percent liquefied crystalline carbolic phenol across her right hand and right cheek while autoclaving virulent *Rickettsia prowazekii* louse-guts—inhaling concentrated rickettsial aerosol into raw pharyngeal mucosa on top of latent

prodromal typhus while third-degree phenol eschar cooked all five right-hand finger-pads white and featureless down to corium?"

Halina stared at her for three stunned seconds—then let out a single breathless, incredulous whistle between her teeth. "Fulminant toxic typhus myocarditis rarely kills inside thirty hours from aerosol alone—you'll have to chart five days' concealed ambulatory fever she hid from you out of stubbornness until collapsing after yesterday's phenol spill!"

"Five days' concealed fever is already half-inked in my head—every lab worker hides thirty-nine degrees so Vesper doesn't dock pay," Sylwia said ruthlessly. "What else sits on your forty-one *Kennkarte* physical marks line?"

Halina pulled the grey card out of her skirt pocket and opened flap two: *Besondere Kennzeichen: Narbe am rechten Unterbauch (Blinddarm).* Special marks: appendectomy scar right lower quadrant.

"Does Anna Nowak have a McBurney scar?" Halina asked quietly.

"No. Unscarred belly."

Cut fresh post-mortem skin with a scalpel tonight and any police medical orderly glancing under a shroud saw gaping unhealed white fat instead of a nine-year-old white scar—UNLESS nobody looked at a typhus abdomen when four hundred livid purple Weigl louse-feeder stipples sat crusted on the right thigh *and* a ruptured turpentine fixation-abscess bandage covered McBurney's point, OR better still: how did mortuary embalmers fake old linear scars in criminal Berlin? No—collodion! Pinch a six-centimeter diagonal fold of pale right-iliac skin together with buried subcuticular white linen thread, paint flexible *Collodium elasticum* blended with zinc-oxide white powder smooth across the depressed white crease until under dim morgue lamplight it formed an exact sunken, shiny pearl-white ten-year-old McBurney scar unless someone sliced it open with a histologist's razor—and no German SS clerk alive bent his nose six inches over a stink-bloated, louse-spotted typhus belly in September heat to slice old appendectomy scars!

"Bring your peroxide, ammonia, Weigl box-straps, and last week's worn stockings over to the contagious dead-house at eleven tonight," Sylwia ordered quietly. "Bronka's cousin Jurek drives the municipal disinfection steam-van out through Ochota barrier at five-thirty tomorrow morning under Vesper's signed sanitary pass—taking one 'shaved conva-

lescent typhus scrub-woman' in deloused grey sackcloth down to Grójec orchard kitchens, five kilometers from Dawid's pines."

Halina looked down at her grey *Kennkarte—Irena Kwiatkowska*, the paper skin that had kept her breathing twenty-six months while parents, aunts, cousins, and sixteen-year-old Rachela turned to smoke and lime—and nodded once without a tremor. "Eleven o'clock."

* * *

Nothing in Dante's *Inferno* smelled quite like a windowless brick infectious dead-house at midnight in early September when city ice-deliveries failed.

Six unpainted pine coffins lay ranged across wet concrete trestles under two yellow paraffin storm-lanterns hung from iron ceiling hooks; bluebottle flies sluggish with night cool crawled silently along red-painted *FLECKFIEBER* stencils until Bronka shut the outer iron ventilator and lit a shallow pan of crude cresol tar by the threshold—not enough to choke living lungs, enough to make tomorrow morning's visitors hold silk handkerchiefs clamped tight over both nostrils from thirty yards off.

On Zinc Cooling-Slab Two lay twenty-nine-year-old Anna Nowak from Górczewska.

Sylwia stood thirty seconds silent at the head of the slab before anyone touched hair or cloth—looking down at the sunken, peaceful, famine-hollowed face of a Warsaw seamstress whose rough left index finger bore fifty tiny black needle-pricks from sewing German uniform linings at twelve groszy an hour until one infected body-louse ended four winters of cold soup. Nothing Sylwia did to this quiet shell tonight hurt Anna Nowak; under Anna Nowak's own name tomorrow afternoon Bronka had already paid three hundred złoty to the cemetery chaplain at Bródno to read real burial prayers over Rachela's neighboring turf so the seamstress didn't go unprayed-for under borrowed ink.

"Let's work," Sylwia said softly.

Ninety minutes of macabre, diamond-hard precision moved without one wasted syllable among the three women.

First, hair: Halina mixed twenty-volume hydrogen peroxide two-to-one with strong liquid ammonia and a pinch of soap-flakes in a porcelain bowl, brushing the foaming caustic paste down Anna Nowak's dark

chestnut hair starting *six millimeters out from the scalp*—preserving exact half-inch dark roots along the center part!—and holding a shielded tin reflector lamp six inches overhead for twenty-five minutes until wet strands lifted to that unmistakable harsh, slightly brassy wartime ash-blond every corridor sentry at Pavilion Three knew by sight, rinsed clean with chamomile water and dried with hot towels tucked round the ears.

Second, thighs and belly: while Bronka dressed the corpse's ankles in Halina's own darned brown woollen stockings, Sylwia ran a fine buried subcuticular white silk gather six centimeters diagonal across McBurney's point in the right iliac fossa, drawing dead dermis inward into a neat puckered trough, dusted trace talc-and-zinc into two layers of drying *Collodium elasticum* brushed feather-thin along the crease—under yellow storm-lantern glare from three feet away, even Bronka squinted twice and swore she was looking at a childhood appendectomy scar! Six inches lower on the anterior right thigh, using a bundle of six fine entomological pins bound round a cork and dipped in dark hemolyzed venous blood, Sylwia stippled two neat rectangular matchbox grids mimicking four weeks of crusted Weigl louse-feeding wheals.

Third—ugliest and indispensable—fingerprints and right cheek:

Sylwia put on thick rubber post-mortem gloves, uncorked eighty-eight-percent liquefied *Acidum carbolicum liquefactum*, and pressed phenol-soaked cotton pads firmly for four minutes across all five distal finger-pulps of the corpse's right hand, plus a splash-track across right palm, wrist, and right malar prominence where a bursting flask would splatter an operator leaning over an autoclave! Dead epidermis coagulated dense, opaque parchment-white and wrinkled featureless inside three minutes flat—destroying every papillary ridge beyond ten-print ink rolling while filling the whole stone room with authentic, overpowering hospital carbolic stench on top of cresol!

Last, Halina unbuttoned her own familiar moth-eaten grey cardigan—the cardigan every orderly, Vesper's clerk, and Kroll's January gate-watchers had seen "Panna Kwiatkowska" wear winter and summer—slipped it gently onto Anna Nowak's stiffened arms over a clean hospital smock, tucked a broken glass Pasteur pipette smear-sheet into the pocket record, and lifted the body with Sylwia and Bronka into Pine Coffin Four.

Then Bronka sat Halina down on an upturned wooden crate beside the zinc sink and took out Walenty's steel barber clippers.

Zzzzzzt. Zzzzzzt.

Long locks of brass-yellow-and-black hair tumbled silent onto wet concrete round Halina's shoes until her narrow skull sat cropped quarter-inch short like every female typhus survivor discharged bald from St. Stanislaus ward Six! Rubbing walnut-hull stain diluted in weak tea lightly round Halina's pale eye-sockets and temples to give peasant sallow suntan, wrapping a coarse grey unbleached linen kerchief low across her brow and buttoning her into ankle-length homespun country ticking smelling authentically of cabbage and steam-disinfectant, Bronka stepped back holding the lantern high.

Gone was crisp Warsaw bacteriologist Dr. Halina Różańska; gone too was nervous blonde Łowicz pharmacist's daughter Irena Kwiatkowska. Sitting on the crate sat twenty-odd dumb-looking Tekla from Grójec powiat going home half-deaf after spotted fever to peel orchard apples.

At twenty minutes past four, out in the pitch-black coal-alley behind the mortuary before eastern sky showed a crack of grey, Jurek's municipal steam-disinfection van idled muffled behind canvas curtains.

Halina paused one second on the iron rear step before climbing inside among rolled sulfur hoses.

No tears—neither woman owned tears anymore. Halina reached down one thin, cold, short-nailed hand without Weigl boxes strapped to her skin for the first time since forty-one, gripped Sylwia's mercury-cracked right hand hard enough to grind bones together once, and spoke six words barely audible above the engine tappet:

"Don't let your Prussian get you hung, Sylwia."

"Tell Dawid not to read fine print in bad lamplight before Christmas," Sylwia whispered back, slapping the canvas flap shut and bolting the outside iron hasp herself as the van crept dark and unchallenged out Nowogrodzka gate carrying Stabsarzt Vesper's genuine violet eagle pass in Jurek's pocket.

Between four-twenty-five and half-past six lay the longest two hours of Sylwia's autumn.

Instead of climbing upstairs to lie down, she locked herself alone inside the abandoned basement *Fleckfieber* laboratory—putting on thin surgical gloves so zero fresh fingerprint overlaid the wiped slate benches —to manufacture the five preceding days of "Irena Kwiatkowska's" fatal

clinical pride before eight o'clock brought Charlottenburg eyes down the ramp.

Using Halina's own stubby chewed-end copying pencil and an old dried drop of typhus-positive guinea-pig ear blood re-wetted in saline on two glass microscope slides, Sylwia back-entered subtle, utterly convincing shaky marginal tallies across Friday, Saturday, and Sunday's louse-colony feeding sheets (*38.4° — Kopfschmerz, Aspirin 1,0*), topped on Monday afternoon at *16:15* by a violently jagged, broken-off ink stroke across Batch Nineteen's autoclave sheet stained brown at one corner with genuine splashed eighty-eight-percent carbolic phenol alongside swept-up shards of a shattered two-liter Pyrex Erlenmeyer flask!

At five-fifty—exact minute Jurek's slow charcoal-gasogene steam van would hit the double post-Bürkl SS *Sonderfahndung* roadblock out at **Okęcie–Grójecka toll-bar**, where dogs and bayonet squads were searching milk-carts down to axle grease!—Sylwia stood motionless beside Theater One's tall second-floor east casement watching September dawn bleed rusty orange above Mokotów's chimneys.

If one alert SS corporal at Grójecka barrier noticed that the bald "convalescent typhus scrub-woman" sitting hunched among sulfur hoses owned smooth microscope-calloused fingertips instead of washboard-cracked knuckles—and telephoned Aleja Szucha at six-fifteen while Anna Nowak lay bleached blonde in Coffin Four back at Lindleya—nobody inside Pavilion Three survived ten o'clock.

Six-fifteen passed. Six-thirty. Quarter to seven.

At six-fifty-two a battered country milk-float rattled routinely into Pavilion One's kitchen yard delivering sour curds from Raszyn—three miles *south* beyond the Okęcie barrier!—and down below the window old Walenty stepped casually out onto the gravel to tip his broom-cap once toward the second-floor surgical glass while whistling two bars of *Szła dzieweczka do laseczka.*

Cleared Okęcie barrier at five-forty-eight without canvas unbolted; rolling clean past Sękocin woods.

Sylwia let out one silent, four-second breath against cold window-glass, went downstairs to drink two cups of scalding black chicory with Bronka, and put on fresh starched linen for the Gestapo.

* * *

At eight-twelve sharp on Wednesday morning the eighth of September, a closed grey Opel Olympia sedan bearing Security Police plates pulled briskly through Lindleya's front iron gates and parked square across Pavilion Three's ambulance ramp.

Reinhart Kroll hadn't come himself today—sending juniors to execute clerical arrests showed Saxon tidiness. Out stepped **SS-Untersturmführer Mahler**, twenty-six, pink-cheeked Berlin police-academy graduate with horn-rimmed spectacles, carrying a leather black-ink fingerprinting case in his left hand and a crisp folder containing Łowicz St. Stanislaus Catholic Parish's certified statement that *the real Irena Kwiatkowska died of diphtheria aged twenty-three in June 1939*, flanked by two burly SD *Scharführer* holding steel handcuffs loose inside pocket slits.

Sylwia met them at the top of Pavilion Three's stone steps wearing a spotless starched white surgical coat, gauze typhus-mask dangling ready round her neck, holding a clipboard inked black-bordered across the top margin.

"Dr. Kotarska?" Untersturmführer Mahler snapped heels briskly, already glancing past her hip toward the basement stairs. "Security Police *Abteilung Vier*. Unlock your basement *Fleckfieber* laboratory without telephoning down—you employ an auxiliary bacteriologist entered as *Kwiatkowska, Irena*, *Kennkarte* Nr. W-088412."

"Employed until twenty-one forty hours last night, *Herr Untersturmführer*," Sylwia corrected him in level, weary German, turning half-round to point southwest across the sunny gravel courtyard toward the low red-brick dead-house annex where red *SEUCHENGEFAHR — FLECKFIEBER* boards hung beside open iron doors. "If your office requires Panna Kwiatkowska's *Kennkarte* for municipal cancellation, here it is in her deceased-effects envelope—along with Stabsarzt Vesper's mandatory epidemic death notification filed at seven a.m. today."

Mahler stopped dead on the top step, pink cheeks going blank behind horn-rims. "Deceased?!"

"Fulminant laboratory *Fleckfieber* complicated by massive virulent rickettsial inhalation after an autoclave carbolic-flask explosion Monday afternoon during the Litewska street-alarm," Sylwia recited with bored, unimpeachable clinical precision, handing him the disinfectant-sprayed envelope by two forceps tips as if sparing his clean fingers typhus contamination! "Concealed prodromal fever five days at her bench rather than

miss Wola vaccine quotas, aspirated concentrated louse-gut suspension when boiling phenol shattered across her right hand and face Monday at four, died in Toxic Isolation Four last night at nine-forty in irreversible myocarditic shock. Coffin Four awaits ten-o'clock chloride-of-lime sealing in the contagious annex if you wish visual verification before burial."

Mahler stared suspiciously from Sylwia's calm dark eyes down to his Łowicz forgery sheet—every instinct taught at Charlottenburg police school screaming *convenient timing!*

"Open Coffin Four," Mahler ordered curtly, waving both SD sergeants behind her across the courtyard gravel. "Nobody buries an *Abteilung Vier* suspect on Polish paper."

"Tie these carbolized gauze pads over mouth and nose and keep trousers tucked tight inside boot-tops so wandering body-lice off fresh slabs don't climb wool seams," Sylwia advised helpfully at the dead-house threshold—watching both burly *Scharführer* immediately step back two yards onto sunny gravel slapping nervously at their ankles while Mahler alone, sweating fiercely behind horn-rimmed lenses fogged by gauze breath, stepped three paces inside the dark, fly-buzzing, cresol-and-rot-reeking stone vault!

Bronka stood waiting beside Pine Trestle Four holding a heavy iron tire-crowbar. At Sylwia's nod, Bronka pried the unnailed pine lid back two feet and held a yellow storm-lantern directly over the head end.

Out rolled ninety-degree enclosed carbolic, dead typhus sweat, and sour cresol thick enough to make Mahler gag aloud behind white gauze!

Inside the rough pine box lay the unmistakable grey-purple moth-eaten cardigan every Pavilion Three watcher knew; brassy peroxide-yellow hair showing dark roots above a sunken, confluent-spotted face half-eaten across the right cheekbone by white phenol eschar; right hand folded across chest displaying five shriveled, snow-white, completely ridge-obliterated third-degree carbolic-cooked fingertips; and down below the hiked hospital smock hem where Bronka had carelessly left shroud linen turned back for "post-mortem spleen check," two crusted purple Weigl louse-box grids above a shiny pale right-lower-quadrant appendectomy crease!

Mahler held his leather fingerprint kit clutched uselessly against his stomach—one two-second squint at five cooked white phenol finger-pulps told any academy graduate ten-print rollers would peel wet dead

slough off onto glass without printing a single whorl, while two fat bluebottle flies buzzing lazily off the spotted collar toward Mahler's spectacles finished whatever courage Berlin had issued him!

"Close it! Nail it down with lime immediately!" Mahler barked muffled behind both gloved hands clapped over his mask, backing fast out into September sunshine and tearing his fogged spectacles off to wipe sweat off white eyebrows. Pulling out his fountain pen on open gravel twenty feet upwind, he scrawled *Leiche besichtigt 8.IX.43, 08:26 — Identität bestätigt, Akte Kwiatkowska wegen Tod geschlossen — Mahler, SS-Ustuf.* straight across Sylwia's epidemic death duplicate, confiscated the cancelled *Irena Kwiatkowska Kennkarte* for Kroll's closed-file archive, and had his Opel Olympia reversing out Lindleya's gate inside ninety seconds to go scrub himself in alcohol on Aleja Szucha!

Beside the dead-house door, Bronka lowered the heavy iron crowbar slowly to her clog-tip and spat once into the nettles.

"Rest eternal grant unto her, O Lord," the old Wola butcher's daughter muttered piously, crossing herself over bloodstained apron linen for poor Anna Nowak going to Bródno under two women's sins while down past Grójec apple orchards a bald girl in peasant sackcloth rode free through morning sun toward pine trees.

Sylwia stood watching the grey dust settle behind Lindleya's iron gates—heart slowing steady from one-twenty back to seventy—and realized that with Halina gone safe into the woods, Mirecki flat upstairs, and Kroll's 1933 original ledger sitting frustrated in Szucha's safe, only one locked door remained unopened between herself and Ludwig Schoeler before autumn broke Warsaw's back.

Chapter XXIV

Red Safelight

Warsaw, 12 September 1943

Nothing inside a hospital smelled cleaner or lonelier on Sunday evenings than the X-ray darkroom behind Theater One: sour acetic stop-bath, cold sodium thiosulfate fixer stinging faint vinegar-sulfur up the nostrils, wet gelatin emulsion dripping slow *plink… plink* off stainless-steel corner clips into porcelain troughs, and four millimeters of sheet-lead lining door and shutters so thoroughly that neither street megaphones nor ambulance bells penetrated louder than seashells held to an ear.

At half-past seven on Sunday the twelfth of September, Sylwia lifted Ward B's last twelve-by-fifteen glass chest plate out of the washing tank under the solitary fifteen-watt ruby-red safelight bulb, hung it glistening crimson-black beside six fractured-rib and tuberculous-cavity films overhead, and dried her fingers carefully on lintless linen.

Five days since Halina Różańska rode past Ochota barriers bald under peasant ticking while Untersturmführer Mahler signed off Anna Nowak's phenol-cooked fingers in lime. Downstairs the basement *Fleckfieber* laboratory stood padlocked under official municipal disinfection seal pending "replacement technician assignment"—safe, silent, scrubbed clean of every trace of Dawid's wires or stolen insulin.

Which left Sylwia alone in red shadow with five centimeters of thirty-five-millimeter celluloid she had carried hidden inside the hollow brass handle of her percussion hammer for eight weeks since July fourteenth.

An hour earlier, at half-past six, she had climbed up to the sunny southwest corner room on the third floor to check **Docent Mirecki's** evening pulse before night nurses settled down, and obtain the radiology cabinet's spare brass Bramah key without waking the technician.

Propped at forty-five degrees against three linen pillows in a faded silk dressing-gown from Karlsbad, sixty-two-year-old Mirecki looked ten pounds lighter than July—cheekbones transparent ivory above neatly trimmed white beard-stubble, yet radial pulse beating regular at seventy-two without ectopic skips. Across his knees lay a thick eighteen-ninety-nine Leipzig edition of Tillmanns's *Lehrbuch der speziellen Chirurgie*—whose hollowed-out center pages, Sylwia noticed dryly as she closed the bedroom latch behind her, held a tiny crystal-detector coil and single Bakelite telephone earpiece wired invisibly into the brass bedstead spring for six-o'clock London shortwave!

"Salerno beachhead's holding against German counter-tanks," Mirecki murmured unashamedly, slipping the tiny earpiece beneath Tillmanns's cover as Sylwia set her stethoscope bell gently over his fifth intercostal apex. "Though anyone expecting British paratroopers over Saski Square before two more winters freeze the Vistula reads fairy stories instead of maps. Heart sounds cleaner, Pani Ordynator?"

"First sound firmer, zero pericardial rub, lungs dry at both bases," Sylwia reported, folding her stethoscope tubing neat. "Two more weeks before stairs, and zero arguments with Zawadzki until October."

When she asked casually for the spare radiology cupboard key to re-check old thirty-nine osteomyelitis glass plates against Tuesday's lectures, Mirecki fished the small notched brass key off his watch-chain without hesitation—pausing two seconds with thin blue-veined fingers resting over hers before letting go.

"You carry half this hospital's brickwork on two shoulders since July, Sylwia—and since Wednesday morning's business in the dead-house, considerably heavier lead than bricks," the old man said very quietly, looking straight through thick pince-nez into her guarded dark eyes without asking where "Irena Kwiatkowska's" living shadow slept tonight. "In nineteen-six I spent two semesters at Berlin's Charité watching old König and Hildebrand operate before race-lunatics turned German science into slaughterhouse bookkeeping. Hard people, Prussians—all square edges and iron timetables—yet once in twenty years you met one whose word held weight when roofs fell in. Whatever knot you're untying downstairs tonight, child, don't cut living vessels out of old pride."

Sylwia hadn't answered a syllable—simply wished him quiet sleep, walked down two flights to Theater One's darkroom annex, and locked four millimeters of lead behind her spine.

Why hadn't she projected Frames Three, Four, and Five before tonight? Because on July fourteenth Frame Two's crossed-out arrest line had already knocked half the breath out of her ribs, and until Mirecki's brass key turned the oak cupboard lock ten minutes ago, the Leitz slide-and-film magnifier sat sealed behind glass.

Now she unlocked the oak cupboard, clamped the small brass Leitz projection-condenser onto the dry bench edge, switched off even the ceiling safelight briefly while slipping the thirty-five-millimeter negative strip into the carrier gate—putting a pale amber filter glass in front of the lens so no stray white crack leaked round the door-jamb—and focused the twelve-inch square image crisp onto a white enameled developing tray propped vertical against the tiled wall.

Frame One: *Polizeipräsidium Berlin, Abteilung IA — 7. März 1933, 18:00 Uhr.* Frame Two: *Kotarska, Sylwia Helena — gestrichen lt. Verf. RWM / Abw. II vom 8.III.33, 11:45 Uhr.*

Slowly Sylwia turned the knurled brass advance thumb-wheel one click right to **Frame Three**.

Sharp black-on-amber German typescript leaped twelve inches wide across white porcelain—headed *REICHSWEHRMINISTERIUM / ABTEILUNG ABWEHR II — Aktenvermerk Geheim (Az. Pers. Sch/33)*, signed at the bottom in steep Prussian Gothic script *von Bredow, Major i.G., 8.III.1933, 11:40 Uhr*:

Der Medizinalpraktikant Dr. med. Ludwig Schoeler (Charité) erscheint heute 11:15 Uhr unaufgefordert im Dienstzimmer und übergibt zwei im Privatpult des verhafteten Prof. Dr. J. Mandelbaum aufgefundene Original-Quittungen der KPD-Unfallstelle Wedding (gezeichnet S. Kotarska, poln. Staatsang.) zur sofortigen Vernichtung.

Gegen verbindliche Unterzeichnung einer siebenjährigen unkündbaren Sonderdienst-Verpflichtung im Sanitäts-Nachrichtendienst (Verzicht auf akademische Habilitation Charité) sowie Übergabe des Nachlass-Dossiers Kapitän z.S. a.D. H. Schoeler betr. Polizeipräsident v. L. wird seitens Abt. Abwehr II gegenüber Abt. IA (Alexanderplatz) dienstliches Sperrinteresse geltend gemacht, Name Kotarska aus Haftliste 419/33 gestrichen und freier Grenzübertritt Bahnhof Friedrichstraße bis 10.III. früh erwirkt.

Sylwia's fingers froze solid on the brass advance wheel.

Against binding signature of a seven-year non-revocable special-service obligation in military intelligence (renouncing academic surgical Habilitation at Charité) AND surrender of the estate dossier of retired Navy Captain H. Schoeler concerning Police President von L., Abwehr II asserts official preemption against Alexanderplatz, strikes the name Kotarska from Arrest List 419/33, and secures unmolested border exit via Friedrichstraße Station through dawn March 10.

She clicked numb-fingered to **Frame Four**—a short handwritten appendix note stapled beneath von Bredow's memo from Alexanderplatz's railway surveillance post at Anhalter Bahnhof dated *8.III.33*:

Überwachung Prof. Mandelbaum: Zielperson erschien 09:50 Uhr am Bahnsteig 3 Anhalter Bhf. (D-Zug Prag), wo Dr. L. Schoeler bereits seit 09:15 Uhr mit zwei gelösten Fahrkarten I. Kl. Berlin–Prag wartete. Nach heftigem Wortwechsel weigerte sich M. einzusteigen und kehrte per Droschke zur Charité zurück (Festnahme dort 12:15 Uhr). Schoeler folgte 10:55 Uhr zur Klinik.

Sylwia switched off the Leitz lamp bulb because the white porcelain tray had blurred underwater, though zero tears fell—her throat simply locked dry and aching as if someone had driven an iron wedge straight behind her thyroid cartilage.

See the whole morning of Wednesday the eighth of March nineteen-thirty-three laid out minute by minute on cold police paper:

At nine-fifteen a.m., twenty-three-year-old Ludwig Schoeler—penniless except for whatever he got pawning his dead father's silver chronometer or his Virchow gold-washed medal that morning!—stands forty minutes in blowing snow on Platform Three at Anhalter Bahnhof holding two paid first-class Prague tickets for old Jakob Mandelbaum and his wife. At nine-fifty stubborn, gallant, blind old Jakob shows up only to argue furiously on the platform that Verdun veterans don't flee hooligans and rides a cab straight back to Luisenstraße to protect his myelin jars!

Ludwig races back behind him at ten-fifty-five knowing the SA trucks are already warming engines on Alexanderplatz—breaks into Mandelbaum's annex office at eleven-fifteen NOT to steal Mandelbaum's clinic for Kleist, to rip Sylwia Kotarska's two signed Communist dispensary receipts out of the roll-top desk forty minutes before storm-troopers smash Jakob's spectacles on the stairs! Runs straight across courtyard

slush to Bendlerstraße's recruiting major at eleven-fifteen, throws away his entire surgical life under von Halden—*Verzicht auf akademische Habilitation Charité*, the single ambition Ludwig breathed for!—plus his dead disgraced father's last naval leverage-papers, signs seven years of his soul into military espionage to scrub her Polish name off tonight's cellars, stands trapped behind upstairs glass at twelve-fifteen unable to lift one finger for Jakob without voiding the deal before Alexanderplatz's clerk inks the erasure—and then walks up four flights to Savignyplatz at ten-fifteen that night in a uniform coat he has owned for five hours to take Sylwia's spit straight across his scarred cheek without uttering one word!

Out in Theater One's scrub-corridor beyond the outer anteroom, two firm boots stopped outside the lead-lined X-ray door and knocked—two short, one sharp.

Not Vesper's waddle; not Bronka's wooden clogs.

Sylwia did not take the thirty-five-millimeter strip out of the Leitz gate. Moving silent across concrete in darkroom shadow, she slid back the inner lead bolt, opened the light-trap vestibule door four inches, saw **Ludwig** standing bareheaded in damp autumn rain-coat carrying a routine leather sanitary-mail pouch for cover in the empty Sunday surgical hall, pulled him straight across both light-trap thresholds by his coat lapel, and slammed the heavy lead-lined inner door bolted behind his back!

* * *

Inside the X-ray room burned only that single fifteen-watt ruby-red bulb overhead, turning white porcelain trays the colour of arterial blood, blackening Ludwig's damp grey gabardine coat to charcoal, and glinting scarlet off six wet glass chest radiographs of strangers' ribs hanging between their heads like flayed angels.

"Careful of the wet glass overhead," Ludwig began low, unbuttoning his rain-spotted coat collar and shaking September drizzle off his cap —"Mahler filed his death-closure memo on *Kwiatkowska* Thursday afternoon without a footnote; your basement file's dead and buried on Szucha, though Berlin's—"

Sylwia didn't let him finish Berlin.

Reaching sideways without taking her eyes off his face, she snapped the brass toggle switch on the Leitz condenser lamp **ON**.

Across twelve inches of white porcelain developing tray directly beside Ludwig's right hip blazed **Frame Three** of *Polizeipräsidium / Reichswehrministerium 8. März 1933—Verzicht auf akademische Habilitation Charité… Übergabe Nachlass-Dossier Kapitän Schoeler… Name Kotarska aus Haftliste 419/33 gestrichen.*

Ludwig stopped mid-breath.

Under blood-red safelight his winter-green eyes turned strange monochromatic slate-black as he glanced down once at Major von Bredow's eleven-forty memorandum glowing crisp against white enamel, saw Frame Four's Anhalter Bahnhof surveillance paragraph sitting half an inch right in the film gate, and raised his head slowly back to Sylwia standing three feet in front of him with both fists clenched white against her white surgical smock.

Five seconds of dead silence ticked away to the slow *plink… plink* of fixer dripping off glass plates into the lead trough.

"Put that lamp off before heat blisters the celluloid," Ludwig said very quietly.

"Ten years!" Sylwia's voice broke out low, hoarse, shaking from heel to crown inside four millimeters of soundproofed lead wall where for the first time in forty-two weeks she didn't have to whisper for sentries! She shoved his wet coat lapel back with both raw hands—not gently, slamming the heel of her fist hard against his dry gabardine chest right beside the silver buttons. "*Ten years*, you arrogant, insufferable Prussian bastard! You stood inside Widow Pohl's doorway at ten-fifteen at night wearing that damned grey coat while Lotte Bergmann swore you sold Jakob for thirty pieces of silver—you let me spit in your face, tear up your train ticket, ride twelve hours on wooden planks to Poznań wishing typhoid and Russian bayonets into your guts every winter until forty-three—and *not once*, not in Room Fourteen at forty degrees, not on Królewska, not lying naked on clean sheets at Świder while I laughed with you, did you open your teeth to tell me whose name sat on Line Two of that warrant!"

Ludwig didn't catch her wrists this time to stop her hitting him; he stood planted flat-footed against the lead door taking both fists square against his chest without giving half an inch, jaw locked white, eyes

blazing back into hers under red glass with sudden, matching, unrepentant fury!

"And what the hell do you imagine would have happened at ten-sixteen on the ninth of March if I *had* told you, Sylwia?!" he fired straight back—voice roughened raw, stripping every cool officer tone clean off the walls! "Think back to twenty-three-year-old Sylwia Kotarska standing beside two packed suitcases with four Reichsmarks sixty in her purse and Jakob Mandelbaum bleeding blind in Columbia-Haus cellar since noon! Suppose I walk into Savignyplatz and say, *By the way, Fräulein Doktor, Jakob refused my Prague tickets at ten this morning, and at quarter to twelve I traded von Halden's surgical clinic and my father's papers to Bendlerstraße so Alexanderplatz wouldn't throw YOU into Moringen camp over two Wedding tetanus slips!* Would you have climbed meekly onto the midnight Warsaw train thanking me kindly?!"

Sylwia's breath caught ragged in her throat—because every drop of honest bone inside her knew the instantaneous, catastrophic answer before he shouted it into her teeth:

"The hell you would!" Ludwig snarled low, stepping one stride forward off the lead door until *he* backed *her* hips hard against the heavy oak edge of the fluoroscopy table under dripping glass ribs! "Inside twenty minutes you'd have marched straight down to Polish Legation or Alexanderplatz station-house in that damned threadbare black coat of yours demanding they release Mandelbaum or arrest the person who actually signed Receipt One-Fourteen—voiding von Bredow's military preemption before dawn, putting yourself behind concentration-camp wire for pride, and making everything I signed away at eleven-forty worth zero!"

"It wasn't yours to buy behind my back!" she gasped, dark eyes burning wet—still refusing to drop one tear onto her cheeks, furious past bearing at owing her breath three times over (1933, March sluice-closet, Skaryszewska!) to the single human being whose equal she had killed herself trying to stay! "Von Halden's clinic was *yours*—you lived inside that dog-cellar twenty hours a day because cutting vessels was the only clean thing in Germany you didn't despise! You threw away surgery to become Canaris's errand-dog in grey wool for *me*, and then watched me treat you like dirt across an operating table in Warsaw—"

"I didn't throw it away as charity for a helpless girl, *Kotarska*!" Both his hands framed the sides of her face—rough warm palms pressing hard over cold cheekbones, thumbs halting a fraction below wet lower lashes while six inches away in blood-red dark his face looked stripped down to every scar Berlin and Russia and Lindleya had ever carved into him. "By March eighth Germany was burning down around Luisenstraße whether I stayed holding von Halden's retractors for Nazi Dozenten like Kleist or signed von Bredow's devil-paper! Saving your stubborn neck was the *single clean bargain* left in the building by noon—and letting you hate my guts across the Polish border guaranteed one thing above earth: whatever happened in Berlin next spring, *you wouldn't come back on a student visa to get killed*!"

Silence slammed back down inside the lead-lined room—broken only by both their ragged breaths steaming faint in cool sixty-degree basement air and water *plink*-ing slow into hypo.

Slowly Sylwia raised both raw, mercury-scarred hands from his coat lapels up to his face.

For thirteen winters—since midnight snow behind Schöneberg ash-bins in December nineteen-thirty—she had looked at that three-centimeter pale crescent scar with four tiny cross-hatched ladder dots beneath his right cheekbone: stitching it raw with juniper schnapps at twenty, spitting square across it in thirty-three, wiping dried Ochota slush and arterial froth off it on Table One in February forty-three when one millimeter of slack in her left thumb would have stopped his heart forever.

Her bare fingertips touched the cool white ridge beneath his right eye, feeling every tiny raised dot of her own twenty-year-old silk needlework under skin burning alive.

"I almost lifted my thumb off your artery on February ninth," she whispered in Polish—speaking her own tongue straight into his mouth for the first time in her life without translating, knowing he understood every word. "*Na stole operacyjnym. Przez dziesięć sekund chciałam pozwolić ci umrzeć za Jakoba.*" (*On the operating table. For ten seconds I wanted to let you die for Jakob.*)

Ludwig didn't flinch—turned his cheek half an inch deeper into her cold palm, closing his eyes for one single second before opening them dark and bottomless onto hers, answering just as quiet in rough, unbroken Polish:

"*Wiem. Dobrze, że byłaś lepszym chirurgiem niż mścicielem.*" (*I know. Good thing you were a better surgeon than an avenger.*)

Sylwia pulled his head down by the nape of his neck and kissed the scarred crescent beneath his right eye first—open-mouthed, salt-wet now as one single hot drop broke loose off her lashes onto his cheekbone—before her mouth slid fierce and starving down two inches onto his lips!

* * *

Ludwig clicked off the hot Leitz lamp blind with his left knuckles without breaking their mouths apart, dropping the room back into pure submerged crimson twilight under the fifteen-watt red bulb.

Nothing between them had ever felt like what broke loose across that oak fluoroscopy table—not June's blackout rage when hatred still armored both their spines, not July's sunlit defiance, not even Świder's stolen golden afternoon where nineteen-thirty-three still sat unspoken behind her teeth. Tonight zero wall stood left between twenty-year-old Berlin kids and thirty-four-year-old ghosts standing neck-deep in Warsaw blood.

Rain-damp gabardine greatcoat hit dry concrete floor; Ludwig's tunic buttons tore open under both their hands together—not popping horn this time, unfastening fast and shaking down to bare skin—while he unbuttoned her starched white surgical coat from throat to knees and slid it wide off her shoulders along with her thin black wool dress underneath, laying the white coat folded double across cold black X-ray tabletop rubber so cold vulcanite didn't freeze her spine!

When he lifted her bare onto the white-coat pad beneath hanging glass rib-cages dripping slow red drops into the trough two feet left, Sylwia didn't lie back passive—sitting upright at the table edge completely naked save black stockings rolled at the knee, wrapping bare arms tight round his bare scarred shoulders to press her face into the sunken crimson-purple keloid trough beneath his missing collarbone! Her tongue tasted clean salt skin right over the living pulse of her own five-zero silk anastomosis beating deep and steady beneath scar tissue—kissing every jagged edge where she had cut dead flesh raw out of him in February without procaine and where he had ripped himself bleeding open in March to save an eighteen-year-old boy behind four inches of brick!

Ludwig's fingers tightened convulsively in her loosened black hair at the feel of her mouth warm and open directly over his chest wound—a low, rough sound tearing out of the back of his throat that sounded closer to pain than pleasure as he caught her under both arms, lifted her mouth straight back up to his, and eased her flat back onto the folded white surgical coat while coming down full length over her between parted thighs.

In deep ruby safelight skin looked bronze-red and shadow-carved; six inches above her face his winter-green eyes shone dark obsidian without a trace of defense left anywhere inside them.

When he slid inside her—slow, thick, scorching hot through drenched slickness that took him all the way to the root without resistance—neither closed their eyes, and neither grabbed rough leverage for combat. Ludwig laced all five fingers of his right hand tight through the scarred left palm he had stitched in thirty-one, pinning their joined hands gently onto white cotton beside her cheek while his left forearm cradled warm behind the nape of her neck, moving inside her in long, deep, aching strokes that rocked her whole body up the smooth table pad and back down into him!

Unbearable how much worse tenderness hurt than violence ever had: every unhurried thrust reaching straight behind her breastbone where nobody had ever been allowed to touch since her mother died when she was eighteen, stripping her so terrifyingly open that Sylwia wrapped her free right arm tight across his bare sweating back, hooking both ankles hard behind his thighs to hold him buried deep against her womb, whispering ragged broken Polish against his jaw—not endearments, neither knew clean soft words, just his name over and over (*"Ludwig—zostań tu —nie puszczaj"*), nails gripping muscle without breaking skin while his mouth kissed wet eyelashes, cheekbones, parted lips, swallowing every trembling breath she drew!

Heat built slower and ten fathoms deeper than ever before—no sharp lightning flash, an unstoppable dark river rising up through pelvis, belly, throat until her whole body arched helplessly into his chest, inner walls clamping round him in long, liquid, shuddering waves that went on and on while she buried her face silently into the curve of his throat; three deep strokes into her tightening heat Ludwig's breath broke rough against her hair, gripping her scarred left hand crushing-tight inside his fist as he drove all the way home and came deep inside her with a long,

low shudder that left him completely still, heavy and warm atop her ribs while red light burned quiet overhead.

Minutes passed—five, maybe ten—measured only by water *plink*-ing slower now off dried glass radiographs into fixer.

Neither spoke politics, neither mentioned Aleja Szucha waiting four streets south, neither dared speak *after the war* because surgeons and intelligence officers in Warsaw in September nineteen-forty-three knew survival curves better than priests did.

Only when Ludwig finally raised himself onto one elbow to pull her white surgical coat edges gently up over her cooling bare shoulders before kissing the corner of her mouth once in red shadow did he murmur against her temple:

"Take that thirty-five-millimeter strip out of the projector and burn it over the sink before you unlock the door, Sylwia. Nitrate base flares clean; safety acetate melts black in spirit flame."

"Already planned," she murmured back against his bare collarbone, keeping one palm flat over his steady seventy-beat heart for ten more stolen seconds before cold air came back in. "Why did you come tonight instead of waiting till Tuesday?"

"Because Tirpitzufer recalled von Berg to Berlin this afternoon for 'budget testimony' before Gestapo auditors," Ludwig said quietly into her dark hair, autumn chill sliding silent under the lead door even before they stood up to dress. "And tomorrow morning a new SS- und Polizeiführer lands from Russia via Mogilev to take over Warsaw streets—Franz Kutschera. Keep your head down this week, my darling."

Meine Liebe—not *Kotarska*, slipped out once bare and unguarded in red dark before he turned to pick up his grey coat off concrete—leaving Sylwia standing motionless beside the porcelain sink with matches in her hand, watching nineteen-thirty-three curl into a tiny black bead of melted acetate ash in blue alcohol flame while October gathered outside the shutters.

PART FOUR

Open Wound

September – November 1943

Chapter XXV

The Signature

Warsaw, 26 September 1943

Summer died in Warsaw between a Wednesday and a Friday without leaving any golden interval behind—only cold grey rain blowing diagonal off the Kampinos marshes, soaking unheated brick tenements black and plastering dead yellow horse-chestnut leaves flat across tram-tracks like wet leather soles.

Since Tuesday the twenty-first, when Brigadeführer Jürgen Stroop's successor **SS-Brigadeführer Franz Kutschera** moved into the Rose Alley villa behind Ujazdowskie with his Mogilev anti-partisan staff, even the sound of boots along Marszałkowska had changed pitch: double patrols of steel-helmeted *Schutzpolizei* carrying cocked submachine guns at hip-level instead of slung over shoulders, stopping random tramcars every twenty minutes to haul passengers coatless into cold rain while checking work-stamps line by line.

Riding north up ulica Okopowa at quarter to three that Sunday afternoon inside a packed, wet-wool-steaming Number One-B tramcar with purple cemetery asters wrapped in newspaper across her knees, Sylwia watched the new Mogilev arithmetic work at six feet.

Three hundred yards short of Powązki's fourth gate—directly alongside the bombed, rain-blackened red brick perimeter wall of the old Jewish Cemetery where birch saplings grew crooked out of mortar craters—iron brakes screeched sparks across wet rails. Two green police troop-carriers wedged diagonal across the tracks ahead; whistles shrilled three short blasts; every sliding tram door banged wide under steel rifle-butts:

"*Alles aussteigen! Kennkarten und Arbeitskarten vorzeigen—schnell, schnell, an die Mauer!*"

Forty damp Sunday passengers—widows carrying jam-jars of heather for graves, railway clerks, mothers clutching small boys by knitted scarves—spilled stumbling down iron steps into ankle-deep brown gutter water while eight helmeted *Schupo* troopers in gleaming black rubberized rain-capes walked slowly down the line with cocked MP-40 barrels leveled waist-high.

Two places ahead of Sylwia stood a gangling, pale-eared boy of sixteen or seventeen wearing a threadbare navy school-cape three inches short at the wrists, hugging a battered black leatherette violin case vertical against his chest to shield its seams from rain. When the *Scharführer* snapped fingers for work-papers, the boy handed over his grey *Kennkarte* alongside a stamped pasteboard pupil's certificate from Professor Lefeld's permitted Municipal Music Trades Course on Okólnik.

The *Scharführer* didn't even read the German seal; holding the damp pasteboard card between two wet black leather thumbs, he tore it leisurely across once—twice—dropped all four soggy quarters straight into the brown gutter swirl between his jackboots, and jerked his chin left toward the open tarpaulin lorry already half-full of shivering young men kneeling hands-on-necks on wet floorboards!

"Fiddlers can shovel peat in East Prussia till spring—*hinauf mit dir!*"

"The violin belongs to the school Conservatory, Herr Wachtmeister—my mother signed five hundred złoty bond for it—" the boy stammered in terrified textbook German, clutching the wet black case until a rifle-butt caught his elbow-joint sideways with a dull wooden crack that sent violin and bow skittering wide across wet cobbles!

Before the boy could stoop for it, two troopers hauled him bodily by collar and belt over the iron tailboard. Nobody in the silent soaked queue dared bend down toward the mud-splashed violin case lying six feet off the kerb—touch confiscated luggage during a *łapanka* and you rode east beside its owner—until the *Scharführer* stepped square in front of Sylwia, water dripping off his steel helmet-rim onto her asters.

Sylwia held out her grey *Kennkarte* clipped open beside her green-bordered *Städtisches Krankenhaus Kindlein Jesu — Chirurgischer Notdienst / Seuchenschutz* epidemic card counter-stamped in violet *Sanitätsabteilung* ink by Kurt Vesper.

Three slow seconds the *Scharführer* squinted from her gaunt, rain-wet face down to Vesper's Wehrmacht eagle, grunted once—"*Weitergehen,*

Ärztin, nicht herumstehen!"—and waved his wet glove north toward the cemetery gate while stepping sideways onto the abandoned violin case with sixteen stone of hobnailed boot, cracking thin spruce soundboard ribs clean in half with a sharp hollow *snap* that followed Sylwia fifty yards up the rain-swept pavement.

At half-past three Powązki Cemetery itself lay nearly deserted under steady chill drizzle.

Sylwia stood bareheaded—black umbrella tilted low against north wind—before Avenue Forty-Two's grey Silesian granite ledger where *HELENA Z ZAMOJSKICH KOTARSKA (1884–1929)* and below it *KAZIMIERZ KOTARSKI, RADCA LEGACJI R.P. (1872–1937)* were cut in sharp square Roman capitals already greening with wet lichen because nobody had scrubbed stone with oxalic acid since thirty-nine. She laid a five-złoty twist of late purple Michaelmas asters beside the rusted iron lantern-hook and stood sixty seconds without praying, listening to rain patter off weeping birches and crows cawing hoarse toward the Jewish cemetery wall half a kilometer south where blown-up marble tombs still lay cratered from spring.

Behind the tall ivy-choked sandstone mausoleum of Collegiate Assessor Pietraszewski ten paces left, wet gravel crunched once under rubber-soled boots.

Sylwia didn't turn fast—slid her right hand casually inside her raincoat pocket where her heavy brass ward-key lay cold, pivoted forty-five degrees as if shaking water off her umbrella ferrule, and stopped breathing for half a beat.

Twelve weeks on the run had pared **Marek Wolski** down to grey gristle and wet bone.

Gone was the neat Polytechnic engineer's trilby and trimmed brown hair: he wore a railway stoker's greasy peaked cloth cap pulled low over ears sticking out above hollow stubbled cheeks, a workman's quilted black cotton *fufajka* jacket too big round the neck, and across his left temple a livid pink four-centimeter graze-scar barely three weeks healed where somebody's bullet had creased periosteum without cracking bone. Under soaked cap-brim his narrow grey eyes burned flat, sleepless, and fever-bright.

"Don't reach for keys, Sylwia," Marek said quietly in Polish from eight feet away among wet cemetery ferns, keeping both bare blue-knuckled

hands visible outside his quilted pockets so she saw he held no pistol. "Nobody's behind the birches. I stood two hours in the mason's shed by Gate Four waiting because cemetery paths don't have house-porters."

Sylwia didn't yield an inch of umbrella shadow between them. "Are you still working for dead men, Marek, or did Kroll's cars miss your ear by half an inch?"

"Kroll's plainclothes team hit my Żoliborz room on the twelfth of August—two minutes after a milk-boy whistled from the corner," Marek said without self-pity, touching nothing near his scarred temple. "Went over two shed roofs into Marymont gardens while Section Two's clean-up audit spent six weeks combing Stach's ashes. They cleared me on Thursday—handed me a fresh platoon north of Praga starting Monday."

"Congratulations," Sylwia said coldly. "Then stay north of Praga and stay off my path."

"I meant to," Marek said. Rain dripped steady off his cloth cap-visor past his crooked nose-bridge; zero lingering lover's rancor sat in his voice —something much colder and heavier, the flat voice in which hospital pathologists read malignancy slides to colleagues they didn't even like. "Until eleven o'clock last night, when two of our boys from postal interception cracked open a courier pouch lifted off an *Abteilung Vier* registry car stalled in mud behind Plac Unii."

He reached inside his quilted vest lining, pulled out an oiled-silk tobacco pouch, and held out three damp five-by-seven glossy Leica contact enlargements still curling wet along their unwashed hypo edges.

"I didn't show Paper Two to *Góra* last night," Marek said softly. "Because show Paper Two upstairs, and by six o'clock tonight three boys who don't know your face put nine-millimeter lead through your back coming out Lindleya's gate—and whatever happened on Koszykowa in June, you pulled bullets out of my railwayman on Pańska without asking a grosz. Read the stamp and read the signature, Sylwia."

Cold rain ticked louder than drum-skins on tight black umbrella silk as Sylwia took the three damp photographic prints in gloved fingers and tilted them under grey sky-glare.

Print One was a covering memo from Aleja Szucha's inter-service liaison registry dated *21.IX.1943*, acknowledging *Abwehrstelle Warschau*'s formal jurisdictional block filed five weeks earlier over municipal epidemic installations.

Print Two was a direct photographic copy of a typed, single-spaced German counter-espionage directive headed:

ABWEHRSTELLE IM WEHRKREIS I / AUSSENSTELLE WARSCHAU *Referat III F (Gegenspionage) — Geheime Kommandosache! Az. III F / W-884/43 Warschau, den*

18. August 1943

Betr.: Operative Abschöpfung u. Überwachung "Nest Lindleya" (Städt. Krankenhaus Kindlein Jesu, Pavillon III).

Sylwia's eyes dropped down seven lines of ice-cold German intelligence bureaucracy while Powązki's wet birch trees seemed to tilt five degrees sideways around her shoulders:

1. *Das Objekt Pavillon III (insbes. chirurg. Aufnahmestation unter stellv. Leitung Dr. med. S. Kotarska sowie angeschlossener Fleckfieber-Kellertrakt) wird mit Wirkung vom 18.VIII.43 als laufender Gegenspionage-Vorgang der Abt. III F geführt ("Vorgang Naht").*
2. *Einzelzugriffe oder Verhaftungen durch Dienststellen der Sicherheitspolizei bedürfen zwecks Vermeidung vorzeitiger Aufrollung polnischer Sanitäts-Verbindungswege der vorherigen Abstimmung mit dem unterzeichneten Referatsleiter.*
3. *Über den laufenden Ausbau der Vertrauens-Abschöpfung wird dem Amt Ausland/Abwehr (Abt. III) monatlich gesondert berichtet.*

And at the bottom right corner—beneath *Für die Richtigkeit* and the round eagle stamp of *Abwehrstelle Warschau*—sat no clerk's rubber stamp, no Hauptmann von Berg *i.V.*, no forgery on earth:

Slantless, razor-sharp vertical copperplate strokes with the exact broken up-tick on the capital *S* and tight-looped *ch* ligature she had counter-signed across Room Fourteen's yellow discharge paper on the nineteenth of April:

Schoeler *Oberstleutnant*

* * *

For ten full seconds rain hammered black silk overhead while not a muscle moved in Sylwia's face or throat.

Look at the words again before breathing: *Dated 18 August 1943*—ten days after Świder's pine-woods bedsheet and wild plums, two days *before* Ludwig stood in Judge Silberstein's study warning her cheerfully about

Palais Brühl invitations while burning blue flimsies! *Code-name: "Vorgang Naht"*—Operation *Suture*, the exact literal German translation of her underground cover-name ***"Szew"**, *which she had* never once spoken aloud inside Room Fourteen or Królewska Sixteen*!!* Paragraph 3: Ongoing development of source-exploitation ("Vertrauens-Abschöpfung") reported monthly to Berlin!*

Across eight feet of wet cemetery gravel Marek watched every drop of colour drain down out of Sylwia's cheeks into her black collar without gloating by a syllable.

"Where did he learn the cover-name *Szew—Naht*?" Marek asked quietly.

Sylwia's mind raced frantically backward over freezing blackness—*Nobody knew "Szew" except Section II's burned files!* When Kroll's Gestapo raided or bought *Inżynier Stach*'s Section II index cards before Stach died on July fifth, *"Szew — Lindleya"* sat on Stach's list—and Ludwig's Baltic-German typist on Aleja Szucha copied Kroll's incoming slips!

Wait: why would Ludwig take *"Szew"* off a stolen Gestapo slip, translate it into *"Vorgang Naht"* on an official August eighteenth *Abwehr III F* dossier, register Pavilion Three *and* her own full name (*Dr. med. S. Kotarska*) as an active German counter-espionage "source-exploitation operation" reporting monthly to Berlin, and **never breathe one single word of that file's existence to her across six weeks**—not at Palais Brühl, not while warning her about Halina's September eighth raid, not even two Sundays ago lying naked across an X-ray table under red safelight whispering *meine Liebe* into her hair?!

"Read Paragraph Two and Paragraph Three like an adult, Sylwia, not like a woman," Marek said harshly through rain, stepping two paces closer beside Kazimierz Kotarski's wet granite slab. "Every intelligence service in Europe runs that identical play when two agencies fight over turf: *Don't arrest the Polish surgeon yet, Kroll—she's MY unwitting penetration channel into the Home Army's medical directorate! Let her swim free through September and October while my watchers log every courier cart, every Grójec disinfection van, every wounded boy brought into Lindleya—and in November when Berlin audits Canaris's eastern numbers, Abwehr rolls up thirty underground clinics in one night to prove Tirpitzufer catches bigger fish than Himmler!*"

Every Grójec disinfection van.

Cold nausea—sharper than goose-fat at Palais Brühl—turned Sylwia's stomach to lead.

On August eighth at Świder, she had walked down a sandy pine path carrying sulfonamide and Grójec papers to Konstancin's fourteen-year-old boy while Ludwig stood smiling on the porch unlocking doors! On September seventh, she had sent Halina out in Jurek's disinfection van toward Grójec orchards—and twenty-four hours later Kroll's clerk Mahler closed Halina's file without a murmur! Had Ludwig protected Halina out of love—or logged Jurek's Grójec disinfection route onto *Vorgang Naht*'s October rollup map while letting Sylwia kiss his cheekbone scar in the dark so she trusted him blind?!

Wait—stop—hold the surgical knife steady! Look at *both* hypotheses side by side without flinching: - **Hypothesis A (Defense):** Paragraph Two explicitly barred Kroll's Security Police from making unilateral arrests inside Pavilion Three without Ludwig's prior sign-off (*bedürfen der vorherigen Abstimmung*)! Maybe Ludwig filed a bogus *Vorgang Naht* "exploitation" claim on August eighteenth as the *only bureaucratic shield left in German law* to stop Reinhart Kroll dragging Sylwia off to Aleja Szucha after Berlin's 1933 folder arrived! - **Hypothesis B (Betrayal / Double Edge):** Even if Ludwig invented *Vorgang Naht* as a bureaucratic shield—**once "Dr. med. S. Kotarska — Vorgang Naht" sat stamped inside Abwehrstelle Warschau's official registry safe with monthly Berlin reporting required under Paragraph Three**, what happened the day Tirpitzufer recalled Ludwig (like Hauptmann von Berg two weeks ago!) and handed Saski Square's safe-keys to Reinhart Kroll or a loyal Nazi colonel?! Whoever opened Folder *W-884/43* inherited a signed German paper certifying either that *Dr. Sylwia Kotarska was a registered Abwehr informant ("Vertrauens-Abschöpfung")*—getting her shot by Polish executioners within six hours!—OR that Pavilion Three was an unharvested Polish underground nest ripe for immediate mass execution!

And knowing that deadly bomb sat ticking inside Saski Square's filing cabinet with *her* name inked across Page One since the eighteenth of August, Ludwig had lain between her thighs on September twelfth whispering *keep your head down, my darling* without telling her the bomb existed!

"Where is Print Three?" Sylwia asked, voice so dead-level and arctic in the rain that Marek blinked rain off his lashes.

Print Three underneath showed only a routine vehicle motor-pool fuel sheet from Saski Square confirming Wanderer car *WH-119402* logged sixty-four kilometers round-trip Otwock–Świder on Sunday 8 August—proving to Marek why she hadn't stayed home Sundays.

Sylwia folded Prints One and Two neatly in half and slid them inside her raincoat pocket—keeping them instead of handing them back!

"Tell *Góra* nothing until Wednesday noon," Sylwia told Marek flatly.

Marek's jaw tightened under grey stubble. "If you run to Królewska to warn him—"

"Warn him of what—his own signature?" Something so black and pitiless looked out of Sylwia's dark eyes across her father's wet grave-slab that Marek involuntarily took half a step back onto the fern border. "If *Vorgang Naht* sits active in Saski Square's registry tonight with Grójec or Lindleya routes attached inside it, shooting me at Lindleya gate leaves the folder sitting intact for Kroll to read on Thursday. Give me forty-eight hours until Tuesday night to find out what sits inside Folder *W-884/43* and burn it at the root—or send your Praga boys Wednesday noon, and welcome to what's left."

Marek studied her gaunt, rain-wet face under black umbrella silk for four silent seconds—recognizing the exact cold tone in which she had held eight inches of Krupp amputation steel six inches from his carotid in June—and gave one curt nod.

"Wednesday noon at All Saints' vestry," he said, turning back into dripping birch-shadow without goodbye and vanishing between wet headstones inside ten strides.

* * *

At nine o'clock that Sunday night rain beat harder against the slanted zinc dormer roof above Pavilion Three's third floor, leaking slow dark drops into an enamel kidney basin Bronka had set under the eave corner.

Sylwia sat upright on the hard wooden stool beside her deal table—raincoat still damp on the peg, purple Powązki asters forgotten in cemetery mud—studying Photostat Print Two under her twenty-power dissecting loupe for twenty unbroken minutes without moving a finger.

Every upstroke, pen-lift, and pressure shading of **Schoeler** matched authentic wet Pelikan nib-ink on linen paper—zero photographic mon-

tage paste-line, zero traced hesitation tremor. Signed personally by Ludwig's steady right hand on Wednesday the eighteenth of August: the exact afternoon before Wanda crawled weeping into Pavilion Three's linen closet with Stefan's death warning, forty-eight hours before Ludwig looked Sylwia straight in the eye on Królewska and said *Have you still got that altered black silk dress from your mother's trunk?*

Not once did Sylwia cry.

Tears belonged to women like Wanda who believed world orders owed private bedrooms mercy. Ten months ago Sylwia had survived Warsaw intact because she trusted zero paper, zero uniform, zero pillow; then across July, August, and September twelfth she had committed the single unpardonable sin of surgery—falling in love with the tissue under her own knife, believing that because twenty-three-year-old Ludwig Schoeler had thrown away Luisenstraße for her in nineteen-thirty-three, thirty-four-year-old *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler after ten years inside Admiral Canaris's house of mirrors wouldn't build a paper cage around her hospital without asking permission!

At ten-fifteen Bronka's heavy knuckle rapped twice on the attic panel: emergency abdominal trauma downstairs—not Polish walk-in, brought clanging through the main gate by two armed German *Bahnschutz* railway-police constables out of *Warszawa Zachodnia* marshalling yards!

Walking down into Theater One five minutes later with her face calm and unreadable above stiff white oilcloth, Sylwia found a forty-five-year-old Polish points-leverman named **Władysław Kurek** lying grey-lipped and rigid across Table One in torn soaked railway corduroy, while directly outside the glass theater doors—refusing Walenty's request to wait in the lodge, standing booted on wet corridor tiles smoking sour-smelling *Machorka* cigarettes and watching every instrument Bronka laid out through the wired glass!—loitered two steel-gorgeted German railway policemen waiting to see whether their prisoner lived long enough to tell Aleja Szucha who helped him uncouple signals wire!

Nine-millimeter Parabellum round fired at forty yards while Kurek jumped a cinder-embankment fence: entry tenth left intercostal space mid-axillary line, exit none, dullness spreading fast across Traube's space into the left flank, systolic pressure seventy-four and falling. Ruptured spleen pulped against ribs.

Scrubbing cold sublimate up her forearms while staring straight out through wired glass at those two dripping German *Bahnschutz* helmets six yards from her sterile drum, Sylwia felt the poison of Marek's Powązki photostat work into every corner of Theater One like coal-gas:

Since the eighteenth of August—forty days ago—every single night admission logged downstairs at Walenty's desk, every disinfection cart rolling out Koszykowa gate, every railway casualty operated under this skylight had sat covered under "Sondervorgang Naht — Abt. III F"!

Did Saski Square pull copies of Walenty's morning police-trauma book every week through municipal health clerks to fatten Paragraph Three's monthly Berlin report? When she opened Władysław Kurek's left upper quadrant two minutes later under light ether—plunging her bare gloved right hand straight behind the stomach into a warm black lake of ruptured splenic blood, mobilizing the shattered friable spleen forward out of deep diaphragmatic ligaments by pure blind fingertip feel so she didn't nip the tail of the pancreas, clamping splenic artery and vein clean in two heavy curved pedicle forceps and lifting two hundred grams of burst purple pulp into Bronka's kidney dish—she heard Kurek mutter three broken delirious syllables under light ether (*"Skrzynka pod trzecim podkładem…" — box under the third railway sleeper*) before Bronka swiftly clapped thicker ether-gauze down over his mouth to drown his voice from the glass door!

Sylwia closed Kurek's left subcostal wall in layers, walked calmly out into the corridor peeling bloody rubber gloves inside out, and looked both armed *Bahnschutz* constables flat in the eye:

"Two liters internal hemorrhage, splenic pedicle tied, shock grave. Move him off flat boards inside five days or shout questions at him before Thursday, and internal ligatures slip inside ten minutes—leaving your station commander an uninterrogated corpse. Sign Walenty's custody receipt at the lodge and post one quiet sentry outside Ward B if regulations require."

Watching the two railway policemen grumble, stamp boots, and sign exactly where she pointed because even armed Germans obeyed cold surgical certainty at midnight, Sylwia climbed back up three dark flights to her slant-roofed cubby at half-past eleven with pulse steady at sixty-eight and ice packed solid around her heart.

Maybe Ludwig built *Vorgang Naht* to block Kroll's teeth. Maybe he built *Vorgang Naht* to feed Tirpitzufer just enough controlled hospital crumbs to save his own Eastern desk after von Berg got recalled.

Either way, *she would not learn which from forty-degree delirium or ten-year-late microfilms ever again.* Tuesday at five o'clock wasn't coming fast enough when Kutschera's police trucks roared past Lindleya every night and Berlin couriers flew daily; showing up unannounced on Monday risked hitting Saski Square officers in his hallway, so **Tuesday at five sharp** he would sit alone across Judge Silberstein's desk while she laid Print Two face-up on green blotter leather.

From the bottom velvet slot of her pawnshop ebony Collin case Sylwia lifted not the heavy amputation blade—too long to pass a sentry coat-brush if Kutschera's new street checkpoints patted sleeves on Królewska—a narrow, razor-pointed **#11 Bard-Parker detachable surgical bistoury blade** locked onto a flat nickel-plated #3 scalpel handle five inches overall.

Taking grey surgical silk and a heavy Glover's needle, she ripped open four inches of black rayon lining inside the wide turn-back cuff of her left raincoat sleeve, stitched a narrow vertical double-cloth scabbard flat along the ulna seam where an open left palm hid steel rigidity completely from casual wrist slaps, cork-tipped the needle-sharp bistoury point with three millimeters of sterile rubber stopper so it couldn't slice through wool prematurely while pulling instantly bare on draw, and slid five inches of surgical steel smooth into her cuff.

If on Tuesday afternoon inside *Wohnung 4* Ludwig looked down at *Vorgang Naht* and lied to her by half a syllable—if one single Polish courier route or Dawid Różański's Grójec pines sat logged inside Folder *W-884/43* for Berlin's November harvest—she had sewn Ludwig Schoeler's left axillary artery together in four minutes on the ninth of February, and she knew down to half a millimeter between first rib and clavicle how fast five inches of #11 steel opened the right one.

Sylwia blew out the attic bulb, lay down flat on her back in pitch-black rain-roar without undressing, and stared open-eyed at dark rafters until morning rounds.

Chapter XXVI

The Canaris Tremor

Warsaw, 28 September 1943

Rain blew straight down Królewska off the Saxon colonnade that Tuesday afternoon at four degrees above zero, stripping dead brown chestnut leaves off wet boughs and slapping them flat across the windshields of parked staff cars.

At two minutes past five nobody answered Sylwia's first short ring on Service Stair B.

For ten heartbeats she stood motionless on the cold stone landing with five inches of #11 surgical steel riding cold along her left ulna inside her stitched cuff-lining, listening to water roar down cast-iron courtyard gutters and wondering whether Aleja Szucha sat waiting behind the cream-painted wood already.

Then footsteps crossed bare parquet inside—one pair only, Ludwig's stride without Mekelburg's heavier country heel—and the security bar slid back.

Ludwig pulled her inside out of the cold draft. Even in dim pantry shadow she saw inside half a second that something in his world had jumped off its rails since Sunday week: he wore full field-grey service tunic buttoned high, boots mud-splashed round the welts from morning roads, packed canvas overnight dispatch-bag strapped buckled beside the hall umbrella-stand, dark rings carved sleepless beneath winter-green eyes.

"Mekelburg's late back from Mirów," Ludwig said low, shooting the iron pantry bar home behind her wet shoulders and reaching automatically with bare warm hands to unbutton her soaked raincoat collar as he had done since summer. "You're freezing—come by the study stove, I lit coal at four—"

Sylwia stepped two paces clear of his hands down the parquet hall straight into Judge Silberstein's study, where orange coal-glow flickered behind the mica window of the tall porcelain stove, turned round facing him beside the mahogany desk without unbuttoning one button of her wet black raincoat, and tossed Marek's damp Leica photostat of **Abwehrstelle Warschau — Referat III F — 18. August 1943 ("Vorgang Naht")** face-up onto green blotter leather.

Simultaneously her right fingers dipped half an inch inside her wide left sleeve-cuff, flicked the sterile rubber cork off the needle point against wool, and drew the five-inch nickel-and-steel **#11 Bard-Parker bistoury** clean out into stove-light—held low, flat-palmed along her thigh where surgeons held blades they meant to use rather than wave.

Ludwig stopped three paces inside the open doorway.

His eyes dropped once—one single razor-fast sweep—to the glossy five-by-seven photostat on green leather, then six inches right to the bright triangular scalpel point gleaming steady beside Sylwia's soaked black skirt, and lifted straight to her white, rain-wet face.

Zero theatrical surprise flickered across his bone structure; zero stammered *where did you get that?* Instead a cold, murderous flash hardened his jaw:

"Kroll's Friday registry car at Plac Unii," Ludwig said instantly. "His courier clerk reported a briefcase snatched in traffic mud—so Polish postal interception photographed *Referat Vier*'s liaison copy inside forty-eight hours and your dead engineer brought it to you."

"Don't talk to me about courier clerks!" Sylwia's voice cut through stove-crackle quieter and deadlier than any shout in the darkroom two weeks ago. "*Eighteenth of August!* Ten days after Świder—forty-eight hours before you stood right there asking about my mother's black silk dress—twenty-five days before you lay on my X-ray table calling me *meine Liebe* while my hospital, my basement laboratory, and my own Polish cover-name *Szew* sat stamped inside Saski Square's counter-espionage safe over your signature as an active *Abwehr* penetration net reporting monthly to Berlin!"

"Put the knife down and let me unlock—"

"Stay three feet back from that desk if you want an intact right subclavian!" The #11 point rose two inches—dead rock-steady, zero tremor in knuckles scrubbed twenty thousand times in cold sublimate. "Who else

sits inside Folder *W-884/43*, Ludwig? Konstancin's pines? Jurek's Grójec disinfection van from September eighth? Thirty underground clinics logged neat on blue flimsies so when Tirpitzufer audits your Eastern desk next month after arresting von Berg, *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler buys his own skin back by handing Warsaw's medical directorate to Berlin on silver plates?!"

For two full seconds Ludwig stared straight at the razor-sharp steel point held by the woman who knew every millimeter of his mediastinum blindfolded—and did not step backward.

Moving both hands slow and wide away from his belt so she saw zero pistol reach, he walked three calm paces *sideways* past her blade—close enough that one flick of her wrist would have laid his throat open to cervical vertebrae, gambling his carotid flat on trusting her brain for ten seconds!—pulled four heavy gilt volumes of Mickiewicz's *Dziady* out of Judge Silberstein's glass bookcase shelf, spun a recessed brass combination dial behind the false wooden book-back three turns left-right-left, and swung the small iron wall-safe open.

Out came a thick blue-linen folder bound with braided black cord and stamped across its cover in identical purple block letters:

III F / W-884/43 — SONDERAKTE "VORGANG NAHT" (VERSCHLUSSACHE).

Ludwig didn't open it himself—he tossed the entire bound folder closed onto Judge Silberstein's desk directly under Sylwia's free left hand and stepped two paces *back* toward the porcelain stove with empty hands folded loosely behind his spine.

"Untie the cord yourself," Ludwig said in a voice cold and level as winter slate. "Read every page from August eighteenth to September twenty-fifth. Then use your #11 blade if you find one living Polish street number or one true syllable inside forty leaves."

Sylwia did not take her right hand off the scalpel handle; pinning the blue folder with her left elbow against green blotter leather, she hooked the black cord loop loose one-handed and flipped the stiff cover open.

Forty onion-skin carbon pages—typed personally on Ludwig's own slantless portable machine without stenographer initials!

Page One: duplicate of the exact August eighteenth cover-sheet Marek had handed her in Powązki rain—claiming *Pavilion Three / Dr. med. S. Kotarska ("Naht")* under exclusive *Abwehr III F* counter-espionage juris-

diction and **forbidding any unilateral Security Police arrest or raid without prior counter-signature of Oberstleutnant Schoeler**.

Pages Two through Thirty-Nine: weekly "source-exploitation transcripts" dated *24.VIII, 31.VIII, 7.IX, 14.IX, 21.IX*—reporting in solemn, suffocatingly plausible intelligence prose how unwitting hospital talk around Pavilion Three revealed Polish Home Army medical supply depots shifting *eastward to Mińsk Mazowiecki abandoned brickworks* (an empty flooded clay-pit!), typhus vaccine couriers operating *via Brest railway postal cars* (actually staffed by three corrupt Gestapo customs inspectors Ludwig wanted Kroll chasing!), and *zero mention of Grójec, zero Konstancin, zero Pańska, zero Mirecki, zero Bronka, zero Halina*!

Every single page inside *Vorgang Naht* was pure, clinically engineered **phantom smoke**—forty sheets of weaponized lies typed out by night to blind both Berlin auditors and Reinhart Kroll while wrapping an iron *Abwehr* jurisdictional fence around Pavilion Three!

Sylwia stared down at Page Thirty-Nine, breath catching dry behind her breastbone as the fatal second half of her Powązki question rose sharp anyway:

"And what happens to me and Pavilion Three the morning Berlin arrests *you* like von Berg and hands this safe combination to Reinhart Kroll?!" she demanded hoarsely, looking straight up across open blue paper into his gaunt face. "Whoever opens this safe without your voice sees forty pages certifying *Dr. Sylwia Kotarska* fed weekly Polish underground reports to *Abwehr*—hanging me from Polish rafters before noon if Kroll doesn't shoot me first on day three when Mińsk Mazowiecki clay-pits turn up empty!"

"Which is why no copy of Pages Two through Thirty-Nine ever went to Berlin—Berlin got four-line blind statistical tallies under number *884* without hospital or personal names—and why the sole named copy on earth sits right under your left hand ready to go into that stove the hour my desk closes," Ludwig said starkly. "Why do you think I registered *Vorgang Naht* on the eighteenth of August, Sylwia?! Because at noon on the eighteenth Kroll's clerk requisitioned *Dzieciątka Jezus* staff lists for Palais Brühl's trap, and under RSHA–OKW Joint Directive Twelve from forty-two, the **single legal instrument left in the Reich** that bars Gestapo *Abteilung Vier* from arresting a Polish municipal doctor without forty-eight hours' military notice is an active *III F* counter-espionage

registration signed by a field-grade officer! Tell you on August twentieth that I had put your underground cover-name—which Kroll lifted off dead Stach's July index card!—onto a German shield-file, and every time Kroll looked across roses at you on August twenty-ninth your eyes would have carried one extra pound of weight!"

Sylwia didn't drop the #11 blade yet—her left hand flipped starkly back to Page Fourteen, dated *7.IX.43*, the very afternoon AK rifles shot Franz Bürkl on Marszałkowska!

"'*Laut unbewusster Äußerung der Quelle Naht im Rahmen der ambulanten Nachbehandlung,*'" Sylwia read the cold German intelligence phrasing aloud off onion-skin paper, tasting every syllable like iron filings, "'*werden verwundete polnische Sabotagekräfte seit Ende August nicht mehr in Warschauer Stadtkrankenhäusern versorgt, sondern über Flößerkähne nach Puławy verbracht…*' And those three Brest railway postal inspectors named on Page Twenty-Nine?"

"Three real SS-customs racketeers running stolen Odessa gold bars to Vienna in sealed Reichspost sacks," Ludwig answered without hesitation, standing motionless by green porcelain stove-tiles with empty hands still folded behind his field-grey back. "Give Kroll and Berlin zero arrestable names inside six weeks and any half-awake auditor smells a paper shield inside ten minutes; feed them three corrupt customs thieves wearing Himmler's own runes in Brest plus flooded Mińsk clay-pits, and RSHA wastes forty detectives chasing its own tail along the Bug River while leaving Lindleya's gates unsearched!"

"Until Tirpitzufer collapses underneath your boots!" Sylwia shot back low and fierce across the desk. "Look at your packed dispatch-bag in the hall, Ludwig! Dohnanyi sits in remand in Berlin, Oster is stripped of duties, von Berg got hauled west two Sundays ago—how many weeks did you think Admiral Canaris's roof had left before Himmler swallowed *Abwehr* whole and inherited every folder locked behind Mickiewicz?!"

A shadow bleak and ancient as winter Baltic water crossed Ludwig's gaunt face.

"Six weeks in August—down to six days since noon today," Ludwig said starkly. "At eleven o'clock this morning Military Judge Advocate General's courier brought word from Berlin: *Oberstkriegsgerichtsrat* Manfred Roeder opened formal *Sonderkommission* treason proceedings against Oster's Eastern liaison circle yesterday. Which was why I sent

Mekelburg out to St. Charles Borromeo's reserve slot at four-fifteen to pull our final termination warning out of Chłodna before shutting Saski Square's external channels permanently tonight—"

Sylwia's fingers loosened half a millimeter round the cold nickel scalpel handle—stunned silent by the ruthless closing jaws around his throat as well as hers—when three flights down in the courtyard iron gate hinges banged hard against stone, rapid uneven footsteps stumbled skipping-and-dragging up Service Stair B, and the kitchen pantry bell didn't ring: somebody hit the cream-painted door once with a shoulder and slid down the frame!

* * *

Ludwig had his Walther PPK clear of his tunic pocket before Sylwia reached the hall; checking through the tiny spy-glass lens drilled in the pantry wood, he cursed under his breath, ripped the iron bar open, and caught **Bruno Mekelburg** under both soaked armpits before the boy pitched headfirst onto waxed kitchen tiles!

Rainwater mixed with thick, dark-crimson blood poured off the right skirt of Mekelburg's grey rubberized motorcycle coat across the threshold in a widening scarlet puddle as tallow-white as February ninth turned upside-down.

"Door—bar it, *Herr Oberstleutnant*—nobody followed past Żelazna—" Mekelburg panted between chattering teeth, hopping on his left boot while dragging his soaked right leg stiff behind him as Ludwig and Sylwia together hauled his seventy-five kilos straight across the pantry onto the scrubbed four-by-six oak kitchen table, sending colanders and earthenware crocks smashing across the tiles!

"Where?" Sylwia barked—all Powązki photostats blasted clean out of existence inside one heartbeat as pure trauma-surgeon hands took over, using the very **#11 Bard-Parker bistoury** she had brought up the stairs to cut Ludwig's throat to slit Mekelburg's sodden grey wool trouser-leg cleanly from ankle to groin in one swift four-foot draw!

Ten centimeters above the right patella along the anterolateral thigh yawned an ugly, ragged star-shaped entry hole blackened with close-range mud splatter—*zero exit wound posteriorly!* Dark red venous and muscular-branch arterial blood welled heavy and steady with every

racing pulse-beat out of swollen, rock-taut vastus lateralis fascia, while distal dorsalis pedis pulse at the boy's bare ankle after she yanked his jackboot off still beat rapid and intact!

Superficial femoral trunk spared—bullet lodged deep against the femur shaft tearing a muscular perforating branch of the *arteria profunda femoris*! Leave a profunda branch bleeding inside closed thigh fascia for another forty minutes and two liters exsanguinated into muscle compartments while shock killed him on kitchen oak; drive him five blocks to *Lazarett Ujazdowski* at five-twenty p.m. with a fresh nine-millimeter gunshot wound inside his leg—

"Chłodna," Mekelburg gasped, clamping his good right fist onto the edge of the oak table while sweat poured down his stubbled twenty-two-year-old cheeks. "St. Charles Borromeo alley—they weren't watching the church kneeler, they waited behind the candle-woman's stall for the four-thirty reserve pickup! Von Berg talked in Berlin, *Herr Oberstleutnant* —only von Berg knew the Tuesday reserve slot! Two of Kroll's leathercoats jumped me at the porch—blew the baker's window across them with an egg-grenade, took one round climbing the coal-cart over Mirów wall, switched carts twice at Krochmalna—"

Ludwig's face turned cold white marble above his open collar as he slammed both inner kitchen shutters bolted tight.

Hauptmann von Berg broke in Prinz-Albrecht-Straße's cellar in Berlin. Which meant Reinhart Kroll hadn't merely staked out Chłodna at four-thirty today—by tomorrow morning Kroll's ballistics men would match blood on Mirów's wall against missing *Abwehrstelle* drivers unless Bruno Mekelburg stood upright or disappeared!

"Can you tie off a profunda perforator here without hospital clamps?" Ludwig asked Sylwia straight across the bloody kitchen table—already stripping off his field-grey gabardine tunic in two jerks and rolling white shirt-sleeves above both elbows before she answered!

Sylwia glanced once inside her light Tuesday handbag: one needle-holder, two small mosquito hemostats, thumb-forceps, silk reel, #11 scalpel—zero deep Farabeuf thigh retractors, zero autoclave, zero procaine, zero ether!

"Deep thigh muscle in a twenty-two-year-old farm boy snaps mosquito clamps in half without retractors," Sylwia said at lightning speed, flinging open Judge Silberstein's oak cutlery drawer beside the sink

and snatching out two heavy solid-silver eighteen-ninety Polish serving forks! "Bend the tines ninety degrees backward two inches from the tip in the pantry door-hinge—smooth blunt curves, don't leave sharp points! Put two liters of tap water and those linen dish-towels boiling hard on the gas-ring, and bring me that full bottle of Pomeranian grain *Korn* plus your sewing button-thread!"

For thirty-five minutes inside Judge Silberstein's shuttered kitchen, while autumn rain hammered courtyard zinc outside and blue gas-flames roared beneath an enamel soup-pot boiling forks, scissors, and unbleached linen thread at rolling hundred-degree steam, twelve years fell clean away back to midnight thunder beneath Luisenstraße.

Zero anesthetic existed in the flat save eighty-proof clear Pomeranian grain alcohol: Ludwig poured half a tumbler down Mekelburg's throat first, splashed the second half raw across both their scrubbed hands and wide across the boy's shaved thigh, folded his own heavy brown leather officer's belt double—history coming full circle onto its own teeth!—and laid the saddle-hide between his corporal's back molars while stepping opposite Sylwia across the bloody oak planks to take both boiled, hinge-bent solid-silver serving forks hot in wet towels.

"Extend the entry wound ten centimeters longitudinal along iliotibial band—now," Sylwia said quietly.

Cut.

Mekelburg arched rigid from neck to heel against kitchen oak—three-fingered scarred left palm slapping flat against wood, boots drumming once before locking iron-still around Ludwig's belt in his teeth—as Sylwia sliced clean through skin and tight fascia lata, evacuating two huge black handfuls of trapped hematoma clot straight onto newspapers!

Deep at the bottom of six centimeters of split, quivering red vastus lateralis muscle spurted a severed two-millimeter perforating artery pumping bright crimson straight up across Ludwig's bare forearms as he hooked both bent silver Silberstein forks deep into muscle bellies and hauled wide with steady, unyielding surgeon's wrists!

"Higher on the upper fork—five millimeters lateral so I see the periosteum!" Sylwia hissed, plunging her mosquito clamp down through rising blood-well blind by fingertip pulse-feel—*click!* Instantly the bright crimson fountain died to dark venous ooze!

Down against the linea aspera of the femur shaft, flattened mushroom-wide where nine-millimeter lead had smacked cortical bone without fracturing the shaft and bounced sideways into muscle, glinted copper-grey metal. Sylwia locked jaws onto the deformed slug with heavy dressing forceps, twisted free, and dropped Reinhart Kroll's bullet *clink* into a Rosenthal saucer!

Two double ligatures of boiled linen button-thread snubbed square round proximal and distal vessel stumps; forty milliliters of raw grain schnapps sloshed straight down into the raw muscle cavity—making poor Mekelburg's eyes roll white to the ceiling with one muffled groan through leather that nearly broke Sylwia's heart for the dog-loyal kid who had broken a blackmailer's nose for her in Praga fog!—left wide unpacked down its center over a boiled linen wick (*per secundam*, always *per secundam* in this cursed war!) with three loose skin-approximating stitches top and bottom and half a pillowcase torn into tight pressure turns.

When Mekelburg finally spat out the wet leather belt onto his chest, white as lard and grinning crooked with shock-sweat at his three good right fingers, he whispered hoarsely at Sylwia:

"Didn't take any bones this time, *Frau Doktor*?"

"Keep your weight off it ten days or I'll come back with a saw, Bruno," Sylwia said, laying one blood-sticky hand gently for two seconds across the boy's wet blond forehead before carrying bloody silver forks to the sink.

* * *

At quarter past seven, with Mekelburg sleeping heavily under twenty milligrams of Sylwia's hidden Koszykowa morphine on Ludwig's narrow iron campaign cot down the back hall, blue smoke curled thick behind the mica window of the study's porcelain stove.

Page by page—all thirty-nine onion-skin disinformation sheets of *Vorgang Naht*, plus two thin cipher pads from the wall safe—went onto glowing anthracite coals from Ludwig's hand while Sylwia stood beside the warm green tiles drying washed forearms on linen. Only the top August eighteenth jurisdictional cover-sheet stayed intact in the safe, because burn the cover-sheet before Kroll was stopped and Kroll raided Lindleya at dawn without asking Saski Square.

When the last curl of blue pelure turned black flake up the chimney, Ludwig shut the brass firebox door with his boot-toe and straightened up beside her in blood-spotted white shirtsleeves—Mekelburg's dark thigh blood dried brown from wrist to elbow along both his forearms, identical to hers.

Silence in the green-lit study tasted wholly different now from five o'clock's cold steel: exhausted, stripped past accusation, standing together on two square yards of floor watching dark water rise round all four walls of the house.

Sylwia picked up her #11 Bard-Parker bistoury lying bare on green blotter leather beside Marek's Powązki photostat, slipped the small rubber cork back onto its needle tip, and slid it into her open Gladstone bag instead of her sleeve scabbard.

"I have to meet Marek Wolski tomorrow noon at All Saints' vestry," she said quietly. "Tell him *Vorgang Naht* was a blind jurisdictional block containing zero Polish names—show him charred ash if he wants—or his Praga platoon shoots first before Friday."

"Show him nothing burned—give him this," Ludwig said, pulling one unburned carbon page he had held back deliberately from Page Twenty-Two (*reporting imaginary partisan rail stores in Mińsk Mazowiecki brick-pits!*) and tearing off the top margin code so Marek's superiors saw with their own eyes inside ten seconds that Schoeler was feeding Berlin fake Mińsk clay-pits rather than Lindleya names! Then Ludwig's grey-green eyes darkened grave on hers across twelve inches of stove glow. "After tonight you do *not* cross Królewska's sawhorses again, Sylwia. Not Friday, not Tuesday."

Her chest tightened sharp—not arguing, knowing the geometry herself: with von Berg broken in Berlin and Chłodna's reserve drop ambushed at four-thirty today, Reinhart Kroll knew *Abwehrstelle Warschau* had been warning Polish-London channels since spring. Right now Kroll's watchers would be photographing every pair of shoes entering Number Sixteen Królewska!

"Where do you put Bruno tomorrow morning?" she asked low. "If Kroll inspects Saski Square's motor-pool drivers looking for limps from Mirów—"

"Mekelburg goes out at five a.m. supine under straw in a field-post courier truck to Königsberg reserve hospital with 'garage ramp crush in-

jury' counter-signed by our garrison surgeon," Ludwig said. "He wanted East Prussian potatoes before frost anyway."

Before leaving, Sylwia walked quietly down the narrow back passage to check Bruno's pressure bandage and dorsalis pedis pulse one final time before curfew patrol thickened outside.

In the tiny whitewashed servant's room behind the pantry—where Judge Silberstein's old Polish cook had once hung blessed palm-twigs above the iron cot—Bruno Mekelburg lay flat beneath two grey wool army blankets, face still damp-pale above twenty-two-year-old blond stubble, morphine dulling the brutal burn of raw grain schnapps deep inside his split vastus lateralis down to heavy warmth.

When Sylwia's cool fingers slipped under the blanket edge at his bare right ankle to count ninety-six steady, warm dorsalis pulses and verify zero fresh blood soaking through the folded linen pillowcase round his thigh, the boy opened heavy-lidded blue farm-boy eyes in dim hall light.

"Heard shouting in the study when I crawled up the stairs, *Frau Doktor*," Mekelburg mumbled thick-tongued through twenty milligrams of morphine—too drugged for Prussian NCO stiff-neck, speaking flat Masurian dialect soft as peat smoke. "Thought Kroll's dogs beat me up the steps till I heard Polish."

"Keep still and sleep, Bruno," Sylwia murmured, tucking grey wool snug back over his bare ankle so draft didn't chill peripheral flow. "No bleeding through; five-a.m. mail lorry puts you among Königsberg nurses by supper tomorrow."

Mekelburg's scarred three-fingered left hand shifted half an inch on top of the blanket without lifting. "Don't—don't hold office paper hard against him, *Frau Doktor*," the boy breathed barely audibly toward the ceiling plaster while Ludwig stood out of earshot locking the study wall-safe down the hall. "December forty-one west of Vyazma—thirty-four below zero, grease frozen solid inside rifle bolts—Russian T-thirty-fours rolled straight through our divisional clearing tent at dusk. Medical captain ran for the half-track first; Major Schoeler took mortar splinters right into his hipbone dragging three enlisted stretcher-boys—me with two frostbitten stumps froze to an iron sled—four kilometers backward across snow behind a horse-sleigh before letting anybody touch his own trousers." Bruno's eyelids sagged three-quarters shut, breath slowing

deep. “Bad tongue on him when fools waste ink… never left a soul behind in mud yet…”

Sylwia stood motionless three seconds beside the narrow iron cot looking down at the sleeping East Prussian farm boy whose missing left fingers she had mocked silently in April and whose femoral branch she had tied off with boiled button-thread on a dead Jewish judge’s kitchen table in September—feeling every neat, partisan category twenty-year-olds lived by crumble quietly to grey dust under her shoes.

Returning down the dark hall to the study doorway, she found Ludwig buttoning a clean shirt beneath his field-grey tunic to walk down to Saski Square’s night cipher room so duty logs showed him calmly at his desk all evening.

He stepped close—clean linen smelling faintly of coal-heat and soap over dried kitchen sweat—resting both palms lightly on either side of her waist without pulling her toward the back passage where his wounded boy slept, simply pressing his forehead quiet and cool against hers in orange coal-shadow for ten slow breaths while rain lashed tall glass outside.

“Don’t come near Saski Square, don’t telephone my extension, and burn that green *Sonderausweis* tonight once you pass Marszałkowska,” Ludwig murmured against her brow. “Give me three weeks to bury von Berg’s Berlin trail across Königsberg and pull Kroll’s teeth out of Lindleya’s file—when ground’s clean, Walenty gets an optician’s postcard for old spectacles.”

Sylwia raised one raw hand to touch the crescent scar beneath his right eye once—memorizing warm bone under cold rain-chill—before stepping back cleanly, picking up Marek’s photostat and Page Twenty-Two’s fake clay-pit sheet, and walking down Service Stair B into black September rain without turning her head under streetlamps all the way home to Pavilion Three.

Chapter XXVII

Gypsum Mouths

Warsaw, 16 October 1943

Pink paper changed colour when flour-paste soaked through from damp October brick behind it—turning the exact livid salmon-wet of sliced raw lung laid on zinc.

On Friday morning the fifteenth of October the first of Brigadeführer Franz Kutschera's new yard-wide *Bekanntmachungen* had gone up wet on every kiosk, tram-stop shelter, and chipped tenement corner from Wola to Mokotów: zero judicial pretense left, zero black borders—just screaming bold black German and Polish type announcing that because unidentified assassins had shot an SS trooper on Wspólna, twenty Polish "terrorists and hostages" had been publicly executed that morning, and **one hundred further named hostages** sat numbered one to a hundred in Pawiak cells ready to be shot on open city pavements at ten-to-one ratio the next hour any German hand bled in Warsaw.

On Saturday afternoon the sixteenth of October at half-past two, Sylwia climbed the dark terrazzo stairs of Number Sixty-Eight Filtrowa carrying two fresh ten-milliliter vials of Danish Novo insulin packed in wet sawdust alongside five grams of Benedict's copper-sulfate reagent.

Inside the cramped third-floor flat, forty days of autumn terror had rearranged every piece of emotional furniture between Wanda and Stefan without breaking a teacup.

Gone were Stefan's pompous *Ostbahn* suspenders and loud evening opinions on German punctuality: sitting quietly by the kitchen window in a darned grey cardigan two sizes too loose round shrunken collarbones—sclerae faded now from bright August picric-acid canary down to pale tallow-parchment—Stefan spent Saturday afternoons pasting Ration Office fuel coupons neat into cardboard ledgers for his harmless new

clerk's stool at Praga's municipal coke-weighing shed, where zero human worker's name ever crossed his ink-pad. Across at the iron coal-range Wanda stirred black roasted-acorn coffee beside a simmering pot of horse-bone marrow soup she had queued three hours before dawn at Hala Mirowska to buy for Staś—hair streaked visibly greyer above both temples since August nineteenth, thin hands chapped raw red from taking in neighborhood darning by night to make up Stefan's lost Wola overtime pay, yet steadier in the eye than Sylwia had ever seen her older sister in thirty years.

Out at the scrubbed pine table nine-year-old **Staś** held the Pyrex test-tube straight in brass wooden-handled tongs above the tiny spirit-flame himself while counting seconds off Stefan's pocket-watch:

"Ninety—one hundred—one hundred and twenty! Look, Ciociu—clear blue-green, not one speck of brick-orange sediment at the bottom!"

"Cleanest kidneys in Ochota," Sylwia agreed gravely, ruffling his thick dark hair and checking his upper thighs where Wanda rotated subcutaneous needle sites down millimeter-ruled grids neat enough for Charité wards. "And what passes beneath the middle third of the clavicle where I tapped your collar?"

Staś grinned gap-toothed, puffing skinny ribs proud under his darned sweater: "*Arteria subclavia, vena subclavia, plexus brachialis!* Learned down to the radial nerve off that torn German pocket book in your coat!"

While Staś ran into the bedroom to put away his glass syringe in boiled linen, Stefan stood up awkwardly beside the window—thin lemon-tinted fingers twisting once round a wooden matchbox—and spoke low before Wanda turned from the range:

"Saw Kubiak's brother-in-law passing Narutowicz Square tram-stop on Thursday morning, Sylwia." Stefan didn't meet her eyes at first, staring painfully down at his own faded yellow thumbnails before forcing his chin up like a man paying debt across counters. "Looked right through me onto the cobbles and kept walking with both hands inside his pockets. Whatever sat inside those two bitter yellow capsules you made me swallow in August… thank you. For the boy."

Sylwia didn't soften it with pretty lies and didn't twist the knife either; she touched one brief hand to Stefan's thin cardigan sleeve—"Keep counting coke-sacks in Praga and stay indoors after dusk, Stefan"—kissed Wanda's warm flour-dusted cheek at twenty minutes past three, and

walked east toward Marszałkowska carrying two round loaves of dark ration bread Bronka had asked her to pick up from the cooperative bakery on Koszykowa.

Cold drizzle had stopped at noon, leaving low leaden clouds dragging across chimney-pots and wet black asphalt gleaming like gunmetal along **Aleja Niepodległości** where it crossed Piusa XI.

Halfway up the block toward the bombed Ministry gardens, Sylwia heard heavy engines accelerating fast from *both* north and south simultaneously.

Every pedestrian within a hundred yards stiffened in mid-stride—feet pivoting instinctively toward courtyard gates for *łapanka* cover—until twenty steel-helmeted *Schutzpolizei* troopers leaping off two open half-tracks didn't herd people *into* trucks at all: instead they swung cocked submachine guns **outward toward the pavements**, driving pedestrians backward tight against shop shutters between Koszykowa and Piusa XI while hammering every wooden courtyard gate bolted from the street side so nobody could duck indoors!

"Stehenbleiben! Auf dem Bürgersteig bleiben—Hände aus den Taschen! Wer sich umdreht oder ins Haus läuft, wird erschossen!"

Stand still on the pavement—hands out of pockets—whoever turns away or runs indoors gets shot!

Sylwia stood wedged flat-backed against the cold iron rolling-shutter of a closed stationer's shop directly across the forty-foot roadway from a long windowless stretch of pockmarked red-brick garden wall. To her left a grey-haired postal clerk held his nine-year-old daughter's face crushed hard inward against his wet wool coat-front so the child couldn't see; to her right an old woman carrying cabbage leaves began whispering *Wieczny odpoczynek racz im dać, Panie* before a single vehicle came round the corner—because since yesterday noon Warsaw already knew what outward-facing rifles opposite a blank brick wall meant.

Down the emptied wet asphalt from the north rolled two vehicles: a grey passenger Mercedes bearing Security Police pennants, and behind it a heavy closed tarpaulin lorry out of ulica Dzielna—Pawiak prison transport.

Zero siren, zero megaphone, zero drum-roll.

Iron tailboard chains clanked down onto wet cobbles. Two Latvian or Ukrainian *Trawniki* guards in black greatcoats jumped down first, yanking back the green canvas flap and prodding inside with rifle barrels.

Out onto the freezing wet October stones dropped **twenty men**—landing hard on *bare, purple-bruised feet* because Pawiak's cellars kept leather boots for winter salvage before trucks loaded.

None wore coats, jackets, or trousers: over bare shivering legs bruised black across shins and thighs from forty-eight hours of cellar truncheons, every prisoner wore a grotesque sleeveless knee-length tunic fashioned out of **stiff brown-white three-ply Portland cement paper sacks** with holes torn rough for head and arms, rustling dry like dead leaves whenever cold wind hit them! Their wrists were twisted behind their backs with thin galvanized baling wire cut deep into swollen flesh; two young boys in front had black dried blood crusted across broken noses and split scalps so they swayed sideways against neighbors to stay upright on bare soles.

And across the lower half of every single face from ear to ear—packed solid between forced-open jaws and smoothed wet across lips, moustache, and chin thirty minutes ago in Pawiak's courtyard before hardening rock-stiff—gleamed a thick, gagging white muzzle of **set surgical plaster of Paris**!

Sylwia's fingernails cut clean through her woollen gloves into her own palms round the bread string.

Yesterday morning at Kutschera's first street execution on Madalińskiego, before firing squads pulled triggers, five bound hostages had roared *"Jeszcze Polska nie zginęła!"* loud enough to ring four blocks down Mokotów windows—so overnight some tidy hygienist on Aleja Szucha had requisitioned fifty-kilo hospital drums of **gypsum splint-plaster**, mixed grey-white paste in buckets, and plugged twenty living human mouths solid to the back molars so men died in Warsaw gutters quieter than slaughtered sheep!

Guards shoved the first five cement-sack figures clumsily shoulder-to-shoulder facing the red-brick garden wall forty feet opposite Sylwia's stationer's shutter.

Wait: the remaining fifteen stood huddled waiting their turn ten paces left beside the lorry tailboard—and as the third man from the left in the second five shifted bare bleeding heels on icy asphalt to prop up a sixteen-

year-old boy sagging faint beside him, he turned his head slowly across the street toward the silent Polish crowd pinned along the kerb.

Above the hardened white gypsum mask crusted across chin and jaw, beneath a four-centimeter pink bullet-graze scar high on the left temple and matted brown hair clotted dark over one eyebrow, two narrow grey engineer's eyes looked straight across forty feet of October air and found Sylwia standing against iron shutters.

Marek Wolski.

Sylwia's heart stopped dead—not jumping, freezing solid inside ice while every instinct screamed *don't move an eyelash!*

Twenty yards down the kerb to Sylwia's left, walking unhurriedly behind the steel-helmeted *Schupo* line in a dry greenish loden coat with hands in pockets and a miniature Leica camera hanging openly at chest-button level—snapping discreet wide-angle frames of Polish faces pressed against the shutters whenever five men stepped to the bricks!—strolled one of Reinhart Kroll's *Referat IV* street spotters!

Catch one woman gasping, lunging forward, or staring fixed in horror at Prisoner Number Eight, and inside ten minutes that loden-coated spotter pulled her *Kennkarte* right off the pavement to match against Prisoner Eight's pocket list!

Across forty feet of cold grey street, Marek saw the Leica spotter at the exact tenth of a second Sylwia did.

Instantly—with the same compact, unsentimental bridge-engineer's discipline with which he had counted tram-bells in Pańska's cellar and handed unloaded pistols across smoke—Marek pulled his grey eyes *away* from Sylwia's face without blinking twice, shifting his gaze three yards past her shoulder onto the stationer's painted tin sign overhead as if scanning sky before rain!

First five stood facing wet red brick.

An SS *Hauptscharführer* in field-grey coat didn't even read sentences—simply raised two black leather-gloved fingers and dropped them.

Five Schmeisser submachine guns chattered one three-second burst together—*brrrrrrrap!*—shockingly flat and dry against brick, kicking brick-chips red into the air while five paper-sack backs jerked stiff against stone and crumpled sideways like empty meal-bags dropped off a wagon. Before boots stopped twitching, the *Hauptscharführer* stepped calmly

along the row firing five single muffled *pop… pop… pop* Walther shots behind ears, stepped back two paces, and pointed at the second five.

Marek walked barefoot across wet cobbles into the fresh dark crimson pool already snaking toward the kerbstone—supporting the half-conscious sixteen-year-old boy beside his elbow with his own wired hip so the child didn't fall face-down into another man's brains before bullets came, turning his back square to the rifles to face red brick without once looking back across the street.

Don't shut your eyes, Sylwia commanded every muscle in her skull as the loden-coated Leica spotter raised his lens ten yards left. *Look straight ahead at brick—surgeons watch blood every morning, don't flinch, don't swallow, owe him stillness!*

Brrrrrrrrap!

Cement paper split across Marek's left shoulder-blade in four grey puffs of dust and wet red mist; white gypsum cracked red against wet cobbles as his knees gave clean and quiet beside the sixteen-year-old boy, still before the single Walther *pop* ever reached him.

Third five. Fourth five.

Total elapsed clock time from tailboard drop to twentieth pistol shot: **four minutes and ten seconds**.

Before the blue cordite smoke even drifted clear above linden branches, four prison orderlies hauled all twenty limp paper-wrapped bodies back over the lorry tailboard by wrists and ankles like cordwood; canvas laced shut; engines roared off north toward Powązki or Warsaw Ghetto brick-kilns where October bodies burned without graves; and right behind the departing grey Mercedes rolled a municipal street-flushing tank-wagon requisitioned ten minutes earlier on Koszykowa, two terrified Polish water-men ordered at gunpoint to open brass two-inch hydrants wide across the red-brick wall!

Cold river water hissed white across stone and asphalt, driving thick dark clots, grey brains, and crumbled white chunks of blood-soaked gypsum plaster swirling pink down the cast-iron gutter grate while *Schutzpolizei* half-tracks climbed roaring back onto axles and pulled out.

* * *

For thirty seconds after the last German exhaust pipe vanished round Piusa corner, nobody along two hundred yards of Aleja Niepodległości moved a shoe.

Then silence broke not into shouting—into a low, rustling whisper of wool coats and wooden soles crossing wet asphalt toward the washed wall.

Nobody cared whether loden-coated watchers still lingered inside corner cafés. Old women knelt right down on soaked cobbles where hydrant water hadn't scrubbed deep mortar cracks clean, opening worn handbags to press clean white linen handkerchiefs—and when handkerchiefs ran out, tearing white crumbs out of ration bread loaves—straight into bright red crevices between bricks so Polish blood wouldn't wash down sewers into rat-water uncollected! Within two minutes somebody produced six stubs of blessed Candlemas wax candles out of a coat pocket, shielded matches inside cupped caps against October wind, and wedged six tiny yellow flames flickering straight along the wet red-splashed brick ledge beside three bunches of crushed Michaelmas daisies!

Sylwia did not cross to the wall.

Keep thirty paces clear of the wall if you carried seventy hospital beds and hidden files on your shoulders—every underground cell rule Marek himself had drilled into her in November forty-two sat dry and iron-clear behind her eyes while cold numbness gripped her legs from hip to ankle so hard each step down Koszykowa felt walked on wooden prostheses.

Only as she passed four yards downwind of the iron storm-sewer grate at the corner did her shoe-sole crunch once across a washed-down white pebble the size of a walnut that hadn't slipped through the iron bars: not stone, a jagged piece of hardened white dental-grade **gypsum plaster** knocked off somebody's jaw by nine-millimeter impact, stained faint pink along its inner tooth-impression ridge.

Sylwia didn't stoop to touch it; she walked straight through *Szpital Dzieciątka Jezus*'s gatehouse arch at four-ten with two cold loaves of ration rye under her arm, handed the bread to Bronka in Pavilion Three's kitchen without speaking a word, and walked straight upstairs toward Theater One.

Out on the first-floor surgical landing **Antoni Majewski**, a forty-two-year-old Wola drop-forge smith whose right hand had been caught obliquely under a slipping two-hundred-kilo steel die at noon, sat

hunched white-lipped on the wooden bench nursing blood-soaked rags while young Doktor Jankowski finished plating an open tibia inside.

"Take ten minutes' hot tea first, Pani Doktor," Bronka muttered low behind Sylwia's shoulder at the kitchen stair-head after one sharp squint at the dead chalk-white ring pinched tight round Sylwia's nostrils and mouth. "You look like somebody walked over your grave on Koszykowa. Jankowski can stitch finger tendons at four-thirty."

"Jankowski shakes after tibial bone-drills, and drop-forge smiths without index and middle extensors starve by Christmas," Sylwia answered in a voice that sounded six miles away even inside her own skull—already unbuttoning her street wool coat and turning both cold-water taps wide open over the porcelain scrub-trough!

For seventy uninterrupted minutes beneath Theater One's bright afternoon glass—having infiltrated twenty milliliters of two-percent procaine without adrenaline round Majewski's wrist median, radial, and ulnar trunks so the burly ironworker lay wide awake behind a green linen towel-screen talking hoarsely about coal prices to keep from thinking about crippled fingers—Sylwia sat on a low revolving iron stool stitching severed white ribbon-ends of *extensor indicis*, *extensor digitorum communis* slips two and three, and frayed dorsal joint capsules together with hair-fine five-zero waxed arterial silk on curved atraumatic eye-needles!

Tendon surgery tolerated zero rage and zero tremor: pull one Bunnell criss-cross stitch half a pound too tight and tendon fibers bunched ischemic like wet string; leave a two-millimeter gap and scar adhesions welded finger-joints stiff forever; let attention drift one tenth of a second —

Every time Sylwia blinked sweat or dry air off her corneas behind her magnifying loupe, forty feet of wet gunmetal asphalt flashed crimson behind her eyelids: bare purple-bruised heels propping up a swaying sixteen-year-old boy on icy cobbles; white plaster of Paris packed hard across bruised lips and chin; narrow grey bridge-engineer's eyes catching hers across forty feet of October light and shifting deliberately three yards sideways onto a painted tin stationer's sign so Reinhart Kroll's Leica missed her face!

In December forty-two on Koszykowa, when coal ran out altogether for three nights before Christmas, memory cut unbidden and razor-clean across the shiny white tendon ribbon between her forceps, *Marek had*

sawed up his own oak Polytechnic drawing-trestle into stove-lengths without asking, boiled two stolen potatoes in salted snow-water on her spirit-ring, and warmed both her ice-cold feet inside his wool shirt against his ribs without even trying to reach higher because she'd lost a twelve-year-old appendicitis boy that afternoon.

Then June came, and lies came, and Stach's poison ampoule came, and she had held eight inches of Krupp steel at his throat and sent him down stairs hating or mourning her—and sixteen months of human breath, warmth, stubborn blind courage, and bad judgment ended inside four minutes and ten seconds wearing a torn Portland cement paper sack with wet surgical plaster gagging his teeth so Warsaw gutters stayed quiet!

Sylwia's needle-holder did not slip half a hairbreadth.

Snip. Five-zero black silk knot laid flat and pearl-smooth inside paratenon sheath. Passive wrist extension tested: index, middle, and ring fingers glided smooth and anatomical across the metacarpophalangeal knuckles without catching a single fiber! Skin closed neat with interrupted horsehair; palmar plaster volar slab molded warm in wet **gypsum bandage**—*sweet Christ in iron heaven, wet white gypsum paste stiffening warm between her own rubber-gloved palms five inches from her eyes!* —smoothed rock-steady from palm-crease to forearm without her jaw unclenching once until Majewski walked out grateful at five-thirty-five!

Only at quarter past six, when day nurses cleared downstairs and frail, papery Docent Tadeusz Mirecki shuffled slowly into the locked ground-floor dispensary wrapped in two cardigans—permitted downstairs two hours daily since October first so long as he climbed zero stairs fast—did Sylwia lock the frosted glass door behind him and speak quietly beside the poison cupboard:

"Marek Wolski was in the second five on Aleja Niepodległości at three-thirty today."

Mirecki—who had never known Marek's real surname, knowing only from winter glances that Sylwia had an engineer friend outside who smelled of wet dog-wool and brought railway bullet inquiries—stopped short beside the zinc sink, watery blue eyes closing behind thick pince-nez for three long seconds before he sat heavily down on the dispensary stool.

"Did he enter here under his own *Kennkarte* at any date?" Mirecki asked in a whisper, old coward's survival instinct and decent colleague's loyalty firing together out of habit.

"Never once," Sylwia said, pulling down the emergency out-patient suture register from January and February anyway to check every single line round February ninth with cold merciless eyes—nothing, Pańska had been sewn in a cobbler's cellar, All Saints' vestry on September twenty-ninth (when she had handed Marek Page Twenty-Two's fake Mińsk clay-pit sheet and parted cleanly without knowing it was the last five minutes of his life!) carried zero paper. "Question is what name Pawiak booked him under when they caught him in Praga—because if Szucha's clerks booked *Marek Wolski, civil engineer*, and cross-matched dead Stach's surviving July scraps…"

They had to wait three hours until nine-fifteen p.m., when old Walenty came shivering in from bolting the night gate carrying a damp, flour-paste-smeared **salmon-pink broadsheet** peeled furtively off an unguarded hoarding behind Lindleya lane before paste dried hard.

Spread flat beneath the single shaded dispensary bulb, wet pink paper smelled sour of rye paste and kerosene ink:

BEKANNTMACHUNG / OBWIESZCZENIE — Der SS- und Polizeiführer im Distrikt Warschau. Twenty numbered names executed at 15:30 hours on sixteen October in reprisal for attacks on German police personnel.

Sylwia's raw index finger ran straight down Numbers One through Twenty without stopping on *Wolski*:

6. Kowalczyk, Janusz, geb. 14.III.1909 Kielce (Heizer).

Janusz Kowalczyk, born 14 March 1909 Kielce — Stoker. Marek's exact birth-day and town attached to the forged railway-stoker's *Kennkarte* matching that greasy peaked cloth cap and quilted black *fufajka* jacket he had worn in Powązki's rain twenty days ago!

Meaning for forty-eight or seventy-two hours down inside Pawiak's concrete vaults—where men got beaten across iron trestles with bull-whips and iron rods until kidneys ruptured—Marek Wolski had held onto his forged stoker's cover without coughing up his real Polytechnic name, his Praga platoon, Koszykowa Thirty-Three, or *Dr. Sylwia Kotarska* —going barefoot onto Aleja Niepodległości cobbles with wet plaster of Paris setting hard around his bruised teeth as *Janusz Kowalczyk, railway*

stoker, taking five rounds into his chest without giving Aleja Szucha one syllable!

* * *

Mirecki shuffled quietly out at nine-thirty leaving her the dispensary key without embarrassing either of them with speeches.

Alone behind frosted glass in dead hospital silence, Sylwia uncorked the five-liter glass pharmacy carboy of ninety-six-percent *Spiritus vini rectificatus*, poured thirty milliliters into a porcelain measure, carried it not to her mouth—to the corner floor drain—and tipped half slowly onto cold tiles the way country carters in Poznań poured first vodka drops onto earth on All Souls' Night for men buried without coffins.

She drank the remaining fifteen milliliters raw in one burning swallow that tore tears into the corners of her eyes purely from chemical vapor, rinsed the porcelain measure clean at the tap, and stood gripping cold zinc with both hands until the floor stopped tilting.

Eighteen days since she had burned her green *Sonderausweis* and walked down Service Stair B on Królewska in September rain.

Zero optician's postcard had come through Walenty's pigeonhole—only silence from Saski Square while autumn tightened round Warsaw like galvanized wire round bare wrists: rumours whispered by ambulance drivers that Berlin's Reich Security Main Office was gutting Canaris's Eastern *Abwehr* stations desk by desk, rumours that three German officers from Königsberg had been flown west under arrest on Tuesday, pink posters blooming fresh every forty-eight hours across wet brick walls.

She did not pray for Ludwig tonight—praying belonged to people who still believed somebody upstairs counted sparrows—she merely walked up three dark flights to her freezing slant-roofed dormer cubby, wrapped two hospital blankets tight over her coat, and lay listening to boots patrol Nowogrodzka until at seven-ten on Wednesday morning the twentieth of October old Walenty climbed three flights grey-faced to hand her a stiff white envelope bearing the black runic return stamp of **Der Kommandeur der Sicherheitspolizei und des SD für den Distrikt Warschau — Aleja Szucha 25, Zimmer 214**:

Vorladung. Summons for **Dr. med. Sylwia Kotarska** to appear in person today at **11:00 Uhr** before *SS-Hauptsturmführer* Kroll for "supplementary municipal epidemic-record deposition."

Chapter XXVIII

The Tramway Salon

Warsaw, 20 October 1943

Before walking up Aleja Szucha a sensible surgeon emptied her pockets the way dying men emptied bladders—leaving behind every scrap of metal or paper that could hang a second person when fingernails came off.

At quarter to ten inside Pavilion Three's locked dispensary, Sylwia laid her gold-cased lapel watch, her hospital master-key ring, her pawnshop ebony Collin scalpel box, and the four remaining blank Vesper movement-vouchers on the marble slab in front of Docent Mirecki and Siostra Bronisława. Into her plain black handbag went nothing except her grey *Kennkarte*, municipal surgical *Arbeitskarte*, one clean linen handkerchief, two hundred złoty in small notes, and today's white *Vorladung* envelope stamped *Zimmer 214*.

She had zero hollow cyanide capsule inside her molar crowns, having refused Section II's potassium-cyanide glass bead back in forty-two because surgeons who carried suicide pills under their tongues bit down twenty minutes too early when bluffing still had legs.

"Four o'clock," Sylwia told Mirecki calmly, buttoning her heavy dark-grey winter wool coat because basement cells in October froze unheated through November. "If I haven't walked back through Walenty's arch by four, Jurek moves Halina and her brother from Grójec to Kielce parish before dawn tomorrow, and Bronka burns Vesper's four blanks in Boiler Two. Don't telephone Stabsarzt Vesper asking after me—Vesper will wet his breeches and tell Szucha everything he doesn't even know."

Mirecki couldn't speak past the grey tremor in his throat; he took her bare right hand between both his papery, blue-veined palms and pressed his dry lips once to her mercury-scarred knuckles in prewar Warsaw drawing-room salute—as if seeing a colleague off onto an ocean

liner rather than twenty minutes' walk south down Ujazdowskie. Bronka didn't kiss anything; Bronka shoved half a chunk of cold salted lard-bread wrapped in greaseproof paper deep into Sylwia's coat pocket (*"Eat before eleven—empty stomachs faint faster on stone"*) and turned furiously back to bang bedpans into boiling water so nobody saw her eyes wet.

October sun shone pale lemon-yellow along **Aleje Ujazdowskie**, lighting drifted carpets of golden-brown Norway maple leaves inside Łazienki Park's iron railings until you reached Plac Na Rozdrożu and turned southwest past white-painted steel dragon's-teeth tank barriers into **Aleja Szucha**.

No trams ran down Szucha anymore—rails rusted orange between clean-swept asphalt kerbs—and no Polish pedestrian walked there unless marched between rifles or carrying a white summons slip in wet fingers. German secretaries in smart Loden capes tripped briskly up and down wide granite steps carrying shorthand pads toward café lunch; motorcycles purred polite by curbstones; Number Twenty-Five itself—built in nineteen-thirty by Warsaw's proud young Ministry of Public Education out of sleek functionalist grey limestone, tall brass-framed modernist windows, and polished travertine marble halls—looked far cleaner and brighter from outside than any hospital in Poland.

Inside the main glass rotunda, an SS *Rottenführer* behind plate glass stamped *10:51* across Sylwia's white summons, confiscated her handbag against a numbered brass cloakroom token, and pointed not up the wide travertine grand staircase toward Second Floor Room 214—down a narrow concrete side-staircase descending beneath courtyard level.

"Warteraum unten links bis Aufruf Zimmer zweihundertvierzehn." *Waiting room downstairs left until called.*

Nobody called that basement corridor a waiting room in Polish. Warsaw called it **the Tramway** (*tramwaj*).

Down twelve concrete steps hit the smell: sour boiled turnip-cabbage from guard kitchens braided thick with wet floor-lysol, unwashed terrified human sweat, stale urine, and underneath the lysol that unmistakable iron-copper butcher-shop sweetness Sylwia scrubbed off theater tiles every day of her life.

Along a whitewashed concrete passage forty feet long sat two parallel double rows of plain varnished wooden bentwood chairs arranged back-to-center like seats inside a streetcar—except turned outward so every

seated prisoner faced **three inches straight into bare whitewashed brick wall**, forbidden on pain of immediate rubber-truncheon blows across the kidneys to turn chin left, right, or rearward!

Fourteen men and three women sat motionless along the wooden rows when the guard pointed Sylwia onto Chair Nine, Left Row: three inches ahead of her nose sat bumpy white limewash stippled with one tiny dried brown pin-head fleck at eye-level; behind her spine paced slow, unhurried nailed jackboots—*clack… pause… clack*—an SS *Sturmmann* slapping eighteen inches of lead-weighted black rubber cable rhythmically against his palm.

Eighteen inches to Sylwia's left on Chair Eight—close enough inside peripheral vision to read grey hair-pins and soaked wool collar without moving an eyeball—sat an elderly Polish woman past sixty in a neat, mended plum-coloured winter coat whose right velvet lapel was stiffened black-brown with dried blood from a split zygomatic arch and swollen purple ear. Every four seconds the old woman's swollen lips moved half a millimeter without emitting sound—not praying Polish litanies, shaping silent classical quantitative beats that Sylwia's Poznań gymnasium ear recognized after thirty seconds by pure lip-rhythm alone:

Forsan et haec olim meminisse iuvabit… Durate, et vosmet rebus servate secundis…

Virgil's *Aeneid*, Book One: *Perhaps one day it will help to remember even these things; endure, and keep yourselves alive for better fortunes.* Some retired girls'-lyceum Latin mistress hauled off Żoliborz beds at five a.m. for mimeographing underground news-bulletins, holding her sixty-year-old skull together between two cellar beatings by scanning hexameters three inches from Gestapo limewash! Down beside the woman's scuffed black lace-up shoe lay one snapped wooden bead off a pocket rosary that had rolled when guards shoved her down; neither woman dared twitch a toe toward it while nailed heels paused three seconds right behind their shoulder-blades—smelling sour of wet boot-grease, cheap peppermint drops, and pipe shag—before *clack… pause… clack* resumed toward the wash-sink.

Ten minutes ticked past in dead tomb-silence. Twenty.

Then, forty feet down the passage beyond a heavy iron-reinforced oak door bearing numbered tin tags, bolts scraped back; two guards dragged someone limp by both armpits—bare bruised heels scraping *scuff-scuff-*

scuff across wet concrete behind them without lifting—and dumped him onto Chair Fourteen behind Sylwia's row while down by the slop-sink an orderly wrung a mop out into a galvanized bucket with a loud wet *slosh*. Nobody coughed; nobody turned an eyeball half a millimeter off three inches of white brick.

Sylwia kept her spine straight, hands loose in her wool lap, breathing slow four-second surgical counts through her nose while chewing nothing save cold arithmetic inside her skull—refusing to let twenty-eight minutes in *the Tramway* soften her knees by half an inch before upstairs began.

At eleven-twenty-four boots stopped behind Chair Nine.

"Kotarska. Zweiter Stock, Zimmer zweihundertvierzehn."

* * *

Upstairs on the second floor, autumn sunlight poured cheerful and warm through tall brass-framed Ministry windows across polished oak parquet and thriving green potted *Monstera* plants along the corridor sills.

Room 214 had once belonged to a Polish Under-Secretary for Secondary Schools: generous proportions, cream walls hung with a framed colour portrait of the Führer above prewar Warsaw oak wainscoting, a long conference table covered in spotless dark-green baize cloth, and over by the radiator a pale-blond German stenographer in a neat grey jumper sitting poised behind an Adler Continental typewriter without looking up.

SS-Hauptsturmführer Reinhart Kroll stood beside the tall window watering a small terracotta pot of flowering purple cyclamen from a glass carafe.

He wore freshly pressed field-grey wool, silver *SD* diamond gleaming above his left cuff, sandy hair combed damp-neat—and on both hands thin snowy-white boiled cotton gloves. Even from twelve feet away as Sylwia crossed the threshold, she noticed the cotton over the inner aspect of his right wrist looked slightly thicker today—layered over gauze underneath—and when he set the glass carafe down, his left thumb went straight to stroking that covered ridge.

"Good morning, Frau Doktor Kotarska," Kroll said gently, gesturing toward the upright oak chair centered facing green baize and bright

window glare while seating himself unhurriedly opposite her with light behind his sandy head. "Forgive the twenty-minute delay downstairs; Wednesday transport clearances crowd the rotunda. May Fräulein Hinz pour you hot herbal tea?"

"Nothing, thank you, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*," Sylwia said calmly, folding raw ungloved hands quietly in her lap so zero tension showed in shoulders or jaw. "I have two strangulated hernias scheduled after two o'clock."

"Optimistic scheduling," Kroll murmured without malice—not threatening, stating calendar weather as a notary might—and opened a clean grey manila binder three inches thick centered squarely on green baize.

He did not shout, did not pace, did not flourish whips. One by one, with delicate white-cotton fingertips, he laid three items side by side across green felt facing her right side up:

First: an eight-by-ten glossy street photograph enlarged sharp from thirty-five-millimeter Leica grain—showing Sylwia herself standing flat-backed in dark wool coat holding two round rye loaves against a stationer's iron rolling-shutter at **three-thirty-two p.m. on Saturday the sixteenth of October**, forty feet opposite bound barefoot men in cement-paper sacks!

Second: a Pawiak prison post-mortem mugshot and ten-print fingerprint card dated *16.X.43*, showing Marek Wolski's bruised dead face before gypsum was packed into his jaw—matched by red ink arrows to a nineteen-thirty-four Warsaw Polytechnic civil-engineering diploma registration card in the name of **Inżynier Marek Wolski, geb. 14.III.1909 Kielce**!

Third: a signed Polish police deposition taken yesterday afternoon from **Helena Walczak, aged fifty-eight, concierge's wife at ulica Koszykowa 33**, testifying that between December forty-two and thirty June forty-three a lean grey-eyed gentleman matching Photograph Two visited Dr. Sylwia Kotarska's fourth-floor room once or twice fortnightly before curfew—until a noisy quarrel with stove-smoke on the afternoon of **thirty June**, after which neither gentleman nor doctor ever slept there again!

Sylwia looked down at all three documents for five measured seconds without changing breath depth by a hair.

Thank God—and thank Marek's silent teeth in Pawiak! Kroll hadn't got Sylwia's name out of Marek under torture; Kroll's own loden-coated Leica spotter on Aleja Niepodległości had recognized *Dr. Kotarska* standing accidentally in the Saturday execution crowd, cross-checked every dead prisoner's prewar Warsaw acquaintanceship circle after matching Marek's Polytechnic thumbprints on Monday, sent two detectives round to Koszykowa Thirty-Three's concierge yesterday, and struck gold on winter visits!

"You recognize Prisoner Six from Saturday's reprisal action on Aleja Niepodległości, Frau Doktor?" Kroll asked mildly while Fräulein Hinz's typewriter keys clicked soft crisp German headers in the corner.

Deny what fifty-eight-year-old Pani Walczak had already sworn on paper, and you walked back down to *the Tramway* inside sixty seconds as a proven liar.

"Certainly, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*," Sylwia answered in cool, level Berlin German, meeting Kroll's pale eyes without blinking against window light. "Inżynier Marek Wolski. His uncle knew my father slightly before thirty-seven through Ministry railway patent arbitrations; we met again casually in autumn forty-two queuing for coal briquettes on Polna."

"He visited your fourth-floor room at Koszykowa thirty-three roughly fourteen evenings between November forty-two and thirty June forty-three," Kroll read pleasantly off Walczak's sheet.

Sylwia allowed one dry, wintry flicker of adult female disdain to touch her mouth—the exact expression no male police officer on earth ever doubted when an unmarried thirty-three-year-old woman doctor explained a man climbing back stairs before eight-o'clock curfew.

"Warsaw winters are cold, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*, and unmarried surgeons of thirty-three are neither nuns nor blind—until one discovers a man is lying about where he spends his afternoons."

Kroll's sandy eyebrows rose one polite millimeter. "And what caused your sudden rupture on the afternoon of thirty June—the exact morning, by curious calendar chance, that Security Police arrested Polish terrorist commander Stefan Rowecki six blocks away on Spiska?"

"Inżynier Wolski walked into my room uninvited at one o'clock using an unauthorized wax-impression key while I was off rounds, burning papers in my stove that smelled considerably less innocent than Ostbahn bridge repairs," Sylwia said—handing Kroll ninety percent of the **physi-**

cal hallway truth Pani Walczak had smelled through the door so every brick held ten tons of weight while cutting away the underground tissue underneath! "When I demanded to know what political lunatic rubbish he was bringing under my hospital license—and ordered him down my stairs at once—he lost his temper, accused me of cozying up to German medical authorities because *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler had pulled me out of Skaryszewska three weeks earlier, and left his key on my table. Being disinclined to wait around an unguarded flat in case hotheads took offense, I moved into Pavilion Three's third-floor interns' quarters that same afternoon."

Click-click-click went Fräulein Hinz's Adler keys; then stopped as Kroll raised one white cotton finger.

For ten seconds Kroll sat very still, pale colourless eyes boring straight into Sylwia's across four feet of green baize while *scritch-scritch* went left cotton across covered right wrist.

He slid Document Four out of his grey binder.

Typed surveillance log from German Quarter gate-wardens at **Królewska Sixteen**: recording *twenty-seven Tuesday-and-Friday entries* by *Dr. med. S. Kotarska* into *Wohnung 4* between twenty-seven April and twenty-eight September—plus an eight-August motor-trip log to Świder—stopping **dead cold** after 19:30 hours on Tuesday the twenty-eighth of September, ninety minutes after an unidentified *Abwehr* corporal shot his way out of Kroll's trap outside St. Charles Borromeo Church on Chłodna leaving Group O blood on Mirów bricks!

"Twenty-seven specialist consultations of thirty to forty-five minutes each—plus a Sunday water-inspection excursion to Otwock pines—for a healed clavicular scar, Frau Doktor," Kroll said softly, every trace of velvet small-talk thinning down to bare Saxon piano wire. "And terminating abruptly on the precise evening of twenty-eight September, when *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler's East Prussian driver vanished off Warsaw rosters toward Königsberg after firing upon Security Police officers at a dead-letter drop on Chłodna originally betrayed during Schoeler's February stay inside your Pavilion Three!"

Every muscle inside Sylwia's ribs locked stone-calm; discreetly behind closed lips she bit down hard onto the scarred inside of her own left cheek—old trick learned from Ludwig himself in Room Fourteen—letting sharp

copper pain anchor her pulse flat at seventy-two so zero flush climbed her neck!

"My attendance at Królewska Sixteen stood under compulsory written order of *Stabsarzt* Doktor Vesper and *Wehrmachtkommandantur Warschau*, renewed expressly by *Herr Stabsarzt* Vesper on twenty-six July over my own stated preference to discontinue," Sylwia replied crisply—reminding Kroll right across the baize that dragging Kurt Vesper onto a witness stand meant hauling out Vesper's terrified July twenty-fourth hospital night too! "On twenty-eight September *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler informed me brusquely that Berlin was closing his Warsaw outpatient file prior to reassignment and canceled future passes. Where his driver went before five o'clock—while two staff officers or kitchen pots occupied his back hall—he naturally did not confide to a Polish municipal doctor."

Kroll leaned two inches forward over green baize.

"Let me save you three unpleasant weeks downstairs, Frau Doktor," he said almost gently, pulling three freshly typed sheets of heavy Reich-eagle deposition bond out of his folder and uncapping a black fountain pen beside her right wrist. "I bear zero personal animus toward Polish surgeons who survive winter how they must—whether in cold rooms on Koszykowa or warm sofas on Królewska. *My* sole administrative interest is **Oberstleutnant Doktor Ludwig Schoeler**."

Sylwia did not look down at the uncapped fountain pen.

"Hauptmann von Berg has already confirmed in Prinz-Albrecht-Straße," Kroll continued softly, "that since spring *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler used unauthorized channels to obstruct Security Police operations in Warsaw—including registering a fictitious counter-espionage shield over your hospital on eighteen August under the charming title *Vorgang Naht*. Unfortunately von Berg lacked firsthand witness proof of *whom* Schoeler passed warnings through in Warsaw. Sign these three pages attesting that under threat of revoking your hospital protection, *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler coerced you between April and September into carrying verbal and written intelligence messages between Królewska Sixteen and Polish underground operative Marek Wolski—now conveniently dead and beyond further harm!—and at twelve-thirty today you collect your handbag downstairs, walk back out into October sunshine to *Kindlein Jesu*, and never see this building again."

Look at the clean, lethal beauty of Kroll's offer:

Marek Wolski was already burned ash; signing three pages blaming a dead Polish engineer and handing Reinhart Kroll high-treason hanging proof against *Oberstleutnant Ludwig Schoeler* before the *Volksgerichtshof* in Berlin bought Sylwia Kotarska instant daylight freedom, seventy safe hospital beds, and Staś's peaceful winter!

Refuse—and right behind Kroll's elbow sat the red internal *Schutzhaft* detention slip sending *Kotarska, Sylwia* down into *the Tramway*'s cellar vaults where rubber cables and iron hooks broke wrists before supper!

Sylwia looked straight across sunlit green baize into Reinhart Kroll's pale, lashless Saxon eyes.

"Were I to sign one word stating *Oberstleutnant* Schoeler passed messages through me to Marek Wolski, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*," Sylwia said in crystal-clear Berlin German without a tremor in syllable or breath, "I would be inventing perjury to buy my lunch. Herr Schoeler never spoke Marek Wolski's name in my presence, never handed me a scrap of intelligence paper, and if he registered my hospital on some bureaucratic turf-file in August without telling me, it matches every underhanded trick I watched him pull on Luisenstraße twelve years ago. I have nothing else to depose."

* * *

For ninety minutes after twelve-thirty Kroll stopped offering tea.

He didn't touch her himself—jurists from Dresden kept clean cuffs—simply kept her standing upright without chair or water two feet in front of blazing south window glare while reading aloud twenty-four separate Polish hospital death-entries, Wola typhus-quarantine dates, Anna Nowak's September seventh admission versus Irena Kwiatkowska's death-hour, hunting one single contradicted date or cracked verb across three solid hours of microscopic cross-examination.

Sylwia stood straight on aching ankles in her heavy winter wool coat—eating nothing of Bronka's pocket bread, tasting salt blood inside her bitten left cheek whenever dizziness flickered behind her eyes—repeating identical timestamps down to the minute (*00:51 clamp, 21:40 exitus Kwiatkowska, 17:00 Tuesday Królewska per Vesper's order*) like an iron metronome forged in Poznań and tempered in liquid nitrogen.

At two-fifteen Kroll suddenly switched tracks without changing pitch —sliding **SS-Untersturmführer Mahler's eighth-September inspection protocol** from Pavilion Three's basement typhus mortuary out from beneath his blotter!

"One technical curiosity before we conclude upstairs, Frau Doktor," Kroll murmured, holding Mahler's typed sheet delicately between white-cotton thumb and forefinger. "Your deceased basement laboratory technician, *Irena Kwiatkowska*, expired at twenty-one-forty hours on seven September—some twelve hours after accidentally spilling eighty-eight-percent liquefied carbolic acid across the palmar ridges of her right thumb, index, and middle fingers. Remarkably awkward clumsiness for an experienced Weigl-feeder on the precise night railway cordons sealed Warsaw after Bürkl's shooting—especially when Charity Ward Admission Number Seven, *Anna Nowak, seamstress, aged twenty-nine*, died of epidemic typhus on the same floor four hours earlier."

Not a lash moved round Sylwia's dark eyes, though inside her heavy wool coat cold sweat slid one thin bead straight down between her shoulder-blades.

"Had *Herr Untersturmführer* Mahler doubted which pauper lay in Box One and which laboratory assistant lay in Box Four when he inspected both open coffins personally at eight-twenty-six a.m., *Herr Hauptsturmführer*," Sylwia answered in bone-dry clinical German, "he stood six inches from both faces with magnifying lens and caliper rule for twelve minutes. Forty-degree *Fleckfieber* rigor shakes glass Pasteur pipettes out of far steadier fingers than a dying twenty-eight-year-old girl's; had I wished to fake carbolic burns on a corpse's hand post-mortem, any first-year forensic student in Dresden knows dead skin lacks vital erythematous blister-margin reaction—which your own Untersturmführer verified around the eschar before signing his seal. Should *Referat Vier* wish to exhume Municipal Typhus Pit Twelve at Bródno after six weeks' autumn rain to re-examine six hundred unlimed charity corpses, Municipal Sanitation will gladly lend picks and shovels."

Fräulein Hinz's pale fingers hovered frozen above her Adler keys; across green baize a faint, ugly flush crept up Kroll's smooth cheekbones at hearing Dresden forensic textbooks thrown neatly back into his teeth.

At quarter to three Kroll finally closed his grey manila binder with a soft flat slap.

All courtroom pleasantness vanished off his thin mouth; pulling a pad of salmon-red internal remand orders (*Einlieferungsschein — Hausgefängnis Zelle*) across green baize, he dipped his pen to fill in *Kotarska, Sylwia Helena — Verdacht der Feindbegünstigung u. Spionagebeihilfe*:

"Admirable loyalty to Luisenstraße classmates, Frau Doktor," Kroll said dryly, scratching hard through white cotton at his covered right wrist. "Let us see whether seventy-two hours standing below stairs improves dates before we bring your Docent Mirecki and that fat scrub-nurse down to compare calendars—"

On the small side-table behind Kroll's left elbow, the black direct-line command telephone—not room switchboard, red-striped Reich Security / Military District priority trunk—rang one long, sharp peal.

Kroll paused with nib poised three millimeters above salmon paper, frowned slightly, picked up the heavy bakelite receiver: "Kroll, *Referat Vier A*."

Sylwia stood motionless two feet before the desk watching Kroll's face.

Whoever spoke on the other end—crisp, clipped, high-ranking Prussian military-judicial brass coming straight down from Cracow General-gouvernement High Command or Berlin RSHA-OKW liaison—did not pause for Kroll's interruptions. Ten seconds in, Kroll stood slowly upright behind his chair; thirty seconds in, every drop of pale pink drained chalk-white out of Kroll's smooth cheeks; sixty seconds in, while uttering only *"Jawohl, Herr Oberstkriegsgerichtsrat… Nein, noch keine Verhaftung vollzogen… Jawohl, Akte wird sofort abgegeben,"* Kroll's left white-cotton index finger dug so savagely and unconsciously back and forth across the gauze-wrapped inner aspect of his right wrist that raw weeping eczema split wide open underneath—soaking a bright five-pfennig circle of **crimson blood** straight through snowy white cotton cuff!

Kroll set the black bakelite receiver slowly back onto its cradle without looking down at his bleeding glove.

For eight seconds dead silence hung inside Room 214 save for autumn flies buzzing sleepy against warm window-glass.

When Kroll looked back up at Sylwia standing motionless before his green baize table, pure cold arsenic sat behind his colourless eyes—the look of a hunter watching quarry yanked bodily out of steel jaws two tenths of a second before teeth met bone.

"At twelve hundred hours today before the Chief Military Prosecutor of *Oberkommando der Wehrmacht* at Cracow," Kroll said in a voice so tight and soft it barely carried six feet across green felt, "*Oberstleutnant* Doktor Schoeler formally dissolved *Sondervorgang Naht* upon signing voluntary relinquishment of *Abwehr* staff immunity and immediate punitive front-line combat transfer—*Frontbewährung*, commanding a divisional reconnaissance-medical combat group on the lower Dnieper bend east of Kremenchug."

Sylwia's knees did not move half a millimeter under grey wool; only the whole sunlit room behind Kroll's sandy head seemed suddenly to lose sound, like film running silent when projector sprockets tear.

Lower Dnieper bend east of Kremenchug, late October nineteen-forty-three.

Even Polish hospital orderlies reading crumpled German communiqués upside-down knew what *lower Dnieper bend* meant this week: thirty Soviet tank armies smashing through burning steppe mud across broken German bridgeheads at five-to-one artillery odds, where staff colonels sent out of disgraced *Abwehr* offices under *Frontbewährung* lasted eleven days on average before Russian Katyushas turned grey wool to red rags!

"As condition of OKW countersigning closure of *Abwehrstelle Warschau*'s autonomous files without public inter-service tribunal," Kroll continued through stiff pale lips, tearing the half-written salmon remand slip once across and dropping it into his wire basket before picking up Sylwia's white morning *Vorladung* summons to stamp **ENTLASSEN — 15:08 UHR** viciously across the bottom in purple ink, "Wehrmacht High Command places all listed municipal medical installations under closed military-epidemic seal retroactive to February. Collect your bag at the rotunda, Frau Doktor. Should one single unregistered bandage cross Lindleya's threshold this winter after your patron freezes in Ukrainian mud, no colonel in Cracow will pick up a telephone a second time."

Sylwia reached across green baize with steady, ungloved fingers, took her stamped white release slip three inches from Kroll's blood-spotted white cotton wrist without glancing down at his stain, inclined her chin two polite millimeters—"Good afternoon, *Herr Hauptsturmführer*"—and walked unhurriedly out down polished travertine stairs, collected her

black handbag on Token Twelve, and stepped past steel tank-barriers out onto sunlit Aleje Ujazdowskie at sixteen minutes past three.

Only fifty yards inside Łazienki Park's deserted side-walk behind thick yellowing hornbeam hedges—where zero Leica lens watched—did Sylwia stop walking, lean one wool shoulder hard against cold iron park railings, spit a mouthful of bright red salt blood from her bitten cheek into dead yellow leaves, and press both raw hands flat across her ribs to hold them together while October wind roared hollow through bare branches overhead.

At six minutes to four—four minutes before her own deadline sent Jurek galloping toward Grójec and Vesper's blank passes into coal-flames! —Sylwia pushed open Walenty's arched postern gate on Lindleya.

Old Walenty took one look at her tall grey-coated figure stepping alive out of afternoon shadow, dropped his broom clattering across cobbles, and crossed himself three times from brow to breastbone before running bow-legged toward the boiler cellar steps shouting *"Jest! Wróciła!"* Down at the foot of Boiler Two's iron stair Siostra Bronisława stood squarely in front of the open roaring furnace door holding Vesper's four green *Sanitätsabteilung* passes pinched ready above red-hot clinkers in iron fire-tongs while Docent Mirecki leaned grey as chalk against the whitewashed wall checking his gold pocket-watch at *3:57*!

At sight of Sylwia walking down the stone steps intact on her own two ankles, Bronka slammed the cast-iron firebox door shut with an ear-splitting *clang*, shoved the four green passes straight back into Sylwia's coat pocket without trusting her voice to speak one word, marched furiously into the scullery, and broke a chipped earthenware soup-plate clean in half into the sink just to have something solid to curse at!

"No cellar?" Mirecki whispered beside the heating pipe, gripping his ebony cane handle hard enough to turn thin knuckles ivory.

"Closed file—military epidemic seal countersigned from Cracow," Sylwia answered evenly, letting zero syllable of *Frontbewährung* or *Kremenchug* cross her raw-bitten mouth because speak his name aloud right now under yellow cellar bulbs and her voice cracked down the middle in front of witnesses. "Tell Jurek Grójec stays quiet through winter. Give me twenty minutes to wash Szucha off my hands and I'll take evening dressings."

Chapter XXIX

Before Frost

Warsaw, 22–23 October 1943

For forty-eight hours after walking out of Aleja Szucha Sylwia operated like a machine driven off flywheel momentum alone—resecting gangrenous bowel on Thursday morning, draining two pleural empyemas Thursday night, lecturing six pale underground medical girls down in the boiler coal-cellar at six a.m. Friday on femoral triangle tourniquet points without pausing once for breath—because stop moving for ten minutes and her brain started multiplying artillery densities east of Kremenchug.

At four o'clock on Friday afternoon the twenty-second of October, when thick yellow river-fog rolled up out of the Vistula valley smelling of coal-barge soot and rotting willow leaves, old Walenty laid afternoon post beside the ground-floor ward register.

Beneath two municipal laundry invoices lay an unsealed buff penny-postcard stamped at *Warszawa 1* main post office two hours earlier, addressed in cramped Polish shopkeeper script to *Wielmożna Pani Dr. med. S. Kotarska, Szpital Dzieciątka Jezus, Paw. III*:

Szanowna Pani Doktor — Oprawki rogowe po naprawie zawiasu gotowe do odbioru przed likwidacją warsztatu w piątek dnia 22 b.m. wyłącznie między godz. 19 a 19.30. Zakład Optyczny, ul. Tamka 41, III p. prawa oficyna.

Horn-rimmed frames after hinge repair ready for collection prior to workshop liquidation Friday 22nd inst. strictly between 19:00 and 19:30 hours. Optical Workshop, ulica Tamka 41, third floor, right courtyard wing.

Sylwia stood motionless under the dim corridor bulb holding six square inches of cheap buff cardboard until her thumb dented the margin.

Not Królewska Sixteen—*Wohnung 4* would be stripped to bare Judge Silberstein parquet under Kroll's binoculars tonight. **Tamka Forty-One**,

plunging steep down the cobblestoned Powiśle escarpment below the Chopin Conservatory straight toward the black Vistula riverfront and the iron arches of the **Średnicowy Railway Bridge**, where eastbound military trains loaded at *Warszawa Gdańska* and *Wschodnia* rumbled night and day toward Brest-Litovsk and the Dnieper!

And *between 19:00 and 19:30 hours*—thirty minutes before eight-o'clock curfew locked every street in Warsaw shut until five-thirty Saturday morning! Nobody scheduled a seven-fifteen appointment forty minutes' walk from Lindleya expecting anyone to walk home before dawn.

At six-fifteen Sylwia signed night emergency coverage over to Doktor Jankowski (*"My sister's boy on Filtrowa has high acetone—if curfews hold me past eight I'll walk straight into morning scrub at six"*), changed into a clean cream linen blouse beneath her heavy dark-grey winter coat without jewels or scent save scrubbed hospital soap, tucked one small oiled-linen surgical packet inside her deep coat pocket, and walked east down Jerozolimskie and Nowy Świat into thickening river fog.

Down Tamka's steep wet granite cobbles streetlamps burned only as dim blue blackout slits fifty yards apart; fog muffled tram-bells uphill into cotton wool, while ahead through damp gloom boomed the hollow rhythmic iron thunder—*ka-klang, ka-klang, ka-klang*—of heavy flatcars rolling east across the Vistula viaduct toward Praga.

Passing beneath the towering brick railway-viaduct arch off Kruczkowskiego three minutes short of seven, Sylwia had to pause ten seconds at the kerb while two mounted *Feldgendarmerie* motorcycles cleared cross-traffic below. Directly thirty feet overhead along the elevated steel girders, an eastbound Wehrmacht *Marschbataillon* replacement transport ground temporarily to a halt behind red signals—steam hissing white and scalding down off coupling-pipes into yellow Powiśle fog, forty chained wooden boxcars smelling of wet straw, gun-oil, and horse-dung creaking bumper to bumper above the street.

Looking up involuntarily for two seconds through drifting river mist, Sylwia saw eight or ten bareheaded German boys no older than seventeen or eighteen—smooth-chinned Saxon and Westphalian conscripts drafted straight out of schoolrooms since Stalingrad—leaning forearms over the waist-high wooden ventilation bar of a boxcar directly above the streetlamp slit, staring silently down without singing a note into dark,

hostile Warsaw cobbles before whistle-blasts shrieked forward, couplings crashed iron on iron, and forty cars of grey wool rolled rumbling east across black water toward the Dnieper cauldron.

Tomorrow night at twenty-three hundred hours, one of those blacked-out eastern trains carried Ludwig.

Sylwia pulled her collar tighter round her chin and walked faster down the wet slope. Number Forty-One was a tall, soot-blackened eighteen-eighties tenement smelling of river damp, cabbage soup, and coal dust; its iron courtyard gate stood unlatched before eight. Sylwia slipped quietly past dark ground-floor workshops up the right rear wooden staircase—worn pine treads groaning faint beneath her shoes—past silent first and second landings until at the top of the third flight, beneath a slanted attic transom, a door bearing a peeled tin plate (*J. Grabowski — Introligatornia*, Bookbindery) stood half an inch ajar off its latch.

Sylwia pushed the wood inward, stepped through into pitch darkness smelling of old dry book-glue, cold pine boards, and damp wool, and felt the door-bolt slide quietly shut behind her shoulder before two bare warm hands caught her face.

Neither spoke one word before their mouths met in the dark—hard, bruised, starving, knocking her felt hat clean off onto bare floorboards as Ludwig backed her flat against cold plaster behind the bolted door and kissed her with zero restraint left on earth, teeth grazing bruised inner lip where she had bitten blood in Kroll's office forty-eight hours ago, hands ripping her heavy winter coat-buttons open to pull her ribs crushing-tight against rough field-grey combat wool!

Only when both tore loose gasping for air in freezing attic gloom did Ludwig strike one sulphur match and touch the wick of a thick tallow candle stub stuck inside a chipped saucer on an upturned bookbinder's press-crate.

Dim yellow flame wavered upward, lighting slanted mansard rafters, a grime-frosted iron skylight trembling softly overhead to distant railway-bridge vibrations, two heavy grey army greatcoats spread layered over three dry straw-filled sacking palliasses in the corner, and **Ludwig himself**.

Sylwia's breath caught like a fishhook behind her sternum looking at him in candlelight.

Gone was the smooth tailored gabardine staff tunic of Saski Square and Palais Brühl: he wore rough, high-collared field-grey frontline wool without staff-crimson tabs—plain dull grey combat shoulder-straps of an *Oberstleutnant* stitched flat so Russian snipers couldn't read silver braid at three hundred yards, heavy marched-in leather jackboots greased black against Ukrainian mud, unbuckled webbing pistol-belt and Walther holster lying across the packing crate beside a battered tin field-canteen. His dark hair had been cropped three millimeters shorter above the ears this morning by some barracks barber, making his gaunt cheekbones, hollow temples, and that pale crescent Virchow scar beneath his right eye look fiercely, heartbreakingly bare—thirty-four years old and carved straight down to Prussian granite.

Instead of melting into his arms, ten days of terror since Aleja Niepodległości and Room 214 exploded straight up out of Sylwia's chest into white-hot surgeon's fury—shoving both open palms hard against his rough wool breastbone!

"*Eleven days!*" she hissed in Polish, voice shaking low and savage through the cold attic. "I looked up divisional combat-group casualty tables from Kremenchug on Stabsarzt Vesper's own casualty circulars yesterday morning! Disgraced staff colonels dumped onto the lower Dnieper bend without winter armor average **eleven days** before Soviet rocket batteries turn them into nameless meat! Who gave you leave to sign *Frontbewährung* behind my back in Cracow on Wednesday noon?! Who asked you to buy my skin off Reinhart Kroll's table a second time with your own carotid?!"

Ludwig caught both her striking wrists in one iron grip against his wool chest—eyes blazing fierce, winter-green, almost laughing without mirth down into her furious dark face six inches below his chin!

"And what would Dr. Sylwia Kotarska have preferred at twelve-forty-five on Wednesday," Ludwig demanded back in rough Berlin German, holding her wrists pinned hard against his breastbone so she felt his heart hammering fast beneath coarse wool, "that I pack a neat pigskin suitcase for Königsberg staff desk while Reinhart Kroll marches you downstairs into *the Tramway* cells and hangs you by both wrists until Mirecki and your sister's child follow you into Pawiak?!"

"I had Kroll stopped cold without giving him one syllable—!"

"Kroll had your red cellar remand slip half-written under his pen at two-forty-five and you know it!" Ludwig snapped, grip tightening until her pulse beat straight against his thumb-bones. "Von Berg cracked wide open in Berlin—by Monday morning RSHA's *Sonderkommission* was landing at Okęcie Airport to seize Saski Square's safes anyway! Wait until Monday, and they arrest me in Warsaw *and* hand you straight to Kroll as my suspected cutout! Walk into Cracow Military Court voluntarily Wednesday morning forty-eight hours *ahead* of Himmler's warrant—demand immediate frontline combat transfer under Wehrmacht *Ehrengericht* jurisdiction in exchange for sealing Warsaw's municipal medical files—and Field Marshal Keitel's own red stamp slams the iron door shut in Reinhart Kroll's bleeding teeth!"

"Leaving you eleven days in freezing steppe mud east of Kremenchug!" Her fingers twisted inside his grip to clutch two fistfuls of his rough field-grey lapels instead, nails digging hard through coarse army wool while dry, furious heat burned behind her eyelids without falling. "You arrogant, insufferable Prussian bastard—making bargains over my head in thirty-three, making bargains over my head in August, throwing yourself in front of Russian tanks so you win the last word—!"

"Every single hour my heart has beaten past twelve-fifty-one a.m. on the ninth of February belonged to your two hands anyway, Sylwia," Ludwig said rawly, releasing her wrists to frame both sides of her fierce, pale face between warm palms, thumbs sweeping hard across her cheekbones. "Did you really think I survived your operating table just to sit alive behind ink-pots while somebody broke those hands in a basement? Besides—" one crooked, reckless flash of twenty-two-year-old Luisenstraße arrogance cut across his mouth inches above hers—"Soviet artillery hasn't met anybody yet who survived you twice."

Sylwia didn't answer with words—she dragged his head down by both wool lapels and bit his lower lip until he groaned deep in his chest, kicking the heavy winter coat off her shoulders onto bare pine boards while eight o'clock curfew bells tolled muffled through Vistula fog outside and locked all Warsaw shut around their attic for nine unbroken hours!

* * *

Cold air inside the unheated Powiśle garret stood barely five degrees above freezing—every exhaled breath rising faint white in tallow candlelight until two bodies wrapped naked between coarse wool army greatcoats turned three straw palliasses into a furnace.

Nothing hurried tonight: no waiting ambulance below stairs, no string quartet tuning Schubert twenty feet beyond velvet curtains, no red darkroom timer ticking toward evening rounds. Every garment came off slow and deliberate in wavering yellow candle-glow so eyes and hands missed zero millimeter before dark took him east.

Kneeling upright over him on grey wool blankets while an eastbound munitions train thundered slow across the iron Vistula bridge four hundred yards away—*ka-klang, ka-klang*, vibrating dry dust motes golden through tallow light and rattling the frosted skylight overhead—Sylwia unbuttoned his coarse army undershirt and stripped it over his cropped dark head, laying both bare palms flat across his warm, lean-muscled ribs and sternum.

Under yellow flame that six-inch keloid ridge beneath his left collarbone stood paler now after eight months—fading from angry spring purple down toward smooth silver-pink cord—while forty centimeters lower above his right iliac crest sat the older indented shell-splinter furrow from forty-one. Slowly, bending low until her unpinned dark hair spilled warm across his stomach and ribs, Sylwia pressed her open mouth first to the forty-one hip scar—feeling his abdominal muscles clench hard beneath her tongue—then trailed slow, scalding kisses up the center line of his sternum until her lips closed soft and hot directly over the living pulse beating heavy underneath her own February suture line.

Beneath her mouth Ludwig drew one ragged, shuddering breath through his teeth, fingers tangling deep into her loose dark hair without pulling her off:

"*Sylwia…*"

"Quiet," she whispered against his collarbone in Polish, sliding slowly upward along his bare length until rough chest hair rasped hot against small hard nipples and her thighs straddled wide across his lean hips, feeling him rock-hard and aching hot against the slick wet seam of her sex already soaked from kissing him by the door. "Tonight you take orders on my ward, *Herr Oberstleutnant*."

Sitting upright above him in dim golden candlelight so he saw every line of her bare throat, collarbone, high pale breasts, and narrow waist framed against dark rafters, she reached one hand down between them, closed surgeon-steady fingers round his thick, burning shaft, guided the swollen head straight to her entrance, and sank down along him inch by slow, stretching, breathtaking inch until she took him to the absolute hilt and gasped aloud at the sheer hot fullness splitting her open!

Ludwig's hips surged upward off the straw palliasse with a raw, guttural groan, both large hands clamping hard round her bare hips and waist—thumbs digging white into her iliac bones—watching through black-dilated eyes as she rode him slow and deep at first, then harder, faster, unforgivingly raw, grinding her clitoris fierce against the coarse dark hair at his groin with every downward slam while her inner walls clenched vice-tight around him like a fist refusing to let go!

"Look at me—don't close your eyes—" Ludwig rasped, sitting halfway upright on the blankets to catch her waist in one arm, burying his mouth rough against her bare throat and sucking dark bruised marks below her jawbone before flipping her seamlessly onto her back across grey wool without slipping half an inch out of her body!

Pinned wide beneath his full lean weight—her ankles locked high and tight above his driving kidneys, fingernails raking four red tracks straight down his scarred shoulder-blades—every shred of fifteen years' pride, Berlin rivalry, terror, and grief burned clean through both of them at once. He fucked her deep, slow-dragging then brutally hard into the rustling straw mattresses, watching every gasping catch of her mouth in tallow-light, sliding one hand down between their slamming bellies to rub her slick swollen clit in tight relentless circles synchronized with every heavy upward stroke until white lightning tore straight up Sylwia's spine from pelvis to skull—back arching clean off grey wool with a broken, muffled cry bitten straight into Ludwig's bare shoulder—and three savage strokes later Ludwig buried his face into the hollow of her neck, groaning her name raw in broken Polish-German against her wet skin as he spent himself scalding and endless deep inside her!

They didn't pull apart afterward in the freezing room—he stayed buried warm inside her under two pulled-up heavy wool greatcoats while candle-wax guttered low into its saucer, his thumb lazily tracing the four

pale eleven-year-old dog-cellar suture dots across her left thumb-base, her bare foot tucked warm between his shins.

Somewhere past midnight, when the tallow wick drowned out into pitch blackness and river fog pressed opaque against the high iron skylight, Ludwig's quiet voice came warm against her breastbone in darkness:

"Do you know when I knew I was completely lost with you—long before February, long before Savignyplatz?"

Sylwia's fingers moved slow through the cropped dark hair at the nape of his neck. "December nineteen-thirty when I called you a thief?"

"October nineteen-twenty-eight," Ludwig murmured—a low rumble vibrating straight out of his ribs into hers. "Third week on Cadaver Nineteen. Every German boy in Waldeyer's hall—myself included—went green round the gills the morning Prosector Krause sawed open Nineteen's putrid mesenteric abscess after the formalin pump failed. Half the bench backed two paces toward the window; and there stood eighteen-year-old Fräulein Kotarska in her shiny home-ironed Poznań cuffs, five feet five and ninety-eight pounds wet, leaning six inches *closer* over green pus with two pairs of forceps in her hands snapping at me in icy grammar-school German to stop blocking her light if I lacked stomach for viscera." His mouth curved warm against her collarbone in the dark. "Went back to my room on Albrechtstraße furious enough to punch plaster—and woke up at three a.m. hard as iron dreaming about knocking those forceps out of your fingers onto the dissecting table."

A real, startled, breathless laugh broke out of Sylwia's throat in pitch darkness—turning inside two seconds into slow hot teeth nipping his ear as she felt him stir thick and heavy against her thigh all over again:

"Eighteen years old and dreaming of corrupting Poznań girls over gangrenous bowel—no wonder Sauerbruch gave you medals, you degenerate."

Before rolling over her again, though, she stayed quiet five breaths in the pitch dark, letting her palm rest flat over the steady drum of his heart while another distant night freight rumbled faint across the Vistula iron spans toward Ukraine.

"Did Jakob Mandelbaum ever make it clean out of Prague?" she asked softly into the dark hollow below his chin—asking the last unanswered Berlin ghost before morning shut the door.

"New York—Mount Sinai Hospital, Manhattan," Ludwig answered quietly, fingers stroking slow up and down the bare curve of her spine beneath heavy grey wool. "Read two papers of his in *Annals of Surgery* folded inside Lisbon diplomatic pouches in forty-one: endotracheal cyclopropane anesthesia in open pleural resections. Married a violinist's daughter from Brünn in thirty-eight; sent Geheimrat von Halden an unsigned Christmas postcard from Zurich in thirty-nine showing nothing except a drawing of a clean spirometer drum."

Something tight behind Sylwia's eyes stung hot and brief in the dark—knowing skinny, stammering Jakob Mandelbaum from Breslau was alive across three thousand miles of clean salt ocean adjusting anesthesia valves under electric lamps where nobody wore yellow stars or gypsum gags!

"And von Halden himself?" she whispered.

"Still operating at seventy-one in sandbagged basement theaters under Luisenstraße while British four-thousand-pounders blow windows out down Schumannstraße," Ludwig said. "Wrote me four lines in March when he heard I'd taken shrapnel in Warsaw—didn't know *who* sewed my subclavian together because military dispatches omitted Polish names, only grumbled in postscript that whoever tied off the first-rib stump without costing me ulnar grip hadn't learned sloppy knots in Munich."

"Damn right they didn't," Sylwia murmured fiercely against his chest—and then all lightness ebbed down to bare hot bone as she lifted her head in pitch blackness, feeling rather than seeing his cropped dark temples between both palms. "Listen to me without jokes for ten seconds, Ludwig. Don't play Prussian hero on the Dnieper to impress dead torpedo-boat captains. If Russian tanks break your flank, retreat; if typhus hits your dugout, boil lice off your seams; if shrapnel clips you, get onto the first hospital train heading west—even if forty-four burns Warsaw to cinders and forty-five burns Berlin down to cellars, don't you dare die in some nameless steppe ditch before I finish arguing with you."

His hands came up warm and iron-steady over hers in the pitch dark, pulling her bare chest flush down onto his so zero cold air sat between breastbones.

"Not in forty-three, not in forty-four, and not for any flag flying between Moscow and the Rhine," Ludwig swore low against her mouth

—speaking Polish first, German second, sealing it in skin instead of ink. "Show me what Poznań girls learned since twenty-eight, *Pani Doktor*."

He rolled her warm beneath the heavy wool caves—mouth descending slow down ribs, navel, and parted thighs in pitch blackness, tongue parting slick hot folds with unhurried, devastating precision until she twisted both fists into wool blankets biting back cries against her knuckles, before climbing back up over her slick trembling body past two a.m. to take her slow, endless, chest-to-chest, palm-laced-in-palm in absolute dark where neither uniform nor border existed anywhere in Europe.

* * *

At quarter to five on Saturday morning a cold greyness paler than milk seeped faintly down through frosted skylight glass; far off across black water a yard locomotive shrieked twice at *Warszawa Wschodnia*, coupling flatcars for tonight's twenty-three-hundred departure toward Brest and Kremenchug.

They dressed silently by touch and dim grey dawn-filter—buttoning linen, buckling cold leather, smoothing wool without switching on matches so zero light showed down Tamka's courtyard well before curfew lifted at half-past five.

When Ludwig buckled his heavy brown pistol-belt round his field-grey waist, he reached inside his inner breast pocket first and drew out a flat, hand-sewn chamois-leather pouch four inches square, pressing it warm and heavy into Sylwia's bare hands.

"Don't argue—listen thirty seconds," Ludwig said quietly, holding her hands closed around the chamois packet. "Inside are twenty British gold sovereigns from my father's Kiel sea-chest—gold buys peasant carts when Reichsmarks and złoty turn to wallpaper—plus two stamped International Red Cross medical-repatriation transit blanks routed via Vienna to **Sanatorium Hochzirl above Innsbruck**, where Friedrich von Halden's uncle directs Alpine tuberculosis surgery three hours from the Swiss wire. Wait—I know you won't leave Lindleya while Warsaw stands!" He cut across her instant breath before she spoke. "Keep it cemented behind loose brick in your attic flue for next summer. Because by July or August next year the Red Army will sit on the east bank of that river out there—and if Warsaw rises between two millstones while Hitler orders every

brick leveled to mud, take Staś, take Wanda, put Halina's name on Blank Two, and get out west to Innsbruck."

"Only if you walk up Innsbruck's mountain road behind us," Sylwia said fiercely under her breath, slipping the flat chamois pouch deep inside her inner coat-lining pocket—and drawing out her own five-inch oiled-linen packet in trade.

Unwrapping the oiled cloth between them in dim grey skylight shadow gleamed zero ribbon, zero photograph, zero lock of hair that could betray identity to Russian or German searchers:

One spotless, mirror-polished five-inch nickel-steel **curved Collin arterial hemostat (*Péan clamp*)** with ratcheted box-lock teeth, wrapped tight alongside two sealed glass catgut suture tubes and two military-grade morphine Tartrate syrettes!

Sylwia unbuttoned the top left breast-pocket flap of Ludwig's front-line field-grey wool tunic herself—directly over his first rib and left subclavian artery—slid the steel Péan clamp and oiled packet snug inside against his heart, and buttoned the grey horn button tight with steady fingers.

"Keep steel over that first rib, Ludwig," Sylwia said, looking straight up into his gaunt, cropped face in grey dawn light without letting one single tear spill past her black lashes—pure fierce Poznań steel holding both of them upright at the edge of the cliff. "If Russian shrapnel opens anything between neck and groin eight hundred kilometers from Warsaw, clamp the proximal stump on the third ratchet click and stay alive on sheer bad temper until they haul you west—because if you dare bleed out in Ukrainian mud after making me love you, Schoeler, I swear to God I'll come east with an amputation saw and drag you back myself."

For three heartbeats Ludwig couldn't even speak—staring down at the woman who had clamped him back from death in February, hated him across fifteen winters, and put an arterial clamp over his heart for Russia.

Then he caught the back of her neck in one warm bare hand, pulled her mouth up to his in one final, slow, bone-deep kiss tasting of salt and cold morning air—no *auf Wiedersehen*, no pious lies—whispered against her lips in clear, steady Polish:

"*Do zobaczenia, Sylwia.*" (*Until we see each other again, Sylwia.*)

"You go down five minutes after curfew bell—I wait twenty till the six-o'clock bakers' carts roll," Ludwig said, stepping back one clean pace into attic shadow with his hand on the bolt. "Go now while stairs are dark."

Sylwia put on her felt hat, buttoned her grey wool coat to the chin, looked once across six feet of dim Powiśle dawn at tall field-grey wool and winter-green eyes watching her memorize every bone, turned cleanly when five-thirty church bells rang faint across river fog, and walked down three dark wooden flights out onto Tamka's wet cobbles without looking back up at the skylight—because surgeons who looked back turned to salt, and Warsaw was waking up bleeding around her ankles.

Chapter XXX

Second Intention

Warsaw, 31 October – 1 November 1943

Hard frost struck Warsaw on the last night of October—locking mud ruts down Lindleya's courtyard solid as cast iron, riming rusted ambulance fenders in white salt-needles, and turning dead horse-chestnut leaves brittle enough to crack like thin glass beneath wooden clogs.

Nine days had passed since Ludwig Schoeler walked out of Tamka Forty-One into river fog; eight days since his eastbound flatcar cleared Brest-Litovsk toward the burning Dnieper bend.

In Warsaw nobody needed newspapers anymore to read the weather: Brigadeführer Kutschera's wet salmon-pink *Bekanntmachungen* hung pasted three layers thick on every brick corner now—Nowy Świat, Piusa, Towarowa, Solec, Młynarska—two hundred and thirty hostages plastered silent at the mouth in paper cement-sacks and shot five by five against sunlit walls inside sixteen days, while every night Polish *Kedyw* squads struck harder back out of cellar doorways at German police cars, leaving shattered windshield glass swept glittering into frosted gutters before seven a.m. trams ran.

Down in Pavilion Three's sub-basement coal vault at nine o'clock on Sunday night the thirty-first of October—separated by eighteen inches of mortared brick from the silent, wax-sealed *Fleckfieber* cellar where six hundred pauper lice cages lay cold since September eighth—twelve girls aged sixteen to twenty-two knelt round three zinc laundry tubs filled to the brim with icy red-dyed water and submerged rubber tubing pumped rhythmic off an enema bulb.

"Eyes up at the brickwork—nobody looks down into the bucket!" Sylwia ordered quietly, walking down the line in her unbuttoned white coat with hands tucked into pockets for warmth while coal dust crunched dry

underfoot. “When cellar roofs collapse or streetlamps go out, you don’t find severed femoral trunks with eyeballs—you find them by warm jet hitting cold index pulp inside three seconds! Zosia, your clamp’s upside down; box-lock faces palmward or ratchets jam on wet gauze. Again.”

Sixteen-year-old Zosia—thin wrists blue with cold water to the elbows, fair braids pinned tight up under a grey kerchief—flipped her curved Péan clamp neat inside wet fingers, plunged blind into murky red water, felt the spurting rubber side-slit on the second pulse-squeeze, and snapped steel jaws shut clean: *click-click-click*. Red jet died instant to zero.

Seated on an upturned coke-crate beside the warm boiler return-pipe with a plaid woollen shawl tucked round thin knees, **Docent Tadeusz Mirecki** tapped his walking-stick ferrule once softly against brick in quiet approval.

“Four seconds faster than half my fourth-year gentlemen before the war, Panienko,” Mirecki murmured dryly behind thick pince-nez. “Provided you remember to leave skin edges *open* afterward instead of sewing mud inside like tailors.”

Up above the coal-chute iron grating sounded three spaced boot-taps—Bronka’s all-clear signal—followed by Bronka herself backing heavy-hipped down the iron ladder carrying a bushel wicker basket of small hard red winter *Kosztela* apples still smelling sharp of country frost and woodsmoke.

“Jurek’s cousin brought orchard windfalls past the toll-bar from Grójec before curfew,” Bronka announced briskly, handing one hard red apple straight into each shivering girl’s wet hand as dismissal bell before leaning sideways toward Sylwia to press a folded two-inch square of coarse brown lard-paper into Sylwia’s palm. “Found stuck under the bottom willow splint.”

While girls dried purple forearms on rough sacking and slipped two by two up separate laundry stairs into dark wards, Sylwia tilted the tiny scrap of brown butcher-paper beneath the single wire-caged boiler bulb.

Zero names, zero village postmark—only four cramped lines penciled in unmistakable neat, round Lwów microscopic-ledger script:

Right cornea clear; reads newsprint at thirty cm without squinting. Dorsal graft took 100% per secundam—chops birch cordwood two hours daily without splitting scar. Delivered four noisy farm boys since Michaelmas;

chestnut stubble two centimeters thick under kerchief already. God keep your hands warm. — K.

K.—Kwiatkowska, dead under pauper pine at Bródno since September eighth while two miles off the Grójec pike Halina Różańska pulled crying Polish farm babies into autumn lamplight with chestnut hair growing back thick beneath her peasant shawl and Dawid's one saved eye read small print by birch-fire!

Sylwia held the two-inch scrap of brown paper against the open boiler-door draft until orange coal-flame licked pencil lead clean to grey ash—feeling one small, fierce knot deep behind her ribs loosen warm for the first night since Powązki rain. Two lives pulled clean out of Kroll's jaws and rooted alive in country earth where zero file reached them.

Over by the warm boiler return-pipe Docent Mirecki rose stiffly off his upturned coke-crate, leaning one blue-veined hand on his cane while reaching inside his cardigan pocket with the other before walking slowly up behind her.

Out into warm orange furnace glow came a slim, worn, burgundy Moroccan-leather pocket case no bigger than a cigar-holder, stamped on its tarnished brass clasp with a faded gold monogram *T.M. — Wien 1898.*

"Billroth's old instrument-maker on Alserstraße ground these twelve curved arterial needles out of English Sheffield spring-steel the autumn I finished my Vienna externship," Mirecki said quietly, pressing the smooth worn leather into Sylwia's coal-dusted hand before she could protest. "Zero rust in forty-five years, and thin enough in the eye to pass six-zero silk through a child's radial trunk without tearing adventitia."

"Keep them for your spring lists, *Panie Docencie*—your pulse is steadier every week," Sylwia said gently.

"Spring lists in forty-four won't be resecting polite peptic ulcers on white linen, my child," the old man answered without self-pity, watery blue eyes calm and clear behind thick pince-nez as coal settled booming inside Boiler Two. "Anyone with eyes sees two armies converging toward the Vistula before next harvest—and sixty-three-year-old coronaries don't climb burning cellar stairs with twenty-pound packs. Keep Vienna steel in your pocket where it works."

Sylwia didn't insult him with false sunny denials; she slipped *Wien 1898* carefully inside her white coat pocket beside her stethoscope, picked up one hard frosted red Grójec apple out of Bronka's basket, bit clean

through crisp sweet white flesh that tasted of peacetime orchards before thirty-nine, and climbed upstairs to check twelve post-operative beds before midnight.

* * *

Monday the first of November dawned clear, windless, and bitter cold under a sky the colour of polished pewter—**Wszystkich Świętych**, All Saints' Day, when nobody in Poland forgot bones under earth or bones burned without earth.

At two o'clock in the afternoon Sylwia walked west along Koszykowa to Number Sixty-Eight Filtrowa, off-duty for ninety minutes while Jankowski covered afternoon dressings.

Nine-year-old **Staś Bielski** stood waiting buttoned up inside the vestibule before she even knocked—cheeks bright winter-apple red beneath his knitted navy wool cap, skinny legs wrapped warm in cut-down adult wool gaiters Wanda had stitched out of Stefan's old railway overcoat, clear eyes shining alert without trace of summer's sweet acetone lethargy. Upstairs Stefan sat quietly shelling dried beans into a crock with pale, harmless lemon-faded palms that nobody in Wola's execution cells hunted anymore; Wanda kissed Sylwia's cold cheek fiercely at the door without chattering once about prewar velvet curtains—four months of close steel had burned silliness clean out of Wanda too—and slipped two tiny round earthenware saucers filled with melted paraffin and string wicks into Staś's mittened pockets.

"Walk as far as the church corner only, Ciociu?" Staś asked hopefully down on the frosted pavement, slipping his small mittened right hand tight inside Sylwia's gloved left palm—right across the stitched thumb-base. "Mama said Powązki trams are packed to the roofs today."

"We don't need Powązki trams today, Stasiu," Sylwia said quietly, turning east with the child toward **Aleja Niepodległości**. "Every street in Warsaw has graves enough this year."

She did not prepare him; nine-year-old Warsaw boys in nineteen-forty-three knew how to read brick walls faster than primers.

Turning out of Koszykowa onto the wide frosted avenue of Aleja Niepodległości at quarter to three stopped conversation dead down three blocks.

Sixteen days ago high-pressure municipal hydrants had washed blood and gypsum crumbs down the cast-iron storm grate opposite the closed stationer's shutter; ten days ago Kutschera's bill-posters had slapped fresh salmon-pink hundred-hostage warnings directly across the bullet-pocked red bricks at eye-level.

Today—in broad two-forty-five daylight under German martial law forbidding public assembly on pain of immediate shooting—**three hundred yards of open pavement in front of the bullet-chipped red-brick wall blazed gold and crimson with over four hundred burning wax grave-lanterns!**

Men in threadbare clerk's overcoats, women in mourning black kerchiefs, railway boys in visored caps walked past in a slow, unbroken, dead-silent river: nobody lingered longer than ten seconds lest cordons close, yet every fifth passerby stooped smoothly in stride to set down another flickering glass-jarred *znicz*, another bunch of frost-stiff white graveyard chrysanthemums, another bough of green spruce, until wax smoke smelled thicker than church incense across cold asphalt! Above the sea of yellow candle-flames, right across the bottom of Kutschera's wet pink execution broadsheet, somebody at dawn had scrawled in foot-high white tailor's chalk:

CHWAŁA BOHATEROM — 16.X.1943 (*Glory to the Heroes — 16 October 1943.*)

Fifty yards north at Piusa corner, a slow-cruising green *Schutzpolizei* open troop-lorry carrying twelve helmeted policemen with submachine guns across their knees braked hard beside the kerb.

Every back along the pavement stiffened; Sylwia shifted her hip half a step sideways between the German lorry and nine-year-old Staś without squeezing the boy's mitten hard enough to frighten him.

The *Schupo* lieutenant in the cab stood half-upright behind his windshield, staring down the avenue at four hundred burning candles and white flowers banking three blocks of brick—then glanced beyond Piusa where three hundred *more* candles flickered already on Marszałkowska's corner, and four hundred more beyond Jerozolimskie! Kick out four hundred candles here and stomp wax across stone, and within twenty minutes eight hundred fresh wicks burned behind your tires while ten windows overhead watched rifle ranges.

Swearing once through white frost-breath, the lieutenant slapped his driver's steel helmet twice—*weiterfahren!*—and the green police lorry ground gears and rumbled away south without a single boot touching asphalt!

Sylwia walked slowly forward with Staś to the exact five-yard stretch of pitted red brick forty feet opposite the stationer's shutter where **Marek Wolski** had braced a sixteen-year-old boy upright with his wired hip and looked away from her eyes to fool a Leica lens.

Without speaking a syllable, Staś pulled both tiny homemade paraffin saucers out of his mittened pockets, knelt on one woollen knee on frosted stone, touched his wick to a burning red glass lantern already guttering beside green spruce twigs, and nestled both small yellow flames steady inside a chipped mortar hollow two inches above pavement level.

Just as Staś rose dusting frost off his wool gaiter, a lean eighteen-year-old boy in a railwayman's visored cloth cap and dark workman's coat—walking briskly south without the faintest trace of March's right-thigh limp!—stooped smoothly two paces left of Sylwia's elbow to lay a small tied bundle of green juniper twigs coated in silver frost straight across the blood-washed kerbstone.

Straightening up in stride, **Leszek**—the boy whose femoral shrapnel wound Sylwia had opened her own patient's stitches to save on March twenty-sixth, and who had run errands for Marek Wolski since forty-two—caught Sylwia's dark eyes across three feet of wax-scented winter air.

Neither spoke a word on an open Warsaw boulevard; neither slowed past four seconds. Only Leszek's fingers touched two silent millimeters to the black visor of his railway cap—not greeting a stranger, saluting *Doktor Szew* over their dead commander's bricks while letting her see with her own eyes that the eighteen-year-old leg she saved walked swift and unbroken into winter—before merging seamlessly back into the silent river of dark overcoats moving north toward Jerozolimskie!

Sylwia stood motionless three seconds behind nine-year-old Staś—bare head bowed half an inch in November frost, zero tears, giving the bridge-engineer who died as *Stoker Janusz Kowalczyk* clean, unashamed silence—before touching Staś's wool shoulder gently and walking him home before early four-o'clock dusk purpled the chimneys.

After handing Staś safely back into Wanda's warm kitchen at quarter past four, Sylwia didn't take the straight Koszykowa tram back to Lindleya.

Instead, with forty minutes of grey All Saints' twilight left before five-o'clock ward rounds, she rode two stops north past Theatre Square and walked alone up **ulica Długa** to the mouth of the ruined printer's archway four hundred meters south of the **Bonifraterska** brick wall—where six months ago in warm May lilac-and-smoke dark she and Halina had climbed down greasy iron manhole rungs beneath twelve empty pine coffins to pull four half-blind human beings out of rushing black filth.

Nobody laid four hundred red glass lanterns or chalked foot-high slogans along Bonifraterska's northern desert tonight.

Beyond the guarded brick wall stretched three square kilometers of utter lunar silence: dynamited red-brick rubble heaps dusted silver with November rime, twisted iron bedframes sticking vertical out of cellar craters like blackened ribs, zero window-light, zero chimney-smoke, zero stray dog barking where four hundred thousand Warsaw lives had breathed, argued, sung Yiddish lullabies, and stitched coats four winters ago. Even Polish passersby hurrying toward Żoliborz trams kept eyes angled away onto their boot-toes passing the Ukrainian sentry-box at Krasiński corner.

Yet as Sylwia paused ten seconds inside the shadowed printer's archway—twenty feet from the round cast-iron sewer lid under which sixteen-year-old Rachela had coughed her last pink foam before Saski Garden—her eye caught one pinprick of warm orange light down at ankle level inside a bombed mortar-gap at the base of the outer brick buttress, shielded carefully behind two broken roof-tiles so sentry boots eighty yards north saw zero glow.

Someone before dusk—a surviving water-board sewer-man like Kazik, an old Christian servant-woman from Nalewki, or some nameless courier passing in dark wool—had wedged one stub of plain white tallow kitchen-candle together with three dried sprigs of wild wormwood inside the broken brick facing north toward Miła Eighteen.

Wax had burned down within half an inch of cold stone; dry frost draft threatened to gutter the tiny flame flat.

Sylwia stepped quietly inside the ruined arch shadow, knelt for four seconds only to shift the broken red roof-tile half an inch windward

with her gloved right hand so north draft missed the wick—watching the solitary yellow tongue straighten tall and steady against dark brick for Rachela and every nameless ash-speck drifted across Warsaw's roofs—and walked briskly south through gathering winter dark back to her hospital.

* * *

At half-past nine that All Saints' night the pewter sky split open from the northeast, spitting the winter's **first dry white snow**: hard, fine, crystalline needles hissing horizontal across Lindleya's dark courtyard roofs and banking white triangles along the wired-glass skylight panes of Operating Theater One—the exact dry iron sleet-hiss of February ninth come full circle nine months later.

At quarter to eleven Sylwia stood in green rubberized oilcloth apron over her wool dress in Theater One finishing routine boil-incision cleanups when zero siren wailed at the front gate—instead three rapid urgent fist-knocks drummed against the *rear laundry chute door* off Koszykowa lane where garbage carts loaded!

Two minutes later Walenty and red-haired student Zofia burst breathless through Theater One's swinging double doors pushing the wheeled iron stretcher low without corridor lamps lit:

Not field-grey wool tonight.

Two soaked, mud-caked Polish railway-yard jackets over seventeen-year-old boys with white-bandages knotted rough round limbs—the younger boy sitting propped at the foot clutching a grazed forearm, the taller boy stretched supine, tallow-white under coal-smudged freckles, dark soaked wool cut away from his **right shoulder and axilla** where bright, frothy-crimson arterial blood soaked straight through three rolled field-dressings packed tight under a twisted stick-windlass!

"Freight siding behind *Warszawa Wschodnia* forty minutes ago, Pani Doktor!" Zofia panted low while slamming theater shutters bolted and twisting up the solitary overhead gas-mantle beside the emergency battery lamp. "Supply-train diversion unit—hit two German *Bahnschutz* guards unloading hospital-train crates from Ukraine, heavy machine-gun opened up off the watchtower—stick windlass slipped coming over Praga bridge!"

Sylwia didn't ask names, units, or papers—already scrubbing sixty lightning seconds in ice-cold sublimate up to red-chapped elbows while Bronka materialised silent as iron out of night quarters to unstop the ether cone!

"Name, boy?" Sylwia asked briskly, stepping wet-handed straight to the iron table as Zofia cut away bloody shirt rags.

"Tadek—*Tadeusz*, Pani Doktor," the seventeen-year-old whispered through blue-white trembling lips, dark Polish eyes wide and terrified on the hissing green gas-mantle overhead—nine months younger than Leszek, fifteen years younger than Ludwig on this exact cold iron table! "Don't—don't take my right arm off, Pani Doktor, I'm a draughtsman—"

"Keep quiet and count backward for Siostra Bronisława and you'll draw bridges till you're eighty," Sylwia snapped gently—touching two gloved fingers for half a second against his cold carotid while looking straight down into the gaping machine-gun furrow across his right deltopectoral groove:

Not main axillary trunk severed—thank merciful physics, three centimeters lower!—the large **subscapular / circumflex humeral arterial trunk** torn ragged half-across where a ricocheting rifle-caliber jacket fragment had chewed pectoralis major apart without shattering humeral head, pumping bright scarlet with every weak radial flutter while dirty black Praga coal-cinders lay ground deep inside torn muscle fascia!

Ether drop-by-drop. Retractors wide—Zofia holding upper Farabeuf hook without flinching a hair!

Inside nine clean, lethal minutes Sylwia cleared clot, clamped proximal and distal subscapular ends in twin curved Péans, extracted fourteen jagged brass-and-lead bullet splinters plus black coal-cinders with thumb-forceps, double-ligated with boiled silk so collateral scapular anastomosis kept the boy's right hand warm pink down to his draughtsman's fingertips, debrided every shred of bruised necrotic pectoralis fringe ruthless to bleeding healthy red fiber, and stopped when Zofia automatically reached for skin-closing needles!

"Put that skin needle back on the tray, Zofia," Sylwia said quietly under the snow-hissing skylight. "Coal-yard cinders four centimeters deep inside muscle—close skin *per primam* tonight for pretty scars, and by Thursday gas gangrene takes his arm and his coffin together. Pack wide

from the floor up with iodoform ribbon gauze—leave every layer open to granulate clean from the bottom."

Per secundam intentionem.

By second intention: how dirty, shrapnel-torn things survived real winters when textbook primary closure rotted underneath silk.

At twenty minutes to midnight Tadek rolled breathing deep, warm-fingered, and stable into the hidden six-bed annex behind Typhus Partition B under forged chronic-osteomyelitis charts already inked in Mirecki's hand; his seventeen-year-old comrade limped out through Koszykowa lane with three stitches in his forearm before midnight patrols passed.

Alone in Theater One with Bronka mopping bloody meltwater off cracked hexagonal tiles, Sylwia stepped over to the corner zinc bench to burn the blood-soaked German Ostbahn medical-supply wrapping papers and canvas haversack straps the two boys had dragged off the *Warszawa Wschodnia* hospital-train siding to pack Tadek's shoulder on the bridge.

Wait.

Stuffed crumpled as packing-wadding around six stolen Bayer sulfonamide tins inside the captured German train-orderly's canvas satchel sat two grease-stained sheets of mimeographed Eastern Front casualty-and-transit bulletins headed **Durchgangslazarett-Zug 614 — Heeresgruppe Süd (Abschnitt Krementschug–Kirowograd), den 28. Oktober 1943**.

Sylwia's wet, cold-reddened hands froze dead still two inches above the zinc bucket.

Slowly she smoothed the crumpled grey cyclostyle sheet flat beneath the green-hissing gas-mantle—scanning forty lines of dry German medical-evacuation routing stamps out of the burning Dnieper cauldron six days after Ludwig left Warsaw:

…Zuführung von 142 Verwundeten der Nachhut-Kampfgruppe Obstlt. Dr. Schoeler nach Durchbruch aus Einschließungsring südwestl. Krementschug am 27.X.43 abends… Führer der Kampfgruppe (leicht verwundet, Splitter linke Schulterhöhe, bei Truppe verblieben) lehnte Abtransport ab…

Sylwia stood stone-still under the snow-ticking glass roof while every word burned straight through her retinas into living bone:

…Delivery of 142 wounded of Rearguard Combat Group Oberstleutnant Dr. Schoeler following breakout from encirclement ring southwest of Kre-

menchug on evening of 27 October 43… Commander of Combat Group (lightly wounded, shell-splinter left shoulder-point, ***remained with unit****) refused evacuation…*

Remained with unit. Refused evacuation.

Out there eight hundred kilometers east across frozen black Ukrainian mud under Katyusha rocket-smoke—with shell-splinters grazing that scarred left shoulder a second time and her five-inch steel Collin arterial clamp buttoned snug inside his breast pocket above his first rib—**Ludwig Schoeler had smashed clean out of Russian encirclement alive on day five and refused the hospital train on sheer bad Prussian temper!**

A tiny, silent, fierce half-laugh—sharp as surgical steel and warm as grain alcohol—escaped Sylwia's bruised mouth in empty Theater One.

"Good paper, Pani Doktor?" Bronka grunted without looking up from wringing bloody lysol water into her zinc pail.

"Best paper printed in October, Siostra," Sylwia said quietly, touching one corner of the crumpled Kremenchug transit sheet to the small blue Bunsen spirit-flame on the instrument trolley and holding it steady between raw fingertips until *Kampfgruppe Schoeler* curled black and weightless into clean grey ash.

At five minutes past midnight she unpinned her blood-spotted green oilcloth apron, scrubbed both hands one final time in cold sublimate at the chipped porcelain trough—feeling the four tiny pale suture scars across her left thumb-base pull taut and strong in icy water—blew out the overhead gas-mantle, and paused ten seconds by the wired-glass casement before climbing up to sleep.

Outside across dark, unyielding Warsaw, November snow fell thicker now—covering bullet-chipped red brick, covering candle-wax on frosted pavements, covering black Vistula iron bridges rolling east and west toward nineteen-forty-four's gathering fire. Nothing inside her ribs lay closed neat under silk anymore; everything lay wide open to cold air, healing raw and indomitable from the floor up, waiting for spring.

End of Book One